

**Layered Empire: Precolonial Continuity, Indigenous Agency, and
Hybrid Knowledge on Bengal's Northeast Frontier, 1790-1810**

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation examines the British imperial encounter with the northeast frontier of Bengal in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, demonstrating that East India Company (EIC) governance was heavily shaped by precolonial continuity and indigenous agency. Through examination of early frontier conditions in Rangpur and Chittagong districts, the Welsh expedition to Assam (1792–1794), the Symes embassy to Burma (1795), and the surveys of Francis Buchanan, it shows how the colonial state was superimposed onto, and forced to navigate, a variety of enduring patterns, including divided and overlapping sovereignty, unrestricted human mobility, local power struggles, elite factionalism, and parallel state-building projects. The dissertation explores the production of early colonial knowledge as a similarly layered process, with diverse groups of informants – primarily religious and political elites – providing vital information to early colonial observers, wrapped in interpretive frameworks that became embedded in the colonial archive. It also shows that, by reading these records ‘against the grain,’ they can be made to expose the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity that characterized the region before the coming of the nation-state. The dissertation challenges the prevailing view of colonialism as marking a sharp rupture with the past on the Southeast Asian massif, offering a new understanding of its earliest manifestations in the region as fragmentary, shallow, entangled with precolonial social and political structures, and intersecting with the exercise of agency by non-European actors.

DECLARATION

I certify that the work contained in this thesis is my own.

Conrad Compagna

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION – pp. 6-39

CHAPTER 1 – Little Kings, Big Criminals, Borderlessness and Dueling Imperialism on Bengal's Northeast Frontier, pp. 40-84

CHAPTER 2 – Networks of Knowledge Exchange and Hybrid Discourses in Early Colonial Knowledge of Assam, pp. 85-121

CHAPTER 3 – Disconnects between Territory, Ethnicity and Sovereignty in Precolonial Assam, pp. 122-157

CHAPTER 4 – Social Connection, Knowledge Exchange and Accommodation on the Symes Embassy to Burma, pp. 158-196

CHAPTER 5 – Empire through the Looking Glass: Late 18th-Century Colonial Knowledge of Burma, pp. 197-233

CONCLUSION – pp. 234-244

APPENDIX A (MAPS) – pp. 245-256

BIBLIOGRAPHY – pp. 257-273

INTRODUCTION

This dissertation covers, chronologically and geographically, British imperial activity in the 18th and early 19th centuries in a region known as the Southeast Asian massif, a geographical body that comprises the highlands rimming Northeast India, Northern Burma, Yunnan and the spinoff mountain chains that extend to Bangladesh and into Southeast Asia down to Vietnam.¹ Its purpose is to highlight historical continuity from the pre-colonial period and the crucial importance of indigenous agency in structuring the early colonial encounter with this space. Thematically it carries this argument through three areas. First, it explores the limited and decentralized nature of early Company governance on this frontier, which allowed many of the patterns characterizing precolonial borderlands to persist into the early colonial period, including fluid tributary arrangements dating from the Mughal era, a lack of monopoly over violence, and the interstate circulation of people, goods and ideas. Secondly, I look at two of the earliest interventions made by the Company on this frontier – a military expedition to Assam (1792-4) led by Captain Thomas Welsh, and an embassy to Burma led by Lieutenant Michael Symes (1795), both of which I interpret as examples of cross-cultural encounter, structured by indigenous power dynamics. Finally, I consider the efforts of the colonial state in Bengal to collect information on its northeastern frontier, highlighting the extent to which it was based in the oral testimony of indigenous informants, whose voices and ideas influenced its contents. I also look at how this rich mass of information, far from reducing the region to artificial coherence, can be disentangled and reinterpreted to reveal the extent to which the relationship between territory, ethnicity and sovereignty in it differed on the cusp of its colonization from the Europe-derived norms that underpin modern nations and nationalism.²

The most current trend in the historiography of the northeast frontier of India is a postcolonial one that has systematically worked to dismantle the enduring grip of nationalist intellectual frameworks on scholarly understanding of it.³ Most of these studies work within a paradigm

¹ Jean Michaud, 'Editorial – Zomia and Beyond,' *Journal of Global History*, 5:2 (2010), pp. 187-88.

² Ernest Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1983).

³ Gunnel Cederlof, *Founding an Empire on India's North-Eastern Frontiers, 1790-1840: Climate, Commerce, Polity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2013); Sanghamitra Misra, 'Changing Frontiers and Spaces,' *Studies in History*, 21:2 (2005), pp. 215-246; David Vumlallian Zou and M. Satish Kumar, 'Mapping a Colonial Borderland: Objectifying the Geo-Body of India's Northeast,' *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 70:1 (2011), pp. 141-170; Sanjib Baruah, 'Territoriality, Indigeneity and Rights in the North-East India,' *Economic and Political Weekly*, 43:12/13

pioneered by scholars of Southeast Asia who, since the end of the colonial period, have sought to highlight the inadequacies of the concepts of the nation and the nation-state when applied to the precolonial past.⁴ They have pointed to a lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity across the whole of this frontier in the precolonial period – these being the three ingredients that, when they cohere (or can be made to cohere),⁵ form the geographical extent and popular basis for the exercise of a nation-state's power. They tend to emphasize the radically transformative impact of European imperialism as the main explainer for how and why these ambiguous and open-ended patterns came to an end. Foucauldian arguments about the connection between knowledge and power are often deployed in these explanations: at the same time as the colonial state was entering into these borderlands and desirous of remolding them according to a more stringent, Europeanized blueprint, it produced a raft of new information that acted to conceptualize the region along the same lines, intellectually transforming it on paper at the same time as it administratively reordered it on the ground.

I use this literature as a point of departure in my dissertation, sharing its skeptical reading of the nation as a valid analytical category for studying the precolonial pasts of South and Southeast Asia. However, rather than focusing on the bureaucratic regime and forms of administrative knowledge imposed on the region by the colonial state and their subsequent transformative impact, I return to the earliest manifestations of colonialism in the region in the late 18th and early 19th centuries, asking questions about the nature and extent of the influence of precolonial

(2008), pp. 15-19; and David Ludden, 'The First Boundary of Bangladesh on Sylhet's Northern Frontiers,' *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bangladesh*, 48:1 (2003), pp. 1-54; Sanghamitra Misra, 'Peasants, Colonialism, and Sovereignty: The Garo Rebellions in Eastern India,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 55:5 (2021), pp. 1681-1717; Sanghamitra Misra, *Becoming a Borderland: The Politics of Space and Identity in Colonial Northeastern India* (London: Routledge, 2011); Sanghamitra Misra, 'The Sovereignty of Political Economy: The Garos in a Pre-Conquest and Early Conquest Era,' *The Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 55:3 (2018), pp. 345-387.
⁴ Edmund Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma",' *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 3:1 (1960), pp. 49-68; Edmund Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1965); F. K. Lehman, *The Structure of Chin Society: A Tribal People of Burma Adapted to a Non-Western Civilization* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1963); James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009); Thongchai Winichakul, *Siam Mapped: A History of the Geo-Body of a Nation* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1994); Willem van Schendel, 'Geographies of Knowing, Geographies of Ignorance: Jumping Scale in Southeast Asia,' *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space*, 20:6 (2002), pp. 647-668; notable theoretical contributions to this literature not from a Southeast Asian context are Sumit Guha, *Environment and Ethnicity in India, 1200-1991* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999) and Owen Lattimore, 'The Frontier in History,' in *Studies in Frontier History* (London: Oxford University Press, 1962), pp. 469-491.

⁵ For an example of not-so-subtle social engineering in a Chinese context, see Thomas Shawn Mullaney, *Coming to Terms with the Nation: Ethnic Classification in Modern China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2012).

social and political structures, power dynamics, and knowledge systems on early colonial rule. I adopt a bottom-up approach, treating the colonial state not as a monolithic and hegemonic presence in the region, but as a meta-state: a small, Weberian bureaucracy resting on top of a variety of precolonial social and political structures, interacting with powerful local actors in a negotiated and contingent manner. By foregrounding the intersection between the pre and early colonial, I hope to show that, both in its political and administrative history and in its forms of knowledge, the early colonial state did not immediately mark a sharp and radical rupture with past dynamics but rather was thoroughly entangled with them.

In highlighting the limited, decentralized nature of the early colonial state, which resulted in the survival of many of the patterns characterizing the region in the precolonial period well into the 19th century, I am influenced by C. A. Bayly, P. J. Marshall and others who have all in different ways reacted to a widespread tendency in the historiography on European imperialism to overestimate the extent and transformative impact of colonial power.⁶ They have sought to demonstrate that the EIC's ascent to power in India was rooted partly in historical trends emanating from Europe, but partly in those of the subcontinent itself, and that the form colonialism was able to take during the 18th and first half of the 19th centuries was determined in large part by the ways in which it interacted with political, economic and social patterns long predating it. No argument explicitly along these lines has been made in the context of British India's northeast frontier,⁷ and so I hope to show that here, the colonial state's weakness and neglect produced a related but if anything an even stronger effect, allowing continuity to bleed over in some cases well into the 19th century.⁸

⁶ P. J. Marshall, *The Eighteenth Century in Indian History: Evolution or Revolution?* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2003); P. J. Marshall, *Bengal – the British Bridgehead: Eastern India, 1740-1828* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987); C. A. Bayly, *Indian Society and the Making of the British Empire* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988); C. A. Bayly, *Rulers, Townsmen and Bazaars: North Indian Society in the Age of British Expansion 1770-1870* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012); Frank Perlin, 'State Formation Reconsidered,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 19:3 (1985), pp. 415-480.

⁷ Works critical of wider trends in the historiography on borderlands include Thomas Simpson, *The Frontier in British India: Space, Science, and Power in the Nineteenth Century* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2021); Lauren Benton, *A Search for Sovereignty: Law and Geography in European Empires, 1400-1900* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010); and Peter Robb, 'The Colonial State and Constructions of Indian Identity: An Example on the Northeast Frontier in the 1880s,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 31:2 (1997), pp. 245-283. Cederlof, *Founding an Empire* also includes a discussion of the limited form of governance practiced on this frontier.

⁸ A good source of information on the difficulty and disinterest the colonial state had in projecting sovereignty into its borderlands in the 19th century is Alexander Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill*

I place consistent emphasis on cross-cultural interaction in my analysis of events in which the colonial state was involved, steering away from narrative structures revolving around the needs and actions of the colonial state and its servants.⁹ I center precolonial continuity and the agency of non-European actors, demonstrating the extent to which the early British Empire in the region was layered over top of and reacting to dynamics long predating its arrival in the region. Rather than reducing power relations to a colonizer-colonized binary, I look at a variety of cross-cutting phenomena such as non-European forms of imperial expansion, aspirations to statehood among tribal highlanders, elite factionalism, ground-level ethnic conflict, and caste-based social stratification. Interactions between ruler and ruled in the early colonial era were also marked by collaboration, negotiation, opportunism, and other forms of strategic maneuvering that cannot easily be sorted into the categories of domination or resistance. In my coverage of the Welsh and Symes missions, the two major events around which the dissertation is based, I have started with an analysis of pre-colonial trends and power dynamics, and then considered how those might have manifested in early encounters with the colonial state, and how the colonial state was forced to account for those dynamics in order to achieve its objectives.

Finally, the nature of the texts that I have encountered over the course of doing this research has led me to a view on colonial knowledge that somewhat diverges from the theoretical strain descended from Edward Said's *Orientalism*.¹⁰ I do not see colonial knowledge as necessarily reflecting only European ideology. Some of it can be encompassed within this critique, for example fiction, knowledge produced in metropolitan contexts through the recycling of texts more immediately arising from experience, or knowledge produced through analysis of indigenous texts, lifting them out of their original contexts and repurposing them for colonial ends. However, the volume of material produced in the course of Europe's centuries-long

Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal (Calcutta: Home Department Press, 1884); a more recent text which also which details the closing of one of the last of these internal borderlands in the late 19th and early 20th centuries is Pum Khan Pau, *Indo-Burma Frontier and the Making of the Chin Hills: Empire and Resistance* (New Delhi: Routledge India, 2021).

⁹ A good discussion of the persistence of Eurocentric narratives in both pro and anti-colonial writing is contained in the introduction to Adam Clulow, *The Company and the shogun: the Dutch encounter with Tokugawa Japan* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014).

¹⁰ A good critique of trends in the treatment of colonial knowledge can be found in the introduction to Anastasia Piliavsky, 'the "Criminal Tribe" in India before the British,' *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 57:2 (2015), pp. 323-354; another good historiographical overview of these debates is Tony Ballantyne, 'Colonial Knowledge,' in ed. Sarah Stockwell, *The British Empire: Themes and Perspectives* (Malden: Wiley-Blackwell, 2008), pp. 177-198.

engagement with other parts of the world is immense, and contains sources written from different perspectives, using different methods, and for varied purposes.¹¹ I focus on examples of colonial knowledge produced through cross-cultural encounter, which opens up new questions on the role of informants drawn from many different social groups, both elite and subaltern, in its construction, and the ideological mark left behind by these groups on its contents. I also point to the evidence contained in knowledge constructed in this manner of the fragmentation, ambiguity and dynamism characteristic of sovereignty relationships and patterns of ethnic identification on the Southeast Asian massif, a place where multiple state, civilizational, sociological and ecological frontiers converged.¹²

Below, I present my thinking on the two main bodies of historiography with which I engage in this dissertation. The first is that on the Southeast Asian massif, a new geographical concept developed by historians and anthropologists in the late 20th century. The first part of this section primarily acknowledges my intellectual debts to scholars such as Edmund Leach, James Scott, and Willem van Schendel, whose work has inescapably drawn attention to the ways in which the logic of the nation is upended in such liminal spaces. In the second half of the section, I introduce what I hope will be my own modest contribution to this debate, by pointing to cross-cutting forms of power relations that do not fit neatly into a colonizer/colonized or state/non-state binary, as well as emphasizing continuity and borrowing as the colonial state layered itself over and adapted to preexisting statecraft traditions. In the second section, I engage with a series of debates surrounding the loose synthesis of postmodern, Marxist, and cultural nationalist ideas that has come to be known as ‘postcolonialism.’ I outline some critiques of how knowledge is treated within this analytical tradition, before presenting my own stance on the subject. In essence, while I find the central insights of Saidian critiques of colonial knowledge useful, I argue that greater attention must be paid to the circumstances under which knowledge was produced and the effects this had on its content. Not all colonial knowledge was a *de novo* imposition of European categories onto passive subjects – much of it was derived from conversations with indigenous informants and shaped by their own views, which were connected

¹¹ See Norbert Peabody, 'Knowledge Formation in Colonial India,' in eds. Douglas M. Peers and Nandini Gooptu, *India and the British Empire* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), pp. 75-99.

¹² These converging frontiers are described well in Willem van Schendel, *A History of Bangladesh* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), chs. 1, 2.

to ideological traditions and political agendas that intersected with those of the colonial state in these exchanges. In the final methodology section, I consider how to perform ‘against-the-grain’ readings of the colonial archive, a technique that I employ extensively across the dissertation. I provide my thoughts on which sources are suitable for such an approach, some of the potential pitfalls of working with them, and how I have attempted to overcome these challenges, including the use of indigenous knowledge where possible to cross-reference the facts contained in the colonial archive and the deployment of contemporary area studies literature to aid in their interpretation.

THE SOUTHEAST ASIAN MASSIF

In this section I lay out some of the critiques of the nation that have influenced my writing, before presenting some of the findings from current anthropological and historical studies on the borderlands of Bengal and on the highlands of Southeast Asia more generally, through which I hope it will become clear that they present one of the most radical possible examples of a space where the logic of the nation ceases to apply. I also present some of my criticisms of the treatment of power in studies of European imperialism, in particular overemphasis on binaries of domination and resistance, and on the alien and transformative nature of the colonial state. I put forward a view of power relations as multipolar and contingent, as well as my contention that the colonial state was not always modern – in fact it started out as a relatively weak and limited affair, operating an infrastructure that was largely refashioned from the non-European states that had governed the region in the past. I end by presaging some of the main arguments running through this dissertation, including an emphasis on the importance of indigenous agency as an explanatory factor in early colonial events, and on the marked similarities in the ways in which late pre-colonial and early colonial states behaved in and thought about the region, partly because they had similar goals and faced similar problems, but also because of direct influence as the colonial state learned from, emulated and incorporated certain aspects of rule from previous orders.

Despite the many efforts made by scholars in a variety of fields since at least the 1950s to highlight the novelty and artificiality of nationalism and of the statecraft techniques associated with the nation-state, these remain a pervasive paradigm. They constitute an attractive model. At

the individual level the nation provides a sense of belonging, and if one belongs to a nation-state that is or purports to be democratic, a sense of control over one's destiny or at least unity in a shared purpose. At the political level a strong nation-state able to maintain order and encourage growth domestically and represent the interests of its population on the international stage seems to be a necessary precondition for fostering and maintaining an acceptable quality of life. The issue is at the empirical level. Having a strong sense of national identity may be sociologically and politically useful, and it may even be useful in an academic sense – the discipline of history as it exists in universities today is after all, the child of 19th-century European nationalism.¹³ Like any other concept though, it can sometimes distort or occlude as much as it reveals.

Nations, nationalism and nation-states – at the core of all of these related concepts is usually some claim to timelessness.¹⁴ It strengthens the sense of national belonging to associate oneself with a stream of human activity flowing hundreds or even thousands of years into the past. The problem is that these claims are often based on a selective, teleological reading of the historical record.¹⁵ Even where scholarship has found some basis for a collective sense of identity predating the modern period, on closer inspection one usually finds a sharp transformation in the meaning of that identity in the modern period,¹⁶ because national identities do not exist in isolation – they are fundamentally juxtaposed against each other, an effect of the proto-globalization of the 19th century bringing together a world that had previously been much more segmentary and localized.¹⁷

Identity and states both change over time, sometimes drastically. It is often possible to pinpoint the origins and spread of a national identity, its entrance into the realm of politics and the metamorphoses it engenders. This is especially true in the context of places colonized by

¹³ I am primarily thinking of Leopold von Ranke. See the introduction to Su Shih-chieh, *Modern Nationalism and the Making of a Professional Historian – The Life and Work of Leopold Von Ranke* (Washington: Academica Press, 2013) for a discussion of the connection of his historical method, which all modern historiography is descended from, to German nationalism.

¹⁴ See the introduction to Prasenjit Duara, *Rescuing History from the Nation: Questioning Narratives of Modern China* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1995).

¹⁵ A good example of the debunking of claims to the timelessness of national unity in a Thai context is Winichakul, *Siam Mapped*, ch. 8, and in particular his critical analysis of modern maps of ancient Thai states.

¹⁶ Victor Lieberman, 'Why was nationalism European? Political ethnicity in Asia and Europe 1400-1850,' *Journal of Global History*, 16:1 (2021), pp. 4-23 gives a good comparison of how modern and premodern forms of political identity differed.

¹⁷ Jurgen Osterhammel, *The Transformation of the World: A Global History of the Nineteenth Century* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2014).

European empires over the course of the 18th and 19th centuries, because the experience of colonization tended to create a new need to find a place for oneself and community in a new kind of world, one marked by foreign domination and heightened interstate competition.¹⁸

The new or reformed states that cropped up as a result of this competition behaved in a different way from their predecessors in that they were much less tolerant of the myriad of political, geographic and sociological ambiguities that characterized life in the early modern period, when states ruled over much more murkily defined populations whose ethnic composition constantly shifted due to migration, conquest and cultural change; when the sovereignty claims of different states often overlapped and interpenetrated, making it difficult to tell where a state began and where another ended; and when large swathes of the world, especially ecologically marginal areas, were not ruled by any state at all.¹⁹

In tracing the process of the formation of any modern state one will usually find some variation on the theme of imposing a more regimented scheme of governance on the territory it controls. One of the best examples of this comes from Thongchai Winichakul's book, *Siam Mapped: A History of the Geo-Body of a Nation*. Thailand presents the rare example of a Southeast Asian state which was never formally colonized by European powers. However, over the course of the 19th century, the Thai ruling elite, in a self-strengthening effort, borrowed wholesale many of the statecraft techniques practiced by neighboring European colonial empires, defining hard territorial borders and hiring European cartographers to demarcate them; ratcheting up state control over borderland principalities, eventually abolishing them completely and incorporating them into a nascent national state; and in the ideological realm making totalizing claims about the timeless and integral unity of what was basically a novel entity. In this way, Winichakul tells us, the 'geo-body' of his nation was created.²⁰

I chose to situate my study of the British Empire on the Southeast Asian massif, or 'Zomia,' because it is the best example I have so far encountered of a space where the logic of the nation

¹⁸ In the Indonesian context see Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 2006) and Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures: Selected Essays* (New York: Basic Books, 1973), chs. 8-10.

¹⁹ Michiel Baud and Willem van Schendel, 'Toward a Comparative History of Borderlands,' *Journal of World History*, 8:2 (1997), pp. 211-242; Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*.

²⁰ Winichakul, *Siam Mapped*.

ceases to apply. The highland areas of South China and mainland Southeast Asia have a set of social, cultural, political and economic rhythms that are so obviously out of lockstep with any of the surrounding nation-states that even as early as the 1950s observers of the region were already concluding that it made little sense to look at them through the lens of nations and nationalism; and therefore that the nation-state, rather than being a normal or an old mode of political organization in the area, must have been a recent European import.

The earliest manifestations of these arguments can be found in the work of Edmund Leach, himself old enough to have briefly been a colonial official in Burma, and whose research took place partly in the colonial period itself and partly in the first moments after independence. In 1960 he wrote a devastating critique of the tendency in late colonial intellectual circles to superimpose European ideas of race and nation onto other societies, noting that it was difficult to reconcile these with the data he had collected in his field research in the mountains and valleys between India, Burma and Yunnan.²¹ Politically, he saw the whole region as an expansive borderland between Indian and Chinese civilization, a garden containing a multitude of states large and small, tangled together with overlapping spheres of influence and interpenetrating political systems. These states often appeared and disappeared in quick succession, and rather than having clearly defined borders they consisted of a core area that projected universalist claims over a vast, loosely dominated hinterland subject to tribute demands, claims that fluctuated with the level of power wielded by particular rulers. These states were based in valleys and rarely able to dominate highlands even if they were in close proximity, though highlanders and lowlanders sometimes lived side by side, as valleys could be found at high altitudes and highlanders fanned outward and downward into cultivable land. These were territorially discontinuous, composite polities comprised of a multitude of subjects with differing claims and relationships to central authority.

Leach saw ethnicity in the region as a product of the relationship between lifeways and ecology, rather than through the paradigm of language, race and migration common to his time. Hill economies were mostly characterized by shifting cultivation and hunting and gathering, and hill people generally had more egalitarian societies, more diverse religious practices and displayed a

²¹ Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma".'

high degree of ethnolinguistic diversity. Valleys were the home of wet rice agriculture, Buddhism, greater levels of social and political hierarchy and a more uniform distribution of cultural markers. Ethnic boundaries were permeable. Leach witnessed entire communities of hill people migrating into valleys and becoming sedentary, Buddhist agriculturalists, transforming their social and political structures and cultural identities in the process, and pointed out examples of settled agriculturalists taking to the hills and modifying or shedding their lowland identities in a reverse process. Leach as a consequence cautioned historians not to posit sharp ethnic boundaries between the region's peoples when there had not been any in the past, and still were none at the time he was writing.

Leach's work on the disconnect between states, ethnic groups and territorial boundaries has had a paradigmatic influence on later writers. In the early 2000s, Willem van Schendel proposed a new geographical framework for looking at the area, based not on contemporary state boundaries or major cultural groupings but on a highland/lowland divide. He coined the term 'Zomia' to describe this vast stretch of territory, roughly the size of Europe and containing a hundred million people who comprise an ornate mosaic of five major language families, many religious traditions and cosmologies, systems of kinship and modes of subsistence, and yet who have not a single state to their name and very little representation in national or international politics and academic life. Traditionally the people of the region have been studied as appendages of the nation-states they are ruled by, rather than as a coherent whole – many of these groups live scattered across several states, called by a different name in each, often with little recognition of the extent to which they bear cross-border resemblances. Schendel proposed that they be grouped together and studied in unison due to the region's peculiar ecology and the ways in which it has shaped modes of subsistence, cultural traits and sociopolitical organization.²²

James Scott in *The Art of Not Being Governed* popularized this new geographical concept, adding to his analysis an anarchist twist. He argued that the central thread connecting all the varied groups of the region was a shared historical experience of resistance and flight from lowland states, which utilized a variety of techniques to concentrate the thinly spread populations of Southeast Asia into agriculturally productive areas where they could form the resource base on

²² Schendel, 'Geographies of Knowing, Geographies of Ignorance.'

top of which statecraft could be conducted. This included: political domination through military force; the appointment of chiefs whose primary loyalty was to the imperial state; social dominance through systems of labor bondage that tied peasants to the land and ensured that they would remain an immobile resource whose produce could be expropriated and whose labor could be used in corvée projects or conscript armies; economic dominance through extractive systems of agricultural taxation and monopolization of trade profits; and cultural dominance through ideas of universal kingship, ritualized court centers, and imperial linguistic, religious and other cultural norms that filtered down into conquered populations, transforming them into a more homogeneous and pliant body of subjects.²³

Scott and these other writers have done an excellent job in making use of techniques of analysis originally developed to understand European imperialism and applying them in a non-European, premodern context. The target of their criticism being not European imperialism, but the state more generally, has allowed them to see many of the similarities between the ways in which precolonial, colonial and postcolonial states in the region have acted towards their most marginalized subjects. However, both Leach and Scott have been criticized for overreliance on abstracted models lacking in empirical nuance, especially lack of attentiveness to the messiness of historical reality, which often defies neat theoretical frameworks.²⁴ Their comparative perspective being my starting point, I add a few more dimensions to my analysis, drawn from the literature on European imperialism on the Indian subcontinent, namely: a focus on power relations beyond the colonizer/colonized (or in Scott's formulation, state/non-state) binary; on the limited, weakly penetrative nature of the early colonial state; and on its entanglement with precolonial borderland patterns.

Rather than focusing purely on the dynamic between colonizer and colonized, I try to bring out the full extent of the complexity of relationships of power on display in the early colonial period. This includes non-European forms of empire building, which for centuries crisscrossed the landscape of South and Southeast Asia, producing layers of transformations which the colonial

²³ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*.

²⁴ Mandy Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin: Histories Beyond the State in the Borderworlds of Burma* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013), pp. 14-20; Mandy Sadan, 'Review of *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* by James C. Scott (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008),' *Reviews in History*, 903 (2010), <https://reviews.history.ac.uk/review/903>.

state itself was layered on top of, and which continued to coexist alongside European empires, competing with them while simultaneously imbibing and repurposing many of their ideas and statecraft techniques.²⁵ It also includes some of the many examples of how political expansion in the quest for wealth and power played out on a smaller scale in minor states, which tended to employ models borrowed from the large and successful imperial cultures they came into contact with.²⁶ I treat the exercise of power by highland tribal chiefs as the most microcosmic manifestation of a drive that was not unlike those of kings and emperors.²⁷ On the northeast frontier of Bengal, such figures forged many state-like entities and fully fledged states, often accompanied by an obscurement of their tribal origins;²⁸ even in contexts where social organization was fluid and authority shifting, political expansion, tribute collection and slave raiding across highland and into lowland areas remained important phenomena that the early colonial state was forced to reckon with.²⁹

I look at how the exercise of power by actors other than the colonial state produced lateral fragmentation, creating openings for the practice of divide and rule politics. Conquest and tributary diplomacy created a landscape of interstate politics that the EIC was able to deftly wade into, offering its support to those in need – for a price – and forging coalitions to encircle its adversaries. I trace the ways in which individual interests and factional conflict linked up with the colonial state, creating within the elite strata of its own domains and in other states shifting pools of enemies and allies with whom colonial officials had to engage in order to gain, exercise and hold onto political power. I also look at the impact of state and state-like power, as well as conflicts within and between groups taking place below the level of the state, on the formation of social cleavages which were productively exploited and exacerbated, but not created by the colonial state.

²⁵ David Ludden, 'The Process of Empire: Frontiers and Borderlands,' in eds. Peter Bang and C. A. Bayly, *Tributary Empires in Global History* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2011): pp. 132-150. Winichakul in *Siam Mapped* discusses the extent to which 19th-century Siam explicitly tried to pattern itself on European colonial empires.

²⁶ Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* and Scott in *The Art of Not Being Governed* both discuss this.

²⁷ Studies of state making efforts by tribal or steppe people include Thomas Barfield, 'The shadow empires: imperial state formation along the Chinese-Nomad frontier,' in *Empires: Perspectives from Archaeology and History*, ed. Susan Alcock (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001): pp. 10-41 and Guha, *Environment and Ethnicity*.

²⁸ See for example Surajit Sinha, *Tribal Politics and State Systems in Pre-Colonial Eastern and North Eastern India* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1987); on the creation of new identities, see Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, in particular chapter 6 ½.

²⁹ Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin*, ch. 1.

Finally, I do not valorize rebellion by reading the modern ideological imperatives of Marxist class struggle or national revolution into a period when the intellectual basis for such forms of social action did not yet exist.³⁰ Resistance from below to the exercise of power from above tended not to be a manifestation of any grand metanarrative of liberation but rather was found in isolated pockets, contingent upon local circumstance and usually geared toward the negation of symbols of authority, the restoration of balance, or the reorganization or reversal of a given order.³¹ Nor was power-seeking behavior by subaltern groups always targeted upward; often it was laterally targeted at the immediate social environment, and rather than being a quest for freedom could take the form of a quest for resources or the domination over other groups, as in the case of banditry or raiding which, if well-organized and on a large enough scale, could begin to take on a state-like form.

Such exercise of indigenous agency was a fundamental force shaping the EIC's encounter with this frontier. The earliest officials who made forays into the region encountered a highly dynamic social and political landscape, one in which a multitude of local and regional actors competed with, resisted or strategically engaged with the Company in the pursuit of their own interests. In Rangpur, the collapse of Mughal authority gave rise to a mercenary economy, where warlords, dispossessed zamindars and bandits, as well as European private traders with armed retinues, operated shifting political networks that the Company had to work through. In Chittagong and in the Garo hills, British officials found themselves balancing conflicts between highland chiefs and lowland Bengali tax farmers and zamindars who pursued microscopic forms of expansion underneath the umbrella of the colonial state but without its knowledge or permission. The EIC became a sought-after imperial patron with the fragmentation of the Ahom monarchy, where elite factions vied for British support to consolidate power, mirroring similar rivalries in Burma's western borderlands, where exiled Arakanese nobles in rebellion against their conquerors courted the Company's backing. At the highest level, the Company had to contend with an ascendant,

³⁰ See the introduction to Dipesh Chakrabarty, *Provincializing Europe: Postcolonial Thought and Historical Difference* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2000).

³¹ Though he has been criticized for seeing a fundamental unity in all peasant revolts, Ranajit Guha, *Elementary Aspects of Peasant Insurgency in Colonial India* (Durham: Duke University Press, 1999) still remains one of the most eye-opening works on the topic, especially his discussion on the ways in which, in the absence of ideological principles that could guide in the construction of a different kind of society, revolt was couched in the terms of restoration of balance, destroying symbols of authority, or repurposing them to recreate a similar order dominated by a new group.

aggressive form of non-European imperialism in the early Konbaung dynasty, which, like its British counterpart, was expansionist and opportunistic, taking advantage of local conflicts in order to annex weaker neighboring states. This was a multipolar and fast-changing landscape of power, one in which the early colonial state was one actor among many, however significant its part may have been.

Throughout the dissertation I also call into question the extent to which the early colonial state was a transformative actor in the late 18th to early 19th centuries, rather than being ensconced in a variety of older patterns not of its own making. All over India until roughly the 1830s, with the entry of a new cadre of administrators animated by liberal utilitarianism and untethered from the Company's traditional mercantile directives,³² the colonial state displayed a peculiar hybridity, partly acting as a modernizing force and partly building on the patterns of its predecessors – the central insight here being that there was no sharp dividing line between the precolonial and colonial periods, only a blending effect as one era slowly gave way to another.³³ I hope to highlight throughout my dissertation the extent to which this pattern prevailed on the massif as well, perhaps in an even more pronounced fashion.

The northeast frontier of Bengal was not a place particularly conducive to the expansion of imperial power. Even the late imperial state in its full flower exercised only shifting and unsystematic control over the region, a pattern that becomes more acute the earlier on the date. This shallow, passing presence was to an extent produced by simple inability to project power, but partly also by design – the EIC's interests in the region were limited and it paid only as much attention as was necessary to secure them. Gunnell Cederlof argues that this minimalistic strategy centered mostly on ensuring security from Burmese invasion and tapping into trade routes linking Bengal with Burma and ultimately China.³⁴ Complex challenges and limited goals combined to produce a weak, contested administration, characterized not by rational institutionalization, but by a series of disconnected attempts to attach the sinews of the colonial state to pre-existing structures – entering into tributary relations with local rulers, taking control

³² Eric Stokes, *The English Utilitarians and India* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1959).

³³ Marshall, *The Eighteenth Century in Indian History*.

³⁴ Cederlof, *Founding an Empire*, in particular chs. 3, 5, 6.

of foreign and military affairs, securing revenues, promoting trade, grabbing control of key resources and otherwise interfering as little as possible in local governance.

The Company tended only to take control of lowland areas where population concentrations were high enough for states to form; the most pristine highland areas (in the sense of lacking state influence) were largely ignored well into the 19th century. This shallowness produced a layering effect. The colonial state based itself primarily in fertile agricultural zones, stringing them together with transportation networks carved through the mountains. This strategy ensured that, at minimal cost and effort, it monopolized the main sources of taxable wealth while also being able to set up garrisons and move troops through mountains and jungles that were lethal if traversed on foot. In terms of governance, it practiced indirect rule. Sometimes it would put the rulers of princely states under the control of a British agent (which was often quite loose, allowing them to function semi-independently in a way reminiscent of pre-colonial tributary relationships); sometimes colonial authorities would abolish a particular monarchy but continue to rely on its service elites to run the machinery of local government.³⁵

The Company's relative disinterest and shallow presence in these borderlands also allowed for much of the mobility, hybridity and overlap that had characterized them in the precolonial period to continue unabated into the early 19th century. District officials remained engaged in a variety of precolonial sovereignty arrangements with minor tributary rulers, who themselves could be beholden to larger neighbors, often more than one simultaneously. There were no properly demarcated borders or evenly distributed mechanisms to control movements of people, so they circulated across the region uninhibited. The Company was also unable to monopolize violence, which meant that in these lightly governed spaces, claimants from many backgrounds arose whose use of coercion in the quest for wealth and power took on a series of morphing forms, from simple banditry to the outright assertion of statehood; the most physically intractable spaces, which were often populated by the groups least amenable to having state power exercised over them, were almost uniformly ignored. The colonial state, at least this early version of it, was clearly not able to superimpose on the territory it controlled in a cookie-cutter way European

³⁵ Robert Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India* (Calcutta: Baptist Mission Press, 1835) and Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal* are both good primary sources on the arc of imperial history in this region, clearly detailing the partial and halting presence of the colonial government in it.

statecraft norms.³⁶ It was already formulating ambitions and taking steps along these lines, but in reality on this distant frontier, it was still presiding over basically the same mode of frontier governance that had been put in place by the Mughals.³⁷

This dissertation will work to demonstrate the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity in the northeast frontier between Bengal and Burma, and in doing so shares an intellectual heritage with postcolonial critiques that work to break apart the nation as an analytical category. At the same time, I emphasize the multipolarity and contingency of power dynamics in the early colonial period, the extent to which the colonial state was in a reactive position, responding to the agency of indigenous actors, and also the extent to which, because of its weak and limited nature, it was layered over a variety of precolonial structures, which allowed for a significant degree of continuity to carry over from the precolonial period. Though the early colonial state was in some ways categorically different from its predecessors, for example in the sophistication of its bureaucratic organization or in its commercial orientation, in its earliest manifestation on this borderland, it remained a hybrid entity. Rather than being a single, monolithic system of governance with total control over Bengal from top to bottom, it was a meta-state layered on top of multiple agglomerated states, societies, economies, and cultures, all with their own historical trajectories intersecting with early European imperialism, significantly influencing the shape that it took in the region.

KNOWLEDGE AND POWER

This section begins by chronicling a fierce series of debates on the relationship between knowledge and power, which emerged out of the cultural and linguistic turn in the humanities in the 1960s and 70s and became vastly influential in subdisciplines of history dealing with imperialism and the study of non-European societies. I outline some of the earliest arguments made in a South Asian context about colonial knowledge, followed by a series of critiques of this earlier literature, before laying out my own perspective on colonial knowledge – namely, that it displays significant variance both over time and depending on the immediate context in which it

³⁶ For the exact opposite argument, see Benjamin Hopkins, *Ruling the Savage Periphery: Frontier Governance and the Making of the Modern State* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2020).

³⁷ The frontier history of precolonial Bengal is covered in Richard Eaton, *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier, 1204-1760* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993) and van Schendel, *A History of Bangladesh*.

was produced. The knowledge produced by the EIC on the northeast frontier of Bengal in the late 18th and early 19th centuries was not fiction, nor was it imposing in an airtight manner European classificatory frameworks onto a subjugated population. While it was produced from within an Enlightenment epistemological framework, it was a pragmatic tool meant to generate through inductive inquiry a factually dense picture of the states, societies, and economies of a region still largely outside colonial control, which Company planners could use to identify their interests and formulate policies to pursue them. Much of it was produced through cross-cultural entanglements that left a deep impact on its character in many ways. In particular, informants from a variety of backgrounds, mostly but not exclusively precolonial ruling elites, not only provided much of the raw factual material from which early colonial knowledge was shaped, but also influenced its interpretive cast.

The modern floor for the debate over the connection between knowledge and power has been set by Michel Foucault, who in the 1960s and 70s wrote a number of works exploring their connection. Foucault was at heart a historian of science, albeit with an idiosyncratic method, which he described as a kind of archaeology in which he uncovered different kinds of statements made about different topics and recorded the ways in which they changed over time, without offering any judgments about their truth value.³⁸ Instead he attributed the massive shift in the way that Europeans understood the world, starting roughly in the Enlightenment, to a deeper shift in the underlying systems governing how statements were made in the first place, which he in turn connected to changes in the ways in which people exercised power over each other. In a series of now classic texts, he tethered the history of scientific disciplines like psychiatry or the development of prison systems to the birth of the modern state, the marriage of institutional organization and observational surveillance, and the substitution of public and symbolically charged violence in favor of a new form of control that regulated social behavior through the collection of individuated knowledge – control that was in one sense more humane, but also more complete.³⁹

³⁸ Michel Foucault, *The Archaeology of Knowledge* (New York: Routledge, 2002).

³⁹ Michel Foucault, *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison* (London: Penguin, 1991); Michel Foucault, *Madness and Civilization: A History of Insanity in the Age of Reason* (London: Routledge, 1961).

Foucault's theories had a major influence on Edward Said's *Orientalism*. Said's landmark text is heavily indebted to Foucault's central idea that in any given period there are a set of unwritten rules governing what can be understood or said about the world, and that those rules are in turn connected to a deeper set of social and political relationships determining who gets to observe whom, whose statements will carry weight and whose will disappear. However, Said only partly adopted Foucault's framework, which was politically ambiguous – skeptical towards the possibility of complete liberation from power structures, and of the grand narratives of the left as well as the right.⁴⁰ Said, whose worldview was shaped by the struggle for self-determination in his Palestinian homeland, combined Foucault's focus on underlying social and political relationships as driving how knowledge was produced, what it contained and how it was used, with a much more conventionally liberal stance, clearly labeling oppressor and oppressed, as well as a blanket dismissal of the truth value of Western representations of the Orient: "Orientalism is more particularly valuable as a sign of European-Atlantic power over the Orient than it is as a veridic discourse about the Orient (which is what, in its academic or scholarly form, it claims to be)."⁴¹

Edward Said's formulation of the relationship between knowledge and power, postmodern at the epistemological level but liberal in its politics, has been extremely influential in postcolonial studies of South Asia. A large number of works have been written in that context about the ways in which the colonial state and its forms of knowledge impacted the subcontinent – *Imagining India* by Ronald Inden, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge* by Bernard Cohn, *Castes of Mind* by Nicholas Dirks, and *Masks of Conquest* by Gauri Viswanathan all being classic examples in this tradition.⁴² Particularly important, not only in South Asian studies but around the world, has been the work of the Subaltern Studies collective, a group of historians initially brought together by Ranajit Guha, a Marxist student of peasant insurgencies who wanted to reintroduce a cultural component to studies on class struggle in a colonial context.⁴³ Some

⁴⁰ This actually caused conflict between the two later in their careers. Karlis Racevskis, 'Edward Said and Michel Foucault: Affinities and Dissonances,' *Research in African Literatures*, 36:3 (2005), pp. 83-97.

⁴¹ Edward Said, *Orientalism* (New York: Pantheon Books, 1978), p. 6.

⁴² Ronald Inden, *Imagining India* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1990); Gauri Viswanathan, *Masks of Conquest: Literary Study and British Rule in India* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1989); Nicholas Dirks, *Castes of Mind: Colonialism and the Making of Modern India* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2001); Bernard Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996).

⁴³ Vinayak Chaturvedi, *Mapping Subaltern Studies and the Postcolonial* (London: Verso, 2000) gives a general overview in the introduction.

radical statements have come out of this group, with Gayatri Spivak arguing for example that authentic subaltern voices can never be accurately represented from within any intellectual tradition that does not originate from them.⁴⁴ All of these texts put strong emphasis on the ability of the colonial state and its associated forms of knowledge to radically reshape society, culture and politics, first in the intellectual realm but ultimately in reality through the utilization of new forms of knowledge in the colonial state's techniques of bureaucratic governance.

There has been significant pushback on the treatment of colonial knowledge as a largely fictional manifestation of the colonial state's will to power, mostly in the form of efforts to tie colonial knowledge back in some way to the social and political realities from which it emerged.⁴⁵ Chief among these is C. A. Bayly's *Empire & Information*, in which he argued that colonial knowledge was produced through an intersection between the colonial state, its needs and suppositions, and indigenous social structures and ideas. He put forward the concept of the 'information order,' a loosely knit collection of knowledge-producing communities who served pre-colonial Indian rulers and who continued to serve as repositories of information and in a bureaucratic capacity in the early colonial period. Brahmin pandits for example, or runners attached to indigenous courts, provided much of the information the EIC used in its early days to establish its foothold.

According to Bayly, the raj ultimately derived much of its power from being able to tap into this information order and utilize what it extracted for practical purposes. In this model, its accuracy was more important than its implicit biases, which were always present but which became much more acute in situations where the colonial state was not able to effectively collect intelligence.⁴⁶

Not only was colonial knowledge influenced by indigenous knowledge, it was also limited in breadth and depth. It failed to penetrate many areas of colonial life, resulting in paranoia and disaster, for example in the frenzied panic surrounding the Thuggee, a half-imagined cult of highway robbers and murderers, likely a phenomenon with some basis in reality as a collection of separate communities of bandits who combined crime and religious rite, but which colonial officials came to view as a monolithic conspiracy, partly through their own fictionalization of

⁴⁴ Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, 'Can the Subaltern Speak?,' *Die Philosophin*, 14:27 (1988), pp. 42–58.

⁴⁵ See Carol Breckenridge and Peter Van Der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993).

⁴⁶ C. A. Bayly, *Empire & Information: Intelligence gathering and social communication in India, 1780-1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), pp. 3-6.

informant narratives revealing a much more heterogeneous set of practices and motivations.⁴⁷ Similar failures occurred on the colonial state's frontiers, for example in wars in Afghanistan and Burma on unknown terrain against unknown enemies.⁴⁸ Frederick Cooper argues that Foucault's vision of the modern state, which produces subjects through its collection of individuated knowledge translated into power over bodies and minds, cannot be transposed easily into colonial situations. Colonial power was spread unevenly, not in a grid but rather in a series of arteries that passed over whole territories and populations, and its object of knowledge was often the community, rather than the individual, as its basis of legitimacy lay in the cooptation of traditional hierarchies, and it was generally too weak to penetrate deeper.⁴⁹

Nor was colonial knowledge totally novel or fantastical in its contents. Often it was capturing real patterns in the societies being observed, though the meaning or valence of those patterns could be transformed as information entered into the colonial archive and was made use of in the everyday course of ruling India. Such arguments have been adeptly made for example by scholars looking at the formation of caste and religious identity and conflict in colonial India. Take the case of so-called 'criminal tribes,' which many for a long time believed were a fiction perpetuated by the colonial state, but which turn out to have a basis not only in pre-colonial knowledge, but also in reality, with some caste groups in India even today not only engaging in widespread criminal enterprise (and serving as muscle for local politicians) but actually representing themselves in their own words to anthropologists as being hereditarily engaged in crime.⁵⁰ C. A. Bayly has drawn links between the religious conflict of the precolonial period and that of the colonial period, questioning the extent to which there really was a major uptick in violence brought on by colonial divide and rule tactics.⁵¹ Another good study is that of Susan Bayly, who concluded that modern caste identities were significantly based in precolonial power dynamics that spilled over into the colonial period. They were hardened in the process of being

⁴⁷ Kim Wagner, 'In Unrestrained Conversation: Approvers and the Colonial Ethnography of Crime in Nineteenth-Century India,' in eds. Ricardo Roque and Kim A Wagner, *Engaging Colonial Knowledge* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012), pp. 135-63.

⁴⁸ James Louis Hevia, *The Imperial Security State: British Colonial Knowledge and Empire-Building in Asia* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), pp. 112-26; Bayly, *Empire & Information*, pp. 97-142.

⁴⁹ Frederick Cooper, *Colonialism in Question: Theory, Knowledge, History* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2005), pp. 48-9.

⁵⁰ Piliavsky, 'the "Criminal Tribe" in India before the British.'

⁵¹ C. A. Bayly, 'The Pre-History of "Communalism"? Religious Conflict in India, 1700-1860,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 19:2 (1985), pp. 177-203.

exploited by the colonial state to solidify its rule, but also by members of caste groups themselves in the context of economic and political struggles, both with the colonial state and between each other, and were not simply manufactured by the census or other colonial drives toward systemization and consolidation of difference and hierarchy.⁵²

In my own treatment of colonial knowledge, I accept the central argument emerging out of French postmodern philosophy that there is an unstable quality to truth, and that the political context in which knowledge is created, and the position of the speaker versus those who are spoken of, are all central ingredients in the construction of knowledge. However, though all knowledge is created in an ideological landscape, it also occupies a spectrum that could be defined as empirical richness. Knowledge which is saturated by ideology can be informative; conversely, benign statements can contain no important information. Almost uniformly, the documents made use of in this dissertation were created for the purpose of establishing, maintaining and extending colonial rule, and as one might expect, the subjective position from which these documents were written was generally one that intellectually facilitated that project. However, these documents were also often produced through real, messily entangled encounters that left their mark, both in terms of anomalies in their empirical contents and in fragments of informant voices embedded in them.

In the late 18th century, the Company was preoccupied with gaining lasting control over territories in Bengal that it had claimed for many decades but had very little presence in, or knowledge of.⁵³ The extent of its authority was very much an open question in these domains, where it encountered a series of stiff challenges to its rule, often of a military nature; beyond its frontiers, it faced regional states such as Nepal or Burma that held real power at the time and posed real potential challenges to its territorial integrity and to the aura of hegemony it was carefully cultivating. Knowledge produced in this era served the important practical purpose of creating an abstract landscape for imperial planners in order to allow them to make informed decisions during their effort to maintain and expand their nascent state.⁵⁴ In order to properly

⁵² Susan Bayly, *Caste, Society and Politics in India from the Eighteenth Century to the Modern Age* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), pp. 1-25.

⁵³ Marshall in *Bengal – the British Bridgehead* discusses the drawn-out lengths the EIC went through over the course of the 18th and early 19th centuries to establish basic control over Bengal, a process that came to its borderlands last.

⁵⁴ Bayly, *Empire & Information*, esp. ch. 3.

fulfill this function, it had to be as accurate as possible, and as a consequence, was created using the most sophisticated techniques Britons of the day had access to, usually inductive forms of inquiry characteristic of the Scottish Enlightenment in which many Company servants were steeped.⁵⁵

Knowledge produced in this way still had an ideological cast, but its power was generated through much more than the simple imposition of stereotypes. The most important dimension, and the one foremost in the minds of its makers, was the application of empirical rationality to the problem of knowing the world. An understanding of this is palpable in the work of Foucault, though it disappears in that of Said. Foucault saw the historical practices of psychiatry or criminology in the 19th century as combining an impetus towards social control with the collection of dense, individuated knowledge that was in one sense empirically valid and extended understanding of the world far beyond its parameters in earlier times, but which also achieved the political effect called for in the needs from which it originated – in other words, it could be both oppressive and true at the same time.⁵⁶ I believe he was ultimately correct and that this dynamic is also present in colonial knowledge, at least when it was applying formalized techniques and rose to the level of a quasi-scientific discourse.

When one goes back to these first moments when new objects of knowledge suddenly appear in the colonial archive, one comes face to face with an important effect: the generative nature of colonial knowledge. I am again influenced by Foucault here, who stressed not only the repressive effects of power, but its productive effects, creating new institutions which required new kinds of information to function and subsequently conjured them into being.⁵⁷ Not all colonial knowledge is simply rehashing information that can be found in indigenous texts or other primary material that can be accessed today. It was produced according to a variety of frames corresponding to practical goals such as conquest, security, control of subject populations, resource extraction, or the encouragement of economic productivity, and its contents were oriented toward those ends, constructing new domains of knowledge correlated with and designed to facilitate each. When

⁵⁵ Jane Rendall, 'Scottish Orientalism: From Robertson to James Mill,' *The Historical Journal*, 25:1 (1982), pp. 43-69.

⁵⁶ Foucault, *The Archaeology of Knowledge*, p. 205.

⁵⁷ Michel Foucault, 'Truth and Juridical Forms,' in ed. James Faubion, *Power* (New York: New Press, 2000), pp. 1-90.

possible, its makers usually built on whatever preexisting knowledge they could find; sometimes though, it is entirely alien, without any obvious correlation to any other kind of knowledge, making it for better or for worse indispensable – an event horizon beyond which one cannot see.⁵⁸

One key source of this new information was the testimony of indigenous informants, which opens up an important field of inquiry – the ways in which the colonial nexus of knowledge and power linked up to and interacted with others. Foucault's theories were originally developed to explain binary power dynamics – prison guard and prisoner, doctor and patient. In colonial contexts, these relationships were often layered, as with a colonial official and a brahmin informant discussing society in terms of caste. One purpose of this dissertation is to show that the knowledge/power problem so obsessed over in a colonial context is universal, and that other such nexuses can be detected lurking underneath the surface of colonial knowledge. This is especially true of knowledge proffered by ruling elites, which tended to resonate with colonial thought by virtue of being generated from a similar ruling position. Such knowledge, which served a similar practical need to know subjects in ways that eased the task of governing them, was folded into hybrid discourses, for example of ethnicity, or of civilization and savagery, that echoed on after the states from which they originated had died.

James Scott and Stevan Harrell in *Cultural Encounters on China's Ethnic Frontiers* have produced the most sophisticated statements on how the relationship between knowledge and power functioned on the pre-colonial Southeast Asian massif.⁵⁹ They see “civilizing projects” as being at the heart of all state activity in the region, precolonial, colonial and post-colonial. The basic features of this ideology display remarkable similarity across space and time, always involving some way of defining and classifying, ranking and ordering peoples according to scales of civilization and savagery derived from dominant imperial norms. Such systems shared similar justifications in that they claimed to be concerned with raising the quality of life and moral standards of backwards, peripheral peoples, and similar functionality in that they

⁵⁸ See for example Willem van Schendel's discussion on the indispensability of Francis Buchanan's surveys to those wishing to understand rural conditions in 18th century Bengal. Francis Buchanan, *Francis Buchanan in Southeast Bengal (1798): His Journey to Chittagong, the Chittagong Hill Tracts, Noakhali and Comilla*, ed. Willem van Schendel (Dhaka: University Press Limited, 1992).

⁵⁹ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, chs. 4, 7; Stevan Harrell, *Cultural Encounters on China's Ethnic Frontiers* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1995), pp. 3-16.

facilitated hierarchical political, economic and social relationships which disproportionately benefited lowland states and dominant social groups. Degrees of civilization and savagery were measured based on proximity, lifeways and habitat. Settlement in core lowland areas, cultivation of the land, deference to authority and the adoption of orthodox ideology were the ideals; distant, wandering nomads who lived in wild, non-state space and refused to recognize state authority or state-authorized cultural norms were a problem to be dealt with, either through exclusion or forced assimilation.

Harrell argues that these cultural pressures have had a profound effect, gradually pulling peripheral groups toward the charismatic center, a process justified by portraying them in denigrating cultural terms – feminine, exotic, ignorant, heathen, child-like – and in temporal terms as living relics of the past who could be pulled into an ascent toward whatever cultural ideals were considered orthodox in a given time and place. This did not just entail paying taxes and laying down arms, but also ethnic change. Entire ethnicities were absorbed, while others hardened, as conquered groups sought to redefine themselves against the dominant culture. New ethnicities were also confected through separation of those who were compliant from those who were not – political labels that over time became ethnic – while the opposite process also occurred, with groups defecting from the cultural core being reclassified as barbarians.⁶⁰

One of the key arguments I make in this dissertation is that the knowledge produced by the early colonial state, because it was reliant on elite informants whose power was emerging from pre-colonial social and political hierarchies, enfolded into it aspects of these earlier systems of thought. Precolonial systems of ethnic classification and ideas about civilization and savagery seeped into the colonial archive, and continued to serve the function of justifying state expansion and transforming populations in a way that made them more amenable to being incorporated into centralized states – though these effects were greatly magnified as they passed into the much more elaborate apparatus of collecting and utilizing knowledge characteristic of the colonial

⁶⁰ Many of the essays in Pamela Kyle Crossley, Helen F. Siu and Donald S. Sutton, *Empire at the Margins: Culture, Ethnicity, and Frontier in Early Modern China* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006) describe such transformations.

‘ethnographic state,’⁶¹ and repurposed to serve a new form of highly bureaucratized government alien to the cultural traditions of the region.⁶²

Knowledge was not purely drawn from high-status groups. Subaltern groups, especially those who were hostile to or uncooperative with the colonial state, did indeed leave behind little trace in the colonial archive, at least in the portions I have seen. On the other hand, those marginalized as a consequence of the exercise of power by other actors can be found aplenty, their voices entering into the colonial archive in the context of a search for support. Because colonial officials were interested in locating rifts in the fabric of indigenous political life they paid great attention to these accounts, which provide an important glimpse into struggles over status and resources taking place outside or below the colonial state’s domain of action. I do not dismiss these representations as solely the byproduct of divide and rule machinations on the part of the colonial state. Like information emerging from the testimony of precolonial indigenous political and religious elites, that of enslaved Manipuris in Burma or Garo chiefs locked in conflict with Bengali zamindars represents the induction of non-European voices into the colonial archive, voices that carried their own political stances and ideological perspectives. In the texts of the late 18th century, these voices are still discernible from within the substrate of colonial ideology in which they are embedded and can be read as attempts at persuasive political engagement.⁶³

The theoretical stance I have outlined in this section serves as a foundation for the rest of the dissertation. I acknowledge the ideological foundations of colonial knowledge but treat this as a universal byproduct of the act of producing knowledge itself. I shift the focus instead to methodology, in particular the careful inductive empiricism of an early colonial state whose existence was still an open question and which was attempting to feel its way through an environment with which it was still largely unfamiliar. I pay close attention to the collection of this early knowledge through cross-cultural encounter, highlighting in particular its reliance on the testimony of indigenous informants from a variety of backgrounds, elite and non-elite, who not only proffered much of the raw material colonial officials were working from but whose

⁶¹ Dirks, *Castes of Mind*, ch. 3.

⁶² Jon Wilson, *The Domination of Strangers: Modern Governance in Eastern India 1780-1835* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2008).

⁶³ This is also discussed in Nicholas Dirks, ‘Colonial Histories and Native Informants: Biography of an Archive,’ in eds. Carol Breckenridge and Peter Van Der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), pp. 279-313.

perspectives can still be detected in fragmentary form in the contents of early colonial texts. Overall, these were hybrid discourses in which the needs and suppositions of multiple groups converged.

METHODOLOGY

In this section I begin with a description of the source material I draw from in the dissertation, which is primarily bureaucratic knowledge produced through early cross-cultural encounters between the EIC and the states and peoples of the region – the material I believe has the highest potential for capturing surviving precolonial historical patterns and the exercise of indigenous agency. I outline some of the analytical difficulties presented in working with such material, as well as the theoretical insights of others who have engaged in ‘against-the-grain’ readings of primary sources produced in situations heavily inflected by relationships of domination and subordination, not only in colonial but also in metropolitan and non-European contexts. Finally, I explain how I have tried to apply these to my own material and why I believe that colonial sources, when selected for rootedness in experience and interpreted through contemporary frameworks, can serve as a medium for the extraction of useful facts about the precolonial world. I then briefly outline how my own circumstances as a distance-learning PhD student based in China impacted my research, highlighting both the extent of my work in the India Office archives and possibilities for future research in the National Archives of Bangladesh.

The colonial archive displays significant variation in the extent to which it can be connected back to precolonial realities of any kind. In general, it was subject to a layering effect; early encounters, often with states and societies still largely unimpacted by colonialism, tended to produce messy, ambiguous texts in which the complexity of precolonial social and political organization can still be detected. As the security of the colonial state increased, especially in the second half of the 19th century, colonial texts – especially works meant for public consumption – became much more refined and systematized in their interpretations, and clear ideological patterns emerged which more closely approximate colonial knowledge as it has been described by its more strident critics. These texts tended to be secondary interpretations of the rough-draft information contained in texts with more immediacy, and were no longer intelligence meant for the internal consumption of an insecure state, but rather were publicly-oriented ideological

statements meant to justify empire, or meticulous schemes of classification and ordering meant to reduce already-pacified societies to intellectual order. It is much more difficult to mine these kinds of texts for alternative voices or pieces of information that are incongruent with the dominant intellectual frameworks of the time. Layers of self-referential discourse are more thickly piled up in them, especially tertiary texts produced by metropolitan novelists, philosophers and other intellectuals who had never been to Asia, and whose audiences and preoccupations were purely domestic.⁶⁴

Throughout the dissertation, I have steered away from secondary or tertiary interpretations not immediately rooted in experience, as I believe that texts occupying these upper layers of the colonial archive are often largely ideological manifestations. I have also, where possible, chosen material produced on states and societies only loosely or not yet under colonial rule at all, in which the exercise of power by actors other than the colonial state and the broader patterns characterizing precolonial life are still visible. Finally, I have made extensive use of texts produced through the collection of testimony from indigenous informants of various backgrounds. It is in these that non-European voices are most clearly present, and so they offer the greatest potential for ‘against-the-grain’ readings looking to recover evidence of forms of social, political or cultural organization differing drastically from the norms prevailing contemporaneously in Europe.

The administrative knowledge produced by the EIC in the course of its deepening engagement with Bengal’s northeast frontier stemmed from multiple points of contact. The lowest layer consists of the records of local governance in Rangpur and Chittagong districts, which are difficult to access as they are located in Bangladesh.⁶⁵ Published selections of these documents do exist, appended to studies of them by mid-19th century colonial officials. District officials were also in communication with the government in Calcutta and would enclose in their communications selections of records related to the topics they were discussing, as well as copies of letters sent to them by other officials and private individuals; the EIC headquarters in London

⁶⁴ See David Ludden, ‘Orientalist Empiricism: Transformations of Colonial Knowledge,’ in eds. Carol A. Breckenridge and Peter van der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), pp. 250-279.

⁶⁵ Ratan Lal Chakraborty, ‘An Introduction to the District Records of Bangladesh,’ *South Asia research*, 11:2 (1991), pp. 175-188.

would also periodically receive large collections of documents about specific issues being deliberated by top leadership, many of which originated at the lowest levels where the government interfaced with local populations. Any material that made its way to Calcutta or London has been collated in the India Office archives.

Both the Symes and Welsh missions were managed by the regional government in Calcutta and left behind a large mass of material. This includes records of the deliberations of government in the lead up to the missions, as well as selections of documents related to issues of frontier governance that the missions were meant to solve. While in Burma and Assam respectively, Symes and Welsh were also in frequent communication with the government. Records of this correspondence were copied in the Bengal Political Consultations (IOR/P series, India Office archives), as well as in their personal papers. Both missions were specifically tasked with collecting intelligence in order to fill in the large gaps in the Company's understanding of neighboring states. Participants on these missions kept tour diaries recording in thick detail their daily business, conducted early cartographic surveys, and were in frequent communication with allied indigenous elites, whom they queried on subjects relevant to the interests of the Company. The results of their inquiries into the social, political and economic conditions of the states through which they moved were sent back to government in manuscript reports. Some of these were published during the lifetimes of their makers; others were rediscovered at a later date and published because of their historical value. On conclusion of the missions the government also conducted debriefings and analyses of the extent to which they were successful and what their likely aftereffects would be.

At the turn of the 18th century, the Company instituted the 'permanent settlement,' a new system of taxation meant to fix rates on land in perpetuity and hold defaulting landlords accountable by auctioning off their property.⁶⁶ These efforts to extend its control deeper into local life were accompanied by the mass collection of information on a scale much larger than anything previously attempted.⁶⁷ Such surveys were conducted all over India by a handful of officials chosen for the task, one of the most notable being Francis Buchanan, whose material I

⁶⁶ Ranajit Guha, *A Rule of Property for Bengal: An Essay on the Idea of Permanent Settlement* (New Delhi: Orient BlackSwan, 1982).

⁶⁷ Bernard S. Cohn, 'Notes on the History of the Study of Indian Society and Culture,' in eds. Milton Singer and Bernard S. Cohn, *Structure and Change in Indian Society* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1968), pp. 3-29.

extensively make use of throughout the dissertation. Generally aided by groups of indigenous interlocutors, surveyors like Buchanan would move from district to district, siphoning up vast quantities of information by any possible means.⁶⁸ Buchanan produced thick descriptions of each district, indexed according to topic, as well as a plethora of related material, from sketches of archaeological ruins to translated chronicles and comparative grammars. Though his descriptions of neighboring states such as Nepal, Assam, Cachar, Jaintia or Manipur could run into the hundreds of pages, they were considered supplementary, attached as appendices to the district accounts. Multiple manuscript copies of these surveys were made, some of which made their way to the India Office; they were also published by Montgomery Martin in the 1830s, who has been criticized for cutting out parts of them.⁶⁹ I cross-referenced the published versions with the originals while I was in London and found no significant alterations in the specific sections I use.

This section of the colonial archive, like the colonial archive as a whole, was fundamentally an artifact of power, produced to facilitate and reinforce colonial conquest. Every text I work from was created within a structure that sought to extend or consolidate colonial rule. Colonial officials compiled intelligence as the conscious agents of a state seeking to govern unfamiliar territories and populations. Even records produced through cross-cultural encounter, which I prioritize for their empirical richness and engagement with indigenous informants, were ultimately structured by the imperatives of colonial administration – mapping political landscapes, identifying social cleavages, and locating sources of wealth to tap. Beyond its practical role in governance, the colonial archive was also ideologically inflected. Although documents meant for internal bureaucratic circulation were generally muted in their celebration of empire or identity-reinforcing function, they still were implicitly filtered through the concepts of civilization and savagery, progress and stagnation, order and disorder or ethnic difference that Enlightenment Europeans used to orient themselves in the world.⁷⁰

⁶⁸ A good explanation of their working methods is in Matthew H. Edney, *Mapping an Empire: The Geographical Construction of British India, 1765–1843* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1997), ch. 2.

⁶⁹ See George R. Kaye and Edward H. Johnston, *A Catalogue of Manuscripts in European Languages*, Vol. 2, Part 2 (London: India Office, 1937), pp. 580–590.

⁷⁰ Jürgen Osterhammel, *Unfabling the East: The Enlightenment's Encounter with Asia* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2018); P. J. Marshall and Glyndwr Williams, *The Great Map of Mankind: British Perceptions of the World in the Age of Enlightenment* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1982).

These issues do not however make the colonial archive inherently tainted, not at least any more so than knowledge produced about subaltern groups in a metropolitan context, or in the course of the drive for empire by premodern, non-European states.⁷¹ Early colonial knowledge was produced through a wide-ranging process of empirical inquiry, bundling together texts, artifacts, spatial and statistical representations, surveillance, oral testimony and other sources coming from many different quarters into a loose pastiche. The fact that these efforts were so broad and eclectic, and presented in a relatively unvarnished state, means that, as with the interrogation records used by Carlo Ginzburg in his famous study of an illiterate Italian peasant tried for heresy,⁷² they can be productively read in a variety of ways, both by reinterpreting phenomena as they emerge and by linking disparate information into new patterns that were recorded in bits and pieces but never conceived of as a whole.

One of the ironies of the necessity of micro-specialization in academic historiography is that imperial history and the study of non-European societies have been largely pried apart from each other.⁷³ There are practical reasons for this at the level of technical skills and the necessity of getting hold of increasingly voluminous literatures on an expanding number of topics, but the result is that it is increasingly difficult to simultaneously keep in view the ideas and activities of the colonial state and those of the states and societies it was embedded within. Hence, I use area studies literature as a guide for interpreting what my primary source material has to say about the nature of the borderlands between South and Southeast Asia in pre-colonial times – and vice versa the ways in which the colonial state on the Southeast Asian massif was influenced by precolonial continuities – in the hopes of constructing a multidimensional picture of how different historical actors and time periods overlapped and interacted.

Colonial knowledge is an important piece of the puzzle for those doing research on South and Southeast Asia, where the documentary record from the pre-colonial period tends to be relatively sparse.⁷⁴ In the context of highland areas populated by non-literate tribal groups, little material is

⁷¹ This is an argument made by Roque and Wagner in the introduction to *Engaging Colonial Knowledge*.

⁷² Carlo Ginzburg, *The Cheese and the Worms* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 2013).

⁷³ D. K. Fieldhouse, 'Can Humpty-Dumpty Be Put Together Again? Imperial History in the 1980s,' *The Journal of Imperial and Commonwealth History*, 12:2 (1984), pp. 9-23.

⁷⁴ D. G. E. Hall, *Historians of Southeast Asia* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1961); H. K. Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 2 (Guwahati: Publication Board Assam, 2007), ch. 1.

available other than what was produced by the colonial state.⁷⁵ However, even smaller states in the region produced court chronicles; larger states like Assam or Burma produced a wealth of historical material. Assam in particular has a rich chronicle tradition both in Indian and Southeast Asian scripts,⁷⁶ and the Burmese court produced large, sophisticated chronicles, some the product of state-sponsored councils;⁷⁷ uniquely among states on this frontier it also produced a large volume of bureaucratic records in the form of royal decrees and local inquests. I have consulted these sources where possible to corroborate the colonial sources and add detail.

The work done for this dissertation was significantly shaped by constraints imposed by personal circumstances. Much of the research and writing was conducted while I was living in China and working full-time. The usual challenges of time, money, and distance were compounded by lockdowns imposed by the Chinese government in response to the COVID-19 pandemic, which made it impossible to leave the country for several years. After mass protests forced the government to lift these measures, a cyberattack on the British Library caused a further research delay. Nevertheless, during a two-week visit to the India Office archives in London, I was able to consult all archival materials related to the Welsh and Symes missions and Francis Buchanan's surveys of the Bengal frontier and its environs, which form the bulk of my primary source base. The principal area where more archival research could be undertaken is in district-level archives, which provide the most fine-grained perspective on Company interactions with its frontier, but they are located in Bangladesh. A research trip to the Bangladesh National Archives would undoubtedly strengthen the dissertation, especially the first chapter.

This section established the methodological framework for my dissertation, detailing my selection of primary sources and the interpretive strategies I employ to extract usable information about non-European societies from the colonial archive. I prioritize bureaucratic records produced through early cross-cultural encounters, which I argue contain the greatest potential for capturing precolonial historical patterns. I acknowledge the complexities of working with such sources, including their origins as instruments for the projection of colonial power and their ideological biases. However, ultimately I argue that while the colonial archive was structured by

⁷⁵ See the introduction to Cederlof, *Founding an Empire*.

⁷⁶ H. K. Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 3 (Guwahati: Publication Board Assam, 2007), ch. 1.

⁷⁷ Thant Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), pp. 79-83.

political imperatives it cannot totally be separated from, it also contains important clues for the reconstruction of non-European history; and that the sheer volume and weight of the colonial archive in South and Southeast Asia necessitates engagement with it, drawing on specialist literature for interpretive guidance. Furthermore, where possible, I incorporate non-European sources in order to reach a comparative synthesis. Finally, I sketched the practical context in which this dissertation was completed, outlining the limitations I faced as, to my knowledge, the Department of History, Classics and Archaeology's first distance-learning PhD student. While I am satisfied with the completeness of my primary research on the Symes and Welsh missions, and on Francis Buchanan's surveys of the Bengal frontier, I also note possibilities for enriching the dissertation through the use of district records kept in the National Archives of Bangladesh.

CHAPTER OUTLINE

The dissertation is structured into five chapters. In the first, I use the bureaucratic knowledge produced by the early colonial state on Bengal's northern border with Assam and eastern border with Arakan to reconstruct in surprisingly baroque detail many of the patterns that had characterized these borderlands in the pre-colonial period. I argue that these lasted well into the colonial period because of the colonial state's limited, disinterested approach to frontier governance, which resulted in a marked lack of administrative regularity and allowed for a whole host of non-state and minor state actors to exercise power beneath it, often unnoticed. I also argue that the first two major interventions made by the colonial state on this frontier, the Welsh expedition to Assam and the Symes embassy to Burma, were prompted and structured by these patterns, which for many decades had continued unnoticed beneath the state's gaze until finally it decided to grapple with them.

In chapter two, I extend my analysis outward to Assam. I cover the two most important attempts made to gather knowledge on this state before its annexation by the Company in the First Anglo-Burmese War (1824): the Welsh expedition and the surveys of Francis Buchanan. I focus on the political alliances forged between different groups of indigenous elites and the colonial state and a corollary relationship between indigenous and colonial knowledge. I point out the reliance of Welsh and his officers on collaborating elites within the Ahom aristocracy, and trace the significance of that in terms of the kinds of knowledge they provided and the ideological

perspective in which it was couched. I do the same for Buchanan in his later surveys, who was reliant on Ahom elites in exile, Bengali Brahmins, and Garo tribal chiefs, among others, all of whom left behind their own fingerprints on the information he collected.

Chapter three considers how the information collected in the course of these drives can be used to highlight the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in Assam in the precolonial period. Patterns such as divided and overlapping sovereignty, ethnic fluidity or cultural hybridity are often supposed to have been buried under the weight of colonial knowledge; here I show that, when knowledge was produced through cross-cultural encounter and inductive inquiry, it could capture them quite handily. In particular I look at evidence of the liminal position Assam occupied between Indian and Southeast Asian civilizations, its elite utilizing many Southeast Asian statecraft techniques and presiding over a heavily syncretic court culture; the expansive yet heavily decentralized exercise of sovereignty in a domain fragmented and attenuated at lower levels of government and in borderlands; and extreme ethnic fluidity, with a largely Tibeto-Burman tribal population in the process of undergoing ethnic metamorphosis through exposure to processes of sedentarization and Hinduization.

The last two chapters look at Burma, the largest and most important of Bengal's immediate neighbors to the northeast. Chapter four looks at the Symes embassy, in my analysis of which I take an approach that differs from much of the literature on Anglo-Burmese relations, where a clash-of-civilizations-style metanarrative predominates. By contrast, I take my cues from global histories emphasizing exchange and similitude. The Konbaung dynasty, which came to power in the Irrawaddy valley in the mid-18th century at approximately the same time as the EIC in India, was itself an empire and a major peer competitor, engaged in a parallel campaign of imperial expansion that eventually crossed paths with the Company's. The Symes embassy provides an opportunity to consider the political, economic and cultural tensions between these two empires, as well as to highlight evidence of mutual learning as the two sides exchanged large quantities of information, accompanied by a diplomatic deal that bears the marks of a short-lived attempt at accommodation.

Chapter five looks at the diaries of Francis Buchanan, who accompanied the Symes embassy early on in his career. While he was in Burma he took detailed notes on the many conversations

he and other embassy members were having with their Burmese hosts. These elite voices are supplemented in his account by the voices of informants from less well-off backgrounds – slaves and servants, as well as members of conquered groups that had lately been folded into the growing Konbaung empire. I look at the multiplicity of voices to be found in this unique document and the entanglements in it between different nexuses of knowledge and power; and use it to reconstruct the dynamic, shifting exercise of sovereignty in Burma's borderlands, as well as radical ethnic change in tribal populations living on its ecological periphery.

The conclusion draws these threads together by arguing that the early colonial state in the northeast frontier did not erase or transform the region's preexisting dynamics so much as entrench itself within them. Patterns of divided and overlapping sovereignty, fluid ethnic identities, and decentralized political power persisted into the early colonial period, while the EIC was forced to reckon the agency of indigenous actors. The conclusion also reiterates that early colonial knowledge did not immediately act to erase precolonial realities; it was often produced through open-ended encounters, and was heavily reliant on inductive inquiry and, in particular, indigenous testimony. As such, it frequently preserves both elite and subaltern indigenous perspectives – if in fragmentary form – as well as a mass of empirical material that allows for the reconstruction of disconnects between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity surviving and running parallel to the imposition of early colonial rule.

CHAPTER 1

LITTLE KINGS, BIG CRIMINALS, BORDERLESSNESS AND DUELING IMPERIALISM ON BENGAL'S NORTHEAST FRONTIER

In this chapter I draw on India Office bureaucratic records and reports and travel accounts produced by colonial officials on the northeast frontier of India in the late 18th and early 19th centuries in order to reconstruct the deep context behind the Welsh mission to Assam and the Symes embassy to Burma. I draw out evidence suggesting that Bengal in the late 18th century was still under a limited form of Company rule, especially in its borderlands, where in many cases the arrangements left behind by the post-Mughal regime it had taken over were still in place. On its frontiers with Assam and Burma, in Rangpur and Chittagong districts respectively, the Company had only a minor presence and was still engaged in a variety of precolonial sovereignty arrangements which crisscrossed and overlapped in dizzying fashion. It was also weak, unable to control flows of people across borders that it could not convincingly demarcate, and its inability to monopolize violence meant that in these lightly governed spaces (often, they were not governed at all), claimants from many backgrounds arose whose use of coercion in the quest for wealth and power sometimes took on the form of statehood, sometimes private armed commerce, and sometimes outright criminality, often shifting between strategies. I then connect the survival of these precolonial borderland patterns to the Welsh and Symes missions, both of which were reactive attempts on the part of the Company to patch the holes it discovered in its sovereignty as major developments in Assam and Burma began to have ripple effects on its territory.

A major strain in the historiography engaging with the question of the colonial state's influence on the northeast frontier of Bengal focuses on the ways in which it deployed new techniques of governance such as mapping and surveying, underpinned by new conceptions of the relationship between territory, ethnicity and sovereignty imported from Europe, in order to transfigure the region along lines that led directly to the formation of the postcolonial nation-state.¹ However,

¹ Bodhisattva Kar, 'Welsh's Fallacy: Rereading the Eighteenth-Century Ahom Crisis,' in ed. Subhas Chakraborty, *The Eighteenth Century in South Asia: New Terrains* (Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Calcutta, 2012), pp. 129-167;

the late 18th and early 19th centuries have been shown by others to have been in many ways a transitional period in which the hybridity and ad hoc utilization of precolonial state forms that had characterized the earliest manifestations of the colonial state in India blended with and began to give way to more stringent and unyielding, Europeanized state forms.² My approach is influenced by these new developments, highlighting the weakness of the early colonial state on this frontier, the survival of the more dispersed, limited form of rule present in earlier times, and as a consequence the survival of many of the patterns that typically characterized borderlands in the precolonial period.

I also use this new picture of the extent to which the colonial state was presiding over borderland areas still exhibiting a great degree of continuity with the past in order to provide a deeper contextualization of the Welsh and Symes missions than what is currently available. Some good studies of these missions exist. In particular for the Welsh mission there is S. K. Bhuyan's encyclopedic *Anglo-Assamese Relations*.³ The run-up to the Symes mission is most thoroughly discussed in a chapter in a PhD thesis by G. P. Ramachandra.⁴ Both are factually dense but are essentially chronological works that do not stray far from the immediate flow of events. My own approach is to build a bottom-up causal model to understand the genesis and course of the Symes and Welsh missions. In doing so, I stress the importance of the 'pull' effect of frontiers in spurring the growth of the EIC's behemoth but discombobulated state, which according to David

Sanghamitra Misra, 'Changing Frontiers and Spaces,' *Studies in History*, 21:2 (2005), pp. 215-246; David Vumlallian Zou and M. Satish Kumar, 'Mapping a Colonial Borderland: Objectifying the Geo-Body of India's Northeast,' *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 70:1 (2011), pp. 141-170; Pum Khan Pau, 'Transborder People, Connected History: Border and Relationships in the Indo-Burma Borderlands,' *Journal of Borderlands Studies*, 35:4 (2018), pp. 619-639; Sanjib Baruah, 'Territoriality, Indigeneity and Rights in the North-East India,' *Economic and Political Weekly*, 43:12/13 (2008), pp. 15-19; Gunnel Cederlof, *Founding an Empire on India's North-Eastern Frontiers, 1790-1840: Climate, Commerce, Polity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2013); David Ludden, 'The First Boundary of Bangladesh on Sylhet's Northern Frontiers,' *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bangladesh*, 48:1 (2003), pp. 1-54; Sanghamitra Misra, 'The Sovereignty of Political Economy: The Garos in a Pre-Conquest and Early Conquest Era,' *The Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 55:3 (2018), pp. 345-387.

² The contributions and bibliographical essays in Peter Marshall, *The Eighteenth Century in Indian History: Evolution or Revolution?* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2003) contain an extensive catalog of arguments along these lines.

³ S. K. Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations, 1771-1826* (Guwahati: Department of Historical and Antiquarian Studies, Government of Assam, 1949); also of note is Kar, 'Welsh's Fallacy,' which does much to illuminate what was happening on the other side of the border before the intervention.

⁴ G. P. Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1795-1826,' (PhD Thesis, University of Hull, 1977), pp. 11-41. The context behind the mission is also discussed much more briefly in Maung Htin Aung, *The Stricken Peacock: Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1752-1948* (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1965), pp. 17-19 and Dorothy Woodman, *The Making of Burma* (London: Cresset Press, 1962), pp. 45-60.

Ludden, “never articulated a centralized process of imperial fusion,” and yet grew continuously due to localized activity not under central control.⁵

The chapter is divided into two parts, dealing with Bengal’s northern and eastern frontiers in turn. I first look at what kind of administration the Company set up in Rangpur district, how it interacted with the many minor principalities to its north, lodged between it and Bhutan, Assam and Nepal, and to what extent it monopolized violence and controlled its borders. I also consider the interconnectedness of northern Bengal and Assam, showing how state breakdown there had major ripple effects across the region, attracting large numbers of bandits and mercenaries from across India, which in turn attracted the attention of the Company’s highest officials, leading to the decision to dispatch a military expedition there in order to rectify what it believed was a major gap in its projection of sovereignty. On the Chittagong frontier, I look at a complicated set of relations, dating from the Mughal period, with a constellation of minor rulers in the hill tracts to the east of the district, as well as the relationship between the Company’s weakly penetrative form of rule and its inability to secure its borders in the face of a flood of refugees from the kingdom of Arakan after its conquest by Burma. I then consider how competition over control of this vast stretch of non-state space led to a deterioration of relations between the two empires, and how the Symes embassy, as well as the simultaneous deployment of a military force to demarcate and control the border, were meant to assert control over this peripheral, contested space.

DIVIDED AND OVERLAPPING SOVEREIGNTY ON RANGPUR’S NORTHERN BORDER

In this section, I analyze the form of rule practiced by the Company in Rangpur district, immediately bordering on Assam, over the latter half of the 18th century, showing how it bore little resemblance to a modern state in its projection of sovereignty or control of borders, but rather was layered on top of patterns of overlapping and divided sovereignty and human mobility, suggesting deep continuity with the precolonial period. I consider the rudimentary system of administration the Company instituted in the district, the ways in which that system was built on Mughal-era tributary frameworks, as well as the ways in which the Company’s drive

⁵ David Ludden, ‘The Process of Empire: Frontiers and Borderlands,’ in eds. Peter Bang and C. A. Bayly, *Tributary Empires in Global History* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2011), p. 140. See also John Galbraith, ‘The “Turbulent Frontier” as a Factor in British Expansion,’ *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 2:2 (1960), pp. 150-168.

towards a more systematized revenue administration in the 1790s produced information that illuminated, for the first time, the survival of many older patterns. I then embark on a series of portraits of border states partly governed by the Company while also being simultaneously ensnared in multiple tributary relationships with surrounding states, including Bhutan and Nepal. Finally, I look at how these ambiguous sovereignty claims created a borderless space in which large numbers of refugees, bandits, and mercenaries moved from place to place largely unhindered, and in which contests for wealth and power continued to be fought, sometimes using violent force, by shifting coalitions of state and non-state actors acting largely outside Company control.

The EIC's initial footprint in Rangpur district, the northernmost district of Bengal bordering on Assam, was light. The Company had little presence there until the 1770s, and when its servants did arrive to govern, they started from zero information, building up a picture of the district's revenue history (really a political history, filled with intrigue and violent conflict) through oral interviews with officials of the previous regime.⁶ They were at first primarily concerned with taxing large landowners and control of the cloth industry around the Company's factory settlement, reflecting the relatively narrow concerns of the Company at that period.⁷ This rudimentary administration seems to have had a heavily circumscribed ecumene. It was essentially acting in a supervisory capacity, watching over the infrastructure of government that had been put in place by the nawabs to ensure that its most basic needs were met, namely the upward flow of resources and the maintenance of its own power.

During this initial period the northern fringe of Rangpur district was largely understood through the prism of Mughal-era tributary relations. It was home to a number of petty states ruled by princes of Tibeto-Burman tribal origin. The Mughals in the 17th century had established loose tributary relations with many of these princes, representing them in their records as zamindars, a general category into which many different kinds of landowners were subsumed.⁸ The early

⁶ Appendix C, 'Account of the settlement of Rungpore previously to the Bengal year 1169 given in on demand of the Collector by the canoongoe of Rungpore,' in Mr. Sisson's Report on the Condition of the Ryots, in Appendix A of Edward Glazier, *Further Notes: The Rungpore Records*, Vol. II (Calcutta: Bengal Secretariat Press, 1876).

⁷ Edward Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore* (Calcutta: Calcutta Central Press, 1873), pp. 16-20.

⁸ My understanding of this system is coming from John F. Richards, *The Mughal Empire* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993). A more in depth look at the relationship between the Mughals and these Koch rajas is in

Company administration in Rangpur relied on Mughal records, and on Mughal-trained officials literate in Persian, to perform the business of governance, and as such, when these princes are mentioned at all in early records, it tends to be in the context of Mughal-era tribute quotas. In these documents, there is little recognition of their ethnic difference, or of their sovereign status, merely of a one-dimensional economic relation.⁹

Some level of increased definition regarding patterns of frontier landownership came into view with the permanent settlement. As the author of a mid-19th century history of Rangpur district put it, efforts to fix in place a regularized system of revenue extraction led to the discovery that the term zamindar was:

...a very wide one, including different classes of owners, the origin of whose rights was very various. Thus, in Rungpore, we have what, for want of better terms, may be styled the semi-feudatory estates, such as Bykuntpore and the Chaklas, held by the Rajah of Cooch Behar; the sub-feudatory of the rest of Coochwara, held by descendants of Cooch Behar officers, who had a century before been inducted by the Moguls into their estates as zemindars; the new purchasers, such as Baharbund and Sorooppore, who could pretend to no rights beyond any limitations the Government might have chosen to have entered in their deeds of possession; the large zemindars, owners of what had been principalities, such as Edrakpore and Dinagepore; and lastly, the smaller ones, which were generally holders of talooks, which had been separate from the larger estates.¹⁰

This layered system of settlements, each with differing tenury rights, was the result of multiple conquests stacked on top of each other, of which the Company's was only the latest. The earliest layer was made up of the fragments of the Koch state, which had been carved out of the local tribal population through processes of ethnic melding, sedentarization, Hinduization and the establishment of interrelated aristocratic lineages controlling a variety of settlements which were

Richard Eaton, *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier, 1204-1760* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1993), pp. 186-93.

⁹ An example is a list of elephants to be delivered in tribute from Koch rajas along the border, who are not recognized as such but instead simply referred to as zamindars by 'Boolchund, Canoongol of Rangamatty,' the official in charge of tribute collection, whose name is signed at the bottom of the document. The officer, as well as the tributary relationship he oversaw, were both of Mughal origin. Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, pp. 66-7.

¹⁰ Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, p. 36.

linked together in hierarchical political relations. Koch Behar's three larger neighbors in Assam, Bhutan and Mughal Bengal had all successively launched invasions of the area, eating away at the integrity of those political relationships and eventually unwinding them completely, so that by the late 18th century, Koch rajas were no longer strongly connected to each other, but rather had been incorporated into the political systems of these other states as isolated clients.¹¹

Scattered among these rested another strata of zamindars that had overseen the process of Mughal colonization of the region; these had significant independent power themselves, often sitting at the center of networks of lesser landholders. The most recent layer was made up of revenue farmers appointed by the Company, who were state functionaries with no independent rights.

The permanent settlement only brought some of these Koch rajas into more definite relationships with the government; others continued to exist only half within the Company's domains at least until the early 19th century. The revenues of estates that had formerly paid regularized land taxes to the Mughals were fixed in place, but distant peripheral states that had only loosely been incorporated into the Mughal system, and who paid tribute in kind or nothing at all, were left out. This jagged, fragmented collection of principalities remained in a state of sovereign limbo for decades. Because of this, as the author of an internal report on affairs in the district in the 1810s wrote, the shape of the district was so "exceedingly irregular and staggering as to bid defiance to all verbal description," which he explained was due to the fact that it lacked any natural boundaries in mountains or rivers, and bordered on five different political entities – the Garo hills, Nepal, Sikkim, Koch Behar and Bhutan, all of which were engaged in vigorous diplomatic and military contestation over control of resources and people along the border.¹² Or as turn-of-the-century geographer Walter Hamilton put it:

¹¹ Tribal state formation is covered from a theoretical perspective (the authors do not cover the Koch, but they are analogous to many of the other case studies from northeast India in the book) in Surajit Sinha, *Tribal Politics and State Systems in Pre-Colonial Eastern and North Eastern India* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1987). A political history of early modern Koch Bihar, drawn from chronicle sources, can be found in H. K. Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 2 (Guwahati: Publication Board Assam, 2007) chs. 4, 5, 6. For the political history of how these states came to be partly governed by the Company, see Nirode Kumar Barooah, *David Scott in Northeast India 1802-1831, A Study in British Paternalism* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1970), pp. 22-37 and A. R. Field, 'A Note Concerning Early Anglo-Bhutanese Relations,' *East and West*, 13:4 (1962), pp. 340-345.

¹² IOR/F/4/533/12847, Extract Bengal Judicial Consultations, August 19th, 1815.

The present possessions of Bootan to the south-west are separated from the Bengal districts by the river Teesta, as far south as Gopaulgunge...To the south of this point the British territories cross the Teesta, and intermix with those of Bootan in a most irregular manner, the line of boundary in this quarter being altogether imaginary. Portions of territory belonging to each state are completely insulated by the possessions of the other, as exemplified in the extensive tract named Phulacotta, which lies to the west of the Teesta, and is completely surrounded by the Bengalese zemindary of Bykantpoor, without any intelligible or even perceptible land marks. The retention of Phulacotta, however, is attended with such lucrative advantages to the Subah of Dellamcotta and the local officers (the closest Bhutanese marcher lord and his retinue), that no hopes are entertained of being able to effect its purchase or exchange for some other space of adequate value.¹³

The dynamic and ambiguous state of these sovereignty relationships stemmed from a number of rival claims being made over them by the Company and by Bhutan and Nepal, both of which operated smaller but locally important imperial systems in the trans-Himalayan region. Many of them stemmed from a 1772 war in which the Bhutanese had invaded and conquered Coch Behar and many of its associated principalities. The Coch raja petitioned the Company for aid, which resulted in a counteroffensive that pushed the Bhutanese army back into the mountains. Coch Behar was thereafter under nominal Company authority, but the war did not produce any conclusive territorial boundary. Rather, the whole line of frontier, Hamilton wrote, was subject to regular "encroachment" by the Bhutanese, who had annexed multiple minor states nominally under the control of the Company.

One focal point of these rival sovereignty claims was the minor Koch principality of Bidyagong, which had been wrested away from the Company's control by Bhutan. According to Hamilton: "The Bidyagong estate was originally obliged to deliver annually 40 elephants to the British government, which last as the feudal superior had the sole right of nominating to the succession. It is true that the Bidyagong chief gave the Bootanners, yearly, about 400 rupees worth of cotton cloths and dried fish, but this was done merely to conciliate the good will of a tribe, which, from

¹³ Walter Hamilton, *A Geographical, Statistical and Historical Description of Hindostan, and the Adjacent countries*, Vol. II (London: John Murray, 1820), pp. 733-4.

its position, was always able to harass his estate." When the Bhutanese penetrated into Bidyagong and reoriented it towards them, the EIC did nothing, as it was of "trivial importance." When the Company did protest in correspondence with the ruler of Bhutan, arguing that he needed documentary evidence of his right to the territory in order to take control of it, the reply came that "it was not customary for the Bootanners to be regulated by writings but by possession" – a rejection of the whole framework of static, rule-bound and paper-based governance practiced by the Company.

Another example of the EIC's engagement in these kinds of indeterminate sovereignty relationships includes Bykuntpore, another Koch statelet, whose territories were "indented," as Francis Sisson, a surveyor of the area wrote, with villages controlled by Bhutan. The Bykuntpore raja controlled estates entirely within Bhutanese territory, and Bhutan controlled the estate of Phulacotta, fully enclosed on all sides by Bykuntpore. On his questioning local people as to the whereabouts of the boundary, they pointed to seemingly random features, which he could not make sense of, leading him to conclude that it existed only in the "fertility of imagination." His poring over earlier Company records suggested to him a reason for this: that after the Company's 1770s war with Bhutan, both had agreed in the peace treaty to restore the region to its former state and give up all conquered possessions, but the Bhutanese had successfully represented many of its new acquisitions as customarily under its control, which the Company turned a blind eye to as part of a pivot to courting the Bhutan government in the hopes that it could link Bengal to Tibet through Bhutan's trade routes.¹⁴

Nor did Bykuntpore have a proper boundary with Sikkim or Nepal. Sisson described the boundary as demarcated by a river only part ways, after which it cut through open country where it existed only in the minds of local inhabitants, then into jungle where even local inhabitants ventured no guesses. The Bykuntpore raja, he said, laid claim to all the forests and wilds up to the hills, while the Nepali authorities controlled Sikkim, and through Sikkim, laid claim to all the forests down to its southernmost reaches – the Sikkim moroung or terai, or adjacent lowlands. He reconciled these two incompatible claims by reasoning that likely the Nepalese were making the aggressive moves, and that the older claim was probably Bykuntpore's, as the raja's family

¹⁴ IOR/F/4/533/12847, Extract Bengal Judicial Consultations, August 19th, 1815.

once resided in the middle of the forest, but had since moved southward to avoid the Gurkhas; but he cautioned that this was speculation, and that likely the tract had frequently changed hands depending on which claimants were strongest at any given time.

Another Koch state under shared sovereignty was Bijnee, which remained largely unknown to the Company until a political event brought it sharply into focus. Hamilton explained this dearth of information as having arisen from the loose and extractive form of governance practiced by the early Company. "In consequence of their remote situation," he wrote, "and the general wildness of the country, the history of the Estates in this quarter was long but imperfectly known, even to the public functionaries at Rungpoor, and so long as the Bijnee Raja paid the customary tribute, no inquiry was made as to the state of the country, or even to ascertain the original nature of his connection with the Mogul Emperor, to whose authority the British government had succeeded."¹⁵

The government in Calcutta only began to pay attention to Bijnee after its raja was kidnapped and murdered, which embroiled the EIC in a conflict with Bhutan over who had the right to install the next one. The Bhutanese acted first, appointing a new raja who, with the aid of his patrons, gathered an army and militarily occupied the territory.¹⁶ The Bhutanese position on this conflict was outlined in a letter written by the marcher lord overseeing it. He wrote that the Bhutanese considered themselves the lords of Bijnee on equal status with the Company, and that the two were supposed to share the duties of arbitrating justice there. He believed the Company had failed in this, either ordering the kidnapping of the raja and the theft of his property or protecting those who had done so. He demanded that the raja and his treasure be returned, or he would sweep down into the plains, plundering the zamindars and taking captives. "Whether I can convey them or not to the hills you shall afterwards see," the letter concludes pointedly.¹⁷

Only after the receipt of this somewhat ominous reproach did the Company begin to make a serious inquiry into Bijnee, which found that the principality had long been subject to two masters, simultaneously paying tribute both to the Company and to Bhutan. It had a fixed, two-

¹⁵ Hamilton, *A Geographical, Statistical and Historical Description of Hindostan*, Vol II, p. 753.

¹⁶ This political history is related in the Sisson report as well as in Hamilton, *A Geographical, Statistical and Historical Description of Hindostan*, Vol II, pp. 753-6, and Walter Hamilton, *The East-India Gazetteer*, Vol. I (London: Parbury, Allen, and Co., 1828), pp. 241-4.

¹⁷ Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, pp. 93-4.

way trade with its northern suzerain, which provided horses and salt in return for a much larger annual shipment of cloth, cotton, silver and other articles. The results of these inquiries also peeled back the veil on the Company's long participation in the snarled tangle of sovereignty arrangements prevailing in Bijnee. On the south side of the river, the Bijnee raja fell under the umbrella of Company sovereignty. In his capacity as a Bhutanese official on the northern side of the river, he ruled in concert with the Bhutanese state, referring high criminal cases to its representatives for approval and paying annual tribute. The main settlement, crowned by the raja's fortress, was a kind of "neutral ground," Hamilton wrote, "so that although he has a guard of Bootanners, and also some sepoy, whom he probably represents as belonging to the English, the officers of neither government interfere at Bijnee, where he is said to harbour many suspicious characters, and even to participate in their plunder."¹⁸ The Company unilaterally determined that the right of appointing who the next raja would be belonged to them. In what was likely an attempt at conciliation, however, it also conveniently announced that the Bhutanese candidate was in fact the best one, retroactively confirming him in an office he had already seized by force.

The disintegration of political authority in Assam had a major impact on the social life of Bijnee, which was flooded by refugees. These had significantly swelled its population, and lived lives on both sides of the river, maintaining cultivation in areas previously governed by Assam, but keeping their families on the Company side because it was less dangerous.¹⁹ These peasants were well-adapted to protecting themselves in an insecure space. They were only intermittently sedentary, moving from place to place to avoid roving armies, bands of decommissioned soldiers and thieves. The raja and his servants, afraid of losing the tax wealth they represented, were suspected of employing coercive methods to keep them in reach.

The anomalous status of Bijnee also seems to have attracted a variety of people who had an interest in keeping themselves out of the reach of neighboring states. Bandits and mercenaries, seeking opportunity in the political vacuum caused by state breakdown Assam, frequently moved

¹⁸ Hamilton, *A Geographical, Statistical and Historical Description of Hindostan*, Vol II, p. 754.

¹⁹ Buchanan describes how this was the situation all across the border between Assam and Bengal. Francis Buchanan, *An Account of Assam: First Compiled in 1807-1814* (Guwahati: Powershift in Association with Faculty Books, 2017), pp. 35-6.

through the principality.²⁰ The activities of these figures occupied a vague space between the realms of criminality and politics. One was Gholam Ali Beg, a Muslim mercenary from north India who had been employed by the Assamese to fight the Moamarias. On refusing to take a pay cut and being summarily dismissed without payment, he and his band of followers turned to banditry, taking up residence in Bijnee, raiding into both Assam and Bengal, plundering merchant vessels on the Brahmaputra, and attacking and looting customs posts which were filled with so much treasure that even his foot soldiers became rich; twelve of them were arrested in EIC domains carrying thousands of rupees. He acquired a "kind of sovereignty over 16 villages, on the eastern bank of the Manas, from which he received a large revenue, readily paid by the inhabitants for protection; but he was at length vanquished by another body of freebooters, led by a Hindustani Rajpoot, named Manick Ray," who drove him into Bhutan and took over his hideout.

The activities of Manick Ray also bled into regional politics. From the roost he had seized from his predecessor, he plundered trade caravans and raided surrounding areas with relative impunity. EIC sepoy were forbidden from crossing borders to arrest him, and the Bijnee raja was suspected of concealing his activities in return for a cut of his profits. Ray was accused of engaging in a kind of micro-imperialism by the king of Assam, who wrote a letter to the Company claiming that he could not repay his debts to European merchants across the border because: "From the eastward and northward the people of Nura, Khamti, Dopla, and Mahamari, had assembled and invaded his dominions; while on the Bijnee frontier, a robber, named Manick Ray, had made repeated inroads, laid waste three pergunnahs, and plundered the custom-house of Kandar." Both Ray and his predecessor were also courted by an Ahom prince, Brajanath, an exiled claimant to the throne, who hoped to use their forces to spearhead an attempt to gain power, though the opposite seems to have happened, in that Brajanath's followers melted away to join the bandits.²¹

²⁰ Hamilton, *The East-India Gazetteer*, Vol. I, p. 77. Much of Hamilton's information seems to have been based on Sisson's original report. Sisson, who was in charge of the police in Rangpur district, included his descriptions of these bandits in the Assam section of his report because they primarily operated there, though they were based in Bijnee. IOR/F/4/533/12847, Extract Bengal Judicial Consultations, August 19th, 1815.

²¹ IOR/F/4/533/12847, Extract Bengal Judicial Consultations, August 19th, 1815.

The Company's relationship to Bijnee underscores its continued participation in pre-colonial patterns of frontier governance all across Rangpur district in the late 18th and early 19th centuries. Its footprint in the region was extremely light and oriented towards loose, high-level political control in the service of resource extraction from layers of intermediary rulers. The district effectively had no border but instead was home to a fragmentary group of Koch principalities over which multiple neighboring states made a variety of overlapping and contested claims to sovereignty and resource rights, and through which people and goods flowed largely unrestricted. These patterns in turn combined to create an ambiguous space that became a hub for refugees, bandits, and mercenaries, who themselves engaged in political contestation, further fragmenting sovereignty relationships in the region. In the next section, I outline how this interconnected set of border states, caught between multiple larger neighbors who exercised fluctuating power over them, combined with flows of armed men from all over northern India to present a serious quandary for Company officials, who wanted their domains to be tranquil, economically productive, and organized along easily comprehensible lines.

LAWLESSNESS AND MINOR KINGSHIP IN RANGPUR DISTRICT

In this section, I sketch out the inability of the EIC to monopolize violence in Rangpur district, a situation that persisted until at least the first quarter of the 19th century. I outline a brief history of policing in the district, showing how, at first, there had been no police force at all, with the Company relying instead on the efforts of local zamindars to maintain order. Escalating rural violence in the 1790s, however, forced the Company to intervene, leading to the creation of a small and largely ineffective police force that was perceived by Company officials as corrupt. This force was outmatched by wandering mercenaries, Sufi pilgrims turned rebels, and bandits from nearby states, many of whom were armed and organized on a large scale. I describe the scope of this lawlessness and the extent to which it was intertwined with legitimate local power holders, as well as how it served as the main labor pool that the EIC itself drew from in its recruitment of soldiers in the region. I then focus on the frontier town of Goalpara, on the border with Assam, showing not only how it served as a congregation point for refugees fleeing the Assam conflict and mercenaries marching toward it, but also detailing the extent to which the Company had difficulty establishing regular control over the town's private European merchant community and even its own local officials.

For decades after the Company's ascent to power in Bengal, it operated no police force at all, though in the last decade of the 18th century it was forced to step in in order to protect the upward flow of revenue against a deteriorating situation in the countryside. In Rangpur district, police duties were at first undertaken by local potentates, who employed guards at markets to collect duties and arrest thieves as they had done under the previous regime; the EIC's actions in this regard were limited to posting bounties on the heads of major bandit leaders and tracking them down with army contingents. By the 1790s, the erosion of traditional sources of authority, hastened by the "predatory phase of colonial rule," had combined with agrarian crisis to produce rural violence (both banditry and explicitly anti-state rebellion) on such a large scale that the Company was forced to step in, both to assert a right to a monopoly of force and to ensure that revenue flows were not impacted.²²

Rangpur district, which had been the site of a major peasant uprising,²³ was one of the focal points of this effort, though it seems to have been largely unsuccessful, one mid-19th century chronicler describing it as "splendid but utopian," before going on to describe various instances of corruption, incompetence, stonewalling of investigations, insurrection and mob justice, besides accusing the police of primarily focusing on protecting the rich and ignoring the rest of the population.²⁴ Reports on the state of policing in the district, compiled in 1814 and 15, shed some light on the reasons why: the district had dispersed settlement patterns, making individual homesteads vulnerable to attack; there was a prevalence of wilderness for bandits to hide in; internal boundaries within the district made little sense and the jurisdictions of various forces were unclear; and lack of borders and proximity to multiple adjacent states allowed fugitives to slip out of reach at will.²⁵

The reports also suggested deeply ingrained corruption among the local police, most of whom were from other parts of India and were suspected of having little connection to or sympathy for

²² Basudev Chatterji, 'The Darogah and the Countryside: The Imposition of Police Control in Bengal and its Impact (1793—1837),' *The Indian Economic & Social History Review*, 18:1 (1981), pp. 19-26.

²³ Jon E. Wilson, "'A Thousand Countries to Go to': Peasants and Rulers in Late Eighteenth-Century Bengal," *Past & Present*, 189:1 (2005), pp. 81-109.

²⁴ Glazier, *Further Notes: The Rungpore Records*, Vol. II, pp. 3-5.

²⁵ Thomas Sisson wrote a number of lengthy and insightful reports on the state of the police in Rangpur district. Two of them are appended in Glazier, *Further Notes: The Rungpore Records*, Vol. II. A third, which discusses among other things police corruption, has already been referenced. IOR/F/4/533/12847, Extract Bengal Judicial Consultations, August 19th, 1815.

local people. Such police, according to Sisson, could not be disciplined as they were posted far away from their commanders, and were accused of being slow to take action, loaning money to local people at usurious rates and violently recouping debts, falsifying crimes in order to collect bribes (including allegedly treating suicides as murders in order to force bereaved family members to cough up money) and engaging in outright banditry, intimidating entire villages into submission by demanding payments while drawn up in full battle formation. Sisson concluded that local people avoided the police at all costs, that they were the “scourges of the districts” they worked in, and that the system as it stood should be totally scrapped and replaced with a more localized one in which villages levied their own police.

Lawlessness in Rangpur district was so advanced that large caravans of wandering armed groups travelled through it, replete with pack animals, elephants, horses and heavy weaponry in tow like rockets and cannons, making them a formidable military threat.²⁶ These were often men of military caste from the Gangetic plain, or Afghans; both could be found dispersed throughout north India in the 18th century, where they frequently founded petty principalities, served as mercenaries or turned to robbery – all professions of the gun.²⁷ Networks of Sufi pilgrims, cut off from their previous sources of income by restrictions imposed by the Company, were also active in the area, where they engaged in attacks on the Company, local zamindars, and the population at large.²⁸ Added to this were marauders based in the highlands of Nepal and Bhutan, some of whom were part of clan groups that were known locally for engaging in a plundering lifestyle – these became designated as ‘criminal tribes’ under the regime of caste classification that took shape in the later 19th century. One tribe, a “thieving gang, called Kichaks or Godemars...generally looked upon as gipsies, who snared game, told fortunes, and stole as they had opportunity,” sometimes appeared on the plains in the thousands, looting zamindari estates, at one point stealing the tribute the Koch Behar raja meant to deliver to the EIC.²⁹

²⁶ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 277-9.

²⁷ Some discussion of these groups, who controlled many portions of north India, existing within and between more traditional states, is found in the introduction to C. A. Bayly, *Rulers, Townsmen and Bazaars: North Indian Society in the Age of British Expansion 1770-1870* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2012).

²⁸ Ananda Bhattacharyya, 'The Wandering Fakirs of Bengal: Heroes or Villains?,' *South Asia Research*, 36:1 (2016), pp. 1-23.

²⁹ Glazier, *Further Notes: The Rungpore Records*, Vol. II, pp. 5-6.

A good example of the extent of the problem is that of two brothers, Sonkar and Mohuntram, who were born in Rangpur but raided from hideouts in both Nepal and Bhutan. They were allies of both the Nepalese and Bhutanese border authorities, who afforded them protection (they lived openly in villages just across the border, in plain sight of Company police outposts) in exchange for a cut of their booty. These two men were part of a wider crime wave which tripled instances of robbery in the district, which the Company got hold of by arresting hundreds of people in 1808, but their mountain hideouts made them impervious to this effort. They held out until 1811, together accounting for half the banditry in the district and a number of murders, until they were arrested by police who had to enter Nepal, almost triggering a war (even after their capture, they were difficult to convict, reportedly bribing and intimidating witnesses).³⁰

Association between these gangs and recognized power-holders was common – armed bandits easily doubled as mercenaries or bodyguards, forming a shadowy underworld to local politics.³¹ Bandits were known to forge alliances with powerful landowning patrons who thought they could gain from retaining them (though they were also known to kidnap zamindars and hold them for ransom as well). In some cases such figures, referred to as gunmen or ‘burkunadzes’ in colonial records, had pretensions to legitimate political power, transitioning from plundering to taxation and endeavoring to set themselves up as minor rajas. In other cases landholders abandoned their estates and took to a nomadic, plundering lifestyle, making the line between bandit and landlord unclear.

Such figures also regularly appeared on the Company's payroll. For example in 1789 an EIC officer tracking a group of bandits through a forest on the district's northern border (they maintained over twenty garrisons therein, and were well-armed and organized, suggesting that they were possibly a rogue mercenary battalion) reported moving through the forest and fighting several actions, but that the bandits eventually escaped to Nepal and Bhutan, though he managed to capture their leader. His troops were several hundred burkunadzes, mercenaries of the same sort as the men he was hunting.³² The Company used burkunadzes in many other capacities, including for border defense and as bodyguards for merchant trains moving up into war-torn

³⁰ Glazier, *Further Notes: The Rungpore Records*, Vol. II, pp. 8-9.

³¹ Much of the following is drawn from Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, pp. 41-3.

³² Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, p. 42.

Assam. Many were also veterans of the Company's regular sepoy army – some had been officers in it, and could be found drilling private militias after the fashion of the Company across northeast India (the Company was also perennially worried about rumors that they were dressing and presenting themselves as actual Company soldiers).³³ This was a military market that seamlessly blended into a criminal underworld, and the early Company was one of its principal patrons.

One of the most difficult parts of the Rangpur frontier was in the vicinity of Goalpara, a frontier town that served as the main point of contact with Assam. Goalpara was the conduit for the northward movement of large numbers of wandering hired guns, who were drawn in by the collapse of the Ahom state and its downward spiral into a long, multi-sided war in which mercenaries played an increasingly large role as the kingdom's traditional system of levying conscripts broke down.³⁴ Moving in the other direction were large numbers of refugees fleeing Assam, who settled in Goalpara district, bringing with them their political struggles. Among these refugees were exiled Ahom nobles who brought small armies of retainers with them, bought up weapons in the district, hired more gunmen and crossed back into Assam to continue the fight – actions which the Company sometimes tried to stamp out, and sometimes fostered if it thought that certain figures had a chance of prevailing in the war and becoming clients.³⁵

Goalpara was home to a small European merchant community, among whom the highest prize was achieving a monopoly over the salt trade to Assam, which for many years was in government hands; in the 1790s the government had relinquished its monopoly, leaving the arena open for others to step in. These merchants behaved in many respects like bandit princes themselves. They employed armed retainers, and were known to use intimidation and violence to recoup their losses. Some were vastly wealthy, building large estates and serving as moneylenders, including to aristocratic clients across the border in Assam, who were eager for

³³ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, chs. VI, VII, VIII.

³⁴ Buchanan describes the breakdown of the traditional system of levying conscripts and relays that the king of Assam employed a large West Indian mercenary battalion who had married local wives and been settled on the land. Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 22-3.

³⁵ A fine-grained account of the history of diplomatic relations between the Company and Ahom aristocrats before and after the Welsh expedition is in Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, chs. VI, VIII.

financing so they could stay in the fight.³⁶ These merchants were reportedly organized into competing factions, complete with flags and factories; some of these factions were suspected of fraudulently representing themselves as operating under the auspices of the Company. In concert with Ahom customs agents across the border, who operated their own monopolies in exchange for passing a cut to the king, cartels on both sides of the border reportedly wielded their power to keep "in awe both the Bengalese and Assamese merchants. The former were only permitted to supply them with what goods they wanted, and to purchase through their hands...Both parties had then very large profits."³⁷

The most notorious of these armed merchants was a German named Daniel Rausch, who employed a private band of Portuguese mestizo mercenaries.³⁸ He had come under the scrutiny of local officials on multiple occasions for his private use of force – there are accusations on record of him at one point invading Assam, taking an Ahom noble who owed him money prisoner, and killing and plundering at will. He achieved, allegedly through coercion, a private monopoly over all trade in and out of Assam, forcing the king's customs agents at the border to sign a written agreement to that effect while they were surrounded by his armed guards. Through such actions he not only made a fortune but also became a major player in local politics.³⁹ His influence in the kingdom was so great that he became the main channel through which the Company conducted diplomacy, deploying him as a messenger and negotiator – at least until he was murdered in Assam, reportedly at the head of a mercenary band he had led into the kingdom to force the repayment of debts. Ahom aristocrats owed him so much money that the Company spent decades after his death trying to recoup their unpaid debts – an important focal point of later treaty negotiations with the king.⁴⁰

³⁶ The outsized importance of the salt trade in the earliest period of Company rule in Goalpara, as well as the misdeeds of early Company officials and private merchants in the region, are discussed at length in Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, chs. II, III, IV. They are also mentioned in Glazier, *A Report on the District of Rungpore*, pp. 52-3.

³⁷ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 42-45.

³⁸ Montgomery Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3 (London: W. H. Allen and Co., 1838), p. 566.

³⁹ IOR/P/114/57, March 16th, 1792, Nos. 10, 11, 12; see also IOR /P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 15 for a report by Welsh on the economy of Assam and the way in which Rausch had gotten a stranglehold of all trade in and out of it through borderline criminal means.

⁴⁰ Rausch's life in Assam after the Welsh expedition is discussed in Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, ch. VIII.

The small number of Company officials stationed in this lonely town behaved in a manner not wholly different from that of Rausch or other adventurers like him. These officials led bifurcated lives, representing the interests of the Company while simultaneously trying to amass private fortunes, often through surreptitious means. This pattern is best exemplified by the first resident, Hugh Baillie, who convinced the Company to give him a legal trade monopoly over salt. He was accused of coercion and corruption by his own colleagues. After discovering that he was employing burkunadzes, ostensibly on the Company's payroll, to intimidate the Bijnee raja into giving him personal trade concessions, the collector of Rangpur, Richard Goodlad, wrote to him: "I do declare to you that I am so convinced of the injustice and cruelty of the monopoly you are aiming at to the utter ruin of numberless native merchants...that even if the Rajah had given you his consent I would not have admitted of it taking place. Much less will I suffer it when you forcibly attempt to possess yourself of it."⁴¹ Baillie's self-interested and summary style of government created a number of personal grudges with zamindars in the district, which ended in a violent showdown in which he employed large bands of burkenadzes in a battle with the raja of the border estate of Mechpara, who, paradoxically, fought with decommissioned Company sepoy. Baillie's battle with the man ended with the town of Goalpara being burned to the ground. Afterward he determined it too dangerous to try to disband the mercenary force he had assembled, so he gave it permission to cross the border into Assam. The Company, rather than replacing him, abolished his post completely.⁴²

The line between legitimate and illegitimate use of force for political and economic ends was murky in late 18th century Rangpur. The Company was far from being in the possession of a monopoly of violence in the district. It operated an inefficient and corrupt police force, and even its own officials were suspected of misusing their political power for private gain. As a result, private European merchants and indigenous elites at the middle level continued to engage in warlike political contestation. Additionally, a thriving mercenary market had cropped up to serve not only these intermediate actors, but also the Company, which relied on the exact same groups to enforce its will at the local level. Mercenary bands were also engaged in banditry, not only in Bengal but also in surrounding states, especially Assam, which had long been subject to

⁴¹ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 141-3.

⁴² Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 179-182.

centrifugal pressures from civil conflict. Over the course of the late 18th and early 19th centuries, the Company devoted a large amount of effort to truncating these patterns, which were a legacy of the diffuse nature of power in pre-colonial India.⁴³ In the next section I describe the immediate background behind the military expedition to Assam led by Thomas Welsh in 1792, one of the first of many efforts that would be made by the Company to rein in the free exercise of power by intermediary and non-state actors and arrogate unto itself sole executive authority over Bengal.

MERCENARY FLOWS AND POWER STRUGGLES ON THE GOALPARA FRONTIER

In this section, I consider the immediate context behind the Welsh mission, which arose from contests for wealth and power among local actors that had long been taking place outside the Company's field of vision, and which the Company was desirous of clamping down on. The primary actor here was the raja of the minor Koch state of Derrung, simultaneously beholden to both the Company and Assam, who was in open rebellion against the Ahom monarch and solicited the Company's support for his cause. He failed to secure it, turning instead to the private merchant Daniel Rausch, who helped him finance the raising of a large mercenary army. Rausch's role in the dispute between the raja and his king, combined with longstanding conflicts between him and customs agents along the border and Goalpara's Greek merchant community, led to a flood of petitions against him. These petitions triggered an investigation that uncovered a hotly contested world of factional politics allegedly marked by kidnapping, plundering, and the use of intimidation to establish illegal private monopolies. In order to recoup his debts, Rausch later became ensconced in the court of the flagging Ahom monarch, who was under serious threat of being overwhelmed by the Derrung raja's mercenary army, which seems to have broken free of the raja's control and begun acting in its own independent interests. The Ahom raja, with Rausch acting as his broker, petitioned the Company to take military action against this mercenary force, which had swollen to several thousand and was reportedly terrorizing the countryside. The captains of this rogue mercenary battalion refused to heed the Company's warnings to disband, insisting that it had no authority over their actions outside of Bengal, which

⁴³ See Peter Marshall, *Bengal – the British Bridgehead, Eastern India, 1740-1828* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), esp. chs. 4, 5.

the Company perceived as a threat to its sovereignty claims over the region, leading to the dispatch of the Welsh expedition to forcibly break it up.

In 1791 and early 1792, a series of petitions were taken down by authorities in Goalpara, which alerted the central government in Calcutta to a shadowy world of factional conflict that had been taking place locally without its knowledge. The first of these petitions was from the Derrung raja Krishnarayan. He was a teenage boy whose father had rebelled against the Ahom king and lost his life, after which the king attempted to transfer control of the principality to a minor branch of the family. The boy, aided by his father's former allies, as well as European private merchants based in Goalpara, in particular Daniel Rausch, continued his father's rebellion. In his petitions, he solicited the Company's aid, claiming that his forefathers had ruled not only over Derrung but also over a large chunk of the adjacent region, which had in ancient times formed the kingdom of Kamrup. He asked for military support in his quest to resurrect the kingdom, and offered to rule it in the name of the Company, paying a large annual tribute in exchange. He was denied, but the Company also expressed neutrality at his desire to take matters into his own hands, allowing him to gather together a large mercenary force from Rangpur, which he marched into Derrung. Successful in his initial goal, he transformed his campaign into one of conquest, forging deep into Assam and occupying the city of Guwahati, the former capital of Kamrup.⁴⁴

At this point, another group of petitioners appeared in Goalpara, all with complaints targeted at Rausch. One group of complaints, made by customs agents operating at the Assam border on behalf of the king, accused Rausch of kidnapping an Ahom aristocrat, as well as his family, holding them hostage, and stealing 60,000 rupees worth of goods from them, as well as engaging in a variety of other coercive business practices such as forcing them to enter into a monopoly agreement with him while surrounded by his armed guards.⁴⁵ Another petition, by two Ahom aristocrats, accused Rausch of heading a large band of mercenaries in a plundering expedition into Assam, supported by 60 Company sepoy and the Company's own military commander stationed at Jugighopa, on the border. It asked the government if they had ordered this.⁴⁶ A third, made by a vakeel on behalf of the Derrung raja, accused Rausch of forcing him to travel with

⁴⁴ Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 2, pp. 295-99; Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 258-80.

⁴⁵ IOR/P/114/57, March 16th, 1792, Nos. 10, 11.

⁴⁶ IOR/P/114/57, March 16th, 1792, No 12.

him to Bengal and holding him there against his will, while simultaneously promising to make him ruler of the whole of Kamrup, after which he escaped and began to collect a mercenary force; it ends with a final plea for support.⁴⁷

The Company ordered an investigation into these complaints, with inconclusive results. The Dooariah of Sonapore, whom Rausch was accused of kidnapping, said Rausch was his friend and ally, that he had gone willingly with him to Bengal, and that his real enemies were in the Ahom government. He begged not to be sent back, or he and his family would be killed.⁴⁸ Answers by European officials stationed in the district all pointed in the same direction: that the only significant body of mercenaries in the area was operating under the raja of Derrung, and that they had taken some limited military actions using local troops at their disposal, but only in an attempt to disperse them.⁴⁹ Rausch himself answered the accusations against him in a less than circumspect manner, denying everything and accusing his enemies, a group of Greek merchants angling to displace him, of conspiring with the Assamese to invent all the charges against him.⁵⁰

This is a thick maze of claims and counterclaims, but can be explained by unraveling them into two threads. The first is that Rausch, sensing an opportunity to play kingmaker, had helped Krishnarayan to assemble his mercenary force, and perhaps accompanied its early forays into Assam, while at the same time trying to control him, leading to a falling out between the two; the raja of Derrung's petition seems to have stemmed from this soured alliance. The second is that Rausch's involvement in the rebellion also earned him the enmity of Ahom government officials, which joined together with long-standing conflict between him and agents along the border as well as a faction of Greek merchants who were locked in struggles with him over debt payments and control of trade.⁵¹ Subsequent interrogations of Greek merchants active in Goalpara and scrutiny of their seized correspondence revealed that this network of Rausch's detractors submitted their positions at the same time as part of a coordinated plot designed to destroy his influence over trade and politics in the kingdom, so that the Greek merchants could take over his

⁴⁷ IOR/P/114/58, June 8th, 1792, No. 9.

⁴⁸ IOR/P/114/57, March 16th, 1792, No. 13.

⁴⁹ IOR/P/114/57, March 16th, 1792, No. 14; IOR/P/114/57, April 27th, 1792, No. 21.

⁵⁰ IOR/P/114/57, April 27th, 1792, No. 22.

⁵¹ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 293-300.

business interests, Assamese merchants and officials could expunge their debts, and he could no longer aid Krishnarayan's rebellion.⁵²

In the next round of correspondence, however, Rausch suddenly appears as a supporter of the Ahom government against Krishnarayan and his rebels, revealing that he had switched sides for financial reasons – and that the Derrung raja and his mercenaries were the primary obstacle between him and his new goal, which was to recoup his debts from Ahom aristocrats. His letters were written from Assam, where he was serving as a mediator between the two camps, facing each other on opposite sides of the town of Guwahati. He made his intentions clear: the Ahom raja had invited him in as a negotiator, and he had accepted the offer in the hopes that he could recoup his debts from clients among the Ahom elite, which amounted to nearly 100,000 rupees; but they could not pay as long as Krishnarayan's mercenaries were destroying the whole region, eroding their tax base. When he visited Krishnarayan on behalf of the Ahom government in order to offer him his throne back in return for peace, the raja agreed but the leaders of his mercenaries refused, saying they would continue fighting until their arrears had been paid, which they fixed at 200,000 rupees.⁵³ A response by the mercenary captains accused Rausch of being the one preventing them from getting paid, suggesting that he at one point may have been involved in financing them.⁵⁴ Subsequent letters from Rausch contain assertions that the mercenaries were openly plotting the conquest of Assam, holding the raja they nominally served virtually hostage, dictating the contents of his letters, and that Goalpara itself was in danger of attack.⁵⁵ (Rangmati, a town on the opposite side of the Brahmaputra from Assam, was actually attacked, and the Company resident, as well as the town's chief revenue officer, were killed).⁵⁶ Enclosed alongside these letters are a series of others from the Ahom monarch and his principal officers repeating the same basic points, urging the Company to aid them in dispersing Krishnarayan's mercenaries.⁵⁷

These petitions caught the eye of Company higher ups in Calcutta because they represented a challenge to its sovereignty claims over Bengal. The mercenary force Rausch had helped to

⁵² Interrogations and translations of seized correspondence of these Greek merchants, in which they plot to overthrow Rausch, can be found on IOR/P/114/59, July 18th, 1792, Nos. 9, 10.

⁵³ IOR/P/114/58, June 8th, 1792, No. 11.

⁵⁴ IOR/P/114/62, September 10th, 1792, No. 48.

⁵⁵ IOR/P/114/62, September 19th, 1792, Nos. 14, 15.

⁵⁶ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, p. 278.

⁵⁷ IOR/P/114/58, June 8th, 1792, No. 12; IOR/P/114/62, September 10th, 1792, No. 49.

assemble was out of control, and had taken to terrorizing the countryside – reports describe the fury of the local peasants at these men, so great that if groups of them got separated from the main force they would be surrounded and butchered, their mutilated bodies hung publicly as a warning to the rest.⁵⁸ What really seems to have attracted their attention however was the open disobedience of the mercenaries, who when asked to return, said that if they were not in Bengal the Company had no power over them,⁵⁹ and who were accused of falsely representing themselves as a contingent of Company troops as a cover for their activities. The Company took a hard line on this and increasingly devoted more time and resources to the issue.⁶⁰ They first ordered the mercenaries to return. When there was no response they began to pull whatever levers they had access to, identifying their homesteads, confiscating their property, and even imprisoning their families to use as bargaining chips, but none of this was enough to force them to put down their arms.⁶¹

In their totality, these petitions revealed a troubling underlying fact for the Company: its exercise of sovereignty in the region was partial and limited at best. It was still engaged in a pre-colonial tributary relationship with the raja of Derrung, who was also a tributary of the Ahom raja and fighting a fully-fledged war against him using a mercenary army largely raised in Company territory. Private European actors in the region, such as Rausch, were also engaged in warlike political contestation with indigenous elites. The mercenaries themselves, who moved in and out of Company territory with impunity, had come to wield significant military power in the area and were using it to extract resources for their own benefit through a kind of pseudo-taxation; they may even have been falsely representing themselves as fighting under the Company's name. When called to account, they denied the Company's authority over them in belligerent language. The combined picture here is one of a distant borderland in which the authority of the Company was only vaguely constituted, a place where its intelligence networks were so thin on the ground that it was not privy to the everyday cut and thrust of local politics. As it became increasingly clear that the Company was not fully in control of Goalpara and lacked the resources at the local

⁵⁸ IOR/P/114/57, April 27th, 1792, No. 21.

⁵⁹ IOR/P/114/62, September 10th, 1792, No. 48.

⁶⁰ See the Calcutta council's decisions at the end of the package of documents presented to it in IOR/P/114/62, September 19th, 1792, Nos. 13, 14, 15, 16, 17.

⁶¹ The imprisonment of families is an assertion made in J. Johnstone, *Captain Welsh's Expedition to Assam in 1792, 1793, and 1794* (Calcutta: Foreign Department Press, 1877), p. 16. It is also alluded to in IOR/P/114/65, November 26th, 1792, No. 6.

level to institute the kind of control it desired, it began deliberations to dispatch a body of troops to the region to occupy it and bring all of the disparate and clashing actors revealed in these petitions under control, which ultimately led to the deployment of a small expeditionary force under Captain Thomas Welsh to Assam in 1792.

STATELESS SPACE IN THE CHITTAGONG HILL TRACTS

In this section, I briefly outline the Company's limited and indirect exercise of sovereignty in what later became known as the Chittagong Hill Tracts after it was formally conquered and brought under imperial dominion in the 1860s. Pre-existing Mughal frontier patterns persisted and shaped the dynamics of early colonial rule in Chittagong district, which was designed to facilitate the upward flow of resources with minimal investment and effort. In the Chittagong hills, the Company inherited a tangled tributary landscape originating in the Mughal era, one in which power was fragmented and layered, requiring reliance on intermediaries such as tax farmers and tribal rajas to maintain a steady flow of cotton, the Company's singular priority during this period. The Company's tributaries in the hills were far from serving as pliant extensions of its administrative will; they were independent rulers in their own right, who went to war with and even conquered territory from the Company when relations broke down. Even during times of peace, the cotton tribute fluctuated from year to year because these intermediary rulers had an equally fluid and negotiated relationship with their own tributaries – village chiefs who oversaw the actual cotton production. Despite an effort coinciding with the permanent settlement in other areas of Bengal to convert these fluctuating tribute payments into fixed monetary obligations, the Company's reach remained tenuous, relying on informal networks of subsidiary rulers well into the 19th century, leaving the Chittagong hills a space only partly under colonial rule.

To the Mughals, the whole of Chittagong had been an ecological and political frontier. Their primary mode of interacting with it had been through colonization efforts led by powerful local zamindars, who protected migrating peasants and financed and coordinated efforts to reshape the land to make it more conducive to agriculture. These colonization efforts layered Bengali

civilization over an older tribal society comprised mostly of Tibeto-Burman speaking peoples.⁶² In the hills, a number of minor states had arisen, often syncretic in nature, with mixed South and Southeast Asian ruling elites, court cultures and methods of statecraft – the pattern across the whole northeast frontier of India, from Assam to Arakan. The Mughals interacted with these minor kings from a great distance, ensuring that their ultimate authority was acknowledged and collecting tribute from them, but otherwise leaving the area largely to its own devices.

When Company officials arrived in Chittagong in the 1770s to establish control over the district, they found an agricultural hinterland that had in the beginning of the early modern period been largely forest, and were disappointed by its economic prospects. Its economy resembled a pattern typical of Southeast Asia in its low levels of commercialization outside of its ports, which were dominated by merchants from all over the Indian Ocean.⁶³ In the countryside, peasants were thinly dispersed across the landscape and there were few villages or commercial transactions taking place, households making what they needed themselves or bartering in temporary markets. There were few shops to be found, nor were wage laborers easy to hire, debt slavery being the most common way for high-status households to procure servants. The heaviest commercial flows were in a few coastal towns, and were mostly monopolized by European merchants. In addition, patterns of landholding were highly dispersed and tenants were in a relatively good negotiating position, given the low population of the district and multitude of places to flee from a rapacious landlord.⁶⁴ Because of this lack of lucrative resources, and the difficulty of extracting them, the Company seems to have settled on a hands-off strategy, focusing on coastal trade and establishing loose control over the most lucrative sources of income inland, but little more.

⁶² The frontier history of precolonial Bengal is covered in Eaton, *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier* and Willem van Schendel, *A History of Bangladesh* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009), chs. 1, 2.

⁶³ Anthony Reid, 'Economic and Social Change c. 1400-1800,' in ed. Nicholas Tarling, *The Cambridge History of Southeast Asia*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), pp. 460-507.

⁶⁴ This information comes from reporting submitted in 1794 to the Board of Revenue by the district's collector in response to being criticized for his failure to raise revenues in the district, reproduced in H. J. S Cotton, *Memorandum on the Revenue History of Chittagong* (Calcutta: Bengal Secretariat Press, 1880), pp. 211-12.

The distribution of police in the 1780s gives a good hint at the tiny size of the colonial state in Chittagong, and where its interests lay.⁶⁵ They protected EIC government offices; customs posts; the treasury of Tripura, a minor princely state along its northeastern border; the official in charge of collecting cotton tribute payments from the rajas of the Chittagong hill tract; and tax farmers. Some were in the employ of court bailiffs, tasked with stopping primarily economic crimes, for example enforcing revenue payments and thief-catching; another large group were stationed in various regions along the frontier to protect against the incursions of bandits and hill tribes. The total number was just over a hundred, doubled by the presence of a large force in the capital where the European merchant community lived (this force was specifically ordered not to operate outside the city).

These were less police in the contemporary sense and more armed guards protecting the Company's assets in the district. Responsibility for actual suppression of crime was, like in most other areas of Bengal at the time, passed downward to the zamindars, to whom all the tasks of policing were outsourced, from capturing criminals to trying them and punishing them, including carrying out executions.⁶⁶ Even after the permanent settlement, when the Company began to involve itself more in the dispensation of police duties, its central innovation was to station mercenaries in markets and on trade routes, paid by levying an additional tax on merchants. The Company's soldiers and police, in other words, had gone from being private security guards for the Company to guards of the region's commercial elite as a whole, merely a recognition that the state's interests lie not only in directly bolstering its own revenues, but also in bolstering the revenues of other merchants who could then be taxed.

The Company's early relationship to the Chittagong hills was even more indirect, and like in Rangpur, was primarily patterned off of Mughal tributary relationships. These were primarily confined to two areas: the tribal kingdom of Tripura, haphazardly draped over both highland and lowland in the north of the district, and the hill rajas in the east of the district bordering on

⁶⁵ The following information comes from correspondence between the government and local authorities in Chittagong in the 1780s and 90s, reproduced in Cotton, *Memorandum on the Revenue History of Chittagong*, pp. 217-19.

⁶⁶ Mughal law, carried out by frontier zamindars, and which included impalement, the severing of hands and feet and other corporal punishments, was in effect in the district up to the 1770s, the Company merely deputing representatives to oversee the carrying out of sentences. See Cotton, *Memorandum on the Revenue History of Chittagong*, pp. 221-2.

Arakan. Like in the case of the Koch rajas of Rangpur, in early EIC records these states too are recorded as zamindaris.⁶⁷ The Mughals, who had their own administrative simplifications, incorporating conquered elites into a social and administrative hierarchy based on hereditary privilege and personal ties, rather than ethnicity,⁶⁸ classified them as such. The Company, which ruled in Chittagong throughout much of the 18th century through the instrument of former Mughal administrative networks, maintained this designation, partly out of ignorance – they had no direct knowledge of these kings, whose dynastic origins had predated the Mughals.

In the hills near Arakan, the Company's main interest was primarily in securing a cotton tribute that had been given to the Mughals and which was collected in the same fashion that it had been during the pre-colonial period, through the informal exercise of power by one ruler over another, a pyramidal scheme in which the exact amount of tribute that could be collected depended on the disposition of power between these layers of rulers at any given moment. Tribute collection connected the Company to two dynastic families, the Phru and Chakma, governors of small states who had given cotton to the Mughals, then the nawabs of Bengal. They continued to provide this to the EIC through a tax farmer drawn from the same family that had provided this service to the nawabs; these farmers also monopolized cotton sales in the district, selling off whatever the government did not collect. The cotton itself was collected from other rulers whose domains were on such a small scale they were invisible to the Company – some presided over areas of settled cultivation, others were tribal chiefs who themselves had every year to collect cotton from shifting cultivators whose political relationship to them was unfixed, and whose agricultural yields varied depending on seasonal conditions.⁶⁹ The actual amount of cotton available fluctuated yearly, and there were at least three layers of sovereignty it had to pass through before it arrived in the hands of the Company.

The Company's early relationship to the Phru and Chakma rajas was caught in a limbo between diplomacy, military and police action and taxation. The amount of tribute the rajas were expected to provide was worked out in yearly negotiations with the Company's tax farmer. If too much

⁶⁷ Alexander Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal* (Calcutta: Home Department Press, 1884), pp. 271-73, 329.

⁶⁸ Richards, *The Mughal Empire*, pp. 59-63, 143-8.

⁶⁹ Cotton, *Memorandum on the Revenue History of Chittagong*, pp. 189-90; Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*, ch. XXII.

friction was produced by these negotiations, fighting would ensue, first locally between the rajas and the farmer, then dragging in the Company. The Chakma rajas, assisted not only by hill tribe feudatories fighting with bows, but also a large group of Bengali bandits under a 'Mun Sarkar,' who had been sentenced in absentia in a zamindari court to having his hands and feet amputated, went to war with the Company in 1776 after such a breakdown, caused by rampant exploitation perpetrated by the Company's tax farmers.⁷⁰

The Chakmas, in their resistance to the Company, demonstrated aspirations to statehood of their own. They conducted raids down into the plains, which may be conceptualized as punitive, and stopped paying taxes, barred Company officials from entering their territory, and refused to come into district headquarters to parlay, which may be conceptualized as protest; but local zamindars addressed complaints to the Company revealing a more ambitious attempt to conquer nearby territory. They began collecting their own taxes from adjacent lowland estates previously governed by the Company, stationing troops in them, forcing the people of the plains to do corvee labor in the hills, as well as minting coins, dispensing justice, setting up customs collection booths, and otherwise dispensing many of the characteristic functions of a state. District authorities tried for ten years to subdue them, losing multiple affrays in the hills, eventually adapting the strategy of an economic blockade, which successfully brought the Chakmas back into a revenue paying relationship with the Company in 1787. They remained, however, important players in local politics until the early 19th century, incorporated into the Company's tributary networks while simultaneously maintaining a great deal of leeway for independent action – a nested sovereignty relationship characteristic of pre-colonial politics in the region.

In 1789, the year of the permanent settlement, the Company made an effort to commute the fluctuating cotton tribute into fixed money payments, but otherwise adopted a hands-off approach to its governance. This move towards the institution of more regularized taxation involved a foray into the area in order to identify who exactly held power in the region, though this was limited only to those who were "fixed both by their habitations and habits, and have claim somewhat hereditary to the places or districts they live in." Other than that, there seems to

⁷⁰ A thorough study on this revolt is Ratan Lal Chakraborty, 'Chakma Resistance to Early British Rule,' *Bangladesh Historical Studies*, 2 (1977), pp. 133-156.

have been little direct interaction, the government instead electing, as it did in many other hill areas, to adopt a policy of severing highland from lowland, barring hill rajas from holding land on the plains and stopping them from levying duties on trade through their domains, an effort to curtail the power they wielded from difficult-to-reach strongholds. This neglect continued well into the next century, with a district commissioner writing in 1829 that:

We have no authority in the hills; the payment of the tribute which is trivial in amount in each instance is guaranteed by a third party, resident in our own territory, and who is alone responsible. He derives his own profit from the arrangement under stipulations which have no place in his agreement with us. He is merely an agent, or mooktear, or medium of communication between his constituents and the authorities. He is not the ruler of the clan he represents, and possesses no control over the members of it.⁷¹

Early Company rule in Chittagong district was decentralized and limited in its goals, much the same as it was in Rangpur. The Company had inherited and built itself over top of a Mughal state structure in the district that was still largely intact, at least in the period in question in this chapter. It exercised only a very loose control over much of Chittagong, including lowland areas; but especially the highland areas in the furthest eastern reaches of the district were largely unknown and ungoverned. The collection of the cotton tribute – the only item of significance for its bare-bones government – was the personal fiefdom of a tax farmer, who sat at the head of a large and shifting pyramidal structure of subsidiary rulers through which the tribute had to pass, fluctuating yearly depending on political conditions and crop yields. The only time the Company got involved was when armed revolt made his job impossible; and even then, its thinly spread resources meant that it could only devote small numbers of troops to the task, allowing rulers in the Chittagong hills to not only evade capture for years but even conquer territory from the Company. Finally although the permanent settlement did institute a more regularized form of resource extraction, it did little to curtail the political independence of rulers in the hills, who remained significant players in local politics well into the next century. In the next section I connect this decentralization to flows of people across the border, showing how, when large numbers of refugees started to pour into this basically stateless space from Arakan after its

⁷¹ T. H. Lewin, *The Hill Tracts of Chittagong and the Dwellers Therein* (Calcutta: Bengal Printing Company, 1869), p. 22.

conquest by the Burmese, the Company could do little, either to stop refugees crossing over or to establish even rudimentary authority over them.

ARAKAN BETWEEN EMPIRES

In this section, I look at how in the Chittagong hills, mass flows of migrants flowed in and out largely unhindered by any state apparatus. This included at least three waves of migrants from Arakan, and migrants moving in the other direction from Bengal, who intermingled in a complex, multiethnic landscape stratified along ecological lines. The latest layer of migration consisted of refugees and rebels fleeing Burmese conquest in Arakan. Much of this migration seems to have been instigated by Arakanese nobles who played losing hands in the factional politics of post-conquest Arakan. Some seem to have initially collaborated with the new regime, but rebelled in the face of heavy burdens placed on them as the Burmese squeezed their newly acquired possessions in order to supply men and material for campaigns against Siam. When they left, they brought not only their extended households with them, but large numbers of their dependent subjects. The Chittagong hills, possessed of little arable land, mostly lining its rivers, had difficulty absorbing this large influx of people, and many lived in a state of destitution and tension with Bengali agriculturalists. This, combined with the political aspirations of these dispossessed landowners, turned the Chittagong hills into a hotbed of banditry and insurgency by the 1790s, targeted both east and west.

The kingdom of Arakan, sandwiched between Bengal and Burma in a small enclave of land facing the coast, had been in the early modern period home to a vibrant state blending South and Southeast Asian court cultures, its liminal position attracting everyone from exiled Mughal princes to Portuguese fortune seekers.⁷² In the latter half of the 18th century, the Arakan court began to spin apart due to factional struggles, leaving it easy prey for its fast-expanding neighbor in the Konbaung dynasty.⁷³ Factions active in the succession struggles within the Arakanese

⁷² S. E. A. van Galen, 'Arakan and Bengal: the rise and decline of the Mrauk U kingdom (Burma) from the fifteenth to the seventeenth century AD' (PhD Thesis, University of Leiden, 2008); see also Sanjay Subrahmanyam, 'Connected Histories: Notes towards a Reconfiguration of Early Modern Eurasia,' *Modern Asian Studies* 31:3 (1997), pp. 735-762.

⁷³ Arthur Phayre, *History of Burma* (London: Trubner and Co., 1883), chs. XVII, XX. Charles Paton, 'Historical and Statistical Sketch of Aracan,' *Asiatic Researches*, Vol. XVI (1828), pp. 353-381 includes a useful oral history, collected from Arakanese elites, of the factional conflict proceeding and continuing into the period of Burmese rule.

court had reached out to King Bodawpaya (r. 1782-1819), the longest-reigning Konbaung monarch, and the architect of much of the dynasty's expansion, presiding over military campaigns into Siam and Assam.⁷⁴ One of his first major acts, two years after seizing the throne, was to launch a major invasion of Arakan. The justification given for this in internal documents relates to Arakan's political instability: to "clear the place of all bad characters" and "restore proper conditions in Arakan for the prosperity of the Buddha's religion." A massive army, comprised of 21 divisions of soldiers, with naval backup, tens of thousands of rifles, hundreds of cannons and nearly a million pieces of ammunition, was dispatched to achieve this goal. Marching orders were given, including detailed battle plans, plans for tracking fugitives fleeing the anticipated sack of the capital through the jungle, and disciplinary admonitions not to allow rank and file troops to drink, rape or steal.⁷⁵

The conquest of Arakan was attended with significant brutality, as was the suppression of dissent in the course of establishing Burmese authority, which combined to produce a major rebellion and refugee crisis. In 1784, the Burmese army, led by the king's sons, crossed into Arakan and rapidly captured the capital. This was followed by a thorough looting of the kingdom. Many of the court's valuables were carried off, from the texts in its libraries to the relics in its temples. The royal family itself was removed to Burma, as well as many of the court's service elites, who were put to work in Amarapura, the Konbaung capital. Tens of thousands of Arakanese were also captured and taken deep into Burma where they served as bonded labor. Large numbers of Burmese colonists moved in the opposite direction, and much of Arakan's land was divided up by Burmese elites. These actions, combined with food confiscations in order to feed a large army that had been gathered to march on Siam, fomented political instability in the region that was to last for decades, marked by persistent insurgency and population displacement, with large

⁷⁴ A concise overview of early expansion is found in William Koenig, *The Burmese Polity, 1752-1819: Politics, Administration and Social Organization in the Early Kon-baung Period* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 1990), ch. 1.

⁷⁵ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 5 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), pp. 75-84.

numbers of refugees and rebels alike congregating in the inaccessible maze of swampy valleys in the Chittagong hills.⁷⁶

Francis Buchanan, who traveled through the area in 1798, producing a short account, one of the only in existence of the region in the 18th century,⁷⁷ described the region as being stratified along ethnic lines – literally, as each ethnic group occupied a different elevation, a common pattern in highland areas of South and Southeast Asia to this day.⁷⁸ River valleys suitable to rice agriculture were populated primarily by Bengali settlers. These were highly organized. Bengali cultivation was a collective enterprise, structured by an underlying, hierarchical relationship moving from zamindar to intermediary authorities to peasant cultivators, providing both security and financing in a framework that allowed for the rapid extension of cultivation into frontier areas. Land was granted tax-free for a specified time to cultivators, who then undertook the arduous, time-consuming process of burning off the jungle, draining swamps and otherwise readying it for cultivation, an outward thrusting, enterprising system that had first brought much of eastern Bengal under Mughal rule, and then had snaked into most of Chittagong's river valleys.⁷⁹

Hilly areas at mid-levels of elevation were generally populated by previous groups of Arakanese migrants, each of which existed in a different state of acculturation and integration into local life, and which had split with each other and morphed into separate ethnicities. The oldest were those that were governed by the Chakma clan, who traced their descent back to Arakanese communities that had migrated into Chittagong during the early modern height of Arakanese

⁷⁶ On the conquest and incorporation of Arakan by Burma, see Jaques Leider, 'Politics of integration and cultures of resistance: A study of Burma's conquest and administration of Arakan (1785-1825),' in Geoff Wade, *Asian Expansions: The Historical Experiences of Polity Expansion in Asia* (London: Routledge, 2015), pp. 184-213.

⁷⁷ Francis Buchanan, *Francis Buchanan in Southeast Bengal (1798): His Journey to Chittagong, the Chittagong Hill Tracts, Noakhali and Comilla*, ed. Willem van Schendel (Dhaka: University Press Limited, 1992). He also wrote several articles based on his findings for Edinburgh philosophical journals. Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of the Frontier between Part of Bengal and the Kingdom of Ava,' *Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 2 (1825), pp. 48-58; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of the Frontier Between Ava and the Part of Bengal Adjacent to the Karnaphuli River,' *The Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 3 (1825): pp. 32-44; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of the Frontier between the Southern part of Bengal and the Kingdom of Ava,' *Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 3 (1825), pp. 201-212; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of the Frontier between the Southern part of Bengal and the Kingdom of Ava (concluded from vol. iii, p. 212),' *Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 4 (1826), pp. 22-36.

⁷⁸ See James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009). Partly also based on my personal observations and conversations with people in Yunnan.

⁷⁹ Buchanan describes this in a similar way to what is reflected in studies of the agrarian settlement of the region. Eaton, *The Rise of Islam and the Bengal Frontier* and van Schendel, *A History of Bangladesh*, chs. 1, 2.

power, when the kingdom ruled there. These were heavily acculturated to Bengali lifeways. They dressed after the Bengali fashion. Chakma aristocrats, who had been partly incorporated into Mughal ruling structures, took Muslim names.⁸⁰ They were Buddhist in faith, and had an organized priesthood patterned off of Burma and Arakan, but had "engrafted" onto Buddhism "many Hindu superstitions, and especially bloody sacrifices offered to the Dehtas, or deities of the woods, rivers, and mountains," wrote Buchanan. Their cultural hybridity was so advanced that, according to Buchanan, they were sometimes called, in ridicule: "Dubaddes, (two-languaged) because they have in general forgotten their original language, which is the same with that of Arakan or Roang, as they call it, and have attained a very imperfect knowledge of the Bengalese, although several of them read and write this dialect. They all, however, retain some words of the Roang language, especially their names; and their priests use both the character and language of Arakan, little different from that of Ava."⁸¹

The second wave of migrants was referred to as Mughls by the English. These had their origins in the mid-18th century. Like the Chakmas, the Mughls too had come to view themselves as a separate ethnic group. They referred to themselves as "men of the hills," and no longer engaged in riverine cultivation like the people of Arakan, whom they took great pains to differentiate themselves from (Buchanan guessed that they were worried about being lumped in with freshly arrived Arakanese because the Burmese were demanding their repatriation). Ethnic change came because of a shift in their relationship to the environment, which was a response to their entrance into a new political context, or as Buchanan put it, their adoption of slash-and-burn agriculture "seems to have been in order to conciliate the Bengalese, among whom they settled. The hills, of which they took possession, were entirely neglected by the Bengalese, as not admitting of being ploughed after the Indian fashion, so that they gave no umbrage."

The Chakmas and Mughls were both organized along similar political lines, into decentralized networks of rulers that were hierarchical but also flexible, pragmatically extending governance over multiethnic populations, the compositions of which differed depending on local context. The Chakmas were ruled by a single raja, located in a settlement in the northern part of the hills

⁸⁰ On Chakma cultural hybridity, see A. M. Serajuddin, 'The Chakma Tribe of the Chittagong Hill Tracts in the 18th Century,' *The Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society of Great Britain and Ireland*, 116:1 (1984), pp. 90-98.

⁸¹ Buchanan, 'An Account of the Frontier Between Ava and the Part of Bengal Adjacent to the Karnaphuli River.'

in which he had set up a rudimentary administration, staffed primarily by Bengali brahmins, as was typical of hill states in the region. Subsidiary settlements were governed by officers under his authority. Each collected a head tax on surrounding residents, not a land tax, as villagers practiced shifting cultivation, changing in extent from year to year. The Mughhs were ruled by three chiefs located in the southern portion of the hills, each of whom commanded the allegiance of multiple hill tribes while also simultaneously paying homage to the Chakma raja and the rulers of Arakan, then later Burma – one of these was in a simultaneous tributary relationship with the Company. These too extensively employed Bengalis, both Hindu and Muslim, in their households, as well as surrounding themselves with large numbers of debt slaves of many ethnic groups. Though ethnically differentiated, the two groups were heavily connected – Mughh rajahs appointed Chakma viziers, and rulers of one ethnicity controlled villages populated by the other. They also occasionally ruled over Bengali settlements, taking over the zamindar's role, and becoming liable to the Company's tax regime, though they remained sovereigns in the hills (sometimes the opposite was true, in that isolated Mughh settlements in Bengali-dominated areas were ruled by local zamindars).

The geographical location of Chakma and Mughh settlements meant that they were intertwined with both highland and lowland. They tended to be on level areas in the hills immediately above neighboring Bengali villages, and were surrounded by livestock, gardens and orchards where they grew cash crops: "ginger, betle-leaf, sugar-cane, indigo, tobacco, and capsicum." They also operated slash-and-burn plots in more inaccessible areas, where they built makeshift villages occupied only when work was being done in the area. Mughh settlements were heavily connected to both acephalous tribes occupying the highest elevations of the mountains and Bengali riverine settlements: they employed Bengalis as fishermen, and Kuki, Zo and other highland tribal communities who lived nearby came under their political influence. Mughh rajahs also operated trade marts overlooking river valleys, which were staffed and frequented by Bengali merchants, who purchased products originating in the hills.

This was an ethnic landscape brimming with diversity, but also one in which each group occupied a specific ecological and economic niche. There was also a relatively high demographic load, at least in areas conducive to agriculture, so that competition for resources was fierce. Freshly arrived refugees from Arakan (some of whom were actually Hindus or Muslims of

Bengali descent themselves) as a consequence were pushed to the very margins of subsistence. They primarily resided in the lowland environment with which they were most familiar, and which was dominated by Bengali cultivators. Their sudden inundation of the area – in one case over fifteen thousand refugees had congregated in a single valley – caused major tensions. The refugees complained of "oppression" by Bengalis (one said they were "detested by Hindus and Muslims alike"), and said Bengali cultivators resented them, seeking to protect their proprietary rights over the best land. Cut out of the system of financing that underpinned ecological expansion in the region, they were forced to survive as an impoverished underclass, in one village by "making umbrellas out of palm leaves." They were porters, boatmen, fishermen – all service occupations that did not require land – and were often subject to corvee demands by local rulers. However, some still believed that they were better off than they had been under the Burmese, a sentiment echoed by one man who told Buchanan that as bad as things were in Chittagong, at least they were not being "butchered like in Arakan proper."

This dislocated context created a ready pool of recruits for exiled Arakanese nobles to draw from in their efforts to organize an insurgency to fight the Burmese – and to finance that insurgency through piracy and banditry. At least some of these rebel leaders had initially supported the invasion and worked with the Burmese, but fled after falling out over the extent to which they were being squeezed for resources to support the war in Siam. They entered into Chittagong with large trains of followers – both the Company and Burmese authorities suspected that they sometimes forcibly uprooted their subjects in order to maintain their power bases.⁸² They tended to reside close to the border where they could easily cross back over, refusing Company offers to provide them with land to permanently settle and openly declaring their intention to liberate their homeland.⁸³ They were organized political actors, attempting to establish control over the territories they had entered – and engaging in infighting among themselves – while simultaneously launching attacks on the Burmese in Arakan, and lobbying the British for support. Some of these militias were estimated to be tens of thousands strong. The most famous,

⁸² IOR/F/4/71/1583, Extract Bengal Criminal and Judicial Consultations, December 14th, 1798.

⁸³ Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, July 16th, 1794.

led by Chin Byan, tried to roll back the Burmese occupation in a failed siege of Arakan's capital, for which he has apparently earned a place in the pantheon of Arakanese nationalism.⁸⁴

The testimony of one of the rebel leaders, captured by the British, provides some insight into the political struggles producing such exiles.⁸⁵ The man, who had been a landlord controlling islands off the coast, called the Burmese tyrants, saying that after their conquest of Arakan, they had killed, in his estimation, hundreds of thousands, enslaved hundreds of thousands of others, and forced many more to flee into the jungle. They also took hostages from all the kingdom's nobles to ensure their obedience, including several of his relatives. A few years later he was embroiled in a dispute with the new government over the provisioning of the army marching on Siam. Though he tried to conciliate local authorities by sending slave girls and other gifts, his islands were attacked, hundreds of his people were enslaved and over a hundred killed, including his wife and son-in-law. His relatives being held hostage sent him a desperate message, urging him to flee, after which they too were killed. He then left with his whole household and all his subjects, who had to fight their way out of Arakan, resulting in the deaths of a hundred more. He finished by saying that most Arakanese nobles had suffered similarly, and begged not to be repatriated to Burma, where he was convinced he would suffer a cruel fate. Although the man's testimony was colored by his own attempt to stave off punishment for rebellion and banditry on both sides of the border, it nevertheless provides insight into the level of violence accompanying the Burmese conquest of Arakan, and the inter-elite conflict and mass exodus underlying the growth of insurgency in Chittagong.

Groups engaging in politically motivated insurgency were also believed to be responsible for a number of economically motivated attacks. In conversations with Company officials,⁸⁶ the Burmese alluded to pirates operating in the tangled warren of islands off the coast, who were attacking not only private merchants, but also royal ships laden with customs duties, which were a lucrative source of income amounting to one tenth of all goods traded in Arakanese ports. European vessels sometimes suffered the same fate – one English captain and several of his crew were murdered after shipwrecking off the Chittagong coast, their vessel found stripped bare of

⁸⁴ Leider, 'Politics of integration and cultures of resistance,' pp. 198-200.

⁸⁵ Mss Eur E63, Erskine to Secretary of Government, October 20th, 1794.

⁸⁶ Michael Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1 (Edinburgh: Constable and Co., 1827), pp. 142-8.

goods.⁸⁷ In the rainy season, when navigation was impossible, they plundered by land, in particular stealing cattle, a crime for which exiled Arakanese nobles were sometimes fined, the money then given to Burmese authorities as compensation.⁸⁸ Such activity was viewed with extreme hostility by both states, in particular because it was disruptive to trade. It is unclear from this evidence what the exact relationship between banditry and insurgency was, but a possible explanation is that one was financing the other.

The Burmese conquest of Arakan sent a flood of refugees into what was effectively a non-state space. The Chittagong hills, a difficult and swampy tract of terrain lying between and influenced by, but not directly governed by either of its large imperial neighbors, was home to a complex ethnic landscape tied to ecology. The few slices of arable land lining the area's riverbeds were largely already under cultivation by Bengali migrants who had arrived from the opposite direction, while the hills were already home to multiple previous waves of Arakanese migrants who had become ethnically differentiated through long residence in a new cultural and economic context. Political disaffection and economic marginalization, compounded by the presence in the area of a small number of exiled Arakanese nobles fleeing punishment at the hands of the Burmese for insubordination, created a hotbed of banditry and insurgency which was damaging the interests of both states. It was the Burmese who acted first, however, through unilateral incursions into Chittagong district, which was perceived as a serious threat by the Company. In the next section I analyze the politics surrounding these inter-imperial borderland clashes, as well as some of the differing ideas about sovereignty fueling them.

BURMESE INCURSIONS INTO CHITTAGONG

In this section I show how a lack of control by any state, and a thriving refugee community engaging in piracy, banditry and armed insurgency, led to a struggle between the Burmese and British empires for control over the Chittagong hills. Burmese expeditions across the Naaf River in 1787 and 1794, justified as efforts to suppress rebellion and restore order, were intended to exert influence over what was viewed as an interstate space. The Burmese asserted their right to govern their newly acquired subjects in Arakan, no matter where they fled, and sought an

⁸⁷ Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, May 9th, 1787.

⁸⁸ IOR/F/4/71/1583, Extract Bengal Revenue Consultations, February 27th, 1795, Minute by President of the Revenue Board.

alliance with the EIC to mutually suppress dissent and strengthen trade relations. The British viewed the incursions as a challenge to the territorial integrity of their empire, and moved to assert a new, Europeanized form of sovereignty over this remote region. They extradited rebel leaders to Burma, mobilized troops, and initiated efforts to formalize borders and establish a permanent presence in the hills, an attempt to transform what was formerly an only partly-governed wilderness into a zone of clearly-defined state control.

The persistence of banditry and insurgency in the Chittagong hills, as well as population drain out of Arakan, led to the Burmese launching a major expedition across the Naaf river in 1787. In correspondence with the company the leaders of the expedition justified themselves on both practical and ideological grounds, revealing both an expansive imperial ambition and a sharp grasp of realpolitik. The expedition, which went unopposed because monsoon rains made it impossible to march a force out in response, sent two letters sent to the Chittagong district authorities, one from the king and one from his provincial governor in Arakan. In them, the Burmese laid out their reasoning behind the incursion.⁸⁹ The first, from the Arakan governor, is short and practical, asking for the repatriation of a number of rebel leaders; the writer warned the Company not to give the rebels asylum, otherwise he would be forced to take matters into his own hands. The second from the king is much more lengthy and ideological, laying out in theoretical terms his claim to the right to govern Arakan. It begins by making the case for the king's virtue and might:

I am lord of a whole people and of one hundred and one countries, and my titles are Rajah Chatterdary (sitting under a canopy) and Rajah Suruj Bunshee (descendant of the sun, and sitting under a splendid canopy of gold). I hold in subjection to my authority many Rajahs. Gold, silver, and jewels, are the produce of my country; and in my hand is the instrument of war, that, as the lightning of heaven, humbles and subdues my adversaries...I am as the sun, blessed with the light of wisdom to discover the secret designs of men...ten thousand Rajahs pay daily attendance at my durbar, and my country excels every country in the world. My palace, as the heavens, studded with gold and

⁸⁹ These were preserved in the Chittagong district records, and were reprinted in Lewin, *The Hill Tracts of Chittagong*, pp. 29-32. The original versions can be found appended to Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, May 9th, 1787.

precious stones, is revered more than any other place in the universe. My occupations resemble the business of the chief angels.⁹⁰

The letter linked Burmese rule in Arakan to the custodianship of a form of Buddhist kingship that had once flourished in the kingdom but was believed to have decayed. It described the justice and wisdom of the previous rulers of Arakan and their patronage of religion, as well as the miraculous wealth (gold literally rained from the sky) and the upright morality and utopian tranquility secured by their reigns. It then portrayed the Konbaung dynasty as the guardian of these fallen traditions: "I likewise preserve a line of conduct and religion similar to the above; but previous to my conquest of Arakan, the people were as snakes wounding men, a prey to enmity and disorder...there were eaters of the flesh of man, and wickedness prevailed amongst them, so that no man relied upon his neighbors." It concluded by transitioning rather abruptly from an otherworldly tone into a series of worldly negotiating points: the king wanted a treaty of commerce and the EIC's help in correcting the "errors and irregularities" of the Arakanese population scattered across the Chittagong hills, who had "deviated from the principles of religion and morality."

The letter is steeped in the language of cosmic authority, religious virtue, and moral restoration. The king portrays himself as the rightful guardian of a fallen Buddhist order in Arakan, invoking divine sanction, mythic grandeur, and his role as a moral locus in order to justify intervention. These are characteristic idioms in Konbaung court rhetoric, illustrating the ideology of universal kingship underpinning its statecraft – one which was based not on systematized claims over well-defined chunks of territory but on charismatic authority over people that at least in theory was limitless.⁹¹ Note though that beneath this elevated register lies a clear-eyed realpolitik: a treaty of

⁹⁰ Lewin, *The Hill Tracts of Chittagong*, p. 30.

⁹¹ Charisma according to O. W. Wolters was an important aspect of ancient Southeast Asian kingship, likely derived from tribal origins, surviving the adoption of Hinduism and Buddhism in modified form. O. W. Wolters, *History, Culture, and Region in Southeast Asian Perspectives* (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 1982), pp. 101-105. The rhetoric of the Konbaung court was dripping with systematic references to the king's charismatic authority. See for example a letter written to the ruler of Vietnam to convey the Burmese ruler's potency: Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 8 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), pp. 63-77. A good exploration of the disconnect between court rhetoric regarding morality and the restoration of order and the practical realities of systemic violence, especially against frontier communities, is Michael Charney, 'Both Benevolent and Brutal: The Two Sides of Provincial Violence in Early Modern Burma', in *A Global History of Early Modern Violence*, eds. Erica Charters, Marie Houllemare, and Peter H. Wilson (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2020), pp. 37-51.

commerce, the reversal of Arakanese population drain, and the quelling of dissent – all of which aligned with the needs of a state trying to establish post-conquest order in a new imperial possession while simultaneously waging a costly war in Siam.

Initially the Company seems to have been rather unperturbed by the incursion, viewing it as a misunderstanding, and was favorably disposed to the Burmese court's proposals. The district collector recommended to the government that it would be prudent to take the Burmese up on their offer, because of the trade opportunities to be gained, because it would deny the French a powerful ally in the region, and because together the two could jointly project power into the region with a view to "extirpating or keeping in subjection the inhuman race of Mugs who have so infested the country for some years past with impunity." The letter sent back concurred with all the Burmese points, expressing hopes that by way of an alliance between the two states, "all turbulent people may be kept in proper awe and subjection."⁹²

Communications seem to have fallen by the wayside however until 1794, when another Burmese army appeared in Chittagong, this time much larger than before. It was led by the governor of Ramree, one of the four provinces of Arakan, who assembled an army of several thousand and marched into Chittagong in pursuit of several men characterized as notorious bandit leaders but whose crimes, as was the case with many of the fugitives the Burmese desired to apprehend, were at least as political as they were economic (Burmese allegations against these men suggested that they had shirked their responsibility in making contributions for the Siamese war, killed messengers, plundered government boats, destroyed neighboring villages and subsequently fled).⁹³ This prompted the assembly of an opposing army, which was sent from Calcutta up to Chittagong, where a tense standoff ensued.

The governor of Ramree, in correspondence with Lieutenant Colonel Erskine, who had been sent out to head him off, represented his actions as a pacification effort conducted in an interstate space.⁹⁴ He said the country was normally well cultivated and peaceful and filled with merchants visiting its ports, but that since the conquest of Arakan by the Burmese many "robbers, adulterers and reprobates" had emerged, which he was tracking into Company territory. He asked for help

⁹² Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, May 9th, 1787.

⁹³ Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations,' pp. 26-7.

⁹⁴ Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, July 16th, 1794.

in apprehending them and expressed his surprise that, given the level of English power in the area, they had not been apprehended already. He did not understand why his actions were being viewed so unfavorably. Because the place in which he decamped was a wilderness far away from any areas of concentrated settlement or cultivation, he wondered why anyone would stake such an uncompromising claim to it. He seems to have had friendly intentions, attempting to ply the colonel with gifts in order to conciliate him, and asking for shipments of muskets, stating that his king remained open to an alliance.

Erskine managed to resolve the crisis peacefully. He seems to have had a certain degree of sympathy for the governor, who admitted that his hand had been forced by the king, who viewed him as possibly complicit in the rebellion (his ethnicity is unclear, but many in his position were ethnic Arakanese who had collaborated with the invasion). According to him, he and his entire family would be put to death if he did not solve the problem he was suspected of helping to create, leaving him unable to withdraw until the three bandit leaders had been given up. The colonel negotiated with him an exit that would ensure he was able to satisfy his king. He was asked to withdraw in exchange for the three bandit leaders, whom the EIC promptly arrested and extradited, though some of the officials involved critiqued the decision on grounds that the evidence for the conviction was relatively light, and that it was politically motivated, made in order to reduce tensions with the Burmese. After being transferred to Burmese custody, two of the three were executed.⁹⁵

This second incursion spurred the government into taking action to establish a more formal boundary and a visible presence on the ground that it could use to assert sovereignty over the areas that it claimed. District officials were concerned that the entrance of such a large body of troops into the area had caused panic among the local population, leading many people to desert their homes and leaving the land uncultivated, not to mention forcing many of the insurgents into more populated areas where they clashed with local zamindars. They recommended permanently stationing a military force on the Naaf river in order to prevent further incursions, stem the free

⁹⁵ Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations,' pp. 37-8.

flow of refugees, and provide a secure area around which those who were already there could safely congregate – and be disarmed and settled.⁹⁶

In order to extend centralized authority into the region, a military encampment was established in the heart of the Chittagong hills in 1794, along with the construction of a road that allowed for the easy passage of troops and supplies. Lieutenant Brougham, stationed at the encampment under Erskine, described the region as depopulated and wild, and the refugees as in an extreme state of deprivation. He submitted a plan to make them productive and loyal subjects by giving them waste to cultivate, the taxes from which would pay for the army's presence. He also recommended the demarcation of a boundary and conducting surveys to establish land settlements around the area in order to establish the Company's presence. He clearly understood that this would represent a transformation of the region. Only with the arrival of the army, he wrote, had the river become the terminus of the Company's dominions, which he cautioned that people in the region had not “hitherto perceived as described,”⁹⁷ an analysis that was confirmed by Erskine's inquiries into the matter, which revealed that the local population considered the wild space between Chittagong and Arakan to be a kind of neutral ground.⁹⁸

These encounters represented the meeting of two empires, similar in their expansionism in the quest for wealth and power, but vastly different in their socioeconomic and cultural underpinnings, and in the beliefs and tactics that flowed from them. The British believed that states were separated from each other by neat boundaries and that within each state only a single government should be in control. The Burmese, on the other hand, recognized no border in Chittagong. They believed that the uninhabited wilderness separating the two states was not under any government's control, and operated on a conceptualization of sovereignty as exercised over people, not places, which meant that even if the Arakanese fled into Chittagong, they were still fundamentally Burmese subjects.⁹⁹ These were major ideological and practical differences, which would result in steadily increasing tensions between the two states that, in the early 19th century, eventually broke out into open war. In the intervening period, a series of diplomatic exchanges took place between them, attempting to adjudicate these and other disputes through

⁹⁶ Mss Eur E63, Extract Bengal Secret Consultations, July 16th, 1794.

⁹⁷ IOR/F/4/71/1583, Extract Bengal Political Consultations January 9th, 1795.

⁹⁸ Ramachandra, ‘Anglo-Burmese Relations,’ pp. 24-5.

⁹⁹ This is described in Htin Aung, *The Stricken Peacock*, ch. 2.

negotiation. The first, most important, and most successful of these embassies was sent the next year in 1795, led by Michael Symes; it forms the subject of the last two chapters of the dissertation.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter I outlined the deep context behind the Welsh expedition to Assam and the Symes embassy to Burma. I showed how, on the Company's northern border with Assam, it did not project power evenly over a specifically demarcated space. Instead, it was engaged in a tangled snarl of overlapping and divided sovereignty relationships with minor princely states over which other regional powers made their own claims. It lacked a monopoly of force over the area, and had no borders, leaving the way open for mercenaries, bandits, merchant-princes and minor kings to freely traverse the region, engaging in open and often violent contestation for power and wealth. Its sovereignty in this borderland was tentative at best, an issue that the Welsh expedition was meant to address, by defeating and disarming mercenaries active in Assam and sending them back to Bengal, and by defending the collapsing Ahom monarchy from multiple challenges to its rule, including popular rebellion and elite factionalism, while simultaneously driving home treaty agreements that pulled it into the orbit of the Company's growing informal empire.

On the Company's eastern frontier in Chittagong district, its influence rapidly faded in the hills into a variety of tributary arrangements originating in the Mughal period, administered by revenue farmers who had performed the same services for the previous regime of the nawabs. Below that level, the Chittagong hills were largely ungoverned by any state. Flows of people and goods moved through them beneath the Company's notice and outside its control. The Konbaung dynasty, the most powerful state in mainland Southeast Asia in the late 18th century, operated a rival imperial system on the other side of these hills, and its conquest of the kingdom of Arakan lying adjacent to Bengal created a major outflow of people who took refuge in them. Politically dispossessed and eking out a living on the social and economic margins of their adopted home, they turned to banditry and revolt, prompting the Burmese to launch a number of punitive expeditions against them, which drew the Company into a tense contest over the political boundaries of the two states. Its dispatch of the Symes mission was part of an attempt to rectify

this, alongside the deployment of a military force to the area to lay claim to, demarcate and police a boundary.

These borderland areas were not fully controlled by Assam, Burma, the EIC or any other state. Rather, they formed interlocking spaces in which none had a controlling stake. Company power in northern Bengal seamlessly blended into, and overlapped with, the power of Bhutan, Nepal and Assam, as well as a variety of minor rajas, zamindars and highland tribal chiefs. In eastern Bengal, a similarly complex landscape of sovereignty could be found, with Company power fading in the hills, giving way to a number of minor rajas who in turn exercised local power over many different groups while simultaneously paying tribute to both the EIC and Burma. Much of this space was outside the reach of any state, especially that which was economically marginal and lodged in impassable terrain. In these places, groups thrived which were referred to in many different ways – rebels, pirates, refugees and bandits are just some of the terms one comes across – the central connecting thread between each being an oppositional relationship to established authority.

Borders, in the sense of lines on a map made real through government enforcement at the ground level, were nowhere to be found; the closest equivalents were a few customs houses or police outposts stationed at key checkpoints. In such a climate, the movement of people, goods and ideas was torrential and uninhibited. Toward Assam, this included merchants, smugglers, exiles, mercenaries and religious functionaries, who brought with them everything from salt and weapons to intelligence hungrily absorbed by Company officials desperate to know anything at all about the rapidly disintegrating situation to the north. From Arakan, flows of migrants had been moving into the Chittagong highlands for centuries; after Arakan's conquest by Burma, these were augmented by a massive influx of refugees, some of whom were powerful nobles with large armed retinues that engaged not only in attacks against Burmese soldiers stationed in their conquered homeland, but also banditry and piracy affecting the whole surrounding area.

The material collected in this chapter points to the weak, decentralized nature of early Company governance on this frontier. In the late 18th century, Bengal's borderlands were a place in which the EIC, despite being in power for decades, had little power or legitimacy. Its administration was rudimentary, focused mostly on securing arteries of commercial and agrarian wealth, and it

made heavy use of servants of the previous regime, who in many cases continued to administer relationships with border zamindars, rajas and highland groups according to Mughal custom. This arrangement, while efficient in ensuring the upward flow of wealth into the Company's coffers with as little effort as possible, left it lacking even basic knowledge of the political, economic or social state of its own borderlands, and unable to control either the exercise of power by non-state actors or the flow of people and goods in and out of the territory it claimed as its own.

In such a power vacuum, it is difficult to retroactively draw a definitive line between legitimate and illegitimate use of force. One can trace in the lively, multi-sided political contests of early colonial Rangpur and Chittagong the biographies of bandits who aspired to kingship, tribal chiefs who became Hindu rajas, and private European merchants whose thuggish use of force in recouping debts is reminiscent of the tactics of modern gangsters. At a more noble level (in a social, not a moral sense), one can find rajas engaged in rebellion-turned-conquest, Assamese nobles locked in deathly factionalism over who would control the future of their kingdom and what the relationship of local fiefdoms would be to the center, and Arakanese nobles who had been driven from their homeland engaging in a combination of politically motivated attacks on Burmese occupying forces and indiscriminate robbery. Presiding over all of this were powerful regional actors such as the EIC and the Konbaung dynasty, who allied with or suppressed these smaller-scale expressions of power according to their own changing priorities. This was a dynamic, shifting political landscape producing everything from the extinction of large, long-lasting monarchies to the sudden birth of empires from unexpected quarters.

The Welsh and Symes missions emerged from the survival, many decades into the colonial period, of pre-colonial and non-European patterns of borderland activity, ones that the Company was submerged in as a successor state to the Mughals. The Company was not the impresario of all of this borderland activity, self-assuredly directing it from above, but rather was sucked into a whirlpool of events not of its own making by powerful currents older than itself. Many of its efforts seem to have fallen into the category of retroactive damage control, efforts to patch up the holes it had discovered in its exercise of sovereignty. It capitalized where it could on these efforts in an attempt to secure more control over the resources and peoples on its frontiers, but these were piecemeal gains won in the moment, more a result of opportunism than any grand plan.

CHAPTER 2

NETWORKS OF KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE AND HYBRID DISCOURSES IN EARLY COLONIAL KNOWLEDGE OF ASSAM

In this chapter I consider the intelligence that the EIC collected on Assam in the late 18th and early 19th centuries, focusing in particular on its emergence from social connections. Early colonial knowledge of Assam was produced by many different methods, from travel observation and cartography to historiography and numismatics, but for much of the information most immediately important to the state – matters like political intelligence, descriptions of government structures, political economy, social stratification or ethnic composition – the most important source of information was the oral testimony of indigenous informants. I consider who these informants were, what their interests were, what perspectives they may have held, how they interacted with early colonial officials, and what fingerprint they may have left behind on the knowledge they helped to create.

The connection between sociability and intelligence gathering is a field of inquiry pioneered by C. A. Bayly, who argued that colonial knowledge was produced at the interstices between the colonial state and groups of elites who had served as the primary repositories of knowledge in the pre-colonial world.¹ His work has been important in fleshing out the connection between representations of the ‘other’ and the social and political contexts they emerged from,² and has been joined by a growing number of analyses of colonial knowledge as a product of cross-cultural encounter pursued in other contexts;³ but not in the case of India’s northeastern frontier, studies of which generally emphasize the alien and transformative nature of colonial knowledge, which is supposed to have imagined and then imposed through the instrument of bureaucratic

¹ C. A. Bayly, *Empire & Information: Intelligence gathering and social communication in India, 1780-1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996).

² See the introduction to Carol Breckenridge and Peter Van Der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993).

³ Nicholas Dirks, ‘Colonial Histories and Native Informants: Biography of an Archive,’ in eds. Carol Breckenridge and Peter Van Der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), pp. 279-313; Richard Eaton, ‘(Re)imag(in)ing Otherness: A Postmortem for the Postmodern in India,’ *Journal of World History*, 11:1 (2000), pp. 57-78; Eugene Irschick, *Dialogue and History: Constructing South India, 1795-1895* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1994); Norbert Peabody, ‘Cents, Sense, Census: Human Inventories in Late Precolonial and Early Colonial India,’ *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 43:4 (2001), pp. 819-850; Phillip Wagoner, ‘Precolonial Intellectuals and the Production of Colonial Knowledge,’ *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 45:4 (2003), pp. 783-814.

rationality an artificial unity on what was once a politically, economically, socially and culturally indeterminate space.⁴ The overwhelming focus on change in this body of scholarship has left the question of how indigenous informants influenced it unexplored.

Precolonial social and political systems produced their own forms of ideologically inflected knowledge, which, as in the colonial context, served to consolidate and perpetuate power structures.⁵ As the colonial state was layered over these existing social and political systems, its forms of knowledge likewise built on the interpretive infrastructure that preceded it. On Bengal's northeast frontier, information was primarily collected from Bengali Brahmins and Ahom aristocrats. Not only did they provide many of the facts that ultimately entered the colonial archive, but their ways of perceiving the world also permeated it, creating hybrid discourses in which the needs and suppositions of precolonial and early colonial elites became intertwined.⁶ I cover two specific examples of this layering effect in the colonial archive, the first being the intelligence collection efforts made by officers on the Welsh expedition, the second being the early 19th-century surveys of Francis Buchanan.

Thomas Welsh was sent to Assam in 1792 in order to prop up the flagging government there and assert control over large groups of bandits and mercenaries circulating around in the northern frontier of Rangpur district. I connect the mission's collection of intelligence to the cultivation of allies within the Assamese aristocracy. State breakdown in Assam had fractured the kingdom's

⁴ Arupjyoti Saikia, 'Geographical Exploration and Historical Investigation: John Peter Wade in Assam,' in eds. Neeladri Bhattacharya and Joy Pachuau, *Landscape, Culture, and Belonging: Writing the History of Northeast India* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2019), pp. 110-128; Bodhisattva Kar, 'Welsh's Fallacy: Rereading the Eighteenth-Century Ahom Crisis,' in ed. Subhas Chakraborty, *The Eighteenth Century in South Asia: New Terrains* (Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Calcutta, 2012), pp. 129-167; David Vumlallian Zou and M. Satish Kumar, 'Mapping a Colonial Borderland: Objectifying the Geo-Body of India's Northeast,' *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 70:1 (2011), pp. 141-170; Pum Khan Pau, 'Transborder People, Connected History: Border and Relationships in the Indo-Burma Borderlands,' *Journal of Borderlands Studies*, 35:4 (2018), pp. 619-639; Sanjib Baruah, 'Territoriality, Indigeneity and Rights in the North-East India,' *Economic and Political Weekly*, 43:12/13 (2008), pp. 15-19; Yasmin Saikia, *Fragmented Memories: Struggling to be Tai-Ahom in India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004); Sanghamitra Misra, 'Changing Frontiers and Spaces,' *Studies in History*, 21:2 (2005), pp. 215-246; Jayeeta Sharma, *Empire's Garden: Assam and the Making of India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011); David Ludden, 'The First Boundary of Bangladesh on Sylhet's Northern Frontiers,' *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bangladesh*, 48:1 (2003), pp. 1-54.

⁵ The relationship between knowledge and power in premodern South Asia is discussed extensively in Sheldon Pollock, 'Deep Orientalism? Notes on Sanskrit and Power Beyond the Raj,' in eds. Carol A. Breckenridge and Peter van der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), pp. 76-133. See also Sheldon Pollock, *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture, and Power in Premodern India* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006).

⁶ A closely related argument can be found in Irschick, *Dialogue and History*.

elite into multiple factions locked in high-stakes conflict, members of whom were actively seeking out the patronage of many surrounding states, hoping to secure their support in taking and maintaining power in exchange for becoming clients. The EIC became one of the principal sources of such patronage. In the beginning Welsh's principal ally was the king who had invited him in, but he quickly came into conflict with him and his principal ministers, forcing him to turn elsewhere for support. He found it in a series of court notables who themselves had come into conflict with the king and were his active enemies. Most of the information collected by the Welsh expedition originated in these individuals, and they influenced Welsh's own views on how the monarchy had traditionally been run, leading him to believe that in the past it had operated on constitutional principles – his own framing, but one which was an attempt to interpret the words of his informants, who were engaged in a struggle over monarchical authority.

Francis Buchanan's early 19th century surveys were conducted in order to bring the Company's gaze down to the local level in Bengal and across the subcontinent. Though this was an effort that primarily focused on Company domains, especially those that were lucrative to rule because of advanced commerce, dense populations and high agricultural productivity, Buchanan's inquiries were wide-ranging and incidentally collected a vast trove of information not only on remote areas nominally under Company rule but also many of the surrounding states and populations. He spent a year in Goalpara, on the border with Assam, where he conducted a series of interviews with local people in order to pull together from many different threads a composite picture of Nepal, Bhutan, Assam and the whole surrounding region. His extensive reliance on the testimony of indigenous informants provides a useful opportunity for the analysis of who they might have been and how their ideas might have affected his own. I isolate three groups: factions of Assamese aristocrats different from the ones that Welsh was speaking to, who provided their own interpretations of Assam in line with their differing interests; Bengali brahmins who served in courts across the region and who emphasized their role in producing cultural transformation in Assam and elsewhere, and aided Buchanan in ordering the human diversity of this frontier into discreet and endogamous caste and tribal groupings; and chiefs from the Garo tribal community occupying the highlands between Bengal and Assam, who were engaged in a struggle to maintain autonomy in the face of encroachment on the part of Bengali zamindars presiding over large estates straddling the mountains.

The chapter is divided into three sections. The first two deal with the Welsh expedition. In the first I trace the social and political history of the mission, showing how heavily reliant it was on networks of collaborators, who were looking for support from outside patrons as they were immersed in a deadly world of factional politics taking place in the context of a protracted conflict following on the breakdown of the Ahom monarch's personal authority. The second section looks at the expedition's production of the first burst of reliable information the Company had access to on Assam, showing how it emerged from collaborating factions within the Ahom elite who used these exchanges to influence Welsh, shaping his views on how the monarchy had traditionally been run, which he combined with his knowledge of English political customs to create an idiosyncratic interpretation of Assam as a constitutional monarchy. The third considers the series of surveys undertaken at the turn of the century by Francis Buchanan from Goalpara, disentangling the jumble of viewpoints within his writing, isolating out the main groups of informants that provided him with information and considering what imprint they may have left on his descriptions of Assam and the surrounding area.

FACTIONALISM AND COLLABORATION ON THE WELSH EXPEDITION (1792-4)

In this section, I demonstrate the extent to which the collapse of political order in Assam during the late 18th century was driven by personal ambition on all sides, as internal factionalism and external opportunism intertwined to erode the kingdom's stability. The king himself, desperate to retain power in the face of popular revolt and declining support among the kingdom's political elite, invited the Company in and willingly offered to become its client, attempting to use its military strength to eliminate his enemies and secure a throne that he otherwise surely would have lost. The Ahom aristocracy, alienated by the king's heavy-handed tactics and his reliance on Bengali ministers, also sought out Welsh's support in order to curtail the power of the king and secure their inherited rights. At the same time, Welsh's actions were deeply shaped by his own personal ambitions: he wanted to conquer Assam and become its ruler himself, against the interests of the Company and in direct contradiction of his orders. Though Welsh was recalled to Bengal for his indiscipline, leaving his conquest of Assam incomplete, the dominant themes in his correspondence of factionalism and self-seeking among the Ahom elite, combined with opportunism on Welsh's part, hidden behind a false, public-facing mask of liberal compassion, illustrates well the intersection of pre-colonial and early colonial contests for wealth and power.

In my section on the relationship between Assam and Rangpur in chapter one I concluded with a discussion of a series of petitions made to the EIC by various parties active in local politics in the Goalpara region. The petition of the Ahom monarch in particular seems to have prompted the commissioning of the Welsh expedition. Welsh's orders were multifaceted, including to break up roving mercenary bands in the countryside and to collect information, but first and foremost he was to prop up the failing monarchy.⁷ The desperation of the king was immediately apparent as soon as Welsh crossed into the kingdom. He sent interpreters to guide Welsh to Guwahati, where he was then based, who gave him information on marching routes to the city, its layout and active battle lines – the city was under siege by the Derrung raja, whose mercenaries were well armed as they had stormed some of the arsenals of the king.⁸ The translator also gave Welsh a letter written by the king explaining that he was in dire straits. He needed Welsh to come as quickly as possible with as many soldiers as possible, writing that “we resemble a loaded boat when sunk. What are we to do?”⁹ When Welsh finally met the king, he was fleeing down the river from Guwahati after having been driven out of the city by a pretender who had suddenly appeared, titling himself the Burge Raja – an obscure figure who the king claimed not even to know, saying that the country was in such chaos that new claimants to the throne appeared daily. The king had been ambushed by the man, who burned down his home; he made a narrow escape with only a few attendants, leaving his own family behind.¹⁰ The king seems to have lost all support by this point, and after entering into Welsh’s camp, was at his mercy.

In the records of his early conversations with Welsh, the king revealed that he intended to use the Company to regain power. He and his prime minister said that they had many enemies, and that they wanted Welsh to bring them all to heel. This included not only Krishnarayan, the Derrung raja and his mercenary army, and the Burge Raja now in control of Guwahati, but also the Moamarias, a large religious sect-turned insurgency that had earlier driven him out of and was now in control of his capital. The king asked Welsh to write back to Calcutta for more troops. Members of the king's inner circle assured Welsh that if the Company brought more troops in

⁷ IOR/P/114/63, October 3rd, 1792, No. 17.

⁸ IOR/P/114/65, November 23rd, 1792, No. 14.

⁹ IOR/P/114/65, November 23rd, 1792, No. 15.

¹⁰ IOR/P/114/65, November 30th, 1792, No. 31.

and reconquered the country for them they could pay for it, but only after they regained control over revenue collection.¹¹

The king and his inner circle provided Welsh the intelligence that he needed to take Guwahati by storm, which he did with minimal casualties on his side, ambushing the Burge raja while he was praying. The raja was captured along with his whole extended household and many of the members of the pretender government he had set up. After Welsh gave them to the king, he had the pretender impaled on a spear and members of his inner circle strangled.¹² It was at this point that Welsh and the king began to come into conflict. Welsh confronted him and reprimanded him for exercising such brutality against prisoners. His subsequent description of the man enclosed in the same set of documents is vitriolic in the extreme. He calls the king poor, debilitated and incapable of conducting his own business, accuses him of being addicted to opium, and of being controlled by his ministers, “who are a set of villains drawing in different ways.” He singled out the king's prime minister – who was an ethnic Bengali – for some of the worst criticism, writing that he was told the man was the author of all the Ahom nobles’ misfortunes and that he was planning to assassinate the king for inviting the Company in, the beginning of a long series of references to internecine conflict among the kingdom’s multiethnic ruling elite.¹³

The tensions emerging between Welsh and his hosts came from multiple sources. One issue revolved around Krishnarayan, the Derrung raja, whom Welsh wanted pardoned – he saw this as a way of starting to rebuild patronage networks that could bring stability to the kingdom, and of recuperating the name of the king, whose murder of Krishnarayan's father was publicly known and widely considered a deplorable act. The king and his advisors refused to do this, saying that they could not forgive treason. Another issue revolved around supplying the Company’s troops. Welsh wrote back to Calcutta that the nobles around the king had massive estates and controlled large numbers of serfs, but gave only a very small portion of their produce to the king and were not in the habit of bringing much to market for sale. Welsh, who at this time was virtually penniless, reporting having trouble scrounging together 1000 rupees to buy rice for his troops, eventually turned to forcing Ahom nobles in a coercive manner to supply him. Welsh also seems

¹¹ IOR/P/114/66, December 17th, 1792, Nos. 47-50; these requests are repeated in a letter by the king to the government, IOR/P/114/65, December 28th, 1792, No. 9.

¹² IOR/P/114/66, December 17th, 1792, No. 47.

¹³ IOR/P/114/66, December 17th, 1792, No. 50.

to have viewed the weakness of the king with a predatory eye. In his reporting on the situation in the kingdom he concludes by saying that if he is allowed to stay long term, “a new source of wealth and riches will flow to the Company,” the implication being that the distracted state of the kingdom would make it an easy conquest,¹⁴ though in a subsequent reply the government reminded him that his mission was not to engage in unrestrained conquest but to guard the king and convince Krishnarayan’s mercenaries to return home by whatever means.¹⁵

In his correspondence with Calcutta, Welsh angled hard for deposing the king or restraining his power, and taking control of the kingdom himself. He insisted that the king was totally incompetent, that his ministers were disobedient, corrupt and despised throughout Assam, and that most of the respectable people in the country were of the opinion that until the king's ministers were dismissed and the state placed under Welsh’s control nothing could be done to alleviate the situation.¹⁶ He subsequently documented a list of accusations against the king made to him by various people, as well as some of his own observations. One consisted of complaints by local villagers that men sent out by the king to gather provisions were engaging in plunder, taking not only more grain than necessary but also extorting money.¹⁷ On hearing that the king was continuing to put to death prisoners of war, Welsh took over and opened up the prison in Guwahati and found 70 people starving and dying. He interrogated the prison keeper who said that he answered directly to the prime minister, who had been refusing to give the prisoners food, and that 113 had already died. He interviewed the prisoners, most of whom he said seemed not to know what their crime was. Infuriated, Welsh had the prime minister put under arrest, as well as the kingdom’s treasurer, a staunch ally of the prime minister. He then began collecting testimony against them, but said that people were afraid to come forward because they thought they would be targeted in the case of his leaving.¹⁸

The breaking point came when the king had one of his servants’ eyes gouged out and nose and ears cut off as punishment for speaking out of turn. Welsh afterward interviewed the man, who had been treated by Peter Wade, the doctor on the expedition (and who included in his

¹⁴ IOR/P/114/66, December 17th, 1792, Nos. 47-50.

¹⁵ IOR/P/114/66, December 21st, 1792, No. 17.

¹⁶ IOR/P/114/68, January 14th, 1793, No. 21.

¹⁷ IOR/P/114/68, January 14th, 1793, No. 22.

¹⁸ IOR/P/114/69, January 28th, 1793, No. 7.

correspondence to the government a grotesque medical description of the man's condition). The servant said that the king had put a question to someone else and he had answered it, after which he was immediately dragged out of the room and mutilated. Nobles who were present confirmed the servant's account, saying that they had begged the king not to do it, but to no avail. After this, Welsh confronted the king, said that the responsibility for the general rebellion against him lay at his own feet, and that in order to make peace with his people he needed to adopt a gentler line of conduct. The king was, according to him, unapologetic, exulting in ordering the punishment and saying that if he was deprived of the power to kill or injure his subjects he would no longer wish to be a king. He said that Welsh was sent to obey his orders, that he could summon a giant army if he wanted to and owed the Company nothing, and demanded that his imprisoned ministers be released. Welsh wrote to the government that the king's words and actions were those of a madman.¹⁹

After Welsh was told by informants that the king was attempting to round up members of the court that had been friendly to him in order to have them killed, he moved against him, curtailing his movements and putting him under guard. He wrote a sharply worded letter to the king saying that when the Company had intervened on his behalf they had no idea what the internal situation in the kingdom was like. He told Gaurinath that his mutilation of his servant had convinced him of his cruel disposition, that he was a tyrant, that he had lost his own throne because of his behavior, and that he was taking control of the kingdom in order to liberate his oppressed people.²⁰ Welsh subsequently replaced the king's council with new figures handpicked by himself, began to hold weekly durbars, reduced the king's staff to a small skeleton in order to provide for his upkeep, and forced him to agree in writing to four propositions: that he let Welsh dismiss any member of the government that he pleased; that he pardon and make peace with all his rebellious subjects; that he stop executing or mutilating people without trial; and that he summon all the principal elites of the country for a council.²¹

Welsh was aided in this move by powerful nobles, in particular the Burra Fokun, the viceroy of Kamrup, the westernmost province of Assam, wrested from the Mughals. He supported Welsh's

¹⁹ IOR/P/114/70, February 15th, 1793, Nos. 15, 16.

²⁰ IOR/P/114/70, February 15th, 1793, No. 17.

²¹ IOR/P/114/70, February 22nd, 1793, Nos. 13, 14.

decision to usurp the king and helped him to craft a plan for the return of the kingdom back to the flourishing state it had been in in what he represented as a past golden age.²² With this man by his side, Welsh wrote a letter which he sent out to the principal elites of the kingdom, in which he said that he understood why they were in rebellion, as the king's government had been highly oppressive, that he had removed the king from power, and that he had come not to conquer but to liberate. The letter then invited each of them to come in to Guwahati and join him in a general council that could begin to knit the kingdom back together.²³

Welsh also enclosed with these letters manifestos justifying his seizure of the state, which were to be put up in public areas. In the first, he said that he had come to restore order to the kingdom but had discovered that the government's ministers were so corrupt and oppressive that they were making his goal impossible. He explained that he had dismissed them and that he would no longer tolerate arbitrary bondage, confiscation, execution without trial or any other oppressive practices. The manifesto concludes by asking the population to register complaints to him in the event of any further similar acts.²⁴ A second manifesto specifically addressed his usurpation of the king, in which he said that his sanguinary disposition had alienated the population, made it easy for rebels and pretenders to gather supporters and stake claims, and had left him virtually destitute, wandering around aimlessly among people who had largely turned their backs on him. Despite this he had stubbornly persisted in his prior practices and thus was a danger to the population. He forbade any of the king's subjects from communicating with him and declared the management of the area around Guwahati to be in the hands of the Burra Fokun.²⁵

Welsh's attempts to secure the support of other elites in the area around Guwahati by way of these letters and manifestos do not seem to have been successful. He found that the tributaries of the Ahom state did not have a fixed or regularized relationship to it but rather were sovereign rulers in their own right whose relations with their suzerain were conducted in an ambiguous space between war, diplomacy and administration. Rulers in the surrounding area corresponded with him but refused to come into treat with him in person. They provided a variety of reasons

²² IOR/P/114/69, January 28th, 1793, No. 7.

²³ IOR/P/114/69, January 28th, 1793, No. 9.

²⁴ J. Johnstone, *Captain Welsh's Expedition to Assam in 1792, 1793, and 1794* (Calcutta: Foreign Department Press, 1877), Appendix A.

²⁵ Johnstone, *Captain Welsh's Expedition to Assam*, Appendix C.

for this. The raja of Lucki Duar, a small mountain pass neighboring the Garo hills, said that he was indisposed because a Garo chief had assembled a force to attack him. He said that he had formerly defeated the Garos and taken control of part of their territory, but in a counteroffensive they pushed him back into the plains and now wanted revenge against him and to take all of his land. He offered to ally with Welsh but for a price – Welsh was to help him retake his lost Garo territories. He finished his letter by admitting that he owed back taxes to the government, which he would pay “when convenient.”²⁶ The Dimarua raja said that he was tributary to the Khyrim and Jaintia rajas and because of this he could not admit Welsh’s messengers into the interior of his country (Welsh bemoaned that this triple sovereignty arrangement, far from constricting him, rendered him in a manner “independent of all at pleasure”).²⁷

Longstanding factional feuds and the de facto sovereign status of powerful Ahom aristocrats made it difficult for Welsh to court them as well. He reached out to the Burra Gohain, a powerful duke who controlled a large fiefdom in eastern Assam and was on the front lines fighting against the Moamarias. He replied that he and his family were too busy to come in, as they had assembled an army comprised of local elites and hill tribe chieftains, and were trying to retake the capital. He also called the king and his advisors repugnant, and made it clear that no one in his camp would countenance him treating with them. He offered to join forces with Welsh, but only on the condition that Welsh send reinforcements, as well as the former prime minister to him, presumably for punishment, as a token of goodwill.²⁸

Welsh concluded from these communications that factionalism in the area was too far gone for him to achieve support through negotiation, and sketched out more detailed plans that amounted to the creation of a colonial administration. He asked for permission to use force to bring in refractory local elites,²⁹ and repeated again that building a smoothly functioning government would require his permanent presence in the kingdom.³⁰ Along with this assertion he included a detailed plan to make that permanent presence profitable for his employers, including the abolition of all the monopolies on commerce operated by people on both sides of the border and

²⁶ IOR/P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 16.

²⁷ IOR/P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 16.

²⁸ IOR/P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 16.

²⁹ IOR/P/115/1, March 22nd, 1793, No. 33.

³⁰ IOR/P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 15.

their replacement with a single Company monopoly over salt. He also proposed redirecting the vast majority of customs revenues and changing practices of taxation in the kingdom, converting the corvee labor traditionally owed to the king and other elites into cash taxes, which he could siphon up. Appended to this plan was a document in Bengali publishing commercial regulations for merchants, intended to curtail their influence over local politics and increase customs revenues. These included free trade in both directions, a transparent list of duties to be paid at the border, banning arms dealing, forbidding customs agents from also acting as merchants, decreeing that they keep account books to be audited on a regular basis, and forbidding any merchants based in Bengal, European or native, from permanently residing in Assam.³¹

As Welsh's presence in the kingdom became more entrenched, a number of key figures went over to his side. One of the staunchest of these allies ironically became Krishnarayan himself, the head of the mercenary army that he had been sent in to deal with. Krishnarayan seems to have been politically astute. He immediately began courting Welsh as soon as he set foot in Assam, sending an envoy out to advocate his case. The envoy made it clear that Krishnarayan desired to work with him; he had even been granted power of attorney to make decisions on his behalf.³² He told Welsh that his patron's primary concern was his own personal safety. Krishnarayan feared that the king would kill him if he turned himself in. He offered to become his ally in exchange for protection.³³

This began a long negotiation, not only with Krishnarayan but also with his extended family and the captains of the mercenary battalions who were living amongst them. Each of these alliances came with a price. Welsh convinced the mercenaries to give themselves up by promising to pay their arrears and assuring that if they peacefully returned to Bengal they would be given asylum. A large chunk of Krishnarayan's force took him up on this offer. Welsh's communications to the government on June 3rd, 1793 contain a lengthy list – an entire army, including each soldier's name, ranks, and the amount of money he was owed (judging by the names, all were from outside of Assam).³⁴ After this he restored Krishnarayan to his throne and gave his brothers lesser seats of power in other areas of Kamrup, while compelling them to swear that they would not

³¹ IOR/P/115/1, March 11th, 1793, No. 17.

³² IOR/P/114/65, November 26th, 1792, No. 8.

³³ IOR/P/114/65, December 17th, 1792, No. 47.

³⁴ IOR/P/115/6, June 3rd, 1793, No. 11.

make war among themselves. In the process he took down a lengthy genealogy of their family which had a clear political slant. It wound all the way back to before the region was conquered by the Ahoms, after which these princes had been forced into the position of clients with greatly curtailed power.³⁵ They wanted the restoration of their family's authority to its former extent – possibly beyond that as they were also asking for control of Kaliabor, where the Ahom viceroy of Kamrup was based – and were willing to pay a massive tribute for that privilege on the order of 100,000 rupees yearly.³⁶

Welsh's other chief source of support while he was in the kingdom came from a faction of powerful Ahom aristocrats, including some of the most illustrious men in the kingdom, who resented Gaurinath's appointment of Bengalis to high positions of power. This included the Solal Gohain, a marcher lord in control of a long stretch of territory around Nagaon, who met with Lieutenant McGregor, one of Welsh's subordinates, who had been sent out into eastern Assam at the head of a scouting party. He whispered in his ear that he could not speak freely as he was surrounded by enemies, but offered to send his vakeel the next day to meet with him privately. The Burra Gohain, a close ally of the Solal Gohain, came as well, leaving his house in secret so that even his own counselors did not know where he was going. During this conversation they told MacGregor that their main objection to the king's government was his selection of ministers. They said that established custom gave the Ahom conquest elite monopoly over high offices and the right to have a say in who was appointed to them, but that Gaurinath had gone over their heads and begun to surround himself with Bengali court functionaries.³⁷

The interview alluded to intense conflict, sometimes spilling out into open warfare, taking place between this faction and that led by the former prime minister and treasurer, who were not members of any of the kingdom's principal aristocratic clans and therefore customarily should not have held such high offices. They accused these favorites of the king of making up a series of false charges against them for political reasons, and asked to be pardoned. They also accused the men of theft and private conquest. They said that although Welsh had sent the prime minister and treasurer into exile, their influence was still felt throughout the kingdom, in particular through

³⁵ IOR/P/115/6, June 14th, 1793, Nos. 11, 12.

³⁶ IOR/P/115/7, June 28th, Nos. 39, 40; IOR/P/115/18, February 3rd, No. 6.

³⁷ IOR/P/115/16, December 16th, 1793, No. 40.

the prime minister's son, who had collected an army around himself and subjected many of the petty rajas and zamindars on the southern borders of the domains of the Bor Baruah, another of the kingdom's principal aristocrats. He said that it would not be enough simply to dispossess these men of their station, but that both of their families – they were intermarried with each other – had to be uprooted from the territories that they controlled, otherwise they would always be able to raise troops and try to enlarge their domains at the expense of their neighbors.³⁸

Welsh arrived at Koliabar shortly after McGregor, and in his own meeting with the Solal Gohain, the Burra Gohain and the Burra Fokun, they said that it was imperative that the ancient form of government be restored to Assam, and that they were willing to pay a steep cost for it. They recommended appointing a man from one of the principal Ahom clans to the office of prime minister, and carted out two young princes who they said were members of the royal family and should be considered for succession to the throne. They said that they had hidden these children from Gaurinath on his succession to prevent them from being mutilated – a normal practice to deny lesser princes the ability to challenge a new king's rule. In return for Welsh handing the kingdom to these men they agreed to pay 150,000 rupees per year. The Burra Fokun would also undertake the task of supplying Welsh's expeditionary force as it moved deeper into the kingdom to defeat the Moamarias. It was also agreed upon that when a new prime minister was appointed, he would enter into an agreement to pay a large amount to defray the costs of the expedition.³⁹ Sivadatta Chetia, the successor eventually chosen, lifted 300,000 rupees out of the king's treasury for Welsh.⁴⁰

As Welsh's force moved deeper into the kingdom, the government in Calcutta become increasingly concerned with its indiscipline and lack of responsiveness to central control. Welsh's final act while in Assam was to recapture the kingdom's capital from the Moamarias. In this action he was aided by the Burra Gohain, who provided intelligence and supplies.⁴¹ After the capture of the capital Welsh's troops thoroughly looted it to the tune of around 100,000 rupees, most of which was then auctioned off in a grand bazaar established in the middle of his camp; his

³⁸ IOR/P/115/16, December 16th, 1793, No. 41.

³⁹ IOR/P/115/19 February 24th, 1794, No. 15.

⁴⁰ S. K. Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations, 1771-1826* (Guwahati: Department of Historical and Antiquarian Studies, Government of Assam, 1949), p. 356.

⁴¹ IOR/P/115/20, March 14th, 1794, No. 28.

officers then turned to infighting over who got what portion, to the extent that some threatened to hire lawyers.⁴² For this they were harshly reprimanded by the government, which said that it was unusual for an army that had come to liberate an occupied country to then pillage it, ordered them to give back all their stolen goods, and fired Lieutenant McGregor, who seems to have been primarily responsible.⁴³ Welsh tried to defend the actions of his men by saying that the king had given the troops permission to loot as a gift for retaking his capital, and that most of the captured property likely belonged to the Moamaria leadership, which had controlled the city for several years, building a series of luxurious mansions (the followers of the king and his counselors also engaged in mass looting of the capital, suggesting that this was plausible).⁴⁴ He also, somewhat more improbably, claimed that the king would compensate the Moamarias, his sworn enemies, for the lost property.⁴⁵ The Governor General wrote back that he found it difficult to understand how a king who had essentially become Welsh's puppet could have willingly consented to anything.⁴⁶

This garish display of self-interest seems to have been what precipitated Welsh's recall. Another factor was the ascension of a new Governor General, Sir John Shore, who took a much less interventionist line in the politics of states surrounding the Company's domains and believed from the outset of his tenure that Welsh's deployment had been a mistake.⁴⁷ In a minute shortly after his taking office, he wrote that Welsh had failed to form a government in the kingdom by getting its elites to negotiate with him, and had failed to pay for the expedition. The new Governor General suggested that Welsh's true aim in the kingdom was not a humanitarian one and immediately ordered him to suspend all military operations unless they were directly connected to his own self-defense or the defense of the king. He also included a list of pointed questions to Welsh about the internal state of the kingdom, as well as the role he had come to

⁴² IOR/P/115/22, April 14th, 1794, Nos. 22, 23.

⁴³ IOR/P/115/22, April 14th, 1794, No. 24.

⁴⁴ IOR/P/115/23, May 28th, 1794, No. 29.

⁴⁵ IOR/P/115/22, April 25th, 1794, Nos. 22-24.

⁴⁶ IOR/P/115/23, May 28th, 1794, No. 37.

⁴⁷ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 392-8.

play in its politics.⁴⁸ Welsh's replies to these questions were very lengthy;⁴⁹ below I abstract from them only the information related to factionalism and collaboration.

Welsh portrayed the breakdown of political authority that he had witnessed as a consequence of the king's tyranny, combined with his surrounding himself with ministers not drawn from the hereditary Ahom nobility. He pinpointed the Bengali family who had held the position of prime minister for at least four generations as the main source of discontent driving factional conflict. He wrote that there were instances in which this family had interfered in succession to the throne, and that in general they had gained control of the king and much of the state, diverting power from the "lawful channel" of the Ahom elite and in particular the royal council. He also put forward the personality of the king as another major source of discontent, describing an uptick of violence in the aftermath of his coronation, including the murder of the Burra Gohain and his five sons, the mutilation of the Bar Barua and numerous other crimes against members of the hereditary nobility, who themselves were riven with factionalism but who he wrote seemed to be united in their sentiments against Gaurinath and his inner circle. He pointed to what he described as the weakness and viciousness of the former administration as having led to a more general insurrection among the population, embodied in the Moamarias, who had driven the king from his capital, forcing him to take to a roving lifestyle in which his favorites were accused of plundering the countryside wherever they went. Through this behavior his authority had evaporated completely, Welsh wrote, and as a consequence most of the kingdom's nobility, from the most powerful down to the most petty, along with a number of obscure adventurers, had set up statelets in every direction.

Welsh said that the king had become largely a figurehead, and that the only source of political stability in the kingdom was himself. The only allies he had made within the Ahom aristocracy and among tributary princes were personally loyal to him; most of them hated Guarinath and would never follow him. He said the only way to solve the problem of this power vacuum was for him to stay permanently in Assam, backed by the Company as a "mediating and controlling influence." In the event of his withdrawal, he suggested the possibility of score settling as factions that had been allied with him fought against those whose interests had been damaged by

⁴⁸ IOR/P/115/18, January 6th, 1794, No. 21.

⁴⁹ IOR/P/115/19, February 24th, 1794, No. 14.

him, and that many of the figures who had attached themselves to him would likely be forced to into exile, as they derived much of their power from their connection to the Company.

The Governor General in his reply said that it was never his mission to take permanent control of Assam, a step he was not willing to authorize. He told Welsh to inform the kingdom's elites that they would be given three months to form a government, and if they could not, the consequences would be on their shoulders. He finished by musing that if it was true that Gaurinath was really so monstrous, it was probably morally wrong to artificially keep him on the throne, and that if he was driven from power, so be it, although he offered to give him refuge in Bengal.⁵⁰ The Governor General also included in this minute two letters, one of them from the treasurer and prime minister deposed by Welsh, and the other supposedly from the king, but which he said was likely fraudulent, written by the former two. Presumably he did so in order to illustrate the treacherousness and intractability of factional politics in the kingdom – and Welsh's own role in exacerbating them – in order to bolster his own argument for pulling out.

The letters portray Welsh as the tyrant rather than the king. The first claimed that he was supposed to have been acting under the authority of the king but instead had effectively usurped him, after which he briefly imprisoned the prime minister and treasurer, and then forced them back into their homes, where they remained trapped for nearly a year. They then were suddenly seized and carried away to exile in Bengal. They said that Welsh had become king in all but name, funneling most of the kingdom's taxes into his hands, and had been the cause of many outrages. They requested that a new person be sent who was more amenable to the king's wishes and that they be released and restored to their posts.⁵¹

The other, supposedly by the king, told a similar story, in which Welsh had overstepped his original mandate, removing the king from power, as well as most of his allies, and either imprisoning them or sending them into exile. He had then put the royal family of Derrung in control of large parts of eastern Assam which were previously controlled by the king, and had generally abrogated unto himself the king's authority and wealth, acted without his orders, confined him, and prevented from washing, praying or speaking to his priests. He asked that the

⁵⁰ IOR/P/115/20, March 19th, 1794, No. 16.

⁵¹ IOR/P/115/20, March 19th, 1794, No. 18.

former monopoly arrangements made by his customs officers at the Goalpara border be restored, and that his prime minister and treasurer be sent back to him. The letter also included a large present of gold.⁵²

Though like Welsh's own correspondence these letters need to be read critically as they were rhetorical instruments meant to achieve a specific political goal, they provide important insight into the extent to which Welsh had become entangled in the kingdom's factional politics as a participant rather than arbiter. They portray him not as the guardian of the king, or as the hand of the Company's interests, but as a heavy-handed usurper who had hijacked the machinery of state out of personal ambition. While clearly framed in order to delegitimize Welsh so that the disgraced ministers could return to their previous positions of power, the letters nonetheless underscore how thoroughly Welsh had become enmeshed in local factionalism in ways that mirrored the ambitions of the elites he claimed to be policing.

On April 7th, 1794 Welsh announced to the government he had created that he was leaving, which set off panic. His account of the meeting describes desperation on the part of the king and his inner circle, who said that without the Company's presence the kingdom would return to its previous state.⁵³ In a subsequent meeting they expressed dismay at the government withdrawing its assistance in the middle of an unwon war, and said that if he withdrew from the capital the king and his council would be forced to follow because they had no independent power base.⁵⁴ The Burra Gohain asked if a rear guard of troops could remain stationed in his stronghold of Jorhat as it would provide the security that he needed to finish the construction of an army that he planned to use to reunite the kingdom.⁵⁵ Letters from the collected members of government, including all five members of the royal council, deluged the Company with requests to let Welsh stay and plans to pay for his expenses. The king also wrote similar letters, begging the government to at least let Welsh destroy the Moamarias before he returned, and station a contingent of troops at the capital to provide a cordon of security around his palace.⁵⁶ On the day he left, the king and his ministers begged Welsh once more to stay, and left with him as well;

⁵² IOR/P/115/20, March 19th, 1794, No. 19.

⁵³ IOR/P/115/22, April 7th, 1794, No. 41.

⁵⁴ IOR/P/115/23, May 12th, 1794, No. 2.

⁵⁵ IOR/P/115/23, May 28th, 1794, No. 31.

⁵⁶ IOR/P/115/24, June 2nd, 1794, Nos. 22, 23.

most of the inhabitants of the city trailed behind. A final round of coordinated letters from the king and all five members of the royal council repeated the same request: that if the government was totally set on this course of action they should let all of the inhabitants of Assam migrate to Bengal because the country would become a death trap.⁵⁷ European private merchants and Bengali merchants who had started to branch out into the Assam trade under Welsh's security umbrella also submitted similar petitions asking for Welsh to stay so that their investments could be protected.⁵⁸

In his short time in the kingdom, the military power exercised by Welsh completely reoriented the kingdom's politics around him, so that when he was finally recalled to Calcutta, his doomful prediction that the kingdom would spin apart proved correct. The period after his withdrawal was marked by an intense round of factional violence. In Guwahati, Welsh's former advisors set up a boy pretender on the throne, writing a letter to the Company explaining that Gaurinath was a "senseless idiot...who had wantonly destroyed three or four score men of rank and murdered the father of Krishnarayan Jemindar (the Derrung raja) with a hatchet" – this group wasted no time in locating and killing those who had crossed them in the past, until they themselves were betrayed, captured and executed, except one that fled to Bhutan.⁵⁹ The Derrung rajas were so entangled with Welsh that two of the three decided to leave with him for Bengal. The king sunk back into obscurity and fell under the sway of the Burra Gohain. He died shortly after of dysentery. In the interim before the First Anglo-Burmese War brought the Company into Assam once again, the Burra Gohain controlled the throne by way of two separate kings, both of whom he elevated to the position, which by this point was largely ceremonial – political authority in the kingdom was coalescing around him and the army that he had created to fight the Moamarias.⁶⁰

The Welsh expedition provides a stark example of how factionalism in precolonial politics intersected with the colonial drive for conquest, creating a mutually reinforcing dynamic that could bring entire states under Company control with minimal effort or expenditure of resources.

⁵⁷ IOR/P/115/24, June 13th, 1794, Nos. 9, 12.

⁵⁸ IOR/P/115/25, July 7th, 1794, Nos. 21-23.

⁵⁹ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 390-1.

⁶⁰ King Badanchandra, who ascended to the throne as a teenager, is described as having lived a largely sequestered life, his main friends being his maid, whom he eventually married, and the poultry keeper's son. His one attempt to wrest real power back from the Burra Gohain ended with a general purge of the court in which his supporters were killed and he was driven into exile in Bengal. Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 424-59.

The fragmented political landscape of Assam, marked by popular revolt, a failed centralization effort by the king, and intense rivalry – sometimes ethnically motivated – within the Ahom aristocracy, provided fertile ground for Welsh's own ambitions. Multiple powerful figures, including the king himself, various Ahom aristocrats and minority rajas, sought to leverage the Company's resources and reputation to facilitate their own quests to gain, maintain, and expand power. These figures aided Welsh's own self-interested efforts, offering him political backing and large sums of money. They also provided intelligence that shaped his and the Company's understanding of Assam and surrounding environs, an intersection between elite factionalism and the production of colonial knowledge that is the subject of the next section.

COLLABORATION, INFORMATION AND INTERPRETATION

In this section, I trace the knowledge produced by the Welsh expedition back to its interactions with the Assamese elite. The Company's intelligence-gathering efforts sought to address critical gaps in its understanding of Assam's political and geographical landscape, with a focus on advancing its political and economic interests. In doing so, it relied on indigenous informants, particularly court functionaries and collaborating elites such as the rajas of Derrung and sympathetic Assamese nobles. These informants used their communications with information-hungry Company officials to advance their own claims, shaping the information collected. Welsh came to believe that Assam's troubles stemmed from Gaurinath's departure from a constitutional order in which collective rule was exercised by the kingdom's primary aristocratic clans. This interpretation, unmistakably influenced by Welsh's understanding of English political customs, also aligned with the interests of his principal collaborators, who sought to diminish the king's authority and maintain the monopolization of political power by the Ahom aristocracy – a Southeast Asian conquest elite whose hereditary privileges were threatened by Gaurinath's appointment of Bengali allies to high positions.

The Company had very little knowledge of Assam before it sent its brief military foray into the kingdom under Thomas Welsh in 1792. Before that time, available knowledge came mostly in the form of a few early modern travel accounts originating in the Mughal Empire's 16th and 17th-century invasions of Assam, out of which came memoirs written by Europeans accompanying the Mughal armies. Persian manuscripts chronicling the wars were also subsequently translated

by Company officials.⁶¹ Prior to the dispatch of Welsh, the only real attempt to collect information made by the Company had centered on trade. In 1787 it appointed an official to Goalpara to monopolize trade with Assam, also asking him to provide a written response to ten questions about Assam. All revolved around the Company's commercial concerns, and in particular the lucrative salt trade, save for the last, which asked what military force would be required to back his activities.⁶² In part this dearth of information was due to the fact that the Assamese state, and most of the states surrounding Bengal, major and minor, barred EIC servants from entry and actively counteracted attempts to gather information.⁶³

This gap in the Company's knowledge of its borderlands became acutely apparent as it tried to grasp the reasons behind the slide into civil strife in neighboring Assam and trace the flows of mercenaries into and out of its territory. Correspondence between Calcutta and local officials in Rangpur district in the period before Welsh's deployment record a scramble for any information that they could find on these patterns, including a variety of rumors that turned out to be untrue, such as that British officers were moonlighting as mercenary captains in Assam.⁶⁴ In Welsh's deployment instructions he was specifically told to solve the problem of this information famine by spending time in Goalpara attempting to collect intelligence before crossing the border; only after Welsh had provided the Governor General with intelligence could he provide any detailed instructions.⁶⁵

The intent from the beginning was to collect information on a large scale. In the Governor General's minute giving his rationale behind dispatching the mission he included a discussion not only of Assam but also of all the Himalayan states from Tibet to Nepal, Bhutan and onward, saying that it was shameful that although this area of the world immediately bordered on Company domains, they knew next to nothing of it, and that rectifying this was in the Company's

⁶¹ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 57-73; Henry Vansittart, 'A Description of Asam,' *Asiatic Researches*, 2 (1799), pp. 171-185.

⁶² Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, p. 159.

⁶³ In the 1760s for example, James Rennell, one of the Company's earliest and most important surveyors, was forced back when he tried to enter Assam (and then nearly hacked to death by Afghan horsemen, yet more evidence of the weak nature of the Company's grip on this borderland). James Rennell, *The Journals of Major James Rennell, First Surveyor-General of India* (Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Calcutta, 1910), p. 84.

⁶⁴ Johnstone, *Captain Welsh's Expedition to Assam*, pp. 8-10.

⁶⁵ IOR/P/114/65, November 26th, 1792, No. 6.

immediate political and economic interests.⁶⁶ The importance of this aspect of the mission is clear in personnel choice. The roster included a surveyor named Thomas Wood, who extended the map making activities of the Company into the Brahmaputra basin. Peter Wade, a doctor who was literate in Persian and Bengali, and who had previously written several medical treatises, was expected to serve as a kind of in-house 'orientalist.'⁶⁷

The primary official in charge of collecting historical, political and geographic information on Assam was Peter Wade, who drew extensively on indigenous knowledge in his reports. He was stationed for the majority of the time in Guwahati, which is where the Ahom government was based as it had been driven out of its usual capital. In his research, he had access not only to the court and its functionaries but also to important figures traveling in and out of the city to meet Welsh and members of the government that had coalesced around him. Wade wrote three texts, all of which bear the imprint of having been constructed in concert with these contacts. The first was a book that primarily consisted of several translated court chronicles, but which also included a lengthy description of the structure of the Assamese government.⁶⁸ The second was a geographical overview focusing primarily on the kingdom's rivers and the towns and cities lying along them.⁶⁹ The third was a history of Gaurinath's reign, but this was lost in transit back to England, though Wade does mention in his private correspondence that the information in this text came from officials at court and visiting nobles, as well as translations of documents proffered to him by court scribes (he had a pandit in his employ who helped him translate and interpret documents).⁷⁰

Wade's translated chronicles passed through the hands of at least two sets of intermediaries. One, written in Bengali, translated by his pandit and given to Welsh as a souvenir, was a Koch chronicle dealing primarily with political events in the area around Derrung, including the wars with the Mughals that had brought the area under Ahom control and late political events terminating in the period of Gaurinath's reign. Likely these were provided by the rajas of Derrung as part of their attempts to court Welsh, and to reinforce their claims to hereditary

⁶⁶ IOR/P/114/63, October 3rd, 1792, No. 17.

⁶⁷ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 300-305.

⁶⁸ John Peter Wade, *An Account of Assam* (Guwahati: Asam Jyoti, 1972).

⁶⁹ John Peter Wade, *A Geographical Sketch of Assam*, appended to Wade, *An Account of Assam*.

⁷⁰ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 393-424.

authority over the erstwhile Kingdom of Kamrup, which they hoped to resurrect with the aid of the Company. The second, part of an Ahom chronicle that originated in Gaurinath's household, was in a Southeast Asian script that could only be read by the family of priests who served as the hereditary keepers of the ancient Ahom religion. With their assistance Wade translated part of it.⁷¹

Wade's structural description of the Ahom government also seems to have been based on similar interactions with court officials.⁷² It begins with the kings and their successors to the throne, moves down to feudatory rajas presiding over statelets in the kingdom's borderlands, and then to the three powerful Gohains that controlled large baronies within the kingdom. The vast majority of his description centers on the kingdom's two principal court centers at the capital of Rangpur and in Guwahati. His focus in particular is on the Fokuns, who were the principal judges and military commanders at both Guwahati and Rangpur. He describes them as well as their subsidiary officers, from Rajkoas, commanders of 6000 men, down to Barrahs, commanders of 20. He also provides a similar breakdown of the kingdom's principal civil officers, starting with the prime minister and then glossing over a wide range of officers, titled Baruahs, performing a variety of specific tasks related to the maintenance of the king's household.

The comprehensive detail in these descriptions suggests that they were constructed with insider knowledge. His description of the Fokuns includes the origins of each office, their respective social status, the differences between their functions, their combined civil and military capacity, the number of men each controlled in times of peace and war both for military purposes and as a corvee labor pool, the way in which they organized armies for campaign, how they administered justice, what their relationship to other parts of the government was, where they derived their income from, and the origin of the dual system of courts operated by the Ahoms in their two capitals. Just to give one specific example, in his description of the Daykial Fokun he describes how the man was in charge of 11,000 conscripts drawn from 11 different groups of 1000 each, each of which were attached to the king's household. At any given time 10 or 20 men chosen from each of these groups would form the king's bodyguards, stationed at the gates of the palace; they also served as his personal attendants. He explains the relative status of this man compared

⁷¹ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. i-v.

⁷² Wade, *An Account of Assam*, v-1.

to other Fokuns in the king's civil and military establishment, and how under him he had an array of goldsmiths, coppersmiths, ironsmiths and other artificers with which he provisioned the king. He also levied an annual tax on all artificers who did not serve the king, such as gardeners, flowermen, washermen, limestone cutters, preparers of clarified butter, salt sellers, sellers of blankets to Bhutan, and sellers of cow tails, musk, sandalwood, cotton and dried fish.⁷³

At no point does Wade explain where he got all this information from but there is little chance that he came to such minutely detailed conclusions alone. His overwhelming focus on the civil and military establishment immediately surrounding the king makes sense as that is where he was located. Most likely he pieced all of this information together through interviews with actual members of the king's establishment, asking them questions and taking notes. Alternatively his pandit may have conducted these interviews and simply provided him the results. Both of these were typical working methods for Company servants looking to collect intelligence at the time.⁷⁴

Wade, in his geographical sketch of Assam, does provide some detail on where he got his information from.⁷⁵ After going over some of the early modern and imperfect sources of information Europeans had access to before his entrance into the kingdom, which he attributed to the “jealous spirit of the Chinese government” that pervaded it, he said that this dearth of information had been rectified insofar as was possible by Wood’s survey and also by his geographical sketch, which was based partly on his personal travels and partly on “my intercourse with the most intelligent and best-informed natives.” He apologized for the “unscientific” nature of the information he was providing, alluding to the fact that it was not a mathematically derived cartography, but an exegesis of his “notes and translations” of these conversations. The information is loosely organized and almost presented in stream of consciousness form, suggesting that it was very little changed from whatever notes he took. It is also filled with blank spaces in places where his informants themselves knew little or nothing, especially when it came to the far east of the country under Moamaria control, which he did not

⁷³ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. xxx-xxxi.

⁷⁴ Jon Wilson, *The Domination of Strangers: Modern Governance in Eastern India 1780-1835* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2008), pp. 4-5; Dirks, 'Colonial Histories and Native Informants: Biography of an Archive.'

⁷⁵ John Peter Wade, *A Geographical Sketch of Assam*, appended to Wade, *An Account of Assam*.

even cover as he said that “every person I consulted either confessed their ignorance of those districts or gave such inconsistent accounts as could not be trusted.”

Wade’s geographical information on Assam also bears the marks of being a secondary interpretation of indigenous knowledge. The account is loosely divided up based on province and district but the most important organizing tool is rivers. Within each locale the description centers on rivers and, along those rivers, settlements, which were generally ruled by minor kings or Ahom aristocrats arranged in layered political relationships. Rivers and settlements tended to be bounded in a vague manner by large stretches of mountain associated with one or more tribal groups. Within this mental map each space was associated with a variety of important landmarks like ferries, customs houses, roads, bridges, shrines, fortresses, palaces, mountain passes or frontier outposts. Characteristics like weather, agricultural productivity, natural productions, and population density are also included, as well as other miscellaneous tidbits of information, for example the sites of important historical events or defunct capitals, mythological tales of rivers that spat out fully formed gold utensils, or a story about a seven-story tower in the king’s palace which supposedly contained a labyrinth inside affording him protection from his rebel subjects. Conspicuously absent are borders. Wade does make some attempt to extrapolate where these might have been, but his remarks are highly speculative postscripts. In its focus on rivers and settlements ruled by potentates stacked up on top of each other in a byzantine, shifting set of political relationships bounded by wilderness associated with groups living outside the state, Wade’s *Geographical Sketch* is unmistakably reflecting at some level a concept of geography that was non-European in origin.

The sum of the political intelligence collected by Welsh not only bears the marks of having been constructed in a similar manner, but also contains evidence that he was being influenced by the representations of his informants.⁷⁶ His account, which is written in rapid fire, almost bullet point prose, suggesting that it too may have been created through asking questions of informants and writing down the answers as quickly as possible, emphasized two things: the ethnically exclusionary nature of the Ahom monarchy, in which high office was the preserve of a small number of aristocratic clans claiming descent from the Southeast Asian conquest elite that had

⁷⁶ This has been printed in Appendix A of Alexander Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal* (Calcutta: Home Department Press, 1884).

founded the state; and limits on the power of the king, combined with a championing of the rights of the kingdom's principal aristocratic clans to participate in a pseudo-democratic oligarchy.

Throughout his account the power of the king was deemphasized, often in an exaggerated manner and with little explanation:

He distributed honors, titles, and offices, without the concurrence, but not without the council of the aristocracy. He was not lord of the soil...He possessed no power over the lives and property of his subjects. He could not make peace in war without the concurrence of the aristocracy. He treated with foreign powers...with the previous concurrence of the aristocracy. In the public councils, he possessed the privilege of a casting voice.⁷⁷

In Welsh's explanation of Assam's "constitutional order," he represents power as being distributed through the ranks of the aristocracy. He vests the majority of it in the kingdom's principal aristocratic clans, and in particular in the figures of the three Gohains, who are made out to be virtual kings in their own right. They had the right to decide succession to the throne if there was no clear best claimant. They had to concur with all the king's major decisions. They could depose him in instances of "great delinquency. Some doubt, however, exists of their legal power of deposition," he wrote, again suggesting that this information was being offered to him by others. They exercised independent sovereignty in their domains, supplied only "trifling articles" for the king's stores and paid no other revenue. The monarch could appoint or remove Gohains, but only with the concurrence of the others, and they had to be from the principal families of the kingdom. The same was true of most other high officials. The prime minister and Burra Fokun also had to be chosen from the principal families of the kingdom, and the Gohains had to concur with their appointment or removal. The same principle extended down to the main officers of the royal household, through almost the whole chain of command of the army, and to dependent rajas in the kingdom's borderlands.

⁷⁷ Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*, pp. 377-8.

Some evidence in the report suggests that Welsh and his collaborators had hoped to drain the king of all real power and turn him into a symbolic figurehead. He includes a special note at the end of his description of the offices of the Teepaum and Seringh rajas, the two successors to the throne appointed by Welsh in consultation with the Burra Gohain. He writes that these successors to the throne were supposed to have a major stake in government to “absolve the monarch from the lesser, and to assist him in the greater cares of Government.” Their rank was supposed to be next to the monarch, and their duties were to communicate the decrees of the aristocracy to the monarch, and to carry into execution his consequent orders. On less important occasions, he writes that the decrees of the aristocracy might be promulgated by these officers without application to the monarch. The Gohains supposedly had the power to depose them as well, meaning that ultimate power in the kingdom would have devolved into their hands.

Welsh’s interpretation of how factional conflict in the kingdom had spiraled so badly out of control centered on the departure from this customary order: the king had surrounded himself with non-Ahom appointees, who had sidelined the king’s council and impinged upon the rights of the Ahom nobility. Gaurinath, in concert with these advisors, represented as beholden to nothing other than personal interest, had then instigated a reign of terror, or as he put it in his own somewhat melodramatic language, the “debauched minority, the ignorance, imbecility, caprice, execrable cruelty, and oppression of Government, whose ministers and low favorites were the dread, detestation, and shame of the great, the scourge, and execration of the people, involved the whole Kingdom in confusion.”

These claims map quite well on to the history of factionalism and collaboration I outlined in the last section. Emphasis on lineal descent from high noble clans as the only legitimate path to political power, on the right of these clans to collectively rule the kingdom at the expense of the monarch, on the departure from these norms by a power-hungry king and his illegitimate, grasping advisors as the catalyst sparking the conflict – all of these are lines of argument that also would have been conducive to the needs of high nobles shut out of power, in particular the three Gohains. These were the exact groups who supported Welsh’s efforts most fervently, who benefited most from his presence in the kingdom, and who had the most to lose from his sudden exit. These or people in their entourages probably were the ones that provided him most of what

he knew about the kingdom's history, the classical structure of its government and the history of factional conflict immediately preceding his entrance.

The EIC's early collection of intelligence on Assam was deeply connected to collaborating factions within the Ahom elite. It had almost no information on the kingdom before Welsh's arrival. One of the mission's main goals was to rectify this. Welsh and his subordinate officers devoted significant effort to translating chronicles, producing descriptions of the kingdom's political system and geography, and explaining the origins of the kingdom's internal strife, along with recommendations for how the Company should go about pursuing its interests. The vast majority of this information was proffered by indigenous informants, likely individuals who worked in close proximity with the mission – court functionaries, the rajas of Derrung, and a select group of Ahom aristocrats who had grievances against the king and were looking to use Welsh to dethrone him in all but name. The texts that emerged from these encounters were not simply a one-sided imposition of European ideology. They contained significant, if fragmentary, imprints of the views of the informants who helped to create them.

THE MANY VOICES OF FRANCIS BUCHANAN'S SURVEYS

The other major source of information the EIC produced on precolonial Assam came from the survey work of Francis Buchanan in and around Goalpara in 1807. Perhaps even more so than the Welsh expedition, Buchanan was heavily reliant on the testimony of indigenous informants. He never actually crossed into Assam; instead, he compiled his work by tapping into the extensive networks of trade, migration, and missionary activity that knit together the whole region of northern Bengal, Nepal, Bhutan, Assam, and the smattering of minor principalities dotting the region, as well as tribal groups occupying adjacent highland areas. Despite this, his writings are still the most lengthy and nuanced description available in a European language of the kingdom before its annexation in the 1820s. Early 19th-century Goalpara, a vibrant, multiethnic border community, was evidently a fruitful place for him to work. He took down voluminous, often contradictory testimony from many different groups. I focus on three: Bengali brahmins, pro-monarchy Assamese exiles in Company territories, and Garo tribal chiefs locked in conflict with Bengali zamindars, their erstwhile conquerors, considering the political priorities

of each group and drawing out how those may have influenced the character of the information they provided to him.

Buchanan was a Scottish doctor, naturalist and ethnographer, trained in the inductive empiricism characteristic of the Scottish Enlightenment.⁷⁸ He was marked out to oversee an ambitious project: the first round of mass statistical surveys commissioned by the colonial state, which would become one of the hallmarks of its style of rule over the course of the 19th century as it sought to simultaneously extend its political control and systematic understanding down to the local level.⁷⁹ This was a monumental task, which saw the production of dozens of volumes of information on the history, geography, politics, economics, and social and cultural conditions of each district of Bengal, as well as many adjacent areas of South and Southeast Asia not formally under Company rule. Buchanan constructed his surveys through a combination of field observation and direct engagement with local informants from a variety of backgrounds, from princes and village leaders to merchants and religious figures, whom he relied on for rough geographical sketches, historical primers, descriptions of political structures and trends, information on trade, agriculture, and natural resources, the social and ethnic composition of populations, the collection of linguistic data, and to provide him with physical objects like texts and coins that he could use to create a holistic understanding of the areas through which he traversed. He was criticized in his own time for this magpie-like methodology, and for heavy reliance on the authority of indigenous informants.⁸⁰ Ironically, though, these qualities are what make his work so valuable to the modern historian – it is not purely the product of European artifice but rather a jumbled mass of competing voices emerging from multiple nexuses of knowledge and power.

⁷⁸ Marika Vicziany, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics in early Nineteenth-Century India: The Surveys of Francis Buchanan (1762-1829),' *Modern Asian Studies*, 20:4 (1986), pp. 625-660; Jane Rendall, 'Scottish Orientalism: From Robertson to James Mill,' *The Historical Journal*, 25:1 (1982), pp. 43-69; Angma Dey Jhala, *An Endangered History: Indigeneity, Religion, and Politics on the Borders of India, Burma, and Bangladesh* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2019), pp. 14-20.

⁷⁹ Bernard S. Cohn, 'Notes on the History of the Study of Indian Society and Culture,' in eds. Milton Singer and Bernard S. Cohn, *Structure and Change in Indian Society* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1968), pp. 3-29.

⁸⁰ Sir George King, 'A Sketch of the Life of Francis Hamilton (once Buchanan), sometime Superintendent of the Honourable Company's Botanic Garden, Calcutta,' *Annals of the Royal Botanic Garden, Calcutta*, 10:1-3 (1905), p. liv.

Goalpara was located on three separate frontiers at once.⁸¹ To the north it was connected through networks of trade and diplomacy to the mountain kingdom of Bhutan, as well as to Assam, where in addition to trade and diplomacy, it was connected by refugees fleeing the kingdom's long-standing civil war, mercenaries moving towards it, and most notably as far as information collection was concerned, exiled political elites and migrant Bengali brahmins who served as religious advisors to the Ahom monarchy, as well as a number of minor rulers scattered across the borderlands between the two states. On the east, Goalpara was connected to a spine of hills populated by a variety of related tribal clan groupings, referred to as a whole – usually by outsiders – as Garos. These groups had, from the mid-18th century onward, increasingly come under the control of Bengali frontier zamindars, a process of internal colonization that was only beginning to come to the attention of the Company. Buchanan during his stay in Goalpara was situated between all of these overlapping frontiers, allowing him access to informants of a wide variety of social and ethnic backgrounds.

One important group of informants consisted of exiled Ahom aristocrats. Though the Company had officially withdrawn from Assam with the departure of Welsh, it continued to be heavily involved in the kingdom's affairs, maintaining contact with many of its elites through petitions for support and the provisioning of arms and ammunition to help the government prevail against its many enemies. Bishnunarayan, one of the Derrung rajas, appeared in Calcutta offering to pay 135,000 rupees yearly for the Company's support in his efforts to carve out a state in Kamrup, the southernmost province of Assam. Brajanath, an Ahom prince, also appeared before the Company offering to pay back the state's massive debts to European private merchants in Bengal if they would make him king (he and his family also petitioned Nepal, Burma and Manipur in a similar fashion). Even Gaurinath's widow was soliciting aid to "regain possession of my country by force of arms." To this was added a major influx of members of the royal family and their supporters fleeing Purnananda Burra Gohain, who had accumulated vast power by forming an army to defeat the Moamarias that was under his personal control; he usurped the king, imprisoned him, put a pliant child who had tenuous ties to the royal bloodline on the throne, and cleansed the court of opposition, causing the flight of powerful aristocrats to Bengal, including

⁸¹ Sanghamitra Misra, *Becoming a Borderland: The Politics of Space and Identity in Colonial Northeastern India* (London: Routledge, 2011).

another Ahom prince, Badanchandra, who also petitioned the Company for aid in removing the Burra Gohain from power in exchange for offering to pay a yearly tribute (unsuccessful in Bengal, he later turned to Burma, his petitions to that state initiating invasion of Assam in 1816). These exiled opposition figures were in frequent contact with EIC officials, and proffered large amounts of information as a way of winning favor while simultaneously taking the opportunity to stake their own claims.⁸²

Buchanan's political intelligence on Assam is strongly pro-monarchy.⁸³ He attributes the descent into civil war during the reign of Gaurinath solely to the king's weakness, which opened the way for mass insurrection and subsequently the ascent to power of the Burra Gohain, who is represented as a tyrant and a usurper (although Buchanan read between the lines and surmised that his competence likely had something to do with his success). The Burra Gohain locked the king away and exiled his ministers, who fled to Bengal. He then conducted a mass purge of the nobility, including some of his own relations, putting them to death in grotesque fashion, and placed a boy with a flimsy claim on the throne, whose family adhered to a heterodox religious tradition, and who was not even given a proper coronation ceremony, the implication being that he was a puppet chosen specifically because he would never be able to gain widespread legitimacy – it was conjectured that he would be killed once he reached adulthood and replaced with another child. The conclusion was that the situation was "ripe for insurrection."

The difference with Welsh's account, which Buchanan seems not to have had access to, is stark. Not a single one of the king's alleged atrocities is mentioned, and nothing is said of the corruption of his government or of widespread popular dissatisfaction with it, all of which were key features of Welsh's explanation of events. In his description of events subsequent to Welsh's departure, the Burra Gohain is represented in a deeply unflattering light. The specificity of the information suggests that it was provided to him by insiders, and its political slant suggests that it was provided by people who were deeply hostile to the Burra Gohain's rule and likely had been on the receiving end of his purges, winding up in Bengal where they were interviewed by Buchanan. Buchanan specifically mentions elsewhere that he had spoken to the exiled prince

⁸² Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, ch. VIII.

⁸³ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 9-13.

Brajanath,⁸⁴ who was eventually arrested by the Company at the request of the Burra Gohain,⁸⁵ so this is the most likely candidate for his source, though it may have been a compilation of conversations with other informants whose names were never mentioned.

A second group of informants Buchanan spoke to were Garo tribal chiefs, who described themselves as engaged in an increasingly violent struggle with Bengali zamindars in the district's eastern borderlands. This struggle began in the precolonial period with zamindars in the area using private militias to conquer and subdue nearby Garo communities, but it picked up pace in the colonial period as local zamindars were able to more easily procure firearms – and because revenue demands on them were higher than in the precolonial period, and punishment for defaulting less forgiving.⁸⁶ Extracting more resources from the Garos (especially cotton, the resource in which tributary payments to the EIC were made, following on Mughal precedent) seems to have been a primary strategy for survival in this situation of heightened economic pressure, so there was a kind of sub-imperialism happening in the hills, originating before but pushed forward by the establishment of Company rule in Bengal, and continuing on outside the purview of the colonial state for many decades. Early colonial governance in Goalpara had rested on convenient, but loose and only half-controlled networks of upward resource distribution originating under the previous regime. Reliance on an intermediary layer of governance rendered it unable to access information on these localized conflicts, which were actively concealed from its gaze by the zamindars, who had a fraught relationship with the Company and likely feared interference or punishment. As tensions mounted, Garo chiefs reached out to Company officials in order to have their complaints addressed, including Buchanan, whose conversations with them provide a unique glimpse into the perspectives of Garo communities living on the tangled verge between highland and lowland.

⁸⁴ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, p. 37.

⁸⁵ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, pp. 443-7.

⁸⁶ Sanghamitra Misra, 'The Sovereignty of Political Economy: The Garos in a Pre-Conquest and Early Conquest Era,' *The Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 55:3 (2018), pp. 345-387; Sanghamitra Misra, 'Peasants, Colonialism, and Sovereignty: The Garo Rebellions in Eastern India,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 55:5 (2021), pp. 1681-1717; Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*; Nirode Kumar Barooah, *David Scott in Northeast India 1802-1831, A Study in British Paternalism* (New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1970), pp. 37-63; also of note is David Scott's report on the Garos, which sheds much more light on these issues, contained in Appendix D of the latter.

The self-reporting of Buchanan's Garo informants reveals a simultaneous tension and closeness with surrounding lowland communities. Garo chiefs entangled with lowland rulers described these relationships as oppressive, and represented their plight to Buchanan in strong terms.⁸⁷ They told him that Bengali zamindars had either conquered and reduced them to submission or stripped them of their land through the use of violent force, and exploited them when they came down from the hills to trade at market. Unable to access government courts to arbitrate their claims, they had turned to raiding and assassination. They represented themselves as different from – more honest, egalitarian and physically stronger than – their lowland neighbors, besides practicing exogamous marriage and emphasizing that they did not follow Hindu purity law. They also said that Garo was a Bengali term that had been imposed on them; they identified along lineage lines. However, in the detailed rendering they provided Buchanan of the relationships between these different clan groupings, it is clear that each group was just as connected to and influenced by its immediate lowland neighbors as it was to the wider Garo community. Those residing close to the lowlands of Assam and Bengal were thoroughly incorporated into lowland life through tributary relations, Hindu conversion and economic interdependence.

The last and most important group of informants drawn on by Buchanan were Bengali brahmins, active in all the frontier areas surrounding Bengal, often serving in the courts of rulers large and small, where they performed administrative tasks and brought an ideological and textual tradition that aided in legitimating kingship and constructing an ordered, caste based social hierarchy. Most kings on this frontier were of Tibeto-Burman tribal origin, and used this brahman presence to reinvent themselves as Hindu rajas, reconnecting their genealogies to India while simultaneously promoting the spread of sedentary agriculture, cultural uniformity and the acceptance of ritual and real inequality, congealing disparate and mobile tribal populations into a form that could more easily support their state building efforts.⁸⁸ The ruling elite in Assam employed the largest-scale example of this strategy, patronizing a network of temples that had aggregated significant numbers of followers and resources, using brahmins both to operate these

⁸⁷ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 85-96.

⁸⁸ Surajit Sinha, *Tribal Politics and State Systems in Pre-Colonial Eastern and North Eastern India* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1987); Sumit Guha, *Environment and Ethnicity in India, 1200-1991* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999). The best theoretical statement in my view on the relationship between ideology and state building in the region is James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009).

temples and to serve in religious capacities at court.⁸⁹ Many maintained family and educational ties to Bengal and traveled back and forth between the two states, so in Goalpara Buchanan was able to meet some of them. This included people who had direct experience serving in the Ahom court and other regional courts at the highest level. Most notably he nursed back to health from an unspecified malady a Bengali brahmin who was from a family that had served the Ahom kings as spiritual advisors. He describes his relationship with this man in warm terms, and points to him as one of his main sources of information on the kingdom, which he used as a guide to cross-check the statements of other informants.⁹⁰

Buchanan's historical information on Assam was drawn mostly from oral accounts provided by these brahmins (though he did collect Koch texts, and produced a manuscript history of the Koch dynasty).⁹¹ Much of it is focused on the activities of brahmins in the kingdom, a perspective that notably diverges from that of Ahom chronicles, which are less focused on religious issues and more on warfare and internal politics, reflecting the aristocratic values and more worldly preoccupations of the kingdom's rulers.⁹² The narrative is one of conversion.⁹³ Descriptions of pre-Hindu Ahom culture center on the fact that it was not Hindu: the Ahoms ate "beef, pork, and all other foods that shock the natives of India, and drank wine," their priesthood was non-brahmin, and their language and names were foreign. Brahmin informants represented their role in the Ahom court as a civilizing one. They described bringing the region under the influence of Hinduism, introducing the Bengali language, greater orthodoxy in worship, and encouraging the more stringent policing of caste boundaries and following of purity taboos. They also claimed to be mitigating the sacrilegious practices of the Ahoms in their pre-converted state, for example human sacrifice (not a well-documented practice and likely untrue) or the mutilation of rival claimants to the throne in order to debar them from succession (this is a well-documented practice, in use right up to the fall of the monarchy).⁹⁴

⁸⁹ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 20-22, 56-7.

⁹⁰ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, p. 1.

⁹¹ A reproduction can be found in S. K. Bhuyan, *Kamrupar Buranji* (Guwahati: Department of Historical and Antiquarian Studies, Assam, 1930), Appendix C.

⁹² S. K. Bhuyan, *Tungkhungia Buranji, or A History of Assam, 1681-1826* (London: Oxford University Press, 1933).

⁹³ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 3-10, also relevant are descriptions of court culture, pp. 15-19.

⁹⁴ The human sacrifice myth is debunked in H. K. Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 3 (Guwahati: Publication Board Assam, 2007), pp. 224-5, though the origin of the myth is attributed to later colonial writers – here it is clear that Buchanan picked it up from his informants.

Over the top of this narrative, Buchanan layered his own opinion, which was that Hindu conversion led to effeminacy and degeneration and the eventual collapse of the monarchy, making it an oddly schizophrenic read, alternating between information provided to him by his informants and his own often censorious commentary. Like many other Enlightenment intellectuals, Buchanan was notoriously hostile to any beliefs that he considered superstitious, including Hinduism,⁹⁵ but in this account his empiricism and prejudices are in tension – rather than drowning out the voices of his informants, he records their comments and his side by side, evidence of tensions that must have existed in many conversations between colonial officials and their informants, but which often left no trace.

In proffering information on human diversity in Assam, Buchanan's brahmin informants divided up the kingdom's communities along caste lines.⁹⁶ Groups were ranked and ordered according to varna. Bengali brahmins themselves were placed at the center, followed by earlier waves of brahmins that had served the Koch kings in the early modern period, and who had "degraded themselves...and instruct the impure tribes, a meanness to which none of those in Bengal have submitted," a statement in line with others peppered throughout his text made by Bengali brahmin informants asserting precedence over those brahmins present in the region before their arrival. Brahmins were followed by the Deo-dhangs, the pre-Hindu Ahom priesthood, who co-officiated court ceremonies alongside brahmins and seem to have been afforded similar status. Next came the Ahom ruling elite, which was represented as an endogamous caste group, though informants acknowledged that before their adoption of Hinduism, the Ahoms had extensively married across ethnic lines. The Kolitas and Koch in Kamrup, the province closest to Bengal, had a similar relationship in that the Kolitas, who were ethnically closer to the people of India, had introduced Hinduism into the region and the Koch, a Tibeto-Burman tribe who formed the region's political elite, ruled in concert with Kolita spiritual guides.

Beyond this elite level, the rest of Assam's population was classified according to the extent to which it adhered to Hindu purity taboos, a conceptualization that cut ethnic groups into pieces if they had not all converted at once. The Chutiya were "divided into two classes, Hindu and Aham...The former have abandoned many of their impure customs...The latter wallow in their

⁹⁵ Vicziány, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics,' pp. 631-2.

⁹⁶ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 51-64.

impurity." In the case of the Koch, people of different origins were conjoined together into a single caste, membership in which was based on conversion.⁹⁷ Reversion to prior religious habits was strongly condemned, as was conversion to Islam – groups that did this were described in a denigrating manner. Highlanders stood outside this classificatory system completely, and were often described in vague, stereotyped terms, suggesting a lack of familiarity, a perception of categorical difference, and actual tensions between those who lived in lowland agricultural settlements and highlanders who lived outside the reach of the state, were weakly integrated into lowland social hierarchies and had not adapted the cultural trappings of Hinduism.⁹⁸

The idea of caste here was being superimposed onto a different kind of society, a tribal one largely of Southeast Asian origins,⁹⁹ in the process transforming it. Bengali migration up the Brahmaputra valley had created a dual ruling elite, partly composed of kings of Tibeto-Burman tribal origin, and partly of high-caste Bengali migrants serving as court functionaries and in the religious domain. These groups introduced new cultural values at the elite level, which created new pressures and incentives all the way down the social ladder – a new set of rules by which prestige was generated and maintained. That set of rules is implicit in the classificatory schemes provided by Buchanan's brahmin informants. Adherence to purity taboos, and more generally the characteristics of sedentary, agrarian life, was the main determinant of civilized status, norms that carried such heavy weight that they were reconfiguring tribal organization, creating new forms of social stratification that emanated outward from the households of kings, pulling people in and arranging them according to their relationship to centralized political and religious authority.

Francis Buchanan's surveys, like the work of Welsh and his team in Assam, were significantly based in indigenous knowledge. In Buchanan's case, this included a variety of informants of differing backgrounds: Ahom aristocrats allied with the monarchy, Bengali brahmins active in court service throughout the region, and Garo chiefs who were living on the verge of highland and lowland under the rule of local zamindars. The competing voices of all these groups can still

⁹⁷ Amalendu Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam: Society, Polity, Economy* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1991), pp. 19-20.

⁹⁸ References to tribal groups, drawn from the testimony of Ahom aristocrats and Bengali brahmins, are scattered throughout Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 67-85.

⁹⁹ Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam*, p. 18.

be detected in his work. Exiled Ahom aristocrats told a narrative of Assam's civil war neatly in line with their own factional interests. Bengali brahmins emphasized their importance as keepers of high culture, and conceptualized the region's ethnic landscape along the lines of caste and settled agricultural civilization, ideas that were prescriptive, bolstering the power of kings and organizing society into tighter hierarchies. Garo chiefs decried what they viewed as oppression on the part of the zamindars who ruled them, petitioning the Company for relief, and defined themselves not only against the people of the plains, but also each other, making it clear that they were not a single ethnic group but a series of interconnected clans. In all this, Buchanan's role was an editorial one, pulling together these many different threads and trying to make sense of them. His surveys reflected the oral life of his informants, frozen at a specific moment in time after passing through the prism of his own understanding.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter, I provided two case studies of Company intelligence collection efforts on its Bengal frontier, in the Welsh expedition to Assam and in the surveys of Francis Buchanan in Goalpara. In the Welsh expedition, I explored how factionalism in Assam was connected to collaboration with the colonial state, how the information collected by members of the expedition emerged from these connections, and how the contents of that information were influenced by the views of anti-monarchy factions at court. Buchanan's surveys displayed a similar hybridity. His knowledge was constructed in concert with multiple groups whose interests can still be detected in his texts: different Ahom aristocratic factions from those that had allied with Welsh and whose narratives were pro-monarchy; Bengali brahmins serving in regional courts who emphasized their own role in overseeing a process of cultural transformation; and Garo tribal chiefs involved in a pattern of simultaneous conflict with and dependence on adjacent lowland zamindars.

The evidence collected in this chapter highlights the extent to which early colonial conquest intersected with a variety of pre-colonial power dynamics. In Assam, this included preceding patterns of interstate conflict and internal elite struggle. Aristocratic factions were navigating a personally and collectively dangerous crisis in which the kingdom had been torn apart and many, high and low, had lost their lives. Participants in this conflict, faced with extreme pressure to

survive, seem to have seen the EIC (as well as other surrounding states) as a potential lifeline, able to guarantee their personal safety and place them securely in positions of power, from which flowed economic benefit. This came at a steep cost: submission to colonial rule, which meant incorporation into a lopsided system designed ultimately for the benefit of others; and it seems to have been one that some were willing to pay, though the consequences may not have been immediately apparent. In Bengal, Buchanan's work picked up the views of a different faction in this conflict, while also pointing to the tensions caused by Bengali agrarian expansion into highland areas, as well as the social power of brahmin elites attached to courts across the region, whose rulers were engaged in state-building intimately linked to sedentarization and Hinduization processes.

On its ascent to power in Bengal in the mid-18th century the Company knew next to nothing about Bengal's peripheries. In seeking to rectify this over the next decades it adapted a variety of strategies to bring new knowledge into its archives, including many that did not involve much in the way of the participation of local people, for example cartography (although maps too could be based on indigenous knowledge), or methods such as textual analysis which may have been based on indigenous knowledge but were carried on in isolation from local populations and without their input. However, much of the information the colonial state desired could not easily be found in texts but rather circulated orally. Hence a major strategy was for local officials to conduct interviews with the people with whom they came into contact in the course of their work and draw from them in attempting to satiate the demand for information by the Company's leadership.

The knowledge proffered by these informants was not neutral. It emerged from nexuses of knowledge and power which existed before, ran parallel to and intersected with that of the colonial state. Knowledge proffered by indigenous informants acted to champion individual and collective claims to status and resources, reify social stratification, police ethnic boundaries, and contrast the world of civilized life against a wild periphery. The voices of 'subaltern' groups, in the few cases when they do enter into the colonial archive, are also fundamentally political. Outlawed mercenary bands and highland tribal chiefs used their words to achieve a traceable effect on the world they lived in – their own truth, one which, like the views of elites, was also calculated to have an effect on the relationships of power they were bound within.

CHAPTER 3

DISCONNECTS BETWEEN TERRITORY, ETHNICITY AND SOVEREIGNTY IN PRECOLONIAL ASSAM

In this chapter, I use early colonial knowledge of Assam in order to highlight a pre-national relationship in the kingdom between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity on four axes. Firstly, I conduct a comparative analysis using Stanley Tambiah's concept of the 'galactic polity,' in order to illustrate the extent to which the Ahom state, founded by a Tai conquest elite from northern Burma, retained many of the key features of a Southeast Asian state despite centuries of Hindu acculturation. Next, I examine the borderless form of territoriality practiced by the Ahoms, another classic feature of Southeast Asian states, in which power was exercised through layers of intermediary rulers and diminished with distance from the center so that, in peripheral domains, multiple overlapping claims to sovereignty coexisted simultaneously. In the third section, I examine the ethnic landscape both of Assam and adjacent borderlands of Bengal in order to highlight the malleability of ethnicity on this civilizational frontier, where a diverse and fragmented mosaic of tribal groups were undergoing processes of sedentarization and Hinduization, often spearheaded by the conversion of local rulers who employed Bengali religious elites. Finally, I conduct a deeper analysis of Ahom court culture, which constitutes the best-recorded example of this process of strategic acculturation. The Ahoms synthesized Southeast Asian ritual, oral, and textual traditions with Hindu influences, reinforcing their exclusiveness as a conquest elite while simultaneously taking advantage of new cultural tools of legitimation in the course of consolidating power.

In studies of the northeast frontier of India, the dominant approach toward colonial knowledge is a post-colonial one, which, broadly construed, is interested in 'decentering' colonial knowledge, pointing to the ways in which it remolded the facts of precolonial Assam to fit into new, Europe-derived categories. In particular, this literature argues that colonial knowledge artificially construed the kingdom along proto-national lines, reading into it a cohesiveness that it did not actually have. An example, written by Bodhissatva Kar, refers to the knowledge produced by the Welsh expedition:

Welsh and his gang arrived in this conjuncture with their dogma of indivisible sovereignty, insistence on well-defined hierarchies, faith in sharply cut borders and ethnically preprogrammed understanding of intergroup conflicts. Underlying such perceptions was the anticipation of a fixed state structure dominated by a defining racial group which squarely fitted into the lamenting narrative of the old aristocrats who became increasingly more helpless to resist the redefining process. This is the fallacy to which I wish to attach the name of Captain Thomas Welsh.¹

Kar is not alone here. While elsewhere in Indian historiography colonial knowledge has been the subject of intense debate,² the small existing literature on the subject in this context is in general united in arguing that the colonial state and its techniques of rule had a deeply transformative impact, reconfiguring the dynamic and open-ended relationship between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity prevailing in the precolonial period along lines that eventually led to nations and nation-states becoming the dominant mode of political organization throughout the region.³

I do not believe that a top-down model of colonial knowledge production, beginning and ending with the needs and ideology of the state, is sufficient to explain the full nature of the evidence contained in the colonial archive. In my previous chapter I described the extent to which early colonial knowledge of Assam – that produced by the Welsh expedition but in particular the surveys of Francis Buchanan – emerged from cross-cultural encounter and was laced with indigenous voices, in particular those of Bengali brahmins and Ahom aristocrats. Though their words must have passed through layers of translation, both linguistic and cultural, and though they were likely subject to some level of synthesis and abstraction, ultimately early colonial

¹ Bodhisattva Kar, 'Welsh's Fallacy: Rereading the Eighteenth-Century Ahom Crisis,' in ed. Subhas Chakraborty, *The Eighteenth Century in South Asia: New Terrains* (Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Calcutta, 2012), p. 143.

² Tony Ballantyne, 'Colonial Knowledge,' in ed. Sarah Stockwell, *The British Empire: Themes and Perspectives* (Malden: Wiley-Blackwell, 2008), pp. 177-198.

³ David Vumallian Zou and M. Satish Kumar, 'Mapping a Colonial Borderland: Objectifying the Geo-Body of India's Northeast,' *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 70:1 (2011), pp. 141-170; Pum Khan Pau, 'Transborder People, Connected History: Border and Relationships in the Indo-Burma Borderlands,' *Journal of Borderlands Studies*, 35:4 (2018), pp. 619-639; Sanjib Baruah, 'Territoriality, Indigeneity and Rights in the North-East India,' *Economic and Political Weekly*, 43:12/13 (2008), pp. 15-19; Jayeeta Sharma, *Empire's Garden: Assam and the Making of India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2011); Gunnel Cederlof, *Founding an Empire on India's North-Eastern Frontiers, 1790-1840: Climate, Commerce, Polity* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2013); David Ludden, 'The First Boundary of Bangladesh on Sylhet's Northern Frontiers,' *Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bangladesh*, 48:1 (2003), pp. 1-54; Yasmin Saikia, *Fragmented Memories: Struggling to be Tai-Ahom in India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004).

knowledge of Assam was in large part an impressionistic rendering of the notions of the two elite groups who governed it. Because of this, it is a strange confection of statements which can be read in many different ways, including ‘against the grain’ to recover evidence of historical patterns differing widely from contemporaneous European experience.

My primary purpose in the chapter is to demonstrate the extent to which it is possible to recover evidence of a lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in pre-colonial Assam from early colonial knowledge. In doing so I draw extensively from interpretive models developed for pre-colonial Southeast Asian states such as Burma or Siam.⁴ I make use in particular of the concept of the ‘galactic polity,’ a term coined by Stanley Tambiah, denoting a state in which rulers exercised power through evocative court symbolism, but presided over governments that were weakly bureaucratized, so power was projected in waxing and waning fashion over domains that were theoretically limitless, but in practice strictly limited, especially across large distances or impassable terrain. Such states were often cobbled together from the partly-incorporated ruins of other states, while at the same time being engaged in shifting tributary relations with surrounding rulers, who themselves held positions, either as giver or receiver, in other tributary networks – a fractalized pattern of overlapping and shared sovereignty relationships. The populations of such states were not unified, proto-national ethnic blocs, but disparate collections of peoples whose major initial commonality was shared subjection to a process of ‘cosmopolitan ingathering,’⁵ or the concentration of populations, often through the application of coercive force, into agriculturally productive zones where their labor could be controlled and its products requisitioned – a tactic ubiquitous across Southeast Asia because of

⁴ Thongchai Winichakul, *Siam Mapped: A History of the Geo-Body of a Nation* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1994); Edmund Leach, ‘The Frontiers of “Burma”,’ *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 3:1 (1960), pp. 49-68; Edmund Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1965); Willem van Schendel, ‘Geographies of Knowing, Geographies of Ignorance: Jumping Scale in Southeast Asia,’ *Environment and Planning D: Society and Space*, 20:6 (2002), pp. 647-668; Michiel Baud and Willem van Schendel, ‘Toward a Comparative History of Borderlands,’ *Journal of World History*, 8:2 (1997), pp. 211-242; James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009); Jean Michaud, ‘Editorial – Zomia and Beyond,’ *Journal of Global History*, 5:2 (2010), pp. 187-214; Jean Michaud, *Historical Dictionary of the Peoples of the Southeast Asian Massif* (Lanham: Scarecrow Press, 2006); Stanley Tambiah, ‘The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia,’ *Journal of Ethnographic Theory*, 3:3 (2013), pp. 503-534. In the Indian context similar works include Frank Perlin, ‘State Formation Reconsidered,’ *Modern Asian Studies*, 19:3 (1985), pp. 415-480 and Sanjay Subrahmanyam, ‘The Mughal State – Structure or Process? Reflections on Recent Western Historiography,’ *The Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 29:3 (1992), pp. 291-321.

⁵ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 245-51.

low population densities, making people a much more important resource than land, and which produced a melting-pot effect, laying the foundations for more monolithic forms of ethnicity.

The Ahom polity was founded in the 13th century by a Tai conquest elite originating in northern Burma, ruling over a population largely comprised of Tibeto-Burman tribal groups similar to those found in Southeast Asia, and using governmental techniques similar to those found throughout Southeast Asia, adapted to similar socioeconomic and environmental conditions.⁶ Yet some of the most significant works on precolonial Assam are written from a conservative, cultural nationalist approach that orients the kingdom, erroneously in my opinion, mostly toward India. *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, for example, a multi-volume work written by a large number of scholars under state auspices, portrays the precolonial Ahom state as “a spectacle of monolithic unity,” and many of the entries are written from an Indo-centric perspective, with the central narrative being one of the advance of Indian civilization into the region over time.⁷ By contrast, I treat the Ahom polity as culturally hybrid, blending Southeast Asian statecraft tactics with South Asian religious ideas. It was positioned at a civilizational crossroads, not unlike the kingdom of Arakan – also lodged between Bengal and Burma – which extensively combined South and Southeast Asian influences, causing it to fall into the “cracks between defining area studies,” as Sanjay Subrahmanyam put it.⁸

The chapter is divided into four sections. In the first I discuss the Ahoms’ extensive utilization of statecraft techniques imported from Southeast Asia. They presided over a flexible, decentralized political system held together by a combination of ritual display, military power, and direct control over labor, natural resources, and trade routes, patterns remarkably similar to what prevailed in Burma, Siam and other mainland Southeast Asian states. In the next section I discuss the borderless form of territoriality espoused by this state, on the frontiers of which multiple overlapping claims to sovereignty coexisted simultaneously. In section three I describe the

⁶ One scholar on precolonial Assam who makes significant effort to connect its history to Southeast Asia is Amalendu Guha. See Amalendu Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam: Society, Polity, Economy* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1991), chs. 1, 4-5.

⁷ H. K. Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vols. 1-5 (Guwahati: Publication Board Assam, 2007); the direct quote is on p. viii.

⁸ Sanjay Subrahmanyam, ‘Connected Histories: Notes towards a Reconfiguration of Early Modern Eurasia,’ *Modern Asian Studies* 31:3 (1997), p. 758; see also Jonathan Saha, ‘Is it in India? Colonial Burma as a “problem” in South Asian history,’ *South Asian History and Culture*, 7:1 (2015), pp. 23-29.

diverse and fragmented ethnic mosaic to be found between northern Bengal and Assam, consisting mostly of Tibeto-Burman tribal populations exhibiting varying degrees of sedentarization and incorporation into states, augmented by a large wave of high caste Bengali migrants, many of whom were clustered around regional courts, and who were culturally transforming the region, shaping the expression of ethnicity through the introduction of caste norms. I also explore this transformation from within the Ahom court, where the monarchy adopted the trappings of Hindu kingship, combining them in a syncretic manner with pre-conquest cultural traditions to create a potent ideological synthesis that allowed them to wield symbols of power from two cultures.

STATE/SOCIETY RELATIONS

This section explores the extent to which dominant models of state formation in Southeast Asian studies align with early colonial descriptions of the Ahom state. I begin by providing an overview of Stanley Tambiah's concept of the 'galactic polity,' originally developed for the study of Siam but widely applied to elucidate key aspects of statecraft across the region, including: political fragmentation, the role of court symbolism, attempts at military centralization, and the importance of controlling manpower resources and nodes connecting local economies to global trade networks. I then relate these concepts to early colonial intelligence collected on Assam, which depicted it not as a proto-national entity in which state and society cohered, but as decentralized, dynamic and marked by a large gulf between ruler and ruled. This included a fractalized political landscape in which lesser rulers governed as kings in their own right, compelling the Ahom monarchy to wield power through a combination of court symbolism and military satrapies managed directly by the king's household. Control over the population was exerted through a pervasive system of corvee labor, while the government simultaneously maintained a monopolistic grip over the kingdom's natural resources and served as the primary conduit for long-distance trade, enabling it to accrue currency for the payment of mercenaries, procurement of weapons, and acquisition of luxury goods essential for status display. All of these qualities mirror with high fidelity Tambiah's description of the galactic polity, suggesting that even after many centuries of acculturation, the skeleton of the Ahom state remained rooted in its Southeast Asian origins.

In Tambiah's model of the galactic polity, he describes Southeast Asian states as heavily decentralized and fragmentary in composition, using the metaphor of a mandala, a visual representation of sacred space in Hindu and Buddhist tradition in which a central spiritual figure or object (for example, the Buddha) is surrounded by layers of subsidiary figures of lesser importance in concentric circles.⁹ Tambiah's argument was that this organization of space, which comes across so magisterially in visual depictions,¹⁰ was also the underlying logic behind state organization in premodern Southeast Asia. The king served as a symbolic center and was surrounded by peripheral rulers who recognized his supremacy but at the same time governed locally with varying degrees of autonomy. Rather than serving as nodes in a bureaucratic network, these states often would reproduce the trappings of kingship and administration in miniaturized form, a phenomenon that he termed administrative evolution. States like these also had no boundaries; they waxed and waned depending on the power of the king at a given moment, and often at their margins, rather than attenuating cleanly and giving way to territory controlled by other states, they tended to intertwine or overlap with them in messy, multipolar tributary relationships.

Tambiah and Southeast Asianists more generally often draw attention to the importance of culture in serving as the ideological glue holding such decentralized polities together.¹¹ The legitimacy of a monarch was rooted in the spiritual position that he occupied in the cosmological order and in his ancestral lineage (genealogical claims often seamlessly blended into mythology). Symbolic or embodied power was expressed in a number of ways: through ritual, through palace architecture and art, and in chronicle or inscription traditions, all of which anthropologists remind us were actually constitutive of the political order rather than merely reflecting it.¹²

⁹ All of the following unless otherwise specified is a summary of Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity.' See also Victor Lieberman, *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, C. 800-1830*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003), pp. 23-66. Nicholas Tarling, *The Cambridge History of Southeast Asia*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993) contains a comprehensive synthetic description of current area studies literature on statecraft in early modern Southeast Asia.

¹⁰ See for example 'Cosmological Mandala with Mount Meru,' Yuan dynasty (1271-1368) silk tapestry, The Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York, <https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/39738>.

¹¹ See for example Victor Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles: Anarchy and Conquest, c. 1580-1760* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1984), ch. 5; Michael Charney, *Powerful Learning: Buddhist Literati and the Throne in Burma's Last Dynasty, 1752-1885* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Centers for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 2006), chs. 3, 5; Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*; and O. W. Wolters, *History, Culture, and Region in Southeast Asian Perspectives* (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 1982), ch. 5.

¹² Clifford Geertz, *Negara: The Theatre State in Nineteenth-Century Bali* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980).

Current scholarship on mainland Southeast Asia stresses that although these practices formed the basic conditions in which states emerged, ambitious rulers also often pursued a variety of strategies in order to gather power into their hands – absolutist drives not unlike those pursued by early modern European monarchs, and which also generated similar friction with elites not part of favored factions.¹³ This included attempts to monopolize the handout of official appointments, especially in core areas close to royal residencies, and also attempts to create centralized military machines that could be used for imperial expansion, with an eye towards bolstering rulers' charismatic potency and also in order to capture populations from peripheral areas and relocate them to more central ones. This was especially true of specialized groups who were able to provide services not readily available in state cores. Amarapura, the capital of the Burmese Konbaung dynasty, for example, was populated in large part by such groups of hereditary slaves to the crown who had been collected from all over the region in the course of the dynasty's many frontier campaigns.¹⁴

In the economy, kings in Southeast Asian galactic polities pursued a similar strategy of attempting to directly control key resources and long-distance trade.¹⁵ This included state monopolies over gold, salt, and other valuable products, and state control of major trade entrepôts such as ports or inland markets. In early modern Siam, for example, foreign traders were required to do business primarily with the royal household, which set prices on imported goods and also controlled the export of key products of interest to Indian Ocean traders.¹⁶ Southeast Asian economies were in general weakly commercialized, and taxation was often in the form of the direct requisition of agricultural produce or artisanal goods. Additionally, when taxes were collected, it was often the case that multiple layers of subordinate officials would take a cut, so that surprisingly little reached the capital. In such a context, this was the fastest and most efficient way to accrue fungible currency, which was important both in the military realm

¹³ This comparative perspective underpins Victor Lieberman, *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, C. 800-1830*, Vols. 1-2 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003).

¹⁴ Early Konbaung centralization efforts are detailed in William Koenig, *The Burmese Polity, 1752-1819: Politics, Administration and Social Organization in the Early Kon-baung Period* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 1990) and Victor Lieberman, 'Political Consolidation in Burma under the Early Konbaung Dynasty 1752 – c. 1820,' *Journal of Asian History*, 30:2 (1996), pp. 152-168.

¹⁵ Victor Lieberman, 'Secular Trends in Burmese Economic History, c. 1350-1830, and their Implications for State Formation,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 25:1 (1991), pp. 1-31; Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles* contains good evidence of such strategies as they played out in practice in early modern Burma.

¹⁶ Sarasin Viraphol, *Tribute and Profit: Sino-Siamese Trade, 1652-1853* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1977), ch. 2.

and in status display, because it was necessary in order to purchase firearms (which could not be produced domestically in sufficient quality or quantity), mercenaries and luxury goods.

Oral accounts of the structure and function of the Ahom polity, provided by Ahom aristocrats and court Brahmins, align closely with this depiction of Southeast Asian statecraft.¹⁷ As in Tambiah's model, these informants described a heavily decentralized political landscape. Political fragmentation prevailed even at the highest levels. The royal council, comprised of a handful of members who undertook much of the daily business of government, was monopolized by a small number of powerful Ahom clans. Descriptions of the politics of this council, and its power struggles with the king, make it clear that this was a state in which sovereignty was negotiated – and often attenuated – through factionalism among this elect group of families, the most powerful of whom had semi-independent fiefdoms of their own in which they exercised monarch-like authority. These dukes, drawn from families who traced their genealogies back to the original conquest of the country, controlled territories containing thousands of households, and were not the king's functionaries to command – his relationship to them resembled tributary diplomacy with lesser sovereigns. These powerful regional rulers, in turn, would be surrounded by an assortment of lesser rulers who, particularly in the borderland areas, were often drawn from non-Tai ethnic groups and derived their power from hereditary rights predating the Ahom conquest. Sometimes, these tertiary rulers were powerful enough to have their own tributaries, commanding, for example, the allegiance of tribal chiefs in adjacent highlands.

These regional and local courts were not simply extensions of a central administration; they were self-contained pseudo-states in their own right, collecting taxes, levying troops, and even conducting their own diplomacy. As a result, the Ahom state system resembled not a single state but a large, unwieldy collection of small principalities stacked on top of each other like a house of cards. This pattern is virtually identical to that found in the Shan states of northern Burma, from whence the Ahoms originated, and as was the case there, likely resulted from the establishment of an 'archipelago' of Tai military colonies throughout the Brahmaputra basin, interspersed among the domains of previous rulers, all of whom acted as subordinate kings

¹⁷ John Peter Wade, *An Account of Assam* (Guwahati: Asam Jyoti, 1972), pp. v-xxxv; Francis Buchanan, *An Account of Assam: First Compiled in 1807-1814* (Guwahati: Powershift in Association With Faculty Books, 2017), pp. 18-24; Thomas Welsh, 'Report on Assam,' in Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*, pp. 374-81.

occupying positions in a layered bundle of tributary networks ultimately centered on the monarch.¹⁸

The importance of conspicuous consumption can be seen in the large administrative apparatus devoted to signaling social status that had blossomed from the household of the king. Such household officials came in multiple ranked echelons, performing a huge variety of tasks. They built and manned the royal barges, procured the king's necessities and luxuries, managed the households of his female relatives, maintained his gardens and Hindu temples, managed the pre-Hindu Ahom priesthood, produced weapons and dealt with communications. Lesser officials served as treasurers, physicians, letter-writers, translators, executioners and managers of the king's assets, which included both objects, animals and people: palanquins (and their bearers), footmen, artisans, jewelers, elephants, horses and weapons. Many of these officials had attached serfs in the hundreds or thousands, granted along with their office, which would have involved large household administrations of their own. This sprawling apparatus of status maintenance, reproducing itself in ever-smaller form, approximates the findings of historians of Southeast Asia. In Bali, Clifford Geertz pointed to luxury consumption as so central to court culture that "power served pomp, not pomp power."¹⁹ In Thailand, Sarasin Viraphol estimated that the king personally controlled a third of the economy through a similarly distended household.²⁰

Under the grand secretary, the administrative structure that prevailed was essentially military in character, and seems to have been designed to create a chain of command superseding the aristocracy. Twelve powerful military leaders with combined judicial authority prevailed over specific areas, and in those areas, divided the population into work gangs who were the major source of the state's wealth and the major source of remuneration for individual officials, also doubling as its main source of military manpower. Wade gives a detailed description of these officers, titled 'Fokun.' They could only be drawn from one of the major aristocratic clans in the kingdom that monopolized high office. They were given prebendal estates for their upkeep, though they were required to live at the capital and could only visit them occasionally; at the capital they lived in manses surrounded by gardens. He describes them as like the "judges of

¹⁸ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 81-2; his argument is building on the observations of Edmund Leach in *Political Systems of Highland Burma*.

¹⁹ Geertz, *Negara: The Theatre State*, p. 13.

²⁰ Viraphol, *Tribute and Profit*, p. 18.

Israel," standing directly below the king and his council and serving as a combination of general, high judge and advisor. He decried this unity of military and judicial authority as one of the "greatest imperfections" in the structure of the government, although it is ironically similar to the form of government practiced by the Company itself in the late 18th century, which C. A. Bayly described as "military despotism."²¹ In Assam it likely had its roots in conquest as well, in generals performing civil functions in the areas where they were located – the expansion of the number of such offices over time tracked closely with the incorporation of new territories into the kingdom.

At the local level, the central institution of government was a system of serfdom, a hallmark of Southeast Asian states, where land was abundant and labor scarce – exactly the conditions prevailing in Assam. Most of the land was worked by serfs (paiks) who paid no rent, but were organized into work gangs under officers of state. Each work gang was obligated to perform four months of service, or commute the service into a money payment. Paiks were organized into a hierarchical structure, governed by gradated ranks of officials. These officials were allotted a set number of paiks, from which they derived their income, along with presents given by their charges. The paiks, when called upon for their four months' service, worked the king's fields, "gardens, fisheries, mines, arsenals, and manufactories," and built his boats. Officials who oversaw their services employed one out of every twenty in their own ventures, as well as obtaining gifts on festival occasions and remuneration from fees collected in the course of performing police and judicial functions. Paiks were also given away to powerful officials for their upkeep in lieu of a salary. They worked the lands of aristocrats, built their homes, and supplied them with furniture, clothing and boats. They were sometimes called upon to construct massive public works, which could require major corvee efforts (some of the causeways crisscrossing Assam were 40 feet high, and the Welsh expedition noted that although the imperial capital was in ruins, the outlines of impressive infrastructure could still be detected).²² They also served as the basis for a conscript army in wartime.

²¹ C. A. Bayly, *Indian Society and the Making of the British Empire* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), p. 79.

²² J. Johnstone, *Captain Welsh's Expedition to Assam in 1792, 1793, and 1794* (Calcutta: Foreign Department Press, 1877), pp. 4-5.

Aside from the paik system, the other major conduit for wealth extraction was a set of trade monopolies.²³ These were granted to merchant-princes in return for a fixed cut of revenues; many of the beneficiaries of these deals were of foreign extraction, a manifestation of the late, externally-driven commercialization of the kingdom. This was a state-centric, mercantilist approach to economic governance. The Ahom governors interacted with the long-distance trade economy in two ways. Firstly they monopolized many of the natural resources of interest to foreign merchants. The Ahom king operated a number of gold, silver, salt and iron mines, as well as controlling gold panning along rivers. The officers in charge of extracting these natural resources were powerful local governors in their own right, governing large numbers of serfs who worked directly for the king, a testament to the importance of these salable resources to the state's overall economic strategy. Secondly, the state commanded the choke points through which trade flowed and collected cash taxes from them, which were important in procuring imports, as well as in the purchase of the mercenaries and firearms, increasingly important as conflict within the kingdom dragged on.

Customs houses farmed out to different individuals were positioned in many locations, some around the borders of the kingdom, others within it, for example at the Kamrup/Assam border (which had once been an interstate border). Four customs farmers in particular were important; these in turn rented out their rights to subordinates. The first was located on the border with Bhutan. This man seems have been of the Chutiya ethnicity, descended from an earlier stratum of nobility who predated the Ahom conquest, and who was in "hereditary possession" of his office. The trade that passed through his hands was large – 200,000 rupees a year. On the other side, the ruler of Bhutan occupied a similar position, monopolizing all cross-border commerce in his realm, so the Assam-Bhutan trade was funneled through both governments, each taking a cut. The other important customs farmers faced Bengal. Here the customs posts had been farmed out to two Bengali brahmins, who were partly assimilated into the Ahom aristocracy, bearing noble titles. The two men controlled land in the area, as well as a string of border posts meant to prevent smuggling, which was rife in the area's winding mountains. They paid 45,000 rupees to

²³ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 41-8.

the king for their positions, and though they were nominally supposed only to levy a ten percent duty on imports and exports, in practice they were largely unregulated.

Such relationships can be contextualized by looking at the economy on a more fine-grained level. One of its main characteristics was that, like in many Southeast Asian states, it had an underdeveloped money economy.²⁴ Its agricultural economy was flourishing and highly diversified, but it was only weakly connected to markets. The majority of skilled artisanry was done by migrant communities from Bengal, or from Kamrup, a province bordering on Bengal that shared much in common with it. This included blacksmiths, goldsmiths, coppersmiths, shoemakers (these, as well as brick-makers, were primarily employed by the king because of sumptuary restrictions, along with a variety of other artisans making luxury goods), barbers, flower sellers, brass wire makers and carpenters. Their trade was often in kind rather than in cash, and they in general lacked capital. Some tasks, like weaving silk, were conducted on a per-household basis, again usually without cash trades involved, though whatever was not consumed in the vicinity was sold to merchants for extra cash. Cotton weaving was done by Bengalis, using mostly product from the hills, and sold by itinerant hawkers. Shops were not common. Artisans were not heavily specialized, but usually cultivated the land in addition to their trade; most artisans worked directly for the king as paiks. Sharecroppers were hard to find, as were day laborers and servants; the lack of venues for market exchange meant that these tasks were generally undertaken by bonded labor. Debt slavery was widespread, and debtors generally worked in the households of political or religious elites whose status allowed them to protect their charges. A few were sold, most to Bengal, but some to hill tribes in the east; Buchanan speculated that many of those were later re-exported to Ava.

These descriptions bear remarkable resemblance to contemporary area studies literature on Southeast Asian state formation. In Stanley Tambiah's formulation of the 'galactic polity,' he argued that in premodern Southeast Asian states, rulers exercised power in large part through evocative court symbolism, as in practice they presided over entrenched aristocracies who themselves exercised king-like authority in smaller and smaller domains. They tried to overcome this diffusion of power by creating and linking institutional structures directly to themselves – a

²⁴ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 58-64.

tactic that would have been familiar to any of the absolute monarchs of early modern Europe. In terms of political economy, they struggled to appropriate manpower and agricultural surpluses – the main sources of wealth in the absence of a lively market economy – through multiple layers of functionaries, each of which siphoned off a take. As a result, rulers often turned to mercantilist exploitation of long-distance trade networks passing through their domains, from which they derived cash, weapons, mercenaries and other resources conferring immediate political benefit. Tambiah's model fits the facts collected by early colonial observers of Assam snugly. The skeleton of this state was built on Southeast Asian models, imported by a Tai conquest elite into the northeastern extremity of what is today India. In the next section I turn to the question of political fragmentation within this state, both at the local level and in its borderlands.

FRAGMENTATION WITHIN, ENTANGLEMENT WITHOUT

In this section, I analyze the geographical information collected by early colonial observers of Assam, which reveals that the kingdom's rulers exercised power not through fixed, clearly demarcated territorial boundaries but over a fluid and dynamic collection of territories that expanded and contracted over time. Vertically, the Ahoms governed through a layered system in which pre-existing elites and foreign conquerors alike were retroactively incorporated into the structure of the state, bureaucrats wielded significant autonomy, aristocrats controlled large fiefdoms and operated as quasi-kings, temple establishments operated with tax exemptions and attained significant political influence, and subsidiary rulers engaged in intense political contestation in their own right. Horizontally, rather than ending abruptly at defined borders, the Ahom state's influence dissolved into a complex web of divided and overlapping sovereignties. This was far from being a centralized governance structure; it was more an interdependent mosaic of semi-autonomous entities loosely incorporated into an umbrella framework centered around the figure of the Ahom monarch.

The central province of the kingdom Buchanan called "Asam proper."²⁵ Even within this heartland, the sovereignty of the monarch was not projected downward and outward in a uniform manner, but rather was layered over top of the private fiefdoms of religious and political elites. It was divided into two parts, along the north and south banks of the Brahmaputra river. South of

²⁵ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 24-7.

the Brahmaputra, around half the cultivated land was owned by the king and worked by paiks. The other half was either rented out or annexed to temples or hereditary aristocratic estates. Some of these were held by spinoff branches of the royal family and located near a palace complex where lesser princes had historically been confined to keep them out of succession struggles; others were the domains of powerful aristocrats who were largely independent outside of fixed service obligations to the state. Some estates were annexed to marcher lords for the upkeep of soldiers meant to guard against the incursions of tribal groups and principalities located in the surrounding mountains. Others were held by Chutia nobles – holdovers from a previous polity that had ruled part of the region before it was conquered by the Ahoms in the 16th century.²⁶ The large island of Majuli, situated between the Brahmaputra and Dihong rivers, was "in a great measure alienated to temples, and to men considered holy."

The upper half of the province, sandwiched against the Himalayas, was host to an even more byzantine set of sovereignty relationships. It was administered by two officers subordinate to the state, though those officers collected only a quarter of the total revenue of the province. "The manner in which the other three shares are collected...renders it highly improbable that the country should be well occupied," he wrote. The practice which Buchanan disapproved of, but was more than capable of comprehending, was one of interpenetrating sovereignty.²⁷ The region was in effect a kind of no-man's land, over which Assam and Bhutan, as well as a variety of tribal highland groups, competed for the right of taxation. In some places, nobody actually governed, though in other places, Bhutan or Assam governed, or practiced a kind of seasonal governance, one state administering a territory for six months before it revolved to the other.

In the hills adjacent to Assam, the Bhutanese also operated a highly decentralized political system.²⁸ The foothills and lowlands under Bhutanese rule were divided into small chunks of territory under officers that collected taxes and served police functions. Border lords were described as moving seasonally. In the summer, they lived in the cool mountains. In winter, they moved down onto the plains, "either to enforce obedience or to invade the territory of neighboring states...They issue suddenly from their passes, make a rapid march, surprise the

²⁶ Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol 2, pp. 55-6, 60-2; Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam*, p. 60.

²⁷ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 39-41.

²⁸ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 67-74.

refractory subject or enemy, and murder every human being, male and female, young and old, that falls into their hands" (though Buchanan also noted that sometimes they peaceably settled disputes). Rather than ruling directly, they primarily dealt with what Buchanan called the "chiefs of the subdued nations" – Koch, Mech, Kachari and other tribal rajas. These conquered rajas paid tribute, and peasant communities on the plains paid land rent, though the sums were unfixed. Only about half of the total made its way up to the government. The rest remained with border lords, who held significant independent power. Buchanan knew little of the structure of the government besides these pass guardians, as they were the only officials his informants dealt with (in fact they operated as miniature kings, rather than functionaries of a bureaucracy; post-conquest negotiations with Bhutan made it clear that the king could not control them).²⁹

In addition to the mountain kingdom of Bhutan exercising significant sway over parts of Assam, a number of tribal groups living in the mountains to the north also made similar claims to the right of taxation over the inhabitants of adjacent lowlands. Tribal groups were represented by Buchanan's lowland informants as collecting revenues by coming down yearly from the mountains, armed and living at "free quarters," plundering those who refused to pay. This was allegedly practiced by several of the adjacent tribal groups – though the accounts he received disagreed about exactly which ones, or where they were from. Additionally, at least three of these groups had settled on the plains. These tangled sovereignty relationships were represented by Buchanan as abnormal. He believed that the Ahoms had originally exercised a more uniform form of sovereignty over the area, and that these other sovereignty claims had emerged as a result of state breakdown in the wake of the kingdom's civil strife. Though his interpretation was likely incorrect, it did not overpower his raw observations, and it is not clear the extent to which these opinions might have been formed in concert with his informants, Ahom aristocrats who may have been inflating their claims over peripheral areas.

The second major province, Kamrup, was wrested from the Mughals in the early modern period, and still bore the marks of conquest. It was governed by an official whose technical rank was low, as the office had sprung from an obscure frontier posting; however, not only did he govern the kingdom's most lucrative province, he was also in charge of diplomatic relations with the

²⁹ Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*, pp. 9-15.

states to the west, including EIC Bengal, making him in practice the second most powerful man in the kingdom.³⁰ He had his own extensive system of administration, basically a second government, subordinate but also parallel to the administrative structure built up around the king. As Peter Wade describes:

He received ambassadors from Bengal, Cosaree, Jwointa and other places, with the pomp of a Sovereign. In the public hall of state at Goahawtee surrounded by the Fokuns and numerous Rajahs of the Western Provinces he received the prostrations as well as the despatches of foreign ambassadors. An ambassador to the Sovereign could not be received unless he was entrusted with a separate address to the Burro Fokun and each of the Patru Muntrees (the three gohains and prime minister). The five Great Officers of State seemed to possess or to claim each a share of the Sovereignty and the ambassador was reminded without an audience and perhaps with insult, unless his master had completed with this aristocratic etiquette.³¹

He also had the power to appoint and remove lesser rajas in the borderlands, and, like the king himself, held the power of life and death over his subjects. The court in Guwahati, the provincial capital, was a reproduction of the king's court in miniature; many of its administrative positions were directly copied in title, function and even number. Its standing army, like that of the king, was composed in large part of mercenaries from other parts of India, paid in cash, armed and disciplined after the European fashion, and commanded by one "Baldi Singha, a native of the west of India." Beneath the governor were six powerful lords organized into a coordinated hierarchy, each with their own even smaller court located in different areas of the province, some with thousands of families under their authority. Such arrangements are another good example of the fractalized nature of sovereignty in precolonial Assam, mirroring closely the phenomenon described by Stanley Tambiah in the Southeast Asian context as "administrative involution."³²

The Ahom state's projection of sovereignty in the conquered territory of Kamrup was refracted through Mughal administrative networks that had preexisted the conquest and which were kept intact. Around half the land in the province was managed by the state and given over to paiks;

³⁰ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 27-37.

³¹ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. xxii-xxiv.

³² Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity,' pp. 523-6.

the other half were either temple lands or worked by zamindars who paid cash rents. The process of revenue collection was similar to what the British had inherited in Bengal: a tax farmer bought up temporary rights to the land (half in cash, half in kind) and lived off whatever rents and gifts he could collect, as well as money taken in the execution of administrative functions. The only major difference with Bengal was that each zamindar was required to reserve a certain amount of rent-free land for paiks in the king's service. After the conquest of Kamrup, it had been loosely incorporated into the Ahom state in classic imperial fashion, simply by extending the main instrument of Ahom rule over top of this older administrative layer.

Around half of Kamrup's land was "rivers, marshes, woods and hills" – wasteland, the quantity of which had grown during the kingdom's prolonged rebellion. In these inaccessible places, rajas presided over minor polities while simultaneously paying tribute to multiple overlords, including Nepal, Bhutan, Assam and Company-controlled Bengal. These princes were described to Buchanan as "the original petty chiefs of the country." Their territories were assessed to provide a certain number of paiks, or a corresponding amount of cash, and they were obligated to provide military service; beyond that, they were essentially independent. Over a dozen of these rajas were listed; others, mentioned in the records of the Welsh expedition, had either vanished or were not known of by his informants, who for this section seem to have mostly been Bengali brahmins serving in these rajas' courts (like the Ahoms, many of them valued brahmin administrative skills and the cultural prestige their presence lent).

Lack of clear-cut boundaries abounds in these descriptions. These princes were ethnically distinct – Garo, Mech and Koch are the ethnonyms mentioned. Many of them were related, usually endogamously, but sometimes through intermarriage across ethnic boundaries. They tended to reside close to the mountains bordering Bengal. Often, their territories straddled highland/lowland trade routes, and they derived significant power from controlling marketplaces, using it to establish authority over clans residing deeper in the hills. Here is a direct quotation of the information collected on one of these rajas:

10. The Raniduyar Raja, in the confusion of the Mahamaris insurrection, seems to have seized on the country immediately west of Gohati: but in fact his real country is south from that town, at the foot of the Garo mountains, and his residence is among the

hills...(his territory contains) a market, where the Garos come to deal with this chief. He is a Garo by birth: but has adopted the worship of Vishnu. An intelligent person, who had been in his service, informed me, that the Raja is bound to furnish constantly to the king 621 Payiks or labourers, and makes presents annually to the value of about 5000 rupees. He ought also, with his countrymen the Garos, to assist in the king's wars...his only profit...is what he receives in presents and in the management of the police. His principal wealth is derived from his connection with the Nuniya Garos, that frequent his market. They pay him no duties; but on a certain day every year he invites all the chiefs and free men of that nation. From 5000 to 6000 usually attend, and are feasted. Every one brings a present in cotton or other commodity...so that, after defraying the expense of a feast, the Raja has a profit of about 15,000 rupees.³³

The quote illustrates the position of the Raniduyar Raja, typifying that of a regional ruler under the umbrella of Ahom sovereignty. The raja was a culturally hybrid figure, a Garo by birth ruling over a lowland territory and integrated into the Ahom tributary network, having invited brahmins into his household and adopted Hinduism, both as a way of integrating into the lowland elite and bolstering his own authority. At the same time, much of his wealth and influence was derived through his connection with Garo tribal communities living outside the reach of the Ahom state, whom he collected duties from and also gifts in the course of annual feasts. His position as both a subordinate ruler in the lowlands and autonomous tribal leader in the highlands underscores the entangled relationship between the two in the region's pre-colonial political landscape.

Tributary rulers were powerful and dynamic political actors in their own right. The Raniduyar raja was able to defeat the Kamrup governor in battle, fielding 5,000 men against him when he came to adjust by force the raja's tribute burden. Such minor kings could control large territories and thousands of families, to the extent that they were able to subdivide their own domains among family members. They were engaged in intense, running contests for power. Some of their territories had significantly expanded and contracted during Assam's period of political fragmentation due to conquest of lowlands theoretically subject to the Ahom king (to whom these rajas were also theoretically subject). Again, Buchanan regarded these power grabs as

³³ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 31-2.

usurpations "to which they were not entitled," and which were "instantly dissolved" when the Ahom government regrouped and was able to retake its lost territories. Again though, the raw information and what was likely his misinterpretation were separated in his account, and he may have simply been adopting the stance of his elite Assamese interlocutors, who had an obvious interest in representing the correct political order as being one of obedience to the center, a claim made all the more pressing by the contravening facts on the ground.

Sadiya, the easternmost province, was largely blank space to Buchanan, as his informants had never been there and gave widely divergent accounts of it.³⁴ Although Buchanan recognized the strange difficulty his informants, some of the most powerful men in the kingdom, had in describing the province to him, he never understood why. They were able to furnish him with the title of the provincial governor, "Sodiya Khaoya Gohaing," which gives some clue. 'Khaoya' is derived from a Tai word meaning prince. The province had been conquered by a Shan prince from Burma a few decades previously, who was then loosely incorporated into the Ahom administration as a provincial governor; however, he was in effect an independent king.³⁵

The accounts Buchanan received from his informants diverged heavily. Some represented the province as tiny, others as large. The difference in size was due to some informants counting only the lowland territories of the region as part of the province. Others included large portions of the surrounding highlands and said that most of the population of the province was composed of tribal inhabitants from these areas – "Michimis and...Kamti...Bhoteas...Miris, Dophlas and Kampos." Others represented these as "independent nations." The Ahom prince Brajanath was the one who made the most expansive claims, including over the Shan migrants who were now in possession of the territory. Buchanan reconciled these accounts by concluding that Ahom authority in the region had shrunk during the civil war; but it is unlikely that any Ahom state had ever systematically controlled its highland periphery.

Of the region's highland population, almost no specific information could be obtained. Even the Shan states on the other side of the border were out of the realm of ordinary experience for Ahom aristocrats, with the exception of a small number in close proximity with whom they maintained

³⁴ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 37-8.

³⁵ Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*, pp. 57-61.

marriage ties. Of the Khamtis, the Shan clan that governed Sadiya, Buchanan could only learn that they had a troubled relationship to the Ahom court, and their original principality was "rather a plain country, but much overgrown with woods;" the Bengali brahmin who told him this "never was there." Of the Nagas, Buchanan only learned from his Bengali brahmin informant that they were "extremely savage," and had little connection to Assam. He could not place them. He made huge mistakes regarding other aspects of the highland social geography of the Sadiya frontier, both in terms of names, locations and political relationships.

His heavily distorted account of the Singpho, a group of tribal migrants from Burma that had settled in the extreme west of the Brahmaputra valley, will suffice as an example: "South from the Abor, or Khamti...is a country called Chingpho, which has a Raja independent of Asam...I imagine that the people of Chingpho are those whom the inhabitants of Ava call Kasi Shan." Khamti and Singpho are both ethnic or tribal markers, not countries. The Singpho had no leader, but rather a number of chiefs among which some were more paramount than others. They were not Shans (though they had migrated to Assam in connection to each other and the boundaries between the two were permeable, which may have been why his informants paired them together).³⁶ Most of the section reads like this and is basically useless for its factual contents; but it originated in Brahminic accounts, so ultimately, one of the things that it tells us is that the area was largely unknown to Buchanan's informants themselves.

This short tour of Assamese political geography should suffice to demonstrate that the Ahom state was merely one system of power draped over and overlapping with many others. Commanders of far-flung border domains took on the appearance of subordinate kings, rather than bureaucratic functionaries; in the case of Sadiya, the governor was self-appointed, and had been retroactively incorporated into the state, at least in theory, blurring the line between officeholder and minor king even further. The monarch had to contend not only with the feudal domains of its own allied religious and political elites, but also those of powerful zamindars whose authority was of Mughal origins, and dozens of minor rajas who conducted their own politics of expansion, accumulating power bases straddling highland and lowland. At the

³⁶ See Mackenzie's section on the Kachin in *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal*; Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma*; Mandy Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin: Histories Beyond the State in the Borderworlds of Burma* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013).

kingdom's margins, tribal groups, as well as adjacent states such as Bhutan, extended their authority into the Ahom domains, collecting taxes and even performing the functions of government, so that people living in these regions were subject to a carousel of overlords. Buchanan's geographical description, rather than reducing the relationship between territory, ethnicity in sovereignty in precolonial Assam to a simplified, proto-national form, actually does the opposite, illustrating instead its deep irregularity.

CASTE, TRIBE AND ETHNICITY IN RANGPUR AND ASSAM

This section examines Francis Buchanan's observations on caste, tribe, and ethnicity in Rangpur and Assam. Both were primarily inhabited by Tibeto-Burman tribal groups undergoing a process of Hinduization, accelerated by the northward migration of high-caste Bengalis, particularly Brahmins, who secured positions in regional courts. Their presence was crucial to the transformation of tribal rulers into Hindu rajas, able to command the hereditary obedience of their subjects through the construction of genealogical claims linking them to divine figures. Court brahmins' imposition of new classificatory schemes on the region, which plotted groups based on a combination of purity norms and conformity to settled agricultural lifeways, had a transformative effect. Caste norms spread out from court centers to encompass surrounding populations, creating sedentary, socially stratified pools of subjects more amenable to being ruled than acephalous tribal societies. This was a transformation shaped by the agency of local populations, who internalized and adapted caste norms in pursuit of social mobility and political legitimacy. It was also non-uniform. Different groups experienced Hinduization to different extents, with some fully participating in the caste system while others maintained hybrid or outsider identities – a dynamic and context-dependent process of ethnic and social reordering.

Buchanan's collected material describes an influx of mostly high-caste Bengali migrants northward into the borderland areas of Rangpur, Jalpaiguri, and Dinajpur and onward into Assam, where they settled in close proximity to the courts of local and regional rulers. It focuses firstly on the activities of the Brahmins who provided it, the majority of whom were employed by rulers in administration, revenue collection, or other professional functions. Others served as private zamindars or religious leaders ministering to either elites or tribal people (those engaged in this work were split into different sub-castes and in conflict with each other, the former

describing the latter as being in violation of purity taboos because of their contact with non-Hindu or only partly Hinduized groups).³⁷

Brahmins were part of a wider wave of Bengali service groups and artisans moving northward into the Brahmaputra Valley, who were producing demographic and ethnic change in the region, partly through the displacement of tribal people, but partly through tribal people's emulation of caste organization in order to attain higher status in a society where elite culture and commercial life were increasingly dominated by Hindu norms. Migrants included bards, astrologers, doctors, scribes and artists. Buchanan noted that caste was confined primarily to these professional groups. Artisanal work was undertaken without reference to caste, save in professions that had been introduced from Bengal – "druggists, workers in shell, and barbers," as well as certain merchant groups, goldsmiths and moneylenders. Buchanan suspected that, because of the high status of these groups, people of tribal origins had begun to refashion themselves along similar lines, blurring the line between migrant and convert. In the far south of the district tribal groups had been entirely displaced by Bengali migrants, many of whom maintained homes to the south where they kept their families, though even these Bengali caste groups took on irregular forms, suggesting that they too were produced through some confluence of migration and conversion.³⁸

A large portion of the population of the district was comprised of Tibeto-Burman tribal groups. Aspirants to kingship had been emerging from these populations for centuries, often in tandem with Bengali brahmins and other service groups – a common pattern in acephalous tribal societies, where would-be rulers faced the question of how to build up power bases without the advantage of obedience to hereditary authority being a cultural norm.³⁹ Many of the minor principalities scattered across the region employed this strategy. The foremost among them was Koch Behar. Buchanan compiled a historical account of Koch Behar based on court chronicles, family papers and conversations with local brahmins. He concluded from these sources that, beginning in the thirteenth century, several waves of brahman migrants had successively entered into the service of the Koch princes at this time. The Koch, he noted, only appeared in chronicles

³⁷ Montgomery Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3 (London: W. H. Allen and Co., 1838), pp. 517-27.

³⁸ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 527-37.

³⁹ Sumit Guha, *Environment and Ethnicity in India, 1200-1991* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999), pp. 62-83.

after their conversion to Hinduism, and from the beginning, were associated with Kolita brahmins (from Kamrup, a defunct kingdom straddling the border between Assam and Bengal), who were likely the writers of these texts. In Buchanan's day, Kolita brahmins still retained the honor of serving as pandits to the Koch court, and managed large temple estates on its behalf; they also retained a high status in Koch communities, with whom they were closely connected through religious and economic ties and intermarriage.⁴⁰

After their invitation of brahmins into the court, the Koch had metamorphosed into Hindu rajas. In the process, they had been endowed with an origin story transformed to suit their new identity – one which served a legitimating function, pointing to the ideological role played by brahmins in these courts, who provided new and useful ways for rulers to represent themselves to their subjects. The Koch ruling family produced texts for Buchanan which declared their celestial origins and linked them to exiled kshatriya princes who had forgotten their original caste strictures and thus had become impure, but who, with brahmin aid, had recovered their purity; he writes that the Koch princes did not like to be reminded of their tribal origins, preferring to be addressed as Hindu rajas. He noted that many of the other elite families in the area of Tibeto-Burman ethnic origins had also adopted Hinduism and reforged their identities in a similar manner – a process he considered to be a manifestation of "national vanity."⁴¹ Though his phrasing is dismissive, he was correct in pointing to the fictional nature of these genealogies, and the ideological function they served.⁴²

The Koch were not a single, blood-related ethnic group, but rather a loose tribal coalition bound together by elite intermarriage and Hindu caste norms, trickling downward and outward from courts employing brahmins – only outsiders, such as the people of Bhutan, Nepal and Bengal referred to them as a single whole.⁴³ Intergroup distinctions among the Koch were in turn related to social stratification. Koch communities were subdivided based on the extent to which they conformed to caste norms; the extent to which they conformed to caste norms in turn was related to social status, with aristocrats being the purest. Some Koch communities had a multitude of

⁴⁰ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 542-5; S. K. Bhuyan, *Kamrupar Buranji* (Guwahati: Department of Historical and Antiquarian Studies, Assam, 1930), Appendix C.

⁴¹ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 414-15.

⁴² Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 220-38.

⁴³ This is the current consensus on the topic as well. See Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam*, p. 19.

status designations for people at different stages of purity. Other communities, less touched by conversion, divided themselves in half based on whether or not they had begun the process of accepting caste strictures. Those untouched made no distinction among themselves, from leaders "down to the lowest peasant that rears pigs or fowls."⁴⁴

One of the effects of sustained acculturation to Bengali cultural norms among the Koch was the creation of uniform subject populations with state-friendly characteristics, such as the acceptance of social hierarchy or the practice of sedentary agriculture. This was an uneven process, affecting different groups in different ways. Some groups spoke only Bengali and had shed their previous tribal appellations, refusing to be associated with them as they had in their unconverted state been considered impure. Other groups were split, with one part being acculturated to Bengali religious, linguistic and agricultural ways and the other part still retaining earlier customs.⁴⁵ Buchanan found that in some remote regions groups still retained languages and modes of life that were totally distinct from what prevailed in Bengal. They ignored caste strictures, practiced mobile, slash-and-burn agriculture and lived in the jungle. They also practiced matrilineal inheritance reminiscent of the Garos (a hill tribe to the east of the district), as were their religious practices and general avoidance of the state. Buchanan surmised that most of the tribal groups in the area had at one point shared much in common with each other, and that the Garos were likely the best example of a non-acculturated group in the district.⁴⁶

Other tribal groups in the region also had histories of conversion to Hinduism, state-building and acculturation to a sedentary lifestyle which bore much in common with the Koch, both in the general trend and in the unevenness of its effects. To briefly illustrate, the Khyen were full Hindu converts who had produced powerful rajas, as were the Kacharis, who, like the Koch, had once held political power in a wide space across the region. The Rabhas were divided based on the extent of their acculturation – those who had adopted Bengali language and cultivation methods were separated from those who had not, though neither had adopted Hinduism and they still intermarried with each other. The Mech had nearly disappeared, transforming their identity wholesale and merging with the Koch, but some remained in a liminal state – "although they

⁴⁴ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 538-45.

⁴⁵ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 501-2.

⁴⁶ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 538-42.

have adopted the language of Bengal, and some of the Hindu customs, they have not been able to wean themselves so completely as the Rajbongsis (the Koch aristocracy) from their impurities, and are not therefore permitted to assume this name." In other areas where Hinduism was less prevalent, they revealed themselves as Mech, as they were not subject to discrimination for assuming the name. These were shifting cultivators. The Nepcha were, according to his informants, "abominable" for their eating of beef. The Hajong had adopted the Bengali language but not Hinduism; however their raja had transformed his identity and considered himself a Rajbongsi, observing dietary taboos and employing brahmins in his court.⁴⁷

Unlike in Rangpur, Buchanan was not able to travel to Assam and make observations himself, so his notes here are entirely filtered through the perspectives of the brahmins who worked in courts across the region.⁴⁸ Like in Rangpur, the system of ethnic classification they were working from was based on Hindu purity taboos and had not only a descriptive but also a productive or transformative effect. It begins with the Bengali brahmins who were furnishing the information, who are represented as indispensable spiritual advisors to the Ahom king, also ministering to tribal congregants throughout the region. Significant attention is given to factionalism within this religious elite, some of whom were allied with the Ahom state; others, who ministered to tribal congregants, were associated with the heterodox sects that had risen up against the king. Brahmin migration northward was accompanied by the movement of other caste groups specializing in professional services, most of whom worked for Ahom and other regional aristocrats or the brahmin religious elite. Migration was also producing widespread cultural change, as communities beneath the elite level took up purity norms to varying degrees at varying rates, and with varying evenness. A few examples:

The Ahoms – slotted in by Buchanan's informants below Assam's brahmin community, in the position of a kshatriya warrior elite. Represented as an endogamous caste group, related in various degrees by blood ties. Particular attention was given to acculturation of the community along Bengali lines in language and religion, though it was mentioned that this was still incomplete.

⁴⁷ Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vol. 3, pp. 545-53.

⁴⁸ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 51-7.

Chutiya – a numerous "tribe" living among the Ahom and divided between "Hindu and Aham," the distinction being that the former had "abandoned many of their impure customs, and have received degraded (Varna) Brahmins as their spiritual guides. The latter wallow in their impurity, and adhere to the Deodhaings (the Ahom priesthood)." The Chutiyas, who had in the pre-Ahom period had their own state,⁴⁹ had been partly incorporated into the Ahom aristocracy as lesser members,⁵⁰ and still retained significant local political power. The process of conversion was taking place among them in a similar manner to how it had spread through the Ahom elite, likely because of their conjoined nature.

Kolitas and Koch – these two groups are described together. Though they were ethnically distinct, they formed a single social system, as they did in Rangpur. The Kolitas (who, in Buchanan's eyes, were indistinguishable from Bengalis both culturally and physiologically) served as merchants and artisans across Assam, as well as spiritual guides, particularly for the Koch, with whom they intermarried. The Koch had features that marked them as of "Chinese origin," and counted many rajas among their midst, as well as serving similar trade and artisanal functions in Assam. Though they were "less abstinent than the Kolitas, and are considered as lower; but still they are admitted to be pure."

Groups were ranked and ordered based on the extent to which they conformed to Hindu purity norms and the lifeways of settled, agricultural civilization. Those who had political power were generally considered purer, especially if they ruled in concert with brahmins and the legitimating cultural practices they brought – likely an aftereffect of their patronization of brahmins and early adoption of caste norms. The ruled were organized according to the extent to which they conformed to purity taboos and practices associated with settled cultivation. Groups that spoke Bengali and practiced sedentary agriculture were generally considered purer; conversely, political decentralization and shifting habitation in the woods and hills were associated with impurity. This mode of thought, like others of its kind,⁵¹ was conducive to state-building efforts in societies with weak social stratification, nebulous political loyalties, and low population

⁴⁹ Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 2, pp. 55-6, 60-2.

⁵⁰ Guha, *Medieval and Early Colonial Assam*, p. 60.

⁵¹ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 98-127; Stevan Harrell, *Cultural Encounters on China's Ethnic Frontiers* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1995), pp. 3-37; Guha, *Environment and Ethnicity*; Surajit Sinha, *Tribal Politics and State Systems in Pre-Colonial Eastern and North Eastern India* (Calcutta: Centre for Studies in Social Sciences, 1987).

densities scattered over large tracts of difficult terrain. Tribal chiefs could, by inviting brahmins into their courts and converting to Hinduism, travel a well-trodden path to becoming rajas and enjoying all the benefits that came with kingly status, while simultaneously encouraging the development of a stratified agrarian social order that could be taxed and controlled.

The social and cultural landscape of northern Rangpur and Assam does not appear in early colonial accounts in crystallized form as a neatly-ordered taxonomy of castes, but rather as a complex, shifting tapestry of tribal groups clearly undergoing a process of ethnic metamorphosis. The region was experiencing an influx of high-caste Bengali migrants, especially brahmins, who found employment in courts across the region, large and small, which valued them for their administrative skills, the cultural prestige they brought, and their role in intellectually ordering the region's peoples according to norms which created coherence and hierarchy in the social realm, as well as promoting adherence to agricultural lifeways. This process, while beginning in the households of rulers, was not confined to them, but rather spilled out across the region, as a variety of people sought to emulate new social norms developed in an elite context in order to bolster their own social and political standing. The results were far from uniform and clearly in flux. Some groups had shed their previous tribal identities, while others exhibited signs of partial adaptation of caste norms and still others, especially communities on the verge of settled agricultural civilization, disavowed them completely. That all of this can be reconstructed from early colonial knowledge is a potent reminder that it did not immediately act to erase the fluidity of ethnic identification in the pre-colonial world.

STRATEGIC ACCULTURATION

In this section, I analyze early colonial descriptions of Ahom court culture, which emerges as a syncretic blend of cultural practices of both Southeast Asian and Indian origins. Like many of the other smaller courts dotted across the region, the Ahoms constituted the political and military half of a dual ruling elite, the other half of which was comprised of Bengali brahmins who served religious and ceremonial roles in the court and in temples across the kingdom. Despite having adopted many of the cultural technologies offered by Brahminic Hinduism, the Ahoms do not emerge in these records as having fully acculturated to the extent that their Southeast Asian origins became obscured. Instead, they appear as a conquest elite that selectively incorporated

the symbols and ritual practices of both South and Southeast Asian traditions to serve fundamental political objectives – marking the legitimacy of the ruler, celebrating the potency of the state, and reinforcing the separation between the ruling aristocracy and its subjects. This is evident in court rituals, where Brahminic rites were introduced without displacing older Ahom practices overseen by the court's indigenous priesthood, ensuring legitimacy across both Hindu and non-Hindu elite circles. The same strategy shaped historical narratives, both oral and textual, which, while incorporating Hindu themes, retained their original Southeast Asian structure centered on dynastic legitimation through the weaving together of mythology and histories of conquest. Taken together, these practices illustrate how political legitimacy in the Ahom state was built on elite stratification and the hybridization of court cultures rather than proto-national unity.

Ethnographic description from the Welsh expedition, and from Buchanan's brahmin informants, represents the Ahoms as a small, exclusive group, the key criteria for inclusion into which was proof of descent from the mythical founder of the kingdom through genealogical claims; these groups were entitled to "retain all the principal offices of state." There were only twenty-six such clans, but there were also a number of other members of the group who were conceptualized as illegitimate offspring of the aristocracy. Buchanan recognized this as more than likely a fiction, offering the speculative explanation that these lesser clan branches were descendants from the soldiers and servants of the conquering aristocracy.⁵² The most current explanation, given by Yasmin Saikia, is that the Ahoms were not a blood-related group at all. Her tracing of the biographies of some of these aristocrats shows that many of them had mixed ethnic backgrounds, a result of the intermarriage between important Ahom clans and other elite families that had predated their arrival in the Brahmaputra valley.⁵³

In a conquest elite displaying significant ethnic diversity in practice, the cultural realm played an important role in the construction of a unified identity. This realm was presided over by two groups – Bengali brahmins and deo-dhangs, the Ahoms' original priesthood. Brahmins serving in the Ahom court were plentiful, holding religious offices and advising the king. Those who held

⁵² Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 52-3.

⁵³ Yasmin Saikia, *Fragmented Memories: Struggling to be Tai-Ahom in India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2004), pp. 113-47.

the highest positions were Bengali in origin, many of whom traveled back and forth across the border to receive religious instruction.⁵⁴ The deo-dhangs, a key component of the king's household, were a tiny group, but one that commanded great respect. They maintained a variety of ritual objects of importance in ceremonies of legitimation, demonstrating the ruler's connection to his putative ancestors, the founders of the Ahom state. Buchanan also wrote that they possessed "a learning and language peculiar to themselves (pre-Hindu religion and a script derived from Burmese), and keep them a profound secret; but they have in many points adopted the worship of Vishnu."

In Assam, as in Southeast Asia, the relationship between central and peripheral rulers, decentralized in practice, was held together through elaborate court rituals symbolizing mutual bonds of loyalty and service obligations. One notable example of these were coronation ceremonies. Buchanan was given a description of these by a brahmin whose family were hereditary retainers of the king, tasked with the responsibility of running them.⁵⁵ He described how on the appointed day, the raja, on full display of the capital's assembled soldiers and nobles, rode an elephant to the place where his mythical ancestors had first descended from heaven and planted a tree on the ground, claiming Assam as their own. He wore potent symbols – a likeness of the pre-Hindu Ahom god slung around his neck, a magical sword, and the feathers of a sacred bird in his turban. He was then bathed in holy water kept in ceremonial vessels, after which he sacrificed a buffalo. The raja then ascended his throne and was showered with gifts from his nobles, after which he gave presents in return to his priests and officers, followed by provisions to the multitude. The full ceremony took over a month, culminating with the minting of new coins in the king's image, signaling the beginning of his reign.

This was an important public display of the king's sacredness and genealogical connection to the mythical founders of the kingdom, which was linked to his right to rule. It also served to bind his assembled courtiers to him, and him to them, as well as to collectively set them out from the wider population as an aristocratic elite. Such ceremonies, which originated in the pre-Hindu period,⁵⁶ rather than being discarded on the court's conversion, were transformed through their

⁵⁴ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, p. 1.

⁵⁵ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 17-18.

⁵⁶ Barpujari, *The Comprehensive History of Assam*, Vol. 3, pp. 5-7.

joint administration by brahmins, who infused Hindu symbols into them. The deployment of multiple iconographies in these ceremonies increased their symbolic potency, allowing the king to project multiple identities: one as a Tai prince who traced his ancestry back to the original military conquest of the Brahmaputra valley; the other as a Hindu monarch whose authority was embedded within a sacred cosmic order.⁵⁷

One of the most vital functions of the deo-dhangs, the pre-Hindu priesthood, was to maintain the Ahom chronicle tradition, which linked Ahom identity both to divine ancestry and to the process of military conquest through which the Ahom state had been forged. This chronicle tradition was of Southeast Asian origin, connected to those of Tai city-states in northern Burma (chronicles from those principalities are substantially similar in tone and content to those of the Ahoms, besides recording how a group of aristocrats broke off and forged through the mountains to found the Ahom state).⁵⁸ Over time, the chronicles shifted linguistically from being written in a Southeast Asian script derived from Burmese to a script derived from Bengali. The preambles, which placed the ruling dynasty within its cosmological context and traced its ancestry deep into the mythological past, linking the rulers of the present with superhuman figures, also shifted to reflect the court's Hinduization. However, the framework of these narratives remained constant because it was connected to the political function they served, which was to construct a shared elite identity and naturalize the aristocracy's monopoly of power.

Wade wrote a history of the kingdom that was a pastiche of at least two chronicles – one a dynastic history of the Ahom kings, and another focused on the Ahom-Mughal wars.⁵⁹ Like others of their kind, these texts served as a vehicle for highlighting the legitimacy of the Ahom monarch and conquest elite.⁶⁰ The narrative begins with a mythological account of the

⁵⁷ This observation is inspired by Phillippe Foret's argument about the importance of Tibetan Buddhism in the Qing dynasty's governance of its steppe periphery. Phillippe Foret, *Mapping Chengde: The Qing Landscape Enterprise* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2000).

⁵⁸ Translations of these were made in the colonial period. See Robert Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India* (Calcutta: Baptist Mission Press, 1835), pp. 108-16; George Scott, *Gazetteer of Upper Burma and the Shan States*, Vol. 1, Part 1 (Rangoon: Superintendent, Government Printing, Burma, 1900), pp. 216-72; Ney Elias, *Introductory Sketch of the History of the Shans in Upper Burma and Western Yunnan* (Calcutta: Foreign Department Press, 1876).

⁵⁹ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 1-179.

⁶⁰ D. G. E. Hall, *Historians of Southeast Asia* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1961), pp. 13-107; Thant Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), pp. 79-83. This observation is also in line with Yasmin Saikia's analysis of Ahom chronicles in their original form. Saikia, *Fragmented Memories*, p. 113.

foundation of the Ahom state, then provides snapshots of the reigns of the early Ahom kings, the details of which seem largely guesswork given the antiquity of the subject matter (it is the chain of connection to present rulers that is important, not the specific details). The text becomes more empirically rich as time goes on, particularly after the founding of the Tungkhungia dynasty, which was in power in Wade's time, to the point that it includes statistical breakdowns of the components of armies, or of slaves taken in war. The major theme that emerges is one of imperial expansion. The history focuses on intrastate warfare in and around the Brahmaputra basin, in particular the conquest of the Chutiya, Kachari and other Tibeto-Burman tribal states existing in the region before the arrival of the Ahoms, and the wars fought against the Mughals that brought a large chunk of the Bengal frontier under Ahom control. Included as well are detailed chapters on the mythological origins and political histories of other regional kingdoms such as Jaintiya, which are represented being as in a relationship of imperial subordination to the Ahoms (though in Wade's time many of these imperial relationships had broken down, they are not represented as such).⁶¹ Emphasized throughout are the pedigree, righteousness, wealth, and power of the ruler, as well as militaristic values – deeds of martial glory, the chastisement of enemies, the submission of hill tribes and lesser kings, and their offerings of tribute and brides – suggesting that elite privilege was conceptualized as being derived from the right of conquest and that the separation of ruler and ruled along these lines was a core feature of the state.

Ahom rulers were socialized through the use of such texts, reinforcing the ideological foundations of their rule. The following is drawn from the preamble of the first chronicle, and gives a sense of the social function they performed (this one specifically says that the text had been commissioned by the king to be a history of kings and their deeds and nothing more):

King of Kings, Lord of the Lightning and of the Royal Canopy capped with Gold...Lord of the Golden palace; Thou art a Monarch, but a Monarch like the Canopy of the skies, surrounding the Globe. Thy heart is illuminated like the Sun and knoweth no trouble nor anxiety. Thy person is beautiful as the lower branches of the Root of Coral. Thou art resplendent above the princes of the earth, like the moon among the stars and admired like. Thine understanding is unfathomable as the ocean, a mountain of greatness among

⁶¹ S. K. Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations, 1771-1826* (Guwahati: Department of Historical and Antiquarian Studies, Government of Assam, 1949), pp. 22-31.

men. Thy goodness extendeth to thine enemies as well as thy friends. Thou art intimate with the Gods and equal to Him Who rules above the Seven Heavens. Yet, Thou who art equal to God, has condescended to order that the following history should be written.⁶²

Ahom monarchs were educated in childhood through oral recitations of these texts. They were narrated by the king's household priest, who attended him and educated him as a child, instructing him in the "profane literature of his ancestors. He entertained and instructed his royal pupil with the Historical Anecdotes of ancient times," Wade wrote.⁶³ The practice underscores how Ahom identity was constructed and reinforced from childhood, ensuring the continuity of elite self-perception across generations.

A similar link between history, identity and political legitimacy emerges from oral accounts collected by Buchanan of the origin myth of the Ahoms.⁶⁴ This was centered around two brothers descended from heaven who came to earth to found a state. Similar origin myths were shared by many different Tai groups across Southeast Asia, particularly in the northern Burmese Shan states.⁶⁵ In each localized version of the myth, the content is generally rearranged to suit the political needs of the teller, which is what occurred in the Ahom version. Though the frame of the tale is recognizably the same as in northern Burmese chronicles, here it is overlaid with Hindu symbolism, reflecting the conversion of the ruling elite, and takes place in Assam, functioning to provide a justification for Ahom rule in the Brahmaputra valley. Buchanan was told that the twelve petty chiefs of Assam, upon being confronted by the founding Ahom princes who had appeared in their midst, "without force, submitted to a person very much their superior in dignity and education," though he noted that this was a matter of debate – some of his Kachari informants had told him the country had once been theirs, and had been taken from them. As was the case with Ahom chronicles, the rearrangement of the contents of a shared Tai mythological corpus to suit a new political setting illustrates how the Ahoms instrumentally deployed historical narratives to construct a shared elite identity and legitimate the separation of ruler from ruled.

⁶² Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 1-2.

⁶³ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, p. xxxiv.

⁶⁴ Buchanan, *An Account of Assam*, pp. 3-14.

⁶⁵ Elias, *Introductory Sketch of the History of the Shans*, pp. 28-38.

The syncretism at work here was so obvious that even colonial observers, not generally known for their subtlety in the treatment of such topics, were able to discern it. Peter Wade argued that the evidence he had collected militated against the idea then in fashion in Calcutta that Hinduism was a static, unchanging faith, writing that:

...the present religious establishment is certainly derived from the conversion of the Monarch and his subjects to the Hindu faith...This fact merits particular notice, as the Literati in general and even Sir William Jones, have adopted an erroneous opinion that the Hindu religion rejects both persecution and proselytism, a notion utterly incomprehensible with the diffusion of that doctrine over a large portion of the globe; unless we suppose the faith of the Brahmuns to have diffused its rays at once like a flash of lightening by general inspiration over innumerable nations.⁶⁶

To conclude, the Ahom polity emerges in the earliest colonial records as an ethnically stratified state in which political power was monopolized by a small conquest elite tracing its origins back to a lineage of Tai princes from northern Burma. Because this conquest elite was in practice a composite alloy comprised of multiple ethnic groups, including other Tibeto-Burman aristocratic lineages, the cultural realm played an important role in the construction of a unified identity. This cultural realm, originally overseen by an indigenous priesthood, increasingly incorporated Bengali brahmins and the cultural technologies of rule they had to offer into its symbolic repertoire. This syncretism can be observed both in court ritual and in its oral and textual traditions, both of which increasingly deployed Hindu concepts over time. However, this was a strategic adaptation of Indian culture for political purposes. At the time of its earliest contact with Company officials in the late 18th and early 19th centuries, the Ahom elite continued to emphasize its Southeast Asian origins and its links to the conquests of the past, which formed the ideological foundations of its rule.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter I used early colonial knowledge of Assam to highlight a lack of overlap between territory, ethnicity and sovereignty in the kingdom in four areas. The first was a state/society

⁶⁶ Wade, *An Account of Assam*, pp. iii-iv.

divide. Descriptions of the structure of the state make it clear that it was an imperial entity based on a Southeast Asian template, forged through conquest and oriented toward the extraction of labor and resources from its subjects. Secondly, I highlighted the Ahom state's uneven projection of sovereignty. Conquest did not produce a coherent state structure, but rather a tangled warren of sovereignty relationships marked by fragmentation within the state's religious and political elite, partial incorporation of a variety of local stakeholders, and entanglement with surrounding states and tribal groups, producing a variety of shifting, byzantine power-sharing arrangements. My account of ethnicity encompassed both Assam and Rangpur district in northern Bengal, showing how what emerges in the earliest colonial knowledge of these areas is not a neatly ordered collection of nationalities, but rather a fragmented landscape of tribes in the process of metamorphosing into castes under the influence of brahmins and other high-status Bengali migrant communities attached to regional courts. Finally, I explored the strategic acculturation of the Ahom aristocracy, illustrating how it selectively integrated Hindu symbolic practices into a Southeast Asian ideological framework, ensuring the long-term survival of an ethnically differentiated conquest elite.

Rather than constituting a pyramidal structure encompassing in a uniform manner the whole population of a defined space, I have endeavored to describe the Ahom polity from the bottom up as a series of partly overlapping layers, beginning with the most basic: the physical environment, determining settlement patterns and modes of life. Following on this was a heavily fragmented ethnic landscape, which was characterized by a high degree of mobility and widespread cultural change. Next came local powerholders, whether tribal chiefs, temple stewards, minor rajas or landed aristocrats, who controlled nodes of population and their resource hinterlands. Layered over these were state functionaries, who in their independence and self-interest were far from machine-like instruments of the ruler's will but often more closely approximated minor kings themselves. Finally, dotted across the regional landscape were powerful courts, whose gravity, attained as much through cultural symbolism as military might, warped this fabric, pulling the different layers into relationships of submission that varied according to distance, topography and the strength of countervailing forces.

The state/society divide in the kingdom feeds into the broader literature on the global history of empire.⁶⁷ Assam's political economy was largely structured along Southeast Asian lines, around mass deployment of corvee labor and state monopolization of trade and natural resources, enabling the monarchy to amass wealth for military and ceremonial expenditures. Efforts by the Ahom conquest elite to maintain their uniqueness and monopoly on political power parallel the simultaneous ethnic and social stratification found in many other imperial formations across the world in the early modern period, including in many parts of Europe.⁶⁸ The many exceptions, contradictions and ambiguities in the structure of the Ahom state, especially in its borderlands, suggest that it was an entity forged through a dynamic process of conquest and incorporation of many different states and peoples by varying methods and to varying degrees, producing a collection of contingent results, captured and frozen at a specific moment in time under the gaze of early colonial observers.

The Brahmaputra valley in the late 18th century was far from being an integral part of Indian civilization "since time immemorial," as one scholar put it.⁶⁹ Rather, it was a true civilizational crossroads in which high-caste Bengali migration and Brahminic Hinduism were layered over top of a social and economic fabric and a form of statecraft very similar to that of Southeast Asia. The Ahom aristocracy selectively incorporated Hindu symbolism into its court culture, commissioning brahmins to officiate in rituals while maintaining its pre-Hindu priesthood and genealogical traditions that traced its origins to ancestral conquest. Similarly, tribal rulers across Assam and Rangpur engaged in a process of strategic Hinduization, aligning themselves with

⁶⁷ John Darwin, *After Tamerlane: The Global History of Empire* (London: Penguin, 2007); Jane Burbank and Frederick Cooper, *Empires in World History: Power and the Politics of difference* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2010); Brian P. Farrell, Donna Brunero and Jack Fairey, *Empire in Asia: A New Global History*, Vols. 1-2 (London: Bloomsbury, 2018); Michael Adas, 'Imperialism and Colonialism in Comparative Perspective,' *The International History Review*, 20:2 (1998), pp. 371-388; Peter Perdue, *China Marches West: The Qing Conquest of Central Eurasia* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2005); see also the relevant entries on state formation in Jerry Bentley, *The Oxford Handbook of World History* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011) and the *Cambridge World History*, in particular the volumes dealing with the early modern and modern period. Jerry H. Bentley, Sanjay Subrahmanyam, Merry E. Wiesner-Hanks, Jürgen Osterhammel and Akira Iriye, *The Cambridge World History*, Vols. 6-7 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015).

⁶⁸ This is an argument inspired by studies of the Qing dynasty emphasizing the continued importance of the Manchu ruling elite's steppe origins to the conduct of politics and the expression of identity. For an overview of scholarship on this topic, see Evelyn Rawski, 'Presidential Address: Reenvisioning the Qing: The Significance of the Qing Period in Chinese History,' *The Journal of Asian Studies*, 55:4 (1996), pp. 829-850. The pattern of combined ethnic stratification and political hierarchy more broadly was characteristic of states across the early modern world, including in Europe. See for example the description of the Austro-Hungarian empire in Ernest Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1983), ch. 2.

⁶⁹ Sristidhar Dutta, *The Matakas and their Kingdom* (Allahabad: Chugh Publications, 1985), p. 1.

Brahminic frameworks to enhance their status. Beneath the elite level, Hinduization was uneven and incomplete, with some groups fully assimilating into the caste system while others maintained hybrid or non-caste identities. Although the influence of Indian civilization frontier is undeniable, it is equally important to simultaneously hold in view the agency of local actors, who strategically incorporated parts of its cultural complex in a negotiated, context-dependent fashion.

At base, I hope this chapter helps to revamp the view that colonial knowledge could only function to distort, rather than illuminate its objects. Though they were carrying out an imperial project, and though their normative perspectives generally served imperial interests, early colonial officials produced a cacophony of information of differing shades of usefulness to the modern historian. Some produced texts based entirely on regurgitated preconceptions, which have little value other than for what they can contribute to contemporary understandings of the ideological aspects of imperialism. Others were major outliers, able to collect evidence of phenomena that diverged heavily from European experience. This was not necessarily because they had political views more palatable to modern tastes; rather, it was because of their use of inductive methods, allowing them to siphon up vast quantities of knowledge – often sourced from indigenous informants – which did not fit into any single intellectual framework, making it ripe for reinterpretation. If one takes the broadest possible perspective, the overall effect of colonial knowledge was that, over time, it buried the messy indeterminacy of the precolonial world under a mass of theorizing which gave it artificial coherence. However, by examining specific parts of the colonial archive, especially those produced through early cross-cultural encounter, it is possible to produce a different picture.

CHAPTER 4

SOCIAL CONNECTION, KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE AND ACCOMMODATION ON THE SYMES EMBASSY TO BURMA

This chapter is an analysis of the embassy sent by the EIC to Burma under captain Michael Symes in 1795, tracing evidence of entanglement and accommodation between the two sides. I map out the surprising degree of socialization and intellectual exchange taking place between embassy members and their Burmese government counterparts in private, out of which came enough information to build the first well-defined image of Burma Enlightenment Europeans had access to; one which was relatively sympathetic in tone in its published form (at least in comparison to the jingoism of the 19th century), while internally being utilized by the Company bureaucracy in the drafting of clandestine plans for exploitation and conquest, a potent reminder of the connection between the collection of intelligence and realpolitik. I then consider the tensions between the two sides in public, which I treat as stemming from the meeting of two different empires, vastly different in their structural and ideological underpinnings but similar in their basic orientation towards expansion in the quest for wealth and power. Finally, I look at how and why the Symes embassy was able to reach a brief detente with the Burmese – unusual in the overall scope of relations between the two states – which I trace back to the loose, pragmatic form of sovereignty practiced by both sides and a willingness to accommodate through an arrangement of interpenetration typical of politics across the early modern world but unusual at this late date.

Conflict-focused narratives have typified the historiography of Anglo-Burmese relations since the colonial period itself. This is a trend that can be detected in some of the earliest histories of Burma written by its new colonial rulers,¹ wherein diplomatic incidents, and the slighted pride that came from them, were pointed to as one of the main justifications for conquest – an argument that can be detected in wispier form in the writings of early professional historians of Burma, many of whom were former colonial officials who, even after the British Empire ended,

¹ The most learned and influential (and also the most condemnatory) of these texts was George Bayfield, 'Historical Review of the Political Relations Between the Government in India and the Empire of Ava,' in Robert Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India* (Calcutta: Baptist Mission Press, 1835); other narratives include John Snodgrass, *Narrative of the Burmese War* (London: John Murray, 1826) and Thomas Robertson, *Political Incidents of the First Burmese War* (London: Richard Bentley, 1853).

seem to have incorporated its memory into their patriotism.² This legacy drove liberal Western scholars and Burmese nationalists alike in the immediate postcolonial period to preoccupy themselves with writing back against the prejudiced ideological prism through which Burma had traditionally been understood in the West.³ Though coming from different ideological poles, these writers seem to have converged on a similar methodology, which was to move back through the colonial archive, identifying areas of conflict between the two states and presenting interpretations that essentially reversed the conclusions of pro-empire writers, shifting blame for the two states' descent into war squarely onto the shoulders of the British Empire, portrayed as an imperialist aggressor looking for new people to conquer and new markets to exploit – or, as Michael Aung-Thwin wrote, "although each of the wars (between Burma and the British Empire) had its own peculiar, 'immediate' causal factors, at bottom lay the worldwide phenomenon of Imperialism."⁴

Given its landmark importance as the vehicle for reopening relations between the two states, the Symes embassy has attracted strangely little attention from modern historians. Maung Htin Aung's *The Stricken Peacock: Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1752-1948* devotes only a single page to it, noting that Symes was unusual in the arc of Anglo-Burmese relations in that he was successful in his negotiations with the Burmese and had a positive outlook on the kingdom.⁵ Dorothy Woodman's *The Making of Burma* also passes over the embassy quickly, noting appreciatively that Symes was more sensitive to the Burmese point of view than his successors tended to be, and that he came away with an agreement which instilled hope of the opening of friendly trade and diplomatic relations, before quickly moving on to a takedown of his odious successor, Hiram Cox, so racist and paranoid that he earned the opprobrium of his own peers, who considered him irrational and incompetent.⁶ The lengthiest and most recent study on the

² John Cady, *A History of Modern Burma* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1958); George Harvey, *History of Burma, from the Earliest Times to the Beginning of the English Conquest* (London: Longmans, 1925); D. G. E. Hall, *Europe and Burma* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1945).

³ The most prominent Burmese nationalist interpretation remains Maung Htin Aung, *The Stricken Peacock: Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1752-1948* (The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 1965); anti-colonial interpretations written from a broadly liberal perspective include Dorothy Woodman, *The Making of Burma* (London: Cresset Press, 1962) and G. P. Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations, 1795-1826,' (PhD Thesis, University of Hull, 1977).

⁴ Michael Aung-Thwin, *A History of Myanmar Since Ancient Times: Traditions and Transformations* (London: Reaktion Books, 2012), p. 176.

⁵ Htin Aung, *The Stricken Peacock*, p. 22.

⁶ Woodman, *The Making of Burma*, pp. 41-5; for a broadside of Cox, straight from the mouth of the EIC governor-general, see IOR/F/4/71/1583, Political Letter from Bengal, March 16th, 1798. See also G. P. Ramachandra, 'Captain

embassy to date, a chapter in a PhD thesis by G. P. Ramachandra, written in the 1970s, assimilates the embassy into a wider narrative of diplomatic quarrels and instances of misunderstanding between the two sides,⁷ part of his effort to rehabilitate the image of the Konbaung monarchs, tarnished as he says in his introduction by colonial writings which contain an “ethnocentric bias of the old-fashioned type.”

In the Indian context, there have been multiple prominent calls to move away from these kinds of debate-hall-style motions for and against imperialism.⁸ In the Burmese context, several studies have also been written that are little by little wriggling out of the pro anti/imperial partisanship that characterized the scholarly exchanges of the 1960s and 70s.⁹ My analysis of the Symes embassy is in a similar light, taking cues from global histories that emphasize similarity, exchange and connectivity rather than conflict and incommensurability.¹⁰

I present the clash between the two states as an ambiguous one between two empires, differing in their methods and worldviews but similar in their expansionary drive. Konbaung Burma was a state fundamentally imperial in orientation, though this was not expressed in the same way as it was in the Company’s case. The EIC, a capitalist trading corporation, was motivated by a desire for cash profits, either through taxing conquered territories or aggressive mercantilism. The Burmese were interested in conquering or rendering neighboring rulers tributary, in large part because it garnered prestige for the court as understood within its own ideological context,¹¹ but also for material reasons, in particular control over human bodies, often slaves taken in war.¹² At base, these were both empires, united in their overall goal of political expansion in the quest for wealth and status, and the root cause of the increasing tensions between them over the course of

Hiram Cox's Mission to Burma, 1796-1798: A Case of Irrational Behavior in Diplomacy,' *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 12:2 (1981), pp. 433-451.

⁷ Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations,' ch. 1.

⁸ See the introduction to Douglas Peers and Nandini Gooptu, *India and the British Empire* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012); for another critique of the pro/anti-imperial binary, see Sanjay Subrahmanyam, 'Making Sense of Indian Historiography,' *Indian Economic & Social History Review*, 39:2-3 (2002), p. 125.

⁹ Thant Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001); Oliver Pollak, *Empires in Collision: Anglo-Burmese Relations in the Mid-Nineteenth Century* (Westport: Greenwood Press, 1982).

¹⁰ Sebastian Conrad, *What is Global History?* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2016).

¹¹ Nicholas Tarling, *The Cambridge History of Southeast Asia*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), pp. 575-9.

¹² For a discussion of the foundations of Burmese political economy (and the ways in which it was changing over the course of the early modern period), see Victor Lieberman, 'Secular Trends in Burmese Economic History, c. 1350-1830, and their Implications for State Formation,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 25:1 (1991), pp. 1-31.

the 18th century was that both were rising to power simultaneously, causing increased competition over border tributaries, trade relations and diplomatic protocol.

Both empires were also capable of a degree of flexibility in the exercise of sovereignty not characteristic of modern nation-states.¹³ I trace their short-lived detente back to this imperial pragmatism. The Burmese practiced a form of statecraft in which court culture was particularly important, elevating the ruler as an object of veneration precisely because the state was heavily decentralized in practice, not only having imperfect control of its own institutional structures, but also coexisting with a variety of other rulers whose power was derived from independent sources, and who were loosely folded into the dynasty's political networks as tributaries or clients.¹⁴ Such flexible systems, glued together by a political center with overwhelming cultural legitimacy, were highly adaptable, able at times of strength to incorporate elites from conquered states, and at times of weakness, to incorporate newcomers staking their own claims to power.¹⁵

The Company was well-versed in instrumentally exploiting such tendencies. Its incarnation in this period was less that of a state, extending uniform bureaucratic control from the loftiest reaches down to the local level, and more that of a 'meta-state,' or a small, European-style bureaucracy overlaying a teeming variety of local and regional political and social systems, many of which were hijacked and repurposed to serve the Company's security and financial interests. In the course of worming its way into other political systems, the Company time and again proved itself willing to engage in the feudal give-and-take of privileges and obligations, and also to be willing to linger in the background, strategically ceding the arena of outward state forms and cultural symbolism to indigenous actors while attempting to furtively grab hold of

¹³ For a description of the differences between premodern and modern forms of sovereignty in Southeast Asia, see Thongchai Winichakul, *Siam Mapped: A History of the Geo-Body of a Nation* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1994). For colonial sovereignty, see Lauren Benton, *A Search for Sovereignty: Law and Geography in European Empires, 1400-1900* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010).

¹⁴ Victor Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles: Anarchy and Conquest, C. 1580-1760* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1984), pp. 10-12.

¹⁵ My model here is the Mughal Empire, in which the emperor's cultural legitimacy long outlasted his actual political power. For early conquests and incorporation of local elites, see John F. Richards, *The Mughal Empire* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993), pp. 59-66, 143-8. For the ways in which the colonial state grew out of, existed within and eventually usurped the emperor's authority, see Abdul Majed Khan, 'Introduction: The Twilight of Mughal Bengal,' in ed. Peter Marshall, *The Eighteenth Century in Indian History: Evolution or Revolution?* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2003), pp. 359-373 and C. A. Bayly, *Indian Society and the Making of the British Empire* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), pp. 169-200.

trade flows, fortified bases and other levers of hard power¹⁶ – exactly the strategy Symes pursued in his negotiations with the Burmese court.

Finally, as was often the case with early Company intelligence collection, here also much of it emerged from social connection with indigenous elites – something of an anomaly in the Burmese context, where aristocrats and officials, wary of the Company, were often tight-lipped.¹⁷ The intellectual exchanges occurring in these informal settings allowed the Symes the embassy to collect a huge trove of information on Burma, revolutionizing the image that Enlightenment Europeans held of the kingdom – an image significantly more positive than what it would later become as the two states lurched toward war and British writers on the kingdom, seized with jingoistic fervor, turned to darkened screeds.¹⁸ I also show though that whether or not Symes was well-disposed to Burma on a personal level, his mandate was to collect information in order to aid the realpolitik calculations of the EIC. This becomes clear in unpublished debriefing reports submitted to the government, where he and his staff laid out in cold terms for their superiors everything they wanted to know about the economic state of Burma and prospects for exploiting it, as well as the political state of the kingdom and how to defeat it in case of war.

The chapter is organized into two halves, the first focusing on sociability and intellectual exchange in the private realm, showing how Symes and his staff were able to bypass the networks of Indian Ocean intermediaries that had stood in the way as gatekeepers for previous embassies, opening up a significant exchange of information between the two sides. I analyze both the public and private manifestations of these knowledge collection efforts, highlighting some of the generous statements made by the officials on the mission, incongruous in the wider context of colonial representations of Burma, as well as the much more Machiavellian tone of post-mission debriefings. In the second and third sections I pivot to public interactions, first

¹⁶ Some important books on how exactly this was accomplished in the hinterlands of the Company's three major presidencies around Bengal, Madras and Bombay include Nicholas Dirks, *The Scandal of Empire: India and the Creation of Imperial Britain* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2006); David Veevers, *The Origins of the British Empire in Asia, 1600-1750* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2020); and Peter Marshall, *Bengal – the British Bridgehead, Eastern India, 1740-1828* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).

¹⁷ C. A. Bayly, *Empire & Information: Intelligence gathering and social communication in India, 1780-1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996) argues that the EIC was unable to forge these kinds of connections in Burma – evidently this was not always the case.

¹⁸ Jacques Leider, 'Alaungmintaya, King of Myanmar (1752-60) – Representations in Burmese and Western Historiography,' *Aséanie* 33 (2014), pp. 18-20.

detailing tensions between the two states arising from a variety of structural oppositions in the realms of trade, political culture and control of tributary states across their shared periphery. Finally, I consider how this impasse was overcome, demonstrating how, in backroom negotiations after the conclusion of the first audience, the two sides were able to hash out a pragmatic deal that represented the possibility of mutual accommodation, however short-lived it turned out to be.

INFORMAL NETWORKING AND KNOWLEDGE EXCHANGE

In this section, I argue that the Symes embassy marked a turning point in British knowledge production on Burma, utilizing its first extensive diplomatic engagement with the kingdom in half a century to create an empirically detailed portrait of it – one which was constructed through extensive contact with indigenous informants. Unlike earlier missions, which relied on Indian Ocean intermediaries to mediate interactions with the Burmese state, Symes and his entourage successfully bypassed these groups and embedded themselves directly within elite Burmese networks. By cultivating personal relationships with key officials – most notably the viceroy of Pegu, who acted as their patron and broker – they gained unprecedented access to the intellectual life of the kingdom. In intimate settings, the two sides exchanged vast amounts of information on subjects ranging from botany and geography to astronomy, glassmaking, and painting. While the published materials from the mission reflect a relatively sympathetic view of the kingdom, likely a byproduct of affective ties developed during the embassy, internal bureaucratic documents point to the underlying purpose of this knowledge collection, which was to provide an aid to realpolitik deliberations over how best to exploit Burma's economic resources and political vulnerabilities. In this way, the Symes mission exemplifies how Company officials fused sociability and Enlightenment empiricism with strategic ambition, using meticulous information collection to construct blueprints for conquest.

The Symes embassy was carrying in tow much greater social and cultural capital than the first round of ad hoc, abortive missions sent by the Company to Burma in the mid-18th century.¹⁹ It was conceived of at the highest level of the government, and was fully resourced and monitored

¹⁹ The research for this is coming from a chapter on these earlier embassies that had to be cut for space. The primary source accounts can be found in Alexander Dalrymple, *Oriental Repertory*, Vols. 1-2 (London: G. Biggs, 1793).

and staffed by officers of high rank and high social class, specifically chosen for skill sets useful in cross-cultural settings. Symes, a member of the Irish gentry, educated at Trinity College Dublin, who went on to become a member of parliament later in life,²⁰ spoke multiple languages, including Persian and Hindi, which allowed him to communicate with many of his Burmese counterparts, especially port officials and staff in charge of diplomatic relations, who tended to speak or employ people who spoke Indian languages. Over the course of the embassy, Francis Buchanan, a young doctor at the time, learned spoken Burmese, and became literate in the language after the embassy's conclusion in subsequent lessons with a private tutor in Calcutta. Thomas Wood, a cartographer who had also served on the Welsh expedition, producing the first European-style maps of the Brahmaputra valley, was also present, as well as a Hindu pandit and a Muslim munshi, who over the course of the embassy provided not only translation but interpretation, helping their employers make sense of the mass of information they collected, as well as entertaining Burmese officials and reporting on their utterances.

The Symes embassy was received by networks of personnel used by the Konbaung court to manage the presence of the Indian Ocean trade community in its ports. Managers of the kingdom's coastal trade were generally drawn from these communities, and were a cosmopolitan cast of actors, including Parsis, Indian Muslims, Armenians and Europeans of a variety of nationalities, especially Portuguese mestizos, but also Spaniards, Dutch and French war captives and English private traders. The Armenian community in particular was quite powerful. Its most powerful members had been inducted into the Burmese aristocracy, governed coastal towns, controlled customs collection and ran monopolies farmed out by the state. These groups also managed the flow of information in and out of the kingdom in concert with reporters to the imperial court who functioned as intelligence-gatherers, and handlers appointed by the state who doubled as spies.

Multiple prior reports had pointed to this diaspora community as actively hampering the Company's efforts. Prior to Symes' dispatch the government had questioned private merchants familiar with Burma as to what obstacles a mission might face. These claimed that Rangoon port officials were oppressive in their extraction of levies against local merchants, and that they

²⁰ Douglas Peers, 'Symes, Michael (1761–1809), army officer in the East India Company and diplomatist,' *Oxford Dictionary of National Biography* (2004).

would conspire to suppress or doctor any direct communication with the court for fear of having their powers curtailed. These officials apparently acted with a significant degree of independence, even appointing their own envoys drawn from the Indian Ocean diaspora community resident in Burma and sending them out to Calcutta, complete with fraudulent documents claiming to be representatives of the king. The Company sent a lesser figure, a private merchant by the name of George Sorrell, out to Rangoon to feel out the possibility for a more public mission. He reported immediately becoming entangled with Rangoon's port authorities, who tried to block him from proceeding – only after bypassing them and communicating directly with the court was he allowed to progress to the capital, where he was given a letter he described as conciliatory and desirous of friendship and trade, though the letter was lost when he was shipwrecked. When the Company wrote back to the court explaining what had happened and requesting another copy of the letter, the correspondence was buried by local officials in Rangoon.²¹

Symes noted something similar in his initial encounters with Rangoon port officials, which were marked by a great deal of intrigue and mistrust.²² Upon landing in Rangoon he was prevented from freely moving, freely making inquiries of the population, freely receiving visitors or corresponding with other Europeans. The embassy's European officials were kept in a villa in Rangoon for a time, though their Indian servants were free to come and go in the course of searching for provisions (and surreptitiously collected rumors and passed on their observations to their employers). All of this was likely done to constrict the possibility of spying or conspiracy. Symes argued heatedly with the government to lift these restrictions, and threatened to leave if they would not. After hours-long negotiations his counterparts finally assented in order not to have the mission terminated before it met with the king.

Symes surmised that much of this initial distrust had been fomented by Indian Ocean middlemen. He noted that such groups tended to have good knowledge of the nature of European maritime empire, and in particular of the territorial acquisitions made by the Company on the Indian subcontinent – the best he had encountered anywhere in Asia. Their interests were also

²¹ Mss Eur E63, Extract Minute by the Governor General, December 24th, 1794.

²² Michael Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1 (Edinburgh: Constable and Co., 1827), pp. 165-92.

directly positioned against those of the embassy, given that part of its writ was to standardize and liberalize trade regulations that they derived significant personal benefit from. According to Symes, they suspected that the EIC, if it established a permanent presence in the kingdom, would begin taking over the role they had been performing. (This is actually exactly what Hiram Cox, Symes' successor, tried to do, though he was both in violation of his own instructions and ultimately unsuccessful).²³

Symes noted that Rangoon port officials and the wider Indian Ocean trade diaspora resident in the city were polite but aloof, refusing to tell him anything substantial about the city's commerce. He suspected that their refusal to communicate was because they felt their interests were threatened by his presence, as one of his mandates was to advocate for European private merchants in the city. He was forced to draw his information instead from the small number of French and English merchants resident in Rangoon, whom he described as a semi-criminal underclass, often fugitives trapped in poverty and preyed upon by Armenian, Parsi or Muslim money lenders who offered usurious loans to get them out of debt bondage. Through them he was able to collect information on the physical characteristics of Rangoon and other major port cities in Burma, their navigability, the kinds of goods on offer in them, the directionality of trade and the connection of trade to politics. Much of this information was tinged with the language of oriental despotism. His sources represented the Burmese government in the worst possible light, arguing that it strangled trade through monopolies and corruption, as well as ravaging warfare and factional infighting. They also lodged with him a long list of complaints such as price fixing, inability to buy commodities from original suppliers, or being forced to employ government mandated translators who acted as spies and lackeys.²⁴

Symes did not take this information at face value. He recognized that European private merchants were locked in a duel with other Indian Ocean diaspora communities over control of the city's trade and that they were likely exaggerating the extent of their oppression in order to influence him. He observed that foreign merchants were often given preferential treatment and exempted from local laws that were deleterious to trade, which is how he explained their dominance in the city's economy. The ship captain who had relayed Symes to Burma also

²³ Ramachandra, 'Captain Hiram Cox's Mission to Burma,' pp. 445-7.

²⁴ IOR/L/PS/19/56, letter from Symes to government, October 21st, 1795.

suggested that many of these disputes arose from cultural differences rather than oppression – Europeans did not understand Burmese laws or customs and port officials, especially those who were new to the job, were equally inexperienced in dealing with Europeans.²⁵ The language of despotism was being instrumentally deployed here to achieve a specific political effect; and Symes, whose social background, interests and outlook differed drastically from that of Rangoon's European diaspora community, was largely immune to their protestations, even blaming them for their own plight.

A key turning point in the mission was the involvement of the viceroy of Pegu, who as the official governing the province that had first received the embassy was tasked with shepherding it to the capital and back. Symes recounted his first meetings with the viceroy, who sent him gifts, explained that he was responsible for his well-being, and apologized for his treatment by port officials. Symes in return said that it was his wish to respect the customs of the country and that he would be grateful if the viceroy would take him under his wing and explain everything to him.²⁶ Throughout the mission, the viceroy was liberal in his hospitality. He took the embassy to watch a temple festival to mark the new year where they witnessed processions, wrestling and boxing, fireworks (actually military-grade rockets that killed one spectator) and a variety of other spectacles (none of which were marred by drunken brawling as they would have been in England, Symes noted approvingly);²⁷ treated the embassy to a theater performance based on the Ramayana, put on in his home by Siamese performers,²⁸ likely captives taken in the late invasion of the kingdom, in which the Burmese captured and brought back the bulk of the Siamese court, including not only its royalty, but also service groups like performers and artists;²⁹ took Symes on an excursion to the ancient ruins of the old Pagan capital (considered the earliest incarnation of the Burmese state), where he came to a full appreciation of the ancientness and dignity of Burmese civilization – likely not an accidental outcome;³⁰ and led Buchanan (who among his many polymathic faces was also a botanist who later would become the director of the Company's botanical gardens in Calcutta), on a tour of the private gardens on his estate in the

²⁵ IOR/L/PS/19/56, letter from Symes to government, July 2nd, 1795.

²⁶ IOR/L/PS/19/56, letters from Symes to government, April 25th, June 5th, 1795.

²⁷ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 196-205.

²⁸ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 208-10.

²⁹ Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma*, p. 93.

³⁰ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, p. 129.

city of Prome.³¹ During another festival for the new year, marked by water fights where young women stalked men through the streets and doused them for fun, Symes was invited again to the viceroy's house, where his wives, concubines, daughters and female servants "surrounded and ambushed without mercy four men ill able to maintain so unequal a contest," Symes recounted fondly.³²

This extensive socialization was accompanied by an equally extensive exchange of information. Buchanan recorded in his diaries being taken by the viceroy of Pegu on excursions to visit ethnic minorities, in which he used his political power to summon village elders so that Buchanan could question them about their religious beliefs.³³ Over dinner, he provided the embassy with a long chart detailing the various ethnic groups in the kingdom and their characteristics as he understood them.³⁴ He also provided geographical information, for example enumerating all of the provinces of the kingdom that he knew of and their districts, as well as its conquered dependencies.³⁵

As the embassy reached the capital, their social world expanded to include a variety of officials who took interest in their arrival, providing more such opportunities. When the Burmese court sent several high state officials to meet Symes and his entourage and settle them down at their residence, they were treated to performances of music and dance and afterward conversed at dinner about botany. Buchanan and a Bengali painter in his employ had made several excursions into the countryside while being conducted up to the capital, producing botanical sketches, many of which the Burmese recognized, pointing out their medicinal applications.³⁶ At another dinner with a state councilor, the viceroy of Pegu and the governor of Bhamo, capital of the kingdom's northernmost province, much of the conversation was about geography.³⁷

³¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 285-6.

³² Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, p. 211.

³³ Mss Eur C12, Francis Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 118-20.

³⁴ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 49-50.

³⁵ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 74-5.

³⁶ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, p. 309.

³⁷ Michael Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2 (Edinburgh: Constable and Co., 1827), pp. 90-1.

Buchanan's diary and published articles in the *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal* are filled with notes on such encounters.³⁸ They include many geographical sketches made by Burmese elites or their servants. Prominent among them were the Bhamo governor and his subordinates, who gave overviews not only of the kingdom's northern frontier, but also routes through Yunnan to Beijing. They were well-placed to provide such information, as they were in charge of carrying out tribute missions to the Qing capital – one of the governor's staffers, born on the northern Burma frontier in a town with a large Chinese population, translated all the place names into Mandarin.³⁹ Other informants included a slave of the heir apparent, who had traveled across Southeast Asia in his master's war train, well positioning him to provide maps of Burma's borderlands with its archrival Siam – this man, whom Buchanan described as his friend, was highly intelligent in Buchanan's estimation, and cross-referenced for him French maps and information provided by other Burmese government officials.⁴⁰ Messengers of the king were able to sit with Buchanan, correcting mistakes in the maps of James Rennell, whose cartographic survey of Bengal in the 1760s (itself based heavily in indigenous knowledge) had been highly speculative when it came to terrain beyond the Company's political reach.⁴¹ Two men from Tavoy, a coastal province lodged between Burma and Siam, chronicled the two states' long struggle for control of their home.⁴² His guards, who had been to war in Manipur, provided him their marching routes into the kingdom.⁴³ His boatman – likely a Manipuri slave captured in the aforementioned attack – gave him tips as to where to place the borders of the Burmese empire, and explained to him the divergent loyalties of different Shan states (they were tributary either to

³⁸ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 74-6; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Route between Tartary and Amarapura, by an Ambassador from the Court of Ava to the Emperor of China,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 3 (1820), pp. 32-42; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava, drawn by a Slave of the King's Eldest Son,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 2 (1820), pp. 262-271; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 7 (1822), pp. 230-239; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map constructed by a Native of Taunu, of the country south from Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 5 (1821), pp. 75-84; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Tarout Shan Territory,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 7 (1822), pp. 71-75; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the country north from Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 4 (1821), pp. 76-87; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 10 (1824), pp. 59-67; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map drawn by a native of Dawae or Tavay,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 9 (1823), pp. 228-36.

³⁹ Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Route between Tartary and Amarapura,' p. 32.

⁴⁰ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' p. 88.

⁴¹ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 55-6; James Rennell, *The Journals of Major James Rennell, First Surveyor-General of India* (Calcutta: The Asiatic Society of Calcutta, 1910).

⁴² Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' p. 128.

⁴³ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 95-6.

Burma, Siam, Manipur or China, though the exact configuration shifted with political conditions).⁴⁴

The embassy was kept in a holding pattern in the capital for a long period, due formally to an eclipse, considered inauspicious and halting most court business, though Symes suspected that the court was probing him, using informal visits to get a better measure of who he was and what his intentions were. The embassy concentrated on producing information during this time as it had little else to do. Thomas Wood, a surveyor attached to the mission, conducted astronomical observations in an effort to map out the capital and its environs, an effort that was supported by the court, which also requested that he calculate the exact time when the eclipse would occur and the proportion of the moon that would be shaded, which generated enthusiasm among the capital's courtiers, though he was apparently obstructed in his measurements in the countryside by peasants who thought he was a necromancer.⁴⁵ Symes busied himself with collating a long historical and structural analysis of the Burmese empire, primarily drawn from conversations with Burmese officials.⁴⁶ Buchanan's diaries are filled with reflections on his excursions around the capital area and conversations not only with Burmese officials, but also representatives of communities from conquered states that had been enslaved and forcibly relocated to form the capital's agricultural and artisanal base.

The exchange of information stopped around the time of the embassy's first audience with the king, about which there were intense negotiations that threatened to scuttle the mission, but after both sides made steps toward accommodation, it started up again. As before, much of it was backed and even initiated by the court. The Bengali draftman employed by Buchanan in making botanical sketches captured the attention of the king, who sent over a painting on glass made by a Siamese artist in his service, asking him to copy it to paper. The painting, of an elephant hunt, was well-received, and the king commissioned more works, such as images of Buddha, as well as asking Symes to provision instructions for the making of European style blown glass, which he could not do, although he had the relevant entry in the *Encyclopedia Britannica* translated.⁴⁷

⁴⁴ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' p. 62.

⁴⁵ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, p. 86.

⁴⁶ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 1-150; Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 33-84.

⁴⁷ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 87-90.

This Bengali painter also became close with the king's Siamese painter. Through him, Symes was able to obtain a number of ethnographic drawings, recording costumes and aspects of court life.⁴⁸ The court also asked for Symes to procure for the king religious works written in Sanskrit, as well as to send a brahmin from India to instruct his court brahmins in astronomy – specifically, the man was to be of pure caste, and his family was to be sent as well, in order to “propagate a race of hereditary astronomers.” This request Symes deferred on, noting that it was not warranted to force a man into exile unless he had committed a crime, though the governor general reported after the conclusion of the embassy that he was searching for a volunteer.⁴⁹ This links to a long-standing pattern of efforts to incorporate Indian learning into Burmese statecraft, which sometimes took a winding path: the king's Armenian interpreter, fluent in English, was observed translating William Jones' work on Hindu law into Burmese.⁵⁰

Texts flowed in the other direction as well. In the interim period while the embassy was readying to depart, Buchanan bought a number of them, at “exorbitant” prices, as the vendor told him he would be severely punished if caught selling books to foreigners; in fact he said he had been punished for such an offense before. Symes made a formal petition to the king's council, asking them if booksellers who sold them books would be punished. After deliberating, the court ruled that not only was it permissible, but laudable to exchange information with foreigners, and presented the embassy with richly decorated copies of an important court chronicle and law code, though nobody could read them.⁵¹

Besides being great in volume, the information produced by the Symes mission was also notably more sympathetic in tone than many later portrayals of Burma. In the preface to the published version of his diary, which would serve as the primary source of information on Burma available in Europe for years to come, Symes wrote that:

The Birmans, under their present monarch, are certainly rising fast in the scale of Oriental nations; and it is to be hoped, that a long respite from foreign wars will give them leisure to improve their natural advantages. Knowledge increases with commerce; and as they

⁴⁸ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 175-6.

⁴⁹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 179-80; IOR/L/PS/19/56, minute from Sir John Shore, January 4th, 1796.

⁵⁰ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, p. 159.

⁵¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, p. 175.

are not shackled by any prejudices of caste, restricted to hereditary occupations, or forbidden from participating with strangers in every social bond, their advancement will, in all probability, be rapid. At present, so far from being in a state of intellectual darkness, although they have not explored the depths of science, nor reached to excellence in the finer arts, they yet have an undeniable claim to the character of a civilized and well instructed people. Their laws are wise, and pregnant with sound morality; their police is better regulated than in most European countries; their natural disposition is friendly, and hospitable to strangers; and their manners rather expressive of manly candor, than courteous dissimulation. The gradations of rank, and the respect due to station, are maintained with a scrupulosity which never relaxes. A knowledge of letters is so widely diffused, that there are no mechanics, few of the peasantry, or even the common watermen (usually the most illiterate class), who cannot read and write...but the feudal system, which cherishes ignorance, and renders man the property of man, still operates as a check to civilization and improvement. This is a bar which gradually weakens, as their acquaintance with the customs and manners of other nations extends; and unless the rage of civil discord again be excited, or some foreign power impose an alien yoke, the Birmans bid fair to be a prosperous, wealthy, and enlightened people.⁵²

Though of course his scales of judgment were drawn from his own social and cultural background, Symes was evidently able to find common ground with his Burmese hosts. Why he and his staff were able to collect so much information on Burma and why their views were more positive than those of later writers can be traced back to the same cause: sociability, and with it, an unusual degree of affective understanding. This did not, however, interfere with their role as servants of the Company. When called upon by the government in Calcutta, they put their knowledge of Burma to use in forging a series of Machiavellian plans for its economic exploitation and military conquest.

Symes pointed to four areas in which Burma slotted into the EIC's overall strategic outlook: its provisioning of timber for ships; its potential as a market for manufactured goods; the importance of denying French access to the economic resources of Burma, as well as its use of

⁵² Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 148-9.

Burma as a potential staging point for military operations against Bengal; and the use of the Irrawaddy valley as highway for British commerce to enter into Yunnan, as well as the possibility for capturing some of the voluminous trade with China in cotton, ivory, tea, silk, birds' nests another luxury goods.⁵³

He wrote that Bengal's shipbuilding industry would be annihilated without access to Burmese teak, as would that of Madras; even Bombay would be affected. Therefore these exports should be secured and increased. However, ships should only be built in EIC domains; the domestic Burmese shipbuilding industry should be strangled. This was particularly important because the Burmese were hard at work creating an environment more conducive to commerce that might make them a threat in the future. They were connecting the kingdom's economy to Indian Ocean trade, providing more security and stability for foreign merchants along the coast, and had in place a variety of subsidies for shipbuilders. Burmese law, he wrote, was "oppressive to the subject," but "lenient to foreigners," and would further attract outside commercial elements. In addition, Burmese ports had lower prices than those of Bengal. Burma's shipbuilding lagged behind not because of lack of expertise, but because only "speculative adventurers" were willing to brave the political conditions of the country; if a more stable flow of investment could be procured, British India's shipbuilding industry would be in serious danger. Symes recommended disqualifying or placing prohibitive duties on Burmese-built ships in order to prevent this. This policy he also connected to military competition – if the Burmese were able to build a powerful navy with French help, it would endanger not only British economic but also naval supremacy in the Bay of Bengal.

These calculations illustrate well the ambiguous political status of the late Konbaung dynasty. On the one hand, the system of exchanging raw materials for finished goods Symes wanted to impose on Burma is classic informal economic imperialism; however, at the same time, he did not conceptualize Burma as weak or backwards, but as an active commercial competitor and military threat. Symes was well-aware of the extensive conquests of the Burmese, their efforts to participate in and gain from Indian Ocean trade, their knowledge of and desire to manipulate the political tensions between different European states, and the military challenges they had already

⁵³ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 214-20; his account submitted to government in IOR/L/PS/19/56 includes more detail.

offered to the EIC on its land borders. His proposals were as much for the elimination of an imperial rival as they were for the extension of informal economic empire into Burma.

On their return to Calcutta Symes and Buchanan were also asked to answer questions about the disposition of the Burmese military, as well as political weaknesses which could be exploited in the event of war. Both of their accounts stressed that the Burmese had a large and well-disciplined army, though not as technologically advanced as the Company's, and that in the event of war, exploitation of ethnic tensions was the path to victory. Symes wrote that only part of the population of the kingdom was Burmese; the rest were conquered people from many different communities. These conquests, in his view, had produced major tensions. He suggested in the context of a war to court these conquered communities, as they would likely be open to the possibility of revolt.⁵⁴

Buchanan was much more detailed in his assessment. He wrote that the Burmese held many conquered nations under "severe bondage" and partly governed many more loosely connected tributaries. Its major cities were also home to large numbers of Chinese, Siamese and Manipuri captives. Though some of these conquered peoples, most notably the Shan of upper Burma, had long ago been incorporated into the Burmese state and were well integrated, others were recently subdued, and in his words "breathing revenge." He included in this category the people of Pegu, whom he described as having been brutalized and many having fled to Siam, the remainder having adopted Burmese dress and language in order to escape oppression. He noted that prophecies were in circulation among them holding that a figure would rise as their deliverer. The Arakanese, whom he noted were similar culturally to the Burmese, were also locked in widespread conflict with their conquerors, many having fled to Bengal, others having been forcibly removed from their homes to other parts of the empire as a method of controlling insurgency. The people of Tavoy and Mergui were also ethnically similar to the Burmese, but traditionally ruled by Siam and politically oriented toward that court.

Buchanan surmised that ethnic tensions in the kingdom were so severe that it would dissolve if subjected to a large-scale, multipronged attack which simultaneously armed its ethnic minorities

⁵⁴ Add MSS 13872, 'Papers respecting Ava,' handwritten notes, no author and undated, but probably testimony taken from Symes by a secretary after his return.

and encouraged them to set up their own nominally independent states under de facto British suzerainty. These could then be harnessed to supply teak for the Company's navy and troops for its army, while a simultaneous monopoly could be extended across the whole area to the exclusion of the Company's European rivals. His conclusion was that Burma "offers to our ambitions a noble object of conquest," but that it would probably overextend the Company's empire and likely prove unprofitable in the long run.⁵⁵

Buchanan's analysis of ethnicity in the Burmese empire was unmistakably slanted for political effect – intended to help his superiors assess the feasibility and utility of conquering Burma and how best to accomplish it. His description here does exemplify a hardening of ethnic categories,⁵⁶ presenting the kingdom as a patchwork of rival, oppressed groups ripe for the application of divide-and-rule tactics – though it does also retain some of the nuance typical of his writings on ethnicity elsewhere, discussing among other things how well-integrated Shan principalities were into the Burmese state, the relatively minor linguistic and cultural (but real political) differences between the Burmese and many of the kingdom's other ethnicities, and the extent to which conquest and assimilation was producing cultural uniformity.

Buchanan's account was produced through sustained interaction with a variety of informants: mostly Burmese elites, who consistently emphasized the relationship between ethnicity and political hierarchy in their self-descriptions of their empire, and representatives of ethnic minority groups such as Manipuris and Arakanese, who aired specific grievances about their treatment. Ethnicity in pre-colonial Burma was a complex and fluid phenomenon, rooted in cultural markers and displaying permeable boundaries and the possibility for transitioning between or simultaneously holding multiple ethnic identities.⁵⁷ However, in practice, ethnic groups often ascribe much more stable identities to themselves and others than what the empirical evidence suggests, likely as a way of maintaining group cohesion, especially in

⁵⁵ Add MSS 13872, Francis Buchanan, 'What to do in case of rupture with Ava,' July, 1796.

⁵⁶ See Michael Charney, *Powerful Learning: Buddhist Literati and the Throne in Burma's Last Dynasty, 1752–1885* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Centers for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 2006), ch. 6 for a critique along these lines.

⁵⁷ F. K. Lehman, 'Ethnic Categories in Burma and the Theory of Social Systems,' in ed. Peter Kunstadter, *Southeast Asian Tribes, Minorities, and Nations* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1967), pp. 93-124.

multiethnic social systems.⁵⁸ This seems to have been the case in late pre-colonial Burma due to the conflicts of the mid-18th century, in which ethnicity came to play an increasingly important role.⁵⁹ Buchanan was likely absorbing and reproducing here the everyday, casual ways that his informants spoke about group difference and political conflict, while also instrumentalizing them for the purposes of conquest and colonization.

Extensive private interactions took place between members of the Symes embassy and their counterparts in the Burmese government, accompanied by a surprising degree of intellectual exchange. These exchanges, made possible by the removal of previous intermediary groups and facilitated by a greater degree of social and cultural capital than previous envoys had access to, allowed the embassy to produce a large volume of information on Burma. The cordiality of each party toward the other is also likely why, in his published material meant for public consumption, Symes formed a more positive opinion of the kingdom than what would become the norm as conflict ramped up in the next century. Whatever warmth he and the others on the mission developed as a result of the hospitality with which they had been treated, it mattered little in deliberations after the embassy regarding what the Company's interests in the kingdom were and how to pursue them. Here, the connection between the collection of information and the pursuit of wealth and power becomes clear. The archive of information collected on Burma was put to use in plans envisioning its economic subordination and political dismemberment. What made them so dangerous was not merely their intent, but the methodology that lay behind them: an inductive process of soliciting and recording of information from many quarters that allowed the Company's imperial ambitions to play out on an expanded empirical foundation.

SOURCES OF CONFLICT

In this section, I present evidence that, despite the extensive private socialization outlined in the last section, the East India Company and Konbaung dynasty were initially at odds over several critical political issues including control of border territories, trade disputes and diplomatic ceremony. The third in particular was central to the mission's course. The Burmese court adopted a rigid stance on ceremonial matters largely for domestic political reasons – diplomatic

⁵⁸ Fredrik Barth, *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries: The Social Organization of Culture Difference* (Boston: Little, Brown & Co, 1969), introduction.

⁵⁹ Victor Lieberman, 'Ethnic Politics in Eighteenth-Century Burma,' *Modern Asian Studies* 12:3 (1978), pp. 455-482.

receptions were a key means of affirming the ruler's ideological centrality, crucial in maintaining political cohesion. Additionally, there were deep misgivings about the Company's presence on Burma's shores stemming from two sources: uncertainty about the nature of the Company itself, and apprehension regarding its expanding imperial footprint in India. A last latent but significant source of friction was the Burmese court's own imperial ambitions. These extended beyond Arakan to encompass claims over parts of Bengal under Company rule, foreshadowing grander aspirations for the reconquest of the Ganges valley, the symbolic heartland of Buddhism. These overlapping tensions created fundamental obstacles to compromise on both sides.

One major source of tension predating the mission was an imperial duel between the two states over the allegiance of smaller neighboring tributaries. Both displayed similar behavior in their dealings with Assam, Arakan, Manipur and other minor principalities interspersed between them. In these states, the general pattern was that internal conflict would cause a breakdown of political order, leading clashing elite factions to reach out to their larger neighbors for support.⁶⁰ The two major sources of this patronage in the area were the EIC and Burma, and much of the conflict between them can be explained by simple opportunism. Both had the backing of certain local elites, giving them a plausible rationale for intervention along the lines of restoring order. State breakdown and political vacuums along the Burma-Bengal border, and the quest by both empires to capitalize on them, loomed large over negotiations between the two powers, and constituted a structural opposition leading them towards conflict.

Another structural opposition existed at the level of political economy. The EIC perspective on this is explained in a long list of grievances taken down by Symes and outlined in a report to high officials in Calcutta in 1794, shortly before his departure. The report was based on the testimony of merchant captains, most of whom involved in the teak trade, important in production of ships at Calcutta and Madras. They accused Rangoon port officials of monopolistic behavior, such as price fixing and not allowing merchants deeper into the kingdom to bypass them and trade more directly with producers and consumers, as well as soliciting bribes and burying complaints to the court.⁶¹

⁶⁰ Bhuyan, *Anglo-Assamese Relations*, chs. VI, VII, VIII, IX; Arthur Phayre, *History of Burma* (London: Trubner and Co., 1883), ch. XX; Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India*, pp. 19-58.

⁶¹ Mss Eur E63, Extract Minute by the Governor General, December 24th, 1794.

These complaints arose from interactions with the large, unwieldy edifice that had sprung up around the extraction of resources from Indian Ocean trade networks in the kingdom. This had long been a vital aspect of Burmese statecraft, being an important source of currency, as well as of war material and mercenaries,⁶² and was managed in large part by Armenian, Portuguese and other diaspora communities who had been integrated into the Burmese elite. These officials were notable for having interests that only partly converged with those of their employers. They seem to have functioned semi-independently in the absence of direct scrutiny from the court, able to set and change their own policies at will – policies which were directly connected to their own livelihoods as they were not paid salaries, but rather expected to subsist on the collection of fees, private monopolies or trade ventures undergirded by their political power.⁶³ The Company had long been interested in weakening the grip these groups had on the governance of trade in the kingdom, and Symes was the first envoy who had a real opportunity to accomplish this.

A final structural opposition existed in the cultural realm. In Burma, as in other Southeast Asian ‘galactic polities,’ the legitimacy of the state was intimately connected with the person of the ruler – the moral and political center of the kingdom. His religious status, and the justice and order that flowed from it, was the theoretical basis for his exercise of power; and his court was the place where, through ritual and rhetoric, his centrality was acted out.⁶⁴ Within Burma, the court governed as an exemplary center, gluing together through the force of symbolic legitimacy and personal ties between ruler and ruled a realm comprised of many smaller courts, each of which reproduced the accoutrements of power in miniaturized form.⁶⁵

This pattern of interactions between a constellation of courts who exercised waxing and waning power over each other, secured in large part through personal ties mediated by symbolic display

⁶² Victor Lieberman, 'Reinterpreting Burmese History,' *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 29:1 (1987), 166-7.

⁶³ George Alves, head of one of the mid-18th century missions to Burma, had this explained to him on multiple occasions by his middlemen. Dalrymple, *Oriental Repertory*, pp. 351-93.

⁶⁴ Tarling, *The Cambridge History of Southeast Asia*, Vol. 1, especially chs. 7, 10; Winichakul, *Siam Mapped*; Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles*; William Koenig, *The Burmese Polity, 1752-1819: Politics, Administration and Social Organization in the Early Kon-baung Period* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 1990); Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*; Stanley Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia,' *Journal of Ethnographic Theory*, 3:3 (2013), pp. 503-534; James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009).

⁶⁵ Edmund Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma",' *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 3.1 (1960), pp. 49-68.

– what Clifford Geertz called the ‘theater-state’⁶⁶ – was seamlessly extended into the realm of interstate relations. The Burmese practiced a hierarchical form of diplomacy common to premodern empires, based on pretensions to universal sovereignty – kings were ‘chakravartin,’ or universal emperors, seen as the “mediating link between the upper regions of the cosmos...and the lower plane of humans and lesser beings.”⁶⁷ Public diplomatic ritual was an essential ingredient in constructing the glittering aura of an emperor, surrounded by the representatives of lesser states who, like the assembled court and the capital’s population, looked toward him as a moral and political center – so much so that these rituals were pantomimed even when no tributary envoys were present.⁶⁸ To intensify the symbolic effect of such meetings, envoys were generally entertained at the capital until they could be received in groups. This seems to have been the central logic that ran through Symes’ first audience with the king, which was housed alongside a provincial delegation from Yunnan until the two could be received simultaneously.

Symes’ audience followed a well-rehearsed script in which he was to play the role of supplicant and bearer of tribute, which he grudgingly did, having specifically been told by his employers not to attach “useless importance to etiquette.”⁶⁹ He did haggle with his hosts over some of the finer points of his reception,⁷⁰ for example arguing that as the Yunnan delegation was provincial, his should be given precedence (this was granted), and requesting to be present when the court prescreened his letters to filter out of them any language that might be insulting to the king.⁷¹ (This was standard practice, and was done with incoming letters from many different rulers, including those from the Chinese emperor, whose letters were altered to suggest fraternity between the two: “From the Emperor in the East...To the Emperor in the West.”)⁷² On the whole, in stark contrast to the approach taken by many later envoys, Symes complied with the

⁶⁶ Clifford Geertz, *Negara: The Theatre State in Nineteenth-Century Bali* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1980).

⁶⁷ Tambiah, ‘The Galactic Polity,’ p. 505; Sunait Chutintaranond, ‘Cakravartin: Ideology, Reason and Manifestation of Siamese and Burmese Kings in Traditional Warfare (1538-1854),’ *Crossroads: An Interdisciplinary Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 4:1 (1988), pp. 46-56.

⁶⁸ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 7 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), p. 64.

⁶⁹ IOR/P/115/34, February 6th, 1795, No. 39.

⁷⁰ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 94-6.

⁷¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 26-7.

⁷² Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 3 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), p. 1.

legitimizing rituals of the court, understanding that they were ideologically important and that it would be difficult for him to complete his mission without participation in them.

Symes' notes on his first audience with the king are perhaps the most detailed account of Burmese diplomatic ceremonies in Company records in the period before the First Anglo-Burmese War, when the Konbaung dynasty was at its height.⁷³ In the royal decrees of Burma, no equivalent description exists, the entries for the Symes embassy on the whole being cursory,⁷⁴ noting only that the Chinese and English envoys should be granted equal status and received on the same day, and that residences should be built for them of equal height; a later order states somewhat frostily, though without explanation: "The Chinese being in a much more cordial relationship than with the British, the envoys from China shall be given a preferential treatment." It would be useful, therefore, to provide a thick description of what exactly this audience entailed, as it was a kind of 'semiotic text,'⁷⁵ in which rhetoric, ritual, behavior, material culture, even architecture were all carefully sculpted to achieve a specific effect, which was to elevate the king, and to arrange everyone around him – including Symes – in gradated ranks, their closeness to him signaling their relative status.

The encounter itself began with a large procession of delegates from both Yunnan and Bengal, and took on a parade-like form, as the tributary envoys were led through the length of the city in order to display to the public their simultaneous submission to the monarch. Leaders of both delegations proceeded on elephants, their deputies on horseback, the servants and guards of both embassies marching on foot beside them in ranks. They were accompanied by a variety of Burmese officials, including translators and minders, a master of ceremonies, a master of strangers, a registerer of presents, a councilor of state and two judges. People crowded around the procession as it moved through the city, and were kept at bay by rod-wielding constables. The path through the streets was strewn with garlands. The shops that lined the route were displaying their finest wares, and large groups of spectators took shade under bamboo mats on latticed frames; even the rooftops were crowded with onlookers. Symes noted that everyone was

⁷³ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 96-113.

⁷⁴ These royal orders can be found from June to August of 1795 in Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 5 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983).

⁷⁵ On reading culture as a text, see Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures* (New York: Basic Books, 1973), ch. 1.

still and eerily silent, squatting on their haunches as the procession moved by, a display of respect for their king.

After the procession dismounted, the master of ceremonies, in what Symes described as an imperious manner, instructed them to bow with a hand over the head multiple times as they walked closer to the palace entrance. According to Symes the master of ceremonies repeatedly, loudly and rudely demanded that he make “superfluous obeisances;” when he whispered a complaint, the man escalated his demands. They waited for several hours in the courtyard of the palace, where they were instructed to take their shoes off and sit cross-legged on carpets facing the throne room beside the Chinese embassy, their presents piled behind them. Here, they witnessed the entrance of the capital’s assembled elite, whose dress and behavior were calculated to maximize the court’s magnificence. One by one, Burmese princes entered on palanquins and elephants, accompanied by officials in velvet robes, shaded by servants holding gilded parasols and escorted by dozens of musketeers drenched with gold livery. The last to arrive was the heir apparent, flanked by six Manipuri brahmins in white, dozens of officials and military officers, and escorted by several hundred troops. This entrance had the desired effect on Symes, who noted that it was conducted with such solemnity and grace that the only comparison he felt worthy was to the Mughals at their height.

The audience hall was a cavernous space, 40 feet tall and supported by dozens of pillars in widely spaced rows. Tumblers, dancers and musicians provided background entertainment. A gilded lattice partitioned the throne room from the rest of the hall. A small door six feet off the ground could be opened to reveal the throne, which was so tall it had to be ascended by steps at the back. The royal family and courtiers took up seats perpendicular to the throne aperture in a long line. The heir-apparent (allowed a stool) and high princes sat on mats clustered around the throne. In descending order the assembled notables of the empire sat cross-legged, arrayed before Symes according to rank. He and the other delegates sat facing this vast group, and were asked to observe their posture, not allowing the soles of their feet to point toward the king. Through this carefully orchestrated arrangement of space, every participant’s position was mapped out in relation to the status of the monarch.

Symes had in tow with him a large assortment of gifts for the king. As was the case with the Macartney embassy to China, which took place at around the same time, these were meant to represent the full scope of British imperial reach and early industrial prosperity.⁷⁶ They included mirrors, glass and guns from Europe, a machine that generated electricity, and muslin, silk and illuminated Sanskrit manuscripts from India, all placed in red satin boxes, balanced on poles and carried into the palace on the shoulders of servants. These were itemized by treasury officials and taken away into the confines of the palace without remark. Symes made no attempt to explain the meaning they were intended to convey, nor is there any evidence that it was understood. On the contrary, he recorded rumors swirling through the capital that his was a tribute mission, signaling the Company's acceptance of a subordinate status.⁷⁷

During the audience, brahmins recited prayers for half an hour, then the letter Symes was to deliver from the governor-general was placed on a silver tray in front of the throne. A scribe, after prostrating three times with his forehead to the ground, read it aloud in a chanting lilt, prostrated three more times, listed off the embassy's presents, prostrated three more times and withdrew. Symes was then questioned by the king, who was sequestered in his private chambers, through a subordinate, who asked about the state of the English king's health and of war and peace in Europe. Symes provided, in Persian, an account of the French Revolution and its ripple effect through Europe, noting to himself that the French, with their "equalizing principles," would likely receive a cold welcome in this court. Then the meeting terminated. The whole assemblage of princes and nobles dispersed, and Symes and the Chinese embassy were led back to their quarters, all in the exact same manner as they had gone forth, as though time were being rewound. The king never spoke directly to Symes or revealed himself, instead remaining concealed in the next room.

A useful organizing concept for the analysis of this ceremony is that of space. The king was at the center of these ceremonies, elevated and hidden (in the Symes embassy's record of their visit to the court of the heir apparent, he was positioned in a similar way, his face even hidden behind a little screen door that he could open to speak directly with callers or keep closed for a unilateral

⁷⁶ Maxine Berg, 'Britain, Industry and Perceptions of China: Matthew Boulton, "Useful Knowledge" and the Macartney Embassy to China 1792-4,' *Journal of Global History* 1 (2006), pp. 269-288.

⁷⁷ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, p. 26.

view).⁷⁸ Arrayed around the king according to their closeness to him in rank and favor were members of the royal family and other powerful figures who formed the main pillars of state, facing outward and also elevated above the envoys. These were received in groups to drive home the effect of diverse supplicants coming into the center from the empire's peripheries. Royal space radiated outwards in a series of concentric circles, from the walls of the palace to the gates of the city itself and beyond. It is no coincidence that in the maps Buchanan collected of Burma drawn by indigenous informants they represented current and former capitals as a series of concentric squares nested within each other like Ukrainian dolls.⁷⁹ This use of architecture and ceremony to symbolically map out in space the centrality of the ruler was a classic aspect of Southeast Asian statecraft.⁸⁰

Symes understood how important symbolic display was to the Burmese court, noting the extent of its punctiliousness in the arrangement of these ceremonies and in all matters of what he called “rank and precedence.” The court had clearly made an all-out effort to impress upon him its full luxury and might. Therefore he believed that the king’s absence was not an accident, but rather a calculated snub, meant to increase the effect of his presence as a tributary, rather than the representative of a “sovereign and an equal power.” It also seems to have signaled to the entire Burmese elite assembled at court on the day of his audience that he was in disfavor. He reported being in near-total isolation afterward, as his former contacts in the Burmese court stopped calling.⁸¹ It is possible that they were worried about attracting scrutiny or even punishment if seen to be associated with him – the viceroy of Pegu eventually suffered this fate, his close relationship to the British putting a target on his back as the two states slid towards conflict in the aftermath of the subsequent and disastrous Cox embassy.⁸² In inquiring about what he could do to obtain a second audience directly with the king, Symes was relegated to sending his staff (armed with a variety of luxury gifts) to speak with the retinues of Burmese nobles, the only channel left to him.

⁷⁸ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 119-20.

⁷⁹ Buchanan, 'Account of two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma,' p. 67.

⁸⁰ Scott discusses how these architectural forms, originally South Asian, were copied throughout Southeast Asia as part of a shared repertoire of state building techniques. Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 111-16.

⁸¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 145-60.

⁸² Ramachandra, 'Anglo-Burmese Relations,' pp. 127-8.

Through these inquiries, Symes learned that he was being distanced because the court was uncertain about the status of the EIC. Misgivings fell along two lines. The Burmese, Symes believed, had an accurate impression of the power of the EIC, and of the value of the coastal trade they represented. They did not, however, view the kind of state it had built in India as legitimate. To understand this, it is important to step back and ask the question of what legitimated the Burmese state. This was kingship, the ideology of which can be broken down into religious and genealogical claims. The king was legitimate because he had an ancestral link to past kings (often, these fictive chains of kinship were projected deep into the mythological past, endowing the ruler with a kind of semi-divinity),⁸³ and because he patronized Buddhism and upheld order and morality in his domains, reshaping the world to resemble ideal models drawn from cosmology.⁸⁴ Contrast that with the Company, which had no king, but rather was a faceless bureaucracy governing along secular and impersonal lines, and which was largely moved by profit motivations. There was apparently little in this model of government to commend itself to the Burmese.

Secondly, the EIC represented a clear danger. Indian Ocean merchants had been warning the court for many years that the Company had usurped power in multiple locations in India through worming its way into local political systems and hollowing them out from within. When this was intimated to Symes he treated the accusation as preposterous, but it is clear that the Burmese were far from naive about the nature of the organization he represented. Finally, the Burmese harbored claims to a number of territories governed by Company in eastern Bengal which had at various points in the early modern period been under the control of Arakan.⁸⁵ These rival imperial claims, which would enlarge over the next twenty years to encompass other states on the Company's borders as well as ambitions for the conquest of the Ganges floodplain, the lost

⁸³ For a discussion of the relationship between chronicles, genealogy and political power in premodern Southeast Asia, see Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, ch. 6 ½. For the ways in which the first Konbaung monarch, who came from a minor gentry family, manufactured these ideological trappings for himself, see Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles*, ch. 5.

⁸⁴ Robert Heine-Geldern, 'Conceptions of State and Kingship in Southeast Asia,' *The Far Eastern Quarterly* 2:1 (1942), pp. 15-30.

⁸⁵ Hiram Cox, *Journal of a Residence in the Burmhan Empire* (London: John Warren and G. and W. B. Whittaker, 1821), pp. 300-303.

birthplace of Buddhism,⁸⁶ combined with misgivings about the nature of the Company-state and its own imperial ambitions to produce a major impasse.

The encounter between Symes and the Burmese court points to a series of broader structural tensions underpinning Anglo-Burmese relations at the close of the eighteenth century. The struggle over the allegiance of minor tributary states reflected an enduring contest for regional hegemony, driven by opportunism and strategic interest. The Company's economic grievances amounted to a desire to dismantle the Burmese state's monopolistic orientation towards oceanic commerce while simultaneously reducing Burma to economic dependency and maintaining its own monopolistic grip over strategically key industries like shipbuilding. Conflicts also extended into the cultural realm, which itself was informed by the political. The elaborate court rituals that positioned Symes as a supplicant were fundamentally connected to the legitimacy of the state, and the court's initial aversion to granting him a direct audience with the king not only arose from a distaste for the Company's form of government and the threat it represented, but also designs over its territory. However, unlike subsequent missions, which often acted to further exacerbate tensions between the two sides, the Symes mission was able to briefly breach this impasse. In the next section I consider why.

MUTUAL ACCOMMODATION

This section examines how the diplomatic deadlock between the EIC and the Burmese court was temporarily overcome. The Company had historically relied on pragmatic engagement and maneuvering within local power structures in order to advance its interests, a strategy that had allowed it to accumulate significant influence in India during a time when it was not powerful enough to impose its will unilaterally. Symes' approach was reminiscent of this, adhering to the ceremonial and hierarchical expectations of the Konbaung court in public while privately working to extract concessions. On the Burmese side, a loose, expansive notion of universal sovereignty shaped the strategy of engagement. The court understood that Britain had conquered parts of India, and was systematically eliminating its European rivals in Asia, closing off opportunities for counterbalancing alliances. It needed to make a deal with a neighboring power

⁸⁶ Burmese imperial expansion, and ambitions in India, are discussed from the Burmese perspective in Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma*, ch. 4.

whose fortunes were rapidly rising, but made every effort to do so on the most favorable possible terms. The court did make concessions, but only those that were least damaging to its interests. While agreeing to rein in some of the excesses of local officials, the Burmese preserved the overall shape of the monopolistic structures through which they governed flows of Indian Ocean trade. They also wanted to ensure that any permanent diplomatic presence in the kingdom would remain subordinate to the king, in effect proposing a sovereignty-sharing arrangement. The result was a negotiated settlement that allowed each side to claim victory – the Company secured an avenue of redress for disaffected traders and permission to establish a permanent resident in the kingdom, while the Burmese court was able to maintain intact the fundamental integrity of its political, economic and ideological order.

The EIC was not a modern state, despite its use of many of the tools associated with modern statecraft.⁸⁷ It was a transoceanic commercial firm which had gone into the business of ruling a territorial empire because it could use political power to collect taxes and rig the economy for its own benefit (and for the benefit of its individual servants, who especially early in its history grew vastly wealthy through taking gifts and using their official positions to set up personal monopolies).⁸⁸ The form it took in its interactions with local and regional rulers was amorphous. In some situations it would appear in the guise of a rival, an equal or a suzerain; in other situations it would appear as a merchant collective, a financier or a purveyor of mercenary military power. This changeling identity allowed it to build an empire not through sheer brute force, acting against powerful Asian states, but by accumulating wealth, social connections, privileges, exceptions, titles and other social, political and economic capital from within them.⁸⁹

Symes' approach to conducting diplomacy with Burma falls squarely within this tradition. In his correspondence with the government in Calcutta he justified his compliance with practices curtailing his freedom, invading his privacy or placing him in a state of ritual inequality, noting that his hosts did not subscribe to his ideas of liberty.⁹⁰ In his diaries he argued that there were cultural differences at work in the constitution and legitimating practices of states not only in

⁸⁷ Philip J. Stern, *The Company-State: Corporate Sovereignty and the Early Modern Foundations of the British Empire in India* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011).

⁸⁸ On corruption within the Company, see Dirks, *The Scandal of Empire*, ch. 2.

⁸⁹ Veevers, *The Origins of the British Empire in Asia*, p. 5.

⁹⁰ IOR/L/PS/19/56, letters from Symes to government, June 5th, August 15th, 1795.

Europe and Asia, but also within Asia, particularly between the freewheeling politics of post-Mughal India and the more staid, ritualized court cultures of Southeast and East Asian states, which often made exaggerated claims to suzerainty over their neighbors. "Like the sovereign of China," he wrote, "his majesty of Ava acknowledges no equal. Indeed, it is the fixed principle of all nations eastward of Bengal, to consider foreign ministers as supplicants come to solicit protection, not as representatives who may demand redress; rather as vassals to render homage, than as persons vested with authority to treat on equal terms."⁹¹ The Burmese, he said, were a "proud and victorious people," who had until that point defeated every rival they came across and majorly enlarged their territorial holdings and political influence around the region. They did not have the "reverence" Indian states did for the EIC, which was the result of military victories that had reverberated throughout the Indian subcontinent, but which were only dimly felt in Burma. His suggestion was that the Company accept this, not only in their dealings with Burma, but all of Southeast and East Asia, which constituted a "body politic...connected by a striking similarity of manners and political maxims; to which, as they cannot be suddenly changed, we ought to assimilate...as far as the dignity of our own (government) will permit."⁹²

There were, however, limits to Symes' tolerance, in particular regarding his not being granted an audience with the king. On this topic he wrote a sharply worded letter, different in tone from much of the rest of his correspondence with the Burmese court, complaining that he had been treated as the delegate of a "commercial settlement" rather than a "sovereign state," that his commercial intentions were actually secondary, and that the Company had no need to solicit the king for safety. "It is not from a petty island that may send out two or three periodical privateers," he wrote, "that a government whose dominion extends from Celon to the mountains of Thibet, from the gulf of Bengal to the western sea, can have anything to dread." The letter concludes by stating that he had not come to "seek favor but to cement friendship, not to supplicate but to propose," that if he was not honored with an audience it would be the last time an envoy was sent by the Company to Burma, and that if there were to be another incursion into Chittagong the result would likely be war.⁹³ Symes' use of a more pugnacious approach here was likely because, unless he was able to negotiate directly with the king, he would not have been

⁹¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 25-6.

⁹² Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 222-3.

⁹³ IOR/L/PS/19/56, indexed to manuscript account of the Symes embassy.

able to obtain a written agreement, the main object of his mission – in short he chose to battle only over the core interests of the state he represented, and treated most matters of form, or those that were related to his personal dignity, as less important, which was exactly what he had been instructed to do and which earned him accolades on his return.⁹⁴

Symes' strategy interlocked with the universal form of sovereignty espoused by the Burmese court. Premodern empires in general were both expansive and elastic, especially so in Southeast Asia, which was home to a heavily fragmented and fast-changing political landscape that Edmund Leach compared to a constellation of stars perpetually winking in and out of existence.⁹⁵ The central pattern in the construction of such states was the forging of personal ties between the ruler and his immediate subordinates, who themselves presided over other webs of patronage, fractalizing outward and downward indefinitely.⁹⁶ This allowed for a great deal of flexibility, facilitating both the incorporation of elites from conquered societies and the accommodation of claimants to power emerging from below or outside the system, as long as they accepted the central logic by agreeing to rule in the emperor's name. In such a system, what mattered was less one's ethnicity and more one's loyalties, which were often given across ethnic boundaries to a ruler with overwhelming cultural legitimacy – true even in the Burmese heartland, where ethnic identity had coagulated to an unusual degree.⁹⁷

The Burmese understood that the Company represented both a rival and a threat. The Konbaung state worked hard to gather its own intelligence, not only by asking incisive questions in their private interactions with members of the embassy, but through a variety of other sources, including European and non-European sojourners landing on Burma's shores, and through spying efforts in India,⁹⁸ led by ostensible pilgrims to important Buddhist sites in the Ganges valley (the Indians they met warned them that the Company was a malign actor, and to ally with hostile Indian rulers to either drive them into the sea or kill them all, including their "children in

⁹⁴ IOR/F/4/71/1583, Political Letter from Bengal, March 16th, 1798.

⁹⁵ Edmund Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma"', *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 3:1 (1960), pp. 49-68.

⁹⁶ In the Southeast Asian context, this pattern is explained under the rubric of 'administrative involution' in Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity,' pp. 523-6; a more generalized discussion can be found in the introduction to Jane Burbank and Frederick Cooper, *Empires in World History: Power and the Politics of difference* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2010).

⁹⁷ Lieberman, 'Ethnic Politics in Eighteenth-Century Burma.'

⁹⁸ Bayly, *Empire & Information*, p. 113-28.

cradles”).⁹⁹ Through these channels, they learned that the Company represented a major threat, especially since it appeared to be besting its rivals not only in India, but also in Europe with the defeat of the French, who had heavily courted Burma, closing off the prospect of a counterbalancing alliance.

The course chosen in order to deal with this threat seems to have been to domesticate it. After a long deliberation running into the night, the king’s council decided to deepen relations with the Company.¹⁰⁰ The next morning, they invited Symes to meet the king in person. They also wrote a letter granting most of his other requests. The most important of these were a mutual exchange of ambassadors and the relaxation of restrictions on merchants operating out of British Indian ports. The court also provided other documents specifying the government’s customs policies and an enumeration of the perquisites of office that could be legitimately collected by local officials, measures Symes had asked for in his negotiations to help merchant vessels better navigate the complex and opaque edifice of trade governance in the kingdom’s ports. Notably they refused the two requests that were most immediately against their interests: to cede the freedom to have diplomatic intercourse with the French, or to specify a boundary between Bengal and Arakan (this was explained by the argument that since the two countries were friends there could be no “difference or distinction” between them, but this can also be read as a tactical refusal by the court to give up its claim over parts of eastern Bengal).

The actual document that Symes obtained was not a treaty, though he interpreted it in this way. In its entrance into the colonial archive it was radically defaced, with much of its original content removed, all that was left being summaries of the concessions it contained.¹⁰¹ In its original form, it was a royal decree, drafted entirely by the Burmese, though taking into account Symes’ suggestions, Symes merely obtaining a copy afterward. Like others of its kind, it functioned as a vehicle for highlighting the ideological legitimacy of the Burmese monarch, and served as a blunt instrument of governance, directing Burmese officials and the Company alike to adhere to its instructions. The document is prefaced by a multipage description of the king’s illustriousness,

⁹⁹ Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 8, pp. 81-82.

¹⁰⁰ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 160-72.

¹⁰¹ The full version is in IOR/L/PS/19/56, indexed to the manuscript account of the Symes embassy. For the cut version, see C. U. Aitchison, *A Collection of Treaties, Engagements, and Sanads Relating to India and Neighboring Countries*, Vol. 1 (Calcutta: Office of the Superintendent of Government Printing, 1892), pp. 348-54.

including an exhaustive list of all the territories and natural resources he controlled, the prowess of his armies, the size and opulence of his capital, his adherence to the customs of his ancestors, his place as the moral compass of his kingdom, and his guardianship and propagation of Buddhism. In terms of tonality, it is couched in language that carefully maintains the ideological centrality of the ruler – what Symes described as “extravagant phraseology,” in his own equally florid prose. It established through rhetoric a hierarchical, yet reciprocal relationship between receiver and the giver, who was, as the preamble stated, “the source of greatness and dignity celestial, whose threshold is as the firmament, and whose supplicants, when he places the Golden Foot of Majesty on their fortunate heads, like the blooming water-lily, are inspired with confidence unbounded.”

The document suggests that the Burmese court conceptualized the Company as a powerful Indian empire to its west similar in size and strength to the Chinese empire to its east. The document describes Symes as a “vakeel,” the Governor General in Calcutta as a viceroy ruling in India on behalf of the absent English king, and the Symes embassy as a tribute mission sent to deliver “letters and presents to the golden feet.” It places Symes’ delegation on the same footing as the Yunnan embassy, describing how they were housed and treated as one. It goes to great lengths to describe the size and power of the Qing dynasty as well as the fact that Burma treated with it on equal terms, including a variety of dubious claims such as that the king was married to three of the emperor's daughters. The letter concludes with an expression of hope that the concessions granted to Symes would establish a similar relationship of parity. States cropping up in the Irrawaddy valley had often in the past been in a relationship of tributary subordination to whatever Chinese dynasty was ruling to the north, a pattern that was interrupted in the mid-18th century after Burma’s defeat of a major invasion force that had crossed over from Yunnan. This victory loomed large in the imaginary of the Burmese elite,¹⁰² and they seem to have viewed the Company’s presence through this lens, as a state likely more powerful than Burma but with which they would not accept anything less than a reciprocal relationship.

¹⁰² For a description of this war, its influence on Burmese elite identity, and the ways in which its legacy influenced Burmese dealings with the Company, see Thant Myint-U, *The River of Lost Footsteps* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2006), chs. 5, 6.

The letter did not represent a major change in the Burmese state's strategy for interacting with the Indian Ocean trading world. In it, the king does express his displeasure with the self-seeking of officials in charge of regulating trade, and admonishes them to rectify it, in the process laying out the court's ideal vision for what trade governance should look like. It does not, however, lift any government-sanctioned rules governing merchants visiting its ports, only those that were informally implemented at the local level without its input. It confirms an onerous (from the perspective of India-based traders) series of perquisites of office for an assortment of port officials dealing with docking trade vessels. In Rangoon, 24 members of government were entitled to various duties on entry and exit, mostly in silver and cloth. Payments were also specified to an entire army of porters, guards, interpreters, writers, accountants, examiners, navigators and others involved in dealing with incoming shipments of goods, as well as to those involved in taxing riverine trade moving up to the capital. This was mostly housekeeping – an attempt to restore control over local officials involved in governing trade, who were overstepping their authority. It did, however, clarify how customs collection was supposed to function, which was in and of itself was a major boon, setting limits on what had previously been a much more informal, personalized and localized mode of governance. This provided visiting merchants and the diplomats charged with representing them a guide to what was acceptable and what was not, giving them more leverage in their negotiations.

Two years later, when Hiram Cox was finally dispatched to take up residence in Burma, it quickly became clear that he and his hosts had differing conceptions of what exactly his role entailed. Cox seems to have viewed it as similar to that of a resident in the British Indian context, who was something between a diplomat and a governor, ostensibly managing foreign relations with his princely state, but often in actuality ruling it, especially in key areas such as succession politics, security and finance. The Burmese, on the other hand, viewed him as a member of their own government, who happened to also serve another master. He would be delegated the authority he needed to govern his own community, though only if it was exercised in the name of the king – much the same strategy of governance as was practiced with other foreign communities in Burma, who were often ruled through a representative appointed from among their ranks. When this was made clear to Cox, he flat out refused the bargain, fuming in his diaries: “Thus easily do these people reconcile to themselves every absurdity they have once

admitted into their scheme of policy! In order to degrade me I am to be made a Burmhan.”¹⁰³ His demand that he be given extrajudicial authority in Burma without having to answer to the Burmese culminated in a dramatic showdown in the king’s council, after which he fled the kingdom by night. The Burmese likely intended the agreement to represent a kind of sovereignty-sharing arrangement typical in the Southeast Asian context, in which the two states would interpenetrate, and where they overlapped, both would exercise simultaneous authority.

The 18th-century EIC’s imperial strategy in India had been fluid and adaptable, built not on brute force alone but on social and political penetration of indigenous states for the purposes of economic manipulation. Unlike modern states, which impose clear administrative and territorial boundaries, the EIC was a mercantile enterprise that leveraged shifting identities – acting as a trading collective, financier, military power, or sovereign authority depending on the context. Symes’ strategy exemplifies this adaptability: rather than insisting on European diplomatic notions of wholly separate and formally equal states, he displayed a willingness to navigate the court’s ritualized political landscape, accepting his personal subordination while pursuing his employers’ strategic goals. The prospect here was of an entanglement in which each side traded away certain things in exchange for others. The Company would respect the king’s dignity and conform to court rituals in exchange for concrete political and economic benefits; Burma would grant the Company trade rights and a permanent presence in the kingdom in exchange for the acknowledgement of the king as the ultimate font of sovereignty. Though this arrangement quickly crumbled as control of policy passed into the hands of more intolerant officials, it does represent an early attempt at accommodation with a powerful regional state, reminiscent of the Company’s strategy in early modern India.

CONCLUSION

This chapter was an attempt to analyze an early episode in diplomatic relations between the EIC and the Konbaung dynasty not through the lens of imperialism and resistance but of inter-imperial competition, combined with the possibility of exchange and accommodation. I first outlined how Symes and his entourage were able to mobilize greater social and cultural capital than previous embassies to bypass the networks of Indian Ocean intermediaries that had

¹⁰³ Cox, *Journal of a Residence in the Burmhan Empire*, p. 354.

previously functioned as their gatekeepers, forming direct connections with the Burmese elite. These connections served as a conduit through which large amounts of communication passed, allowing for the construction of the first empirically detailed portrait Europeans had access to of Burma – one that, at least in its publicly available form, was more sympathetic in tone than what would prevail in the 19th century. The internal bureaucratic knowledge produced by the mission was drastically different in tone, utilizing the nuanced information collected through these exchanges to craft plans for the informal economic domination and formal dismemberment and conquest of the kingdom, a stark reminder of the ultimate realpolitik purpose of colonial intelligence gathering.

In terms of interstate relations, the embassy was marked by competition but also a move toward the rough accommodation of the two sides' imperial interests. Tensions were multifaceted, involving struggles over control of tributary states on the peripheries of the two empires, as well as over the Konbaung state's monopolistic control over Indian Ocean trade flows, juxtaposed against the Company's interest in dismantling such barriers while simultaneously maintaining its own protectionist policies connected to key state prerogatives. A third point of tension was over political culture, specifically as it manifested in diplomatic protocol, which in the Burmese context was carefully orchestrated to reflect the sacrality of the monarch and his position as the locus point for a vast spiderweb of hierarchical relations of patronage. Another key point of tension was the nature of the Company as a trading house that had gone into the business of imperialism – a novel and aggressively expansionist form of government that was viewed by the Burmese as not only threatening but also illegitimate. Despite these wide-ranging points of tension, both sides also evinced flexibility in their negotiations with one another, which ended in a pragmatic deal in which Symes was able to secure key political and economic privileges for the Company by ceding the cultural sphere to his hosts, allowing them to present their concessions to him as an act of imperial benevolence, folding the local representatives of a powerful rival, both symbolically and in practice, into the Burmese political order.

The intellectual history of the mission demonstrates the extent to which early colonial knowledge emerged from social connection to indigenous elites. Symes and his staff were lavishly entertained by their hosts as guests of honor, providing opportunities to develop affective relationships as well as to exchange information, often that which was of political value, but also

that which was merely interesting. Cross-cultural communication of this sort, sustained during a short and rapidly closing window of opportunity, is why the Symes embassy was so uniquely successful in collecting information on Burma, producing essentially the whole corpus of European knowledge on Burma for decades to come, and also why in some ways it was unusually sympathetic in tone. Though Symes, Buchanan, and Wood may have been acting partly out of pleasure and curiosity, they were also government officials, and their collection of information served a political purpose. The study of other cultures was intimately connected to the Company's imperial project – only by developing, to the best of its ability, an understanding of the nature of the people and places it operated in could it go about securing its interests. The Symes embassy illustrates the extent to which colonial knowledge was connected to power not only through its subjective framings of other cultures, but also through empirical depth, often the result of inductive inquiry.

This was not the meeting of two nation-states called Britain and Burma, but rather the meeting of a trading corporation with pseudo state-like powers and a premodern Southeast Asian 'galactic polity,' both of which were imperial in orientation in the basic sense of following an expansionist path in the quest for wealth and power. The Company, though it was in the middle of undergoing a transformation that was to turn it into a tool of the British nation-state, still had one foot in a world in which it had been a private institution run for the benefit of its servants and their financiers, the workings of which went on outside of the public eye and with little governmental oversight. This incarnation of the Company was a hybrid entity combining state-like characteristics with the bottom line of a trading house. It operated through sinking its tendrils into a variety of polities of indigenous origin, which were used as the foundation for building a colonial presence while simultaneously erecting a facade that outwardly resembled the precolonial status quo, obfuscating the true degree of its power. This form of sovereignty was able to exist within the bodies of other states. Company power had grown out of the accumulation of grants and privileges under indigenous regimes in India, only spilling out into the open after over a century. The strategy Symes pursued harkened back to this formative period.

Just as the Company's strategy toward securing its interests in Burma bears the marks of an instrumental, rather than a rights-based attitude toward the exercise of sovereignty, so too does

the Burmese strategy toward accommodating those interests. Burmese officials worked hard to learn more about the Company, not only in its Indian but also its European political context. Their eventual decision to grant Symes many of his requests emerged from political calculation. The Company was too large and powerful, and its rivals in Europe and India too weak and distant, not to make some kind of arrangement, but it had to be done while preserving the king as a ritual and political center. The actual steps taken were mostly in the economic realm, and mostly functioned to police the behavior of wayward officials, rather than constituting a total rewrite of the system in place to extract resources from Indian Ocean trade networks. The court may even have believed that better trade relations would be mutually beneficial – statements to this effect can be found in Company records.¹⁰⁴ The exchange of ambassadors, the centerpiece of the agreement, turned out to be a sovereignty sharing arrangement, common in premodern Southeast Asia, but unacceptable to the man selected to fill the position, Hiram Cox, who believed that the best way to conduct diplomacy was to inspire fear – possibly the worst choice for ambassador the Company could have made to a state that jealously guarded its dignity.¹⁰⁵

This was a meeting between two states that were much closer to each other in power than they would be in the next century, as European empires were turbocharged by industrialization and modern nationalism, eventually allowing them to establish lopsided relations with even the largest and most venerable of Asian empires. Though in the Symes embassy it is possible to detect the burgeoning of an attempt on the part of the Company to impose its will over Burma, an inkling of the colonial encounter that was to come, in other aspects, such as cross-cultural intellectual exchange or in the malleable sovereignty practices displayed by both sides, it was also partly rooted in the more freewheeling proto-globalization of earlier times.¹⁰⁶ The late 18th century was an ambiguous moment when old and new imperial strategies coexisted, one a more muscular, identitarian form of imperialism connected with the nation-state and the other a subtler and more behind-the-scenes form, emerging out of the dispersed and negotiated sovereignty relationships that had characterized the early modern period across the world, including in both

¹⁰⁴ A letter to this effect was contained in the Chittagong district archives. T. H. Lewin, *The Hill Tracts of Chittagong and the Dwellers Therein* (Calcutta: Bengal Printing Company, 1869), p. 29.

¹⁰⁵ Cox, *Journal of a Residence in the Burmhan Empire*, pp. 363-5.

¹⁰⁶ For a collection of seminal essays on this, see A. G. Hopkins, *Globalization in World History* (London: Pimlico, 2002).

Britain and Burma.¹⁰⁷ While the Symes embassy contains elements of both forms, it leaned more heavily into the latter.

¹⁰⁷ Jon Wilson, *The Domination of Strangers: Modern Governance in Eastern India 1780-1835* (London: Palgrave Macmillan, 2008) compares British and Bengali sovereignty forms, making the argument that in the 18th century they were more similar than is often believed.

CHAPTER 5

EMPIRE THROUGH THE LOOKING GLASS: LATE 18TH-CENTURY COLONIAL KNOWLEDGE OF BURMA

This chapter is a study of the knowledge produced by the Symes embassy, in particular the diaries of its doctor, Francis Buchanan. It presents a case study in how the inductive forms of inquiry he pursued influenced the character of the information he produced, both at the level of discourse and at the level of its factual contents. I look at his extensive interactions with a variety of indigenous informants while in Burma, most notably Burmese ruling elites, tracing the complexity of the relationship between knowledge and power in the context of an intellectual exchange between two empires, one in which multiple discourses about ethnicity and civilization met and influenced each other. I also point to possibilities for reconstructing from this text evidence of how conquered groups in the Burmese empire thought of their relationship to their conquerors, in particular Manipuri captives forcibly relocated to serve as a bonded labor pool around the capital. Finally, I show how the material Buchanan collected can be used to trace the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in late 18th century Burma. I outline the imperial dynamism of the Konbaung dynasty, whose state-building efforts produced a shifting, fragmented landscape of overlapping and divided sovereignty relationships in its northern borderlands. On the ecological margins of the empire, Buchanan collected clear evidence of the porousness of ethnic boundaries between highlanders and lowlanders, and came to the conclusion that migration and acculturation had produced drastic shifts in ethnic identification, making the typical linguistic taxonomies used in his time to establish differences between ethnic groups of little use.

Many of the works explicitly addressing colonial knowledge in the Burmese context have emphasized its transformative or distorting impact. Aurore Candier's analysis of the term *lu-myo* exemplifies this approach, showing how precolonial Burmese classificatory categories were reconfigured as they were translated and adopted to suit colonial intellectual frameworks so that

they ultimately came to align with European concepts of nation and race.¹ Michael Adas has argued that early colonial observers projected a narrative of catastrophic decline onto precolonial Burma – particularly in their depiction of the Ava–Pegu wars – by exaggerating the scale of devastation and depopulation in order to justify colonial conquest.² Maitrii Aung-Thwin, in *The Return of the Galon King*, has likewise argued that colonial knowledge about the Saya San Rebellion was a power-inflected construct, later uncritically adopted by Burmese nationalists and international academics alike.³

There is, however, a growing body of scholarship on colonial knowledge in the Southeast Asian context that emphasizes the agency of Southeast Asian actors, contextual specificity and the role of indigenous informants. Scholars such as Alicia Turner, Andrew Huxley, Christian Lammerts, and Michael Charney have shown that Burmese intellectuals continued to shape legal, religious, and political discourse well into the colonial period, adapting precolonial forms of knowledge in order to navigate a new colonial context, working with the colonial state – if fleetingly – to construct a hybrid legal system, and reworking European ideas to serve their own ends.⁴ Mark Clement has argued that colonial knowledge was shaped by the specific positionality of its producers – Henry Gouger’s account of his captivity in Burma was written not from a masterful colonial position but from the viewpoint of a private trader of humble origins caught in the crossfire of a conflict between two large states.⁵ Most closely aligned with the present chapter is the work of Marie de Rugy, who demonstrates how early colonial mapping in Indochina relied heavily on indigenous maps and the testimony of informants.⁶

¹ Aurore Candier, ‘Mapping Ethnicity in Nineteenth-Century Burma: When “Categories of People” (lummyo) Became “Nations,”’ *Journal of Southeast Asian studies*, 50:3 (2019), pp. 347-364.

² Michael Adas, ‘Imperialist Rhetoric and Modern Historiography: The Case of Lower Burma before and after Conquest,’ *Journal of Southeast Asian Studies*, 3:2 (1972), pp. 175-192.

³ Maitrii Aung-Thwin, *The Return of the Galon King: History, Law, and Rebellion in Colonial Burma* (Athens: Ohio University Press; Singapore: NUS Press, 2011).

⁴ Alicia Turner, *Saving Buddhism: The Impermanence of Religion in Colonial Burma* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2014); Andrew Huxley, ‘Positivists and Buddhists: The Rise and Fall of Anglo-Burmese Ecclesiastical Law,’ *Law and Social Inquiry* 26:1 (2001), pp. 113-142; Christian Lammerts, *Buddhist Law in Burma: A History of Dhammasattha Texts and Jurisprudence, 1250–1850* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2018); Michael Charney, *Powerful Learning: Buddhist Literati and the Throne in Burma’s Last Dynasty, 1752–1885* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Centers for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 2006).

⁵ Mark Clement, ‘A Cross-Cultural Encounter in Pre-Colonial Burma: Henry Gouger’s Narrative of Commerce and Captivity, 1822–26,’ *Journal of Burma Studies* 17:2 (2013), pp. 335-371.

⁶ Marie de Rugy, *Imperial Borderlands: Maps and Territory-Building in the Northern Indochinese Peninsula (1885–1914)* (Leiden: Brill, 2022).

The diaries of Francis Buchanan have never been the subject of a focused study,⁷ but his proto-anthropological research into the relationship between territory, ethnicity and sovereignty in late 18th century Burma is important because it challenges the assumption that colonial knowledge was produced through a rigid, top-down imposition of European categories. In order to collect information about Burma, Buchanan relied heavily on oral testimony and indigenous maps given by informants from both elite and non-elite backgrounds. The significance of this is at multiple levels. He captured evidence of the subjective viewpoints of his informants, most notably aspects of an imperial discourse circulating among the Burmese officials that he was closely in contact with; but also subaltern perspectives such as those of slaves captured in wars with Manipur or highland tribal groups living under Burmese rule and undergoing processes of cultural and political assimilation. The raw, unfiltered nature of his diary entries, many of which consisted of recorded conversations, also meant that he captured evidence of patterns lying outside the immediate realm of European experience – such as entangled, pluralistic forms of sovereignty or fluid, dynamic ethnic identification – that were notoriously difficult for colonial observers to understand.

Buchanan's conversations with Burmese elites about ethnicity and civilization represent an important bridge between pre-colonial and colonial forms of ruling knowledge, both of which were ideologically inflected and functioned to represent conquered people in ways conducive to their subjection.⁸ His lists of ethnic groups, organized around their political status and economic

⁷ They are sometimes utilized as source material for making a wide variety of arguments unrelated to my own. See Jacques P. Leider, 'Natural Resources, Agricultural Produce and Commercialized Goods in Pre-colonial Myanmar: A Survey of some Travel Accounts (c. 1570-1800),' in ed. MHC Golden Jubilee Publication Committee, *Essays in Commemoration of the Golden Jubilee of the Myanmar Historical Commission* (Yangon: Myanmar Historical Commission, 2005), pp. 109-133; Victor Lieberman, 'Secular Trends in Burmese Economic History, c. 1350-1830, and their Implications for State Formation,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 25:1 (1991), pp. 1-31; D. G. E. Hall, *Europe and Burma* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1945), p. 83; C. A. Bayly, *Empire & Information: Intelligence gathering and social communication in India, 1780-1870* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996), p. 118. None of these works cover indigenous knowledge or utilize the bulk of the text, which was focused on geography and ethnicity.

⁸ There is a large literature on this, particularly in the Chinese context, where imperial regimes were dominated by highly educated literati who produced a much greater volume of source material than what can be found in most other parts of Asia. Stevan Harrell, *Cultural Encounters on China's Ethnic Frontiers* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1995); Joan-Pau Rubies and Manel Olle, 'The Comparative History of a Genre: The production and circulation of books on travel and ethnographies in early modern Europe and China,' *Modern Asian Studies*, 50:1 (2016), pp. 259-309; Magnus Fiskesjö, 'On the "Raw" and the "Cooked" Barbarians of Imperial China,' *Inner Asia*, 1:2 (1999), pp. 139-168; Laura Hostetler, *Qing Colonial Enterprise: Ethnography and Cartography in Early Modern China* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2001); Pamela Kyle Crossley, Helen F. Siu and Donald S. Sutton, *Empire at the Margins: Culture, Ethnicity, and Frontier in Early Modern China* (Berkeley: University of

function in relation to the imperial center, bear striking similarities both to premodern conceptualizations of ethnic difference as they are described in secondary literature, and to later British colonial classifications, revealing the ways in which pre-modern, non-European rulers, including in Southeast Asia, engaged in the ideologically inflected classification and ordering of their subjects; and the ways in which the colonial state absorbed and utilized these ideas for its own purposes.

Embassy members also spoke to representatives of conquered groups, which presents the opportunity to ask the question of how resistance to state authority was understood in a pre-modern, non-European empire into which Enlightenment derived notions of popular sovereignty and equality had not yet disseminated.⁹ When given the chance to speak, especially without minders present, many of these informants did indeed highlight tensions with the Burmese state; many did not though, and some also highlighted lateral tensions arising from smaller-scale instances of state-building which were directly patterned on Burma, Siam and other large regional states that served as examples for aspirant monarchs on their peripheries.¹⁰ These tensions do not correspond perfectly to ethnic tensions in the modern sense,¹¹ nor to anti-imperialism as a principle, at least in the way it would come to be formulated as a result of the formation of Marxist and nationalist independence movements in the late colonial world. This was a lively and ongoing contestation between ruler and ruled, but also a fragmentary and

California Press, 2006). For similar arguments made in other contexts see Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, chs. 4, 7 and Sheldon Pollock, 'Deep Orientalism? Notes on Sanskrit and Power Beyond the Raj,' in eds. Carol A. Breckenridge and Peter van der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993), pp. 76-133.

⁹ A major issue identified by critics of postcolonialism is the injection of modern values derived from Enlightenment philosophy into analysis of tensions between ruler and ruled in pre-colonial societies where political and social relationships were conceptualized in different ways. Rosalind O'Hanlon, 'Recovering the Subject: subaltern Studies and Histories of Resistance in Colonial South Asia,' in ed. Vinayak Chaturvedi, *Mapping Subaltern Studies and the Postcolonial* (London: Verso, 2000), pp. 72-115; Jon E. Wilson, '"A Thousand Countries to Go to": Peasants and Rulers in Late Eighteenth-Century Bengal,' *Past & Present*, 189:1 (2005), pp. 81-109.

¹⁰ Scott and Leach extensively discuss this borrowing of statecraft techniques. James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009); Edmund Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1965).

¹¹ Victor Lieberman, 'Ethnic Politics in Eighteenth-Century Burma,' *Modern Asian Studies* 12:3 (1978), pp. 455-482, discusses the ways in which ethnopolitical conflict in pre-colonial Burma differed from modern expressions of nationalism.

localized one, conducted in the terms of balance, negation or reversal of existing power relationships, not their complete transformation, which required a vision that was yet to come.¹²

Work done in the context of premodern Southeast Asia has shown that monarchs in that region of the world tended to espouse an ambitious concept of universal sovereignty paired with extensive in-practice decentralization, presiding over large, rapidly expanding and borderless polities that functioned by attaining the loose submission of minor rulers, incorporating them into tributary practices suffused with universalist symbolism.¹³ Evidence of this can be found throughout Buchanan's Burma diaries, but specifically I address its manifestations in northern Burma's borderlands, in an area that later became known as the Shan states, a collection of dozens of minor Tai principalities organized into loose coalitions while at the same time juggling multiple allegiances to different overlords in China, in Siam and in northeastern India.¹⁴ The political state of these borderlands in the late 18th century presents a classic case study in the divided and overlapping sovereignty relationships prevailing in Southeast Asia before the advent of the nation-state in the region, clearly recorded by Buchanan both in the notes of his conversations with informants, and in the geographical sketches they made for him.

The outlines can also be made out in Buchanan's work of a process often referred to in the area studies literature as 'cosmopolitan ingathering,' or the collection of diverse populations, either through enticement or coercion, into agriculturally viable areas, bolstering the social and economic resources of states existing in a part of the world in which land was plentiful but labor

¹² For a discussion of how revolt was expressed before the entrance of modern revolutionary ideologies into India, see Ranajit Guha, *Elementary Aspects of Peasant Insurgency in Colonial India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1999).

¹³ Thant Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001); Thant Myint-U, *The River of Lost Footsteps* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2006); William Koenig, *The Burmese Polity, 1752-1819: Politics, Administration and Social Organization in the Early Kon-baung Period* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan, Center for South and Southeast Asian Studies, 1990); Edmund Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma",' *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 3:1 (1960), pp. 49-68; Thongchai Winichakul, *Siam Mapped: A History of the Geo-Body of a Nation* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1994). The broader models of state formation in the introduction to Victor Lieberman, *Strange Parallels: Southeast Asia in Global Context, C. 800-1830*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003) and Stanley Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia,' *Journal of Ethnographic Theory*, 3:3 (2013) are also helpful.

¹⁴ Good histories of this region are Sao Saimong Mangrai, *The Shan States and the British Annexation* (Ithaca: Cornell University Southeast Asia Program, 1965); Patterson Giersch, *Asian Borderlands: The Transformation of Qing China's Yunnan Frontier* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2006); and Mandy Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin: Histories Beyond the State in the Borderworlds of Burma* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2013).

scarce, and in which commerce was relatively undeveloped, forcing governments to translate power into wealth through direct control of the bodies of their subjects and direct requisition of goods and services.¹⁵ This theme is so ubiquitous in Southeast Asian history that James Scott has called premodern Southeast Asian states centripetal 'manpower machines,' which, rather than ruling over discrete populations, instead subsisted by coaxing or coercing a wide variety of peoples into their orbit, who congealed together into uniform subject populations only through ipso facto processes of cultural change.¹⁶ Buchanan encountered the process in two places: in the immediate vicinity of the capital of Amarapura, where a large number of slaves had been relocated to serve as a pliant labor force for the state and its associated ruling elite after being taken prisoner during the conquest of the minor state of Manipur, lodged between Burma and Bengal; and also on the ecological verge of the Burmese empire, where he recorded plentiful evidence of entanglements between highland and lowland, as well as ethnic fluidity as tribal populations being incorporated into the Burmese polity were simultaneously undergoing a process of acculturation leading to wholesale metamorphosis. These observations challenge both later colonial and nationalist narratives that sought to define Southeast Asian ethnicities in rigid, territorially bounded terms, revealing a world in which identity much more protean.

The chapter is divided into four sections. The first two look at the combination of elite and non-elite voices that are submerged in Buchanan's text. In the first section, I sketch in broad outlines the ways in which Buchanan collected his information, going on to consider how Burmese officials, in the testimony they provided him, classified ethnic groups and represented civilization and savagery, as well as the connections between their ideas and the project of creating and governing an empire in a premodern, non-European context – and the ways in which these ideas bled into the colonial archive. The second section traces the passage of subjects from the conquered kingdom of Manipur to the dynasty's capital Amarapura, where they formed a bonded service population clustered around the court. In it I highlight the varying ways in which Manipuri and Burmese informants conceptualized these relationships, which reveal an imperial pragmatism on the part of Burmese elites, who justified these population transfers in

¹⁵ Nicholas Tarling, *The Cambridge History of Southeast Asia*, Vol. 1 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1993) chs. 7, 10; Koenig, *The Burmese Polity*, chs. 2, 4; Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, Vol. 1; Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*; Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity.'

¹⁶ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, p. 90.

realpolitik terms, as well as a combination of horizontal tensions between ruler and ruled, and lateral tensions arising from smaller-scale conflicts between and among conquered groups in and around Manipur. In the third and fourth sections, I discuss the evidence Buchanan left behind of two processes not typically recoverable from colonial knowledge – divided and overlapping sovereignty relationships, and ethnic transformation. I demonstrate how his descriptions of informal rule over client princes in Burma's northern borderlands with China reveal the overlapping, divided and otherwise ad hoc forms of sovereignty emerging from the indeterminacy of a three-way imperial contest there also involving Siam. I then present the evidence Buchanan collected of the incorporation of the Chin, a tribal highland group, politically, economically and socioculturally into lowland life, and the blurred ethnic boundaries that resulted, which led him to the conclusion, unorthodox for his time, that language and ethnicity had no necessary correlation.

ETHNIC CLASSIFICATION IN THE BURMESE EMPIRE

This section examines the process through which Buchanan's Burma diaries were produced, arguing that they exemplify the inductive empiricism characteristic of the Scottish Enlightenment in which Buchanan, a doctor trained at the University of Edinburgh, was steeped. His central working method was the questioning of indigenous informants. In his notebooks he meticulously recorded a thick tangle of statements made by people of many different walks of life, often with the subjective valuations of the phenomena they discussed still partly intact. Buchanan relied heavily on Burmese government officials to fill in gaps in his understanding of ethnicity in the region. Their representations were not ideologically neutral. In general, the empire seems to have been conceptualized by them as a diverse garden of peoples, all beholden to a single imperial center. Ethnic groups were seen in bounded terms as fixed units of population that could be politically dominated and economically exploited, and were ranked and ordered in hierarchical fashion depending on the extent to which they conformed to Burmese lifeways. Such views of ethnicity were not unlike what prevailed in the later colonial period, the major difference being that the colonial state undertook a sustained effort to introduce into the realm of ethnic classification a new level of precision and fixity, and to make more explicit use of such knowledge in its methods of rule. The ideas underpinning colonial thinking about ethnicity in Burma are present in the earliest moments of interaction between the Burmese and British ruling

elites and seem to have been forged through standardization and repurposing, rather than invention.

While the Symes embassy was in Burma, it collected a great variety of material, which taken together represents the first coherent picture that the EIC, and Europe at large, had access to on the kingdom. Its importance was recognized contemporaneously and much of it was published in the early 19th century in journals and printed books,¹⁷ but ultimately the information produced was meant first and foremost for the internal consumption of the EIC, and some remains in manuscript form in the India Office archives. This includes the diaries of Francis Buchanan, at the time a young doctor attached to the expedition.¹⁸ Buchanan, an odd and ambitious polymath described by a contemporary biographer as “lonely, arrogant and precise,” spoke multiple languages and compulsively collected information on everything from ichthyology to the origin myths of highland tribal groups.¹⁹ He went on to become one of the most important Company surveyors of the early colonial period, producing dozens of volumes of description on the Indian subcontinent and adjacent states,²⁰ a trove of information that forms the bedrock of inquiry on a number of subjects of which, before his research was conducted, little trace can be detected in the historical record.²¹

¹⁷ Michael Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vols. 1-2 (Edinburgh: Constable and Co., 1827); Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Route between Tartary and Amarapura, by an Ambassador from the Court of Ava to the Emperor of China,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 3 (1820), pp. 32-42; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava, drawn by a Slave of the King's Eldest Son,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 2 (1820), pp. 262-271; Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 7 (1822), pp. 230-239; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map constructed by a Native of Taunu, of the country south from Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 5 (1821), pp. 75-84; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Tarout Shan Territory,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 7 (1822), pp. 71-75; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the country north from Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 4 (1821), pp. 76-87; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 10 (1824), pp. 59-67; Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map drawn by a native of Dawae or Tavay,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, Vol. 9 (1823), pp. 228-36.

¹⁸ Mss Eur C12, Francis Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava.'

¹⁹ Marika Vicziany, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics in early Nineteenth-Century India: The Surveys of Francis Buchanan (1762-1829),' *Modern Asian Studies*, 20:4 (1986), pp. 637-8.

²⁰ These are contained in the India Office archives, Mss Eur C12-14, D70-98, E68-73, G10-25; Kurukh D1; NHD 2-3. They were partly published later in printed form in Montgomery Martin, *The History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, Vols 1-3 (London: W. H. Allen and Co., 1838).

²¹ Willem van Schendel, who said of Buchanan's surveys that they "provide us with the first detailed information in existence about many parts of rural Bengal," published the manuscript of his Chittagong journey because it had the potential to "push back the curtain of ignorance for that part of the country by some sixty years." Francis Buchanan, *Francis Buchanan in Southeast Bengal (1798): His Journey to Chittagong, the Chittagong Hill Tracts, Noakhali and Comilla*, ed. Willem van Schendel (Dhaka: University Press Limited, 1992), pp. x-xi.

Buchanan's methodology was in an empiricist tradition marking it out as different from early modern European travel accounts, and from the textualist orientalism in vogue in intellectual circles in Calcutta, paralleling in many ways the fieldwork of the modern anthropologist.²² He was an intellectual magpie, collecting eclectic bits of observation and explanation from others and pasting them together into a kind of synthetic pastiche. These others were from many walks of life, from slaves to princes, and were his acknowledged collaborators – unlike many colonial writers, he often accredited his sources of information, though these biographical snapshots are tantalizingly brief.²³ This co-authorship gives his writing an unusual richness, and makes it of much use to modern historians, as it captures something of the conversational life of the period, through which a vast amount of information must have flowed unrecorded.

Buchanan's Burma diaries are the earliest example of these methods at work, having been written before he was posted in India, where he spent most of his career. During his accompaniment of Michael Symes from the port of Rangoon to the capital Amarapura and back, Buchanan collected information from a wide variety of people. Foremost among these were the Burmese government officials who guided and received the embassy, as well as members of their often populous entourages, which included lower-ranking officials stationed in specific locales as well as servants, many of them bonded. Some of these were drawn from the subjects of conquered states or their descendants, others were Burmese who had become ensnared in debt, forcing them to seek the patronage of powerful protectors. Some of his subjects, particularly hill tribespeople, were summoned before Buchanan by Burmese government officials, likely as a gesture of goodwill to sate his curiosity. The same was also done with slaves taken during military excursions into surrounding states such as Siam, Manipur or Arakan. Though many of his encounters were mediated in some way by Burmese officials, he also went on excursions without them, visiting villages in the Burmese countryside populated by a variety of different ethnic groups.

²² Bernard S. Cohn, 'Notes on the History of the Study of Indian Society and Culture,' in eds. Milton Singer and Bernard S. Cohn, *Structure and Change in Indian Society* (Chicago: Aldine Publishing, 1968), pp. 3-29.

²³ For example, in his *An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava*, he wrote that the map had been drawn up for him by "a man in great poverty, who said, that, at the time, he was a slave of Eimshe mayn, the heir-apparent of the kingdom, and who probably had been reduced to the servile state by debt, as his intelligence and manners denoted a person who had held considerable rank, and received a good education." Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava, drawn by a Slave of the King's Eldest Son.'

A text like Buchanan's Burma diaries cannot be sufficiently explained by focusing purely on his a priori beliefs about the world and their connection to the project of colonial domination. He was a Company servant and he was working from within a specific 'episteme' – that of a pro-imperial Enlightenment rationalist, to paint him in the broadest possible strokes – which was determined by his training, career path and other aspects of his life trajectory.²⁴ All writing is influenced by its social, political and intellectual context. Depending on the procedures used though, the results can be more or less empirically grounded. Buchanan's writing, because it was so heavily reliant on the testimony of indigenous informants, is not purely his own but actually is the composite product of the contributions of many people, and as such is useful for understanding not only the intellectual and political history of European imperialism in Southeast Asia, but also the worldviews of his informants.

In accessing indigenous knowledge, Buchanan was not accessing a realm of greater truth free from the problem of the relationship between knowledge and power. His reliance on Burmese officials for information and to facilitate his research meant that his work rested on top of another nexus of knowledge and power not of his own making. Burmese officials commanded the bodies of their subjects, and used that power to elicit testimony not always freely given. In proffering information to Buchanan, they also unwittingly handed over fragments of non-European imperial discourse. Like other empires ruling over large, multiethnic domains, whether modern or premodern, the Burmese employed a variety of ideological tools to rank and order different groups. This included ethnocentric notions of cultural difference that prized the lifeways of settled, agricultural civilization above those of nomads or slash-and-burn agriculturalists occupying ecological marginal areas, as well as 'state simplifications' in geography and in ethnic classification, which acted to construct a series of neatly ordered political, economic and social units that could be conveniently ruled over, and whose labor and resources could be conveniently appropriated.²⁵ This was not an indigenous equivalent of Nicholas Dirks' 'ethnographic state,' predicated on intellectual as much as political or economic

²⁴ For more on this, see Vicziány, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics'; Sir George King, 'A Sketch of the Life of Francis Hamilton (once Buchanan), sometime Superintendent of the Honourable Company's Botanic Garden, Calcutta,' *Annals of the Royal Botanic Garden, Calcutta*, 10:1-3 (1905), pp. i-lxvii; and Angma Dey Jhala, *An Endangered History: Indigeneity, Religion, and Politics on the Borders of India, Burma, and Bangladesh* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2019), ch. 1.

²⁵ State simplifications is a term coined by Scott. James Scott, *Seeing like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1998).

conquest,²⁶ but rather a much looser and less standardized collection of ideas that was less directly connected to modes of governance, and thus arguably less impactful on the lives of the Konbaung dynasty's subjects. Nevertheless, the basic need to bring intellectual order to spaces and populations as part of the process of governance is there, and in these very early encounters between Burma and the British Empire, such ideas were absorbed into the colonial archive, where they became entrenched in its foundations.

Burmese concepts of ethnicity filtered into the colonial archive through the Symes embassy's networking with government officials. Such exchanges often occurred on social occasions like dinners, or in one memorable case, at teatime with the viceroy of Pegu and other officials from Rangoon.²⁷ Buchanan closely recorded this encounter in his notebooks – given the immediacy of detail in his entry, it is likely that he was writing during or shortly after the encounter itself, serving as a kind of stenographer for Symes. In Buchanan's notes, he records a Burmese official saying that, not far from where they were sitting, there was a town called 'Yo-myo,' or Yo state. The town was surrounded by villages where an ethnic group called the 'Yo' lived, who were according to him "very ugly, having white teeth, large bellies, and long hair hanging down from their heads." Their language was a dialect of Burmese related to that spoken in Tavoy, on the Tenasserim coast next to Siam, meaning that, in a linguistic sense, the Yo were not far from the Burmese – and yet the officials were making their ethnic difference clear. Intrigued, Buchanan probed the official to describe to him in more detail not just the Yo, but all the ethnic groups in the kingdom he could think of. The official obliged by helping him to create a written list, to which commentary was afterward added by all of the officials present. The list is reproduced below, with original ordering, spelling and abridged commentary:

Kula (a name referring to all people from India, including Hindus, Muslims, Europeans and Armenians)

Shan (Siamese subject to the Burmese king, of many kinds, the officers present enumerated many Shan principalities tributary to Burma)

²⁶ Nicholas Dirks, *Castes of Mind: Colonialism and the Making of Modern India* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2001), ch. 3.

²⁷ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 49-50.

Yoodara (Siamese subject to the king of Siam. Officials present tried to persuade Buchanan that the Burmese monarch appointed the Siamese monarch and could remove him at will, a claim Buchanan was skeptical of)

Tarouh, or Chinese (settled all over in large numbers, controlled the cotton and silk trades in and out of China; Buchanan noted that the finest silk was made by the Chin, which he spells in this list as Kiayn)

Kathee (the people of Manipur; an official present had been at the sack of the Manipur capital 14 years previously and recounted how many were enslaved after. He noted that they were skilled artisans)

Yathain (the people of Arakan, who were numerous, officers present described towns in the region and how to get to them)

Da way (called Tavoy by Europeans)

Tanayutharce (the people of Mergui or Tenasserim)

Lo

Lowa

Lu-laung

Pashoo or malayo

Pashee (another name for Muslims, a corruption maybe of Parsi)

Karayn (it was said that there were two kinds, Burmese and Mon Karen)

Kiayn (great silk workers, made expensive garments bought as gifts for the Burmese royal family)

Yo (made sugar)

Kahiayn (located on the other side of the Chindwin river between Burma and Manipur)

Ka du

Talain or Mon

Pa laung (described as a kind of Shan living northeast of the capital, grew tea and sold it in urban markets)

The man finished by claiming that each of these groups had a representative in the capital, suggesting symbolic or actual political submission. These officials' statements were ideological in nature. The claims to dominion made over the many states and communities enumerated in the list were precociously expansive. Amarapura was an imperial hub, as they suggested. Many rulers, in particular the governors of the Shan states, scattered across northern Burma into China and Siam, regularly were in personal attendance at both the royal and princely courts – the embassy itself encountered many of them. Other rulers, such as those of Siam or Arakan, had been at various points forcibly relocated to the vicinity of the capital,²⁸ and some Manipuri and Assamese princes traveled willingly there to solicit aid in their succession bids.²⁹ However, the list exaggerates the level of control over many of these groups, and its systemization, including both those whose allegiances were shifting (Manipur) and some that were the Konbaung dynasty's active enemies (Siam). Acephalous highland tribal groups could not have been incorporated as thoroughly into the state as they suggested, as they had no hereditary rulers who could be co-opted as proxies – or, in James Scott's terminology, no 'handles' by which they could be gripped.³⁰ The list therefore reflects more an ideal model of tribute relations, in which the king served as a kind of gravitational well, attracting into his orbit lesser rulers and subject populations.³¹

The list also constructs ethnicity in ways conducive to the needs of the state. The central logic driving it is not cultural affinity, but political affiliation and economic utility.³² Hence the Shan

²⁸ Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma* describes these relocations.

²⁹ Envoys and royals from these states were observed at court by the next Company ambassador, Hiram Cox, *Journal of a Residence in the Burmhan Empire* (London: John Warren and G. and W. B. Whittaker, 1821).

³⁰ Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, p. 258.

³¹ For metaphors on the resemblances between Southeast Asian interstate relations and the model of the solar system, see Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, Vol. 1, pp. 22-5 and Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity.'

³² On the role of political relations and economic 'niche' in the construction of ethnicity, see Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, ch. 7.

and Siamese, who exhibited many cultural similarities, were separated from each other based on which state controlled them (in other schemes provided to Buchanan, the Shan themselves were similarly carved up based on their tributary loyalties to surrounding rulers). A similar system was used for the Karen and other highland tribal groups partly assimilated into multiple lowland states. Units of rule were simultaneously also economic units, producing tea, silk, sugar and other products important in elite status display or long-distance trade. There is a certain cross-pollination here with control over labor, as in the case of Manipur – the ethnic group and its economic function (skilled artisanship) were fused together because most Manipuris living in Burma were slaves brought to the capital to serve in this capacity.

Finally, a highland/lowland divide emerges. Lowland groups feature more prominently, and are described in greater detail. The ethnic identifiers in use here – Siamese, Mon, Chinese – would also have been substantially similar to those used by those groups themselves, because in each case there was a clear, long-lasting political center around which a stable sense of ethnic identity could congeal.³³ Highlanders, on the other hand, do not populate the list as heavily, and are often accompanied by little commentary. When they feature at all, it is usually as a result of their intersection with lowland economies, suggesting that they were primarily conceptualized as traders coming down periodically to key markets. The terms used to describe them were catch-all terms used to refer to large numbers of people living in certain areas and sharing certain characteristics, such as non-agricultural lifeways, divergent forms of religion, or lack of social hierarchy or stable political structures. Many of these communities in reality were in a state of fragmentation, identifying primarily based on local kinship ties, and absorbing in amoeba-like fashion members of many different ethnic groups from highland and lowland alike.³⁴

The ways of thinking about ethnicity that come across in this and other encounters recorded in Buchanan's notebooks were not the heavily standardized ones of the late colonial state. There is no logical ordering to the list – ethnic groups were likely enumerated as they come to memory. A mix of categorization methods are used – sometimes the key marker is geographical origin,

³³ See Lieberman, 'Ethnic Politics in Eighteenth-Century Burma' for an explanation of how stable identities congealed around political cores.

³⁴ The Kachin, for example, were first known to the British through ethnic monikers borrowed from surrounding lowlanders such as the Burmese or Assamese; it was only in the 1830s when they realized that these groups, though organized along lineage lines, shared enough in common culturally that they could be considered a single whole. Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma*. See also Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin*, pp. 29-34.

sometimes association with an extinct state, sometimes political control, sometimes cultural similarity – and it is far from comprehensive, but rather seems to have been focused primarily on groups with which the speakers were familiar because of their geographical proximity or outsized importance. Nor were these ideas the product of a concerted research effort or explicitly used as blueprints for how bureaucratic governance should proceed. Imperial power dynamics were present, but they were implicit, and less rigid or all-encompassing than the textualized, institutionalized classificatory systems of European colonial empires.

Nevertheless, the list is completely an artifact of indigenous knowledge – members of the Symes embassy knew nothing of most of these groups when they entered the kingdom, not even their names. Yet most of the major ethnic groups of colonial Burma spring to life in it, pre-packaged into a form clearly recognizable as the rough-draft antecedent of later colonial thought on ethnicity in Burma, both in empirical contents and ideological function. The forms of categorization used in Victorian censuses of colonial Burma for example overlap significantly with this list jotted down in Buchanan's journal. Although by that point all of these ethnic categories had been heavily overlaid with the race theory in vogue at the time, the census takers acknowledged that they were borrowing categories from the Burmese in their classification of various minority groups, and that this was sometimes the cause of inaccuracy – the ethnic moniker, the language, the birthplace, the religion and the self-identity of an individual person rarely totally conformed to these ideal types, because originally they were not meant to denote races but rather notions of difference which were much broader and vaguer, despite also connected being in their own way to the exercise of imperial power.³⁵

The Company servants of the late 18th century were rarely without their notebooks and tended to be meticulous collectors of tidbits of information, as often the easiest – and sometimes the only – way to fill in the blank spaces in their understanding of local societies was to ask questions of knowledgeable people. This was especially true when it came to abstract phenomena not observable to the naked eye, of which concepts of ethnic difference are an excellent example. In the Burmese context, the people most likely to have a wide-ranging understanding of ethnicity across the geographical extent of the kingdom were government officials, who were also the

³⁵ *Government of India: Census of 1891, Imperial Series, Vol. IX - Burma Report, Vol. I* (Rangoon: Superintendent, Government Printing, Burma, 1892), ch. X.

Symes embassy's constant companions. Hence in Buchanan's work lies the beginning of a process of inheriting basic information about ethnicity and civilization in a Burmese context from Burmese elites themselves. In later censuses, we see the full flowering of a layering effect in which ideas picked up – probably through many encounters such as the ones recorded by Buchanan – were refined, built on, qualified, and reformatted to suit the needs of a state that ruled with much more precise tools than those of its predecessors, but which was often building on the political and intellectual latticing they left behind.

AMARAPURA AS A COSMOPOLITAN INGATHERING

Buchanan's Burma diaries provide a vivid account of the Konbaung state's practice of 'cosmopolitan ingathering,' a state-building strategy common in premodern Southeast Asia in which conquered groups were forcibly relocated to the Burmese heartland to serve economic, military, and cultural functions. Most of the captives encountered by the embassy in the vicinity of the capital Amarapura were taken from the conquered state of Manipur, today in the extreme northeast of India. Buchanan's diaries provide insight into how both Burmese elites and conquered people perceived their relationship. His information was based principally on conversations with indigenous informants, many of whom were Burmese officials, who represented the situation as beneficial to both conqueror and conquered. Manipuris were interviewed as well, their responses bringing to light tensions not only with the Konbaung state but also between and among ethnic groups in and around Manipur itself, which was a multiethnic, hierarchically constituted, empire-like polity not unlike Burma, if much smaller in scale.³⁶ These captives, drawn from a society that was heavily stratified and fragmented in its own right, did not articulate resistance in modern nationalist terms – as the oppression of one ethnic group by another – but rather framed their grievances in localized terms, focusing on violations of established norms governing relations between ruler and ruled in a premodern imperial setting, where at least some degree of subjection to outside control and extractive demands was common.

³⁶ See for example the latter half of Gangmumei Kamei, *History of Manipur: Precolonial Period* (New Delhi: Akansha Publishing House, 2015) for a description of Manipur's creation of a minor imperial polity whose reach extended well into what is now modern Burma.

Since the inception of the Konbaung dynasty, Manipur had been subject to a number of incursions in which large numbers of captives were taken away, the fourth in 1774 spilling over into several neighboring states, as well as into the surrounding highlands (captives designated as Manipuri actually came from a variety of backgrounds).³⁷ Many of the kingdom's inhabitants, whether of high or low social status, had been forcibly resettled around the capital, where they served the state and its elite in various capacities. Such mass population transfers were a common tactic pursued by states across the arc of premodern Southeast Asian history, which faced low population densities, an overabundance of land and weak exchange economies, making it imperative to locate sources of labor, place them in areas where their surplus could easily be expropriated, and fix them in place insofar as was possible. The population of the Konbaung capital featured a superabundance of such groups (75% according to some estimates),³⁸ many of whom possessed rare skills of interest to the state, such as gunsmiths, artists or religious functionaries.³⁹

The embassy's first encounter with Manipuris came in the form of the boatmen tasked with ferrying them to the capital. Burmese records include frequent references to such people, who formed an important component of the capital's labor force.⁴⁰ Symes was informed by his hosts that they had been captured during one of Burma's invasions of the kingdom. He noted that this was standard practice in Southeast Asia, and that slavery was practiced with an eye toward assimilating new subjects into the host society, especially children, who were more pliable than

³⁷ Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma*, chs. 3, 4 contain good information on these wars. Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1 has a historical overview given to him by veterans of them; documents related to them can also be found in Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885* (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), Vols. 3, 4, 5, in particular those in Vol. 3 discussing Alaungpaya's initial attack and subjugation of the kingdom (that of January 19th, 1759 for example).

³⁸ Victor Lieberman, 'Political Consolidation in Burma under the Early Konbaung Dynasty 1752 – c. 1820,' *Journal of Asian History*, 30:2 (1996), p. 167.

³⁹ For a comprehensive overview of the relationship between slavery and warfare and premodern Southeast Asia, see Michael Charney, *Southeast Asian Warfare, 1300–1900* (Leiden: Brill, 2004), ch. 9.

⁴⁰ To give an example of the flavor of this documentation, in 1806 the Manipuri slaves assigned to work for a certain nobleman "were scattered; get them in one group and let them serve the noble whom they were originally assigned to serve;" in the same decree Manipuri slaves are assigned, along with Siamese slaves, to a large-scale construction project of some kind, with the admonition: "the people in this service shall not give the excuse that they had been working for this prince or that minister...get back all these people and keep them in one single group;" war boat crews, also Manipuri, were to be recovered, reorganized and kept better track of. Than Tun, *The Royal Orders of Burma, A.D. 1598-1885*, Vol. 5 (Kyoto: The Center for Southeast Asian Studies, Kyoto University, 1983), pp. 283-4.

adults born free.⁴¹ A description by Symes, based on his conversations with Burmese officials,⁴² of the enslavement of Chinese war captives after the Qing army in Burma was encircled and defeated provides a more explicit recounting of these practices. The Qing army, he wrote, was routed with:

...dreadful carnage...Of the Chinese army, not a man returned to his native country. About 2500 were preserved from the sword, and conducted in fetters to the capital, where an exclusive quarter in the suburbs of the city was assigned for their residence. Those who did not understand any particular handicraft were employed in making gardens, and in the business of husbandry. Mechanics and artificers were compelled to ply their trades according to the royal pleasure, without any other reward for their labour than a bare subsistence. These people, however, were encouraged, as are all strangers, to marry Birman wives, and consider themselves natives of the country. Compliance with so hospitable and general an invitation, confers even on slaves taken in war certain immunities, from which those who refuse the connexion are by law debarred.⁴³

Symes drew a connection not between this practice and the chattel slavery of European colonial empires in the Americas, but the slavery of the "wisest and best governed nations" of Greco-Roman antiquity. He said the assimilation of captives into the host society was evidence of a "Lacedemonian liberality...They are sensible, that the strength of an empire consists in its population, and that a prince is great and powerful, more from the number of his subjects, than from the extent of his territory." This explanation, likely echoing those of the high officials he was in contact with, is not unlike the consensus in contemporary historiography about slavery and its effects in Southeast Asia, which stresses its 'open,' incorporative nature, in contrast to 'closed' systems resting on permanent differentiation and subjugation, and links this back to the nature of the demographic problems slavery was attempting to solve in different societies –

⁴¹ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, p. 6.

⁴² On the methods by which he collected historical information Symes says this: "These extraordinary events, having happened within the memory of many persons still living, are authenticated by individuals who themselves bore a part in the transactions: and although their relations are liable to that bias which is inseparable from the human mind, when the passions are engaged, and self-interest is concerned; yet the leading facts are such as do not admit of misrepresentation. To these, therefore, I have confined myself as closely as perspicuity would allow." Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol 1., p. 2.

⁴³ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 1, pp. 89-90.

where wealth came primarily in the form of people, rather than land, 'open' systems generally prevailed.⁴⁴

Buchanan's diaries provide further evidence of this elite perspective. He recorded an encounter in which the embassy, in the Company of Burmese officials, witnessed a group of Manipuris wearing Burmese dress singing as they rowed along the Irrawaddy, hauling vegetables to sell at market in Amarapura. The governor of Pegu remarked that they appeared "well reconciled to their state," that their industry procured them high wages and that they had excellent soil, an advantage they did not enjoy at home. He then pointed to their economic value – they were gunsmiths, goldsmiths, farmers and artificers, often producing work of higher quality than the Burmese were able to obtain elsewhere. He also praised their military characteristics.⁴⁵ (Symes noted in his collected military intelligence on the kingdom that Manipuris played a major role in the king's army, composing most of his household cavalry. Several thousand were ensconced throughout the capital district; their skill on horseback was considered admirable. Most of the Burmese army's gunsmiths were also Manipuri, and were able not only to manufacture guns but also to repair imported muskets, including old ones turned out of EIC arsenals).⁴⁶

Because of the role Burmese officials played in chaperoning the embassy, much of the information collected by Buchanan was influenced by them, either directly repeating their views or limited by state-facilitated encounters in which it would have been difficult for captives to offer full-bore critiques of their captors. Embassy members were able to shirk their minders at times though, and have more unadulterated conversations which are revealing of tensions. Symes for example described to Buchanan going on a walk by himself through Manipuri villages around the capital and speaking with their inhabitants. Questions about their living conditions produced a flood of complaints. They told him that they got nothing for their labor, and could hardly live above subsistence level.⁴⁷ Others described to Buchanan scenes of total devastation when asked about the Burmese invasions. Informants put the number of captives taken at a hundred thousand (probably inaccurate, but it does provide a sense of the psychological

⁴⁴ Kerry Ward, 'Slavery in Southeast Asia, 1420-1804,' in eds. David Eltis and Stanley Engerman, *The Cambridge World History of Slavery*, Vol. 3 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2011), pp. 163-185.

⁴⁵ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' p. 71.

⁴⁶ Symes, *An Account of an Embassy to the Kingdom of Ava*, Vol. 2, pp. 57-8.

⁴⁷ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' p. 72.

magnitude of the destruction). Some believed that Manipur had been completely deserted, not knowing that the principality had in fact survived the attacks and lived on.⁴⁸

The testimony of these informants, beyond revealing tensions with the Burmese, also reveals that Manipur itself was a multiethnic, imperial entity cobbled together through a process of ‘cosmopolitan ingathering’ remarkably similar to what prevailed in Burma, if on a smaller scale. A Burmese official who had marched with one of the armies that invaded Manipur told him that there were actually several ethnic groups living in and around the kingdom and that they had all been subject to capture, so the Manipuri population around the capital was more diverse than Buchanan had assumed.⁴⁹ In Amarapura he was introduced to a group of Manipuri brahmins, who provided an account of the surrounding principalities, which they described in classic mandala fashion – the Manipuri king ruled over smaller, peripheral kings orbiting him in concentric circles.⁵⁰

Buchanan also spoke to a Manipuri of Bengali descent who had been born in Burma to a slave captured in war. The man’s personal story speaks to the complexities of Manipur’s pre-conquest political landscape. His father had told him their country was once located west of Manipur, and used to have its own kings, but the Manipuris had conquered it and brought many of the inhabitants back to Manipur; later, they had been captured by the Burmese. Buchanan noted that they called themselves ‘banga,’ and that they spoke an Indian language.⁵¹ He also spoke to another member of this community who had been enslaved as a child and brought to the Burmese capital. The man plotted the location of ‘banga,’ which he described as the historical capital of a lost kingdom, on a map, placing it toward Bengal.⁵² It is unclear what kingdom these men were describing. It could have been Cachar, Jaintia or Tripura, all of which were west of Manipur, and in which Bengali populations were present, both as cultivators and court functionaries.⁵³ In any case, this is evidence of a layered imperialism: Manipur, a highland state

⁴⁸ Buchanan, ‘Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,’ pp. 73-4.

⁴⁹ Buchanan, ‘Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,’ pp. 74-5.

⁵⁰ Buchanan, ‘Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,’ pp. 74-6.

⁵¹ Buchanan, ‘Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,’ p. 95.

⁵² Buchanan, ‘Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,’ p. 100.

⁵³ A lot of primary source documentation on these areas is woven into Alexander Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes of the Northeast Frontier of Bengal* (Calcutta: Home Department Press, 1884), pp. 145-9, 217-45, 269-87.

founded by tribal groups who freely borrowed from the technical libraries of both South and Southeast Asian statecraft, employed much the same imperial strategy as the larger neighbor that eventually conquered it.

There are a multitude of voices clamoring to be heard in Buchanan's Burma diaries. They tell the story of a muscular form of imperialism practiced by the Burmese state, predicated on the conquest of bordering kingdoms, mass population transfer and forced social, economic and political integration. Not only can the political and economic outlines of this project be detected, so too can its intellectual outlines in the views of Burmese elites, who explained such practices without reservation in practical terms as a means of bolstering the state's resources. Also present are the views of conquered groups, who in some cases directed criticisms towards their conquerors, but who also revealed cross-cutting tensions at the local level. Burma was not the only expansionist polity in the region; many smaller neighboring polities owed their existence to the importation of Burmese statecraft techniques into tribal settings, reproducing the same hierarchical chains of patronage, and the same demographic agglomeration, in miniature form. The presence of both elite and non-elite perspectives in Buchanan's writing is a testament to the sophistication of his methodology, which was not to immediately impose his own views but to siphon up raw information through many different modes in order to develop a detailed descriptive picture of his object before moving on to theorizing.

HOUSE OF CARDS-STYLE STATE BUILDING IN BURMA'S BORDERLANDS

In this section, I shift focus to information collected about Burmese rule in the Shan states, a smattering of city-states scattered across what is today northern Burma, as well as adjacent highland areas in China, Thailand, Laos and Vietnam. My purpose is to demonstrate the extent to which Buchanan's inductive methods allowed him to access information emerging from outside of European experience, in this case on the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in the Konbaung dynasty's northern borderlands. No member of the embassy ever visited the Shan states. The information collected, primarily by Buchanan, came entirely from conversations with court officials, most notably the Burmese governor put in place to represent the authority of the king in his northern borderlands, though Shan princes themselves, present in the capital's courts, also provided information, as did a whole host of other actors of lesser social

origin who interacted with the embassy in various capacities. The picture these informants gave was of a vague, borderless domain, sometimes expanding, sometimes contracting, over which Konbaung authority was exercised in loose, informal fashion from the highest heights, secured mainly through control of key military and economic choke points and rarely penetrating deeply.

The Shan states, ruled by Tai princes, formed a complex, shifting political landscape, starting with their internal politics, which were often tumultuous and involved a heavy dose of political entrepreneurship (some Shan princes were self-made and self-styled).⁵⁴ Shan states often formed loose coalitions, which could result from intermarriage or war, and China, Siam, Burma and Manipur all claimed suzerainty over portions of the region, claims which were both overlapping and constantly evolving, tracking closely with the relative strength of each power.⁵⁵ Burmese rule over adjacent Shan states was long-standing, sometimes dating to the 16th century, and had resulted in a fusion of court cultures as the Shan aristocracy were symbolically incorporated into the ranks of Burmese officialdom;⁵⁶ over newly-captured states it was more tenuous, especially over those that had been annexed after the Konbaung dynasty's mid-18th century war with Qing China. Dovetailing with this expansion, the Konbaung court had also initiated a process of transition to more absolute and formalized rule in the region.⁵⁷

Buchanan's informants represented the political geography of the Burmese empire in aggregate form, as being comprised of a large number of city-states cobbled together like a house of cards. At the most elementary level, the basic unit of political order was the urban settlement and its surrounding agricultural hinterland. It was to one or another of these settlements that informants generally fixed their political identity, rather than to an ethnic group, or to the Burmese umbrella state. City-states were not represented as bordering each other directly in consecutive order, but rather as being interspersed with large areas of wilderness populated by tribal groups living outside the reach of the state.

An official in Rangoon gave Buchanan an account of the surrounding "countries" (likely a translation of *maung*, a term with cognates in many other Southeast Asian languages and used to

⁵⁴ Mangrai, *The Shan States and the British Annexation*, ch. 5.

⁵⁵ Giersch, *Asian Borderlands*, pp. 97-127.

⁵⁶ Lieberman, *Burmese Administrative Cycles*, pp. 113-130.

⁵⁷ Lieberman, 'Political consolidation.'

denote both cities and states, a nod to the importance of city-states as the individual building blocks of political order across the region).⁵⁸ He placed Toungoo to the south (which had given rise to Burma's eponymously-named previous dynasty), which controlled mixed Burmese and Shan settlements; Shan states to the east and south; other Shan principalities close to China but subject to Burma; Burmese towns on the right of the Chindwin, wild tribes on the left which inhabited scattered villages and were "rude and fierce, but raise rice;" Shan settlements on the right bank of the Chindwin above the Burmese towns, also subject to the Burmese king, living amid rivers that produced gold dust; and Shan states interspersed with tribal populations surrounding Ava to the north and east. Maps drafted by informants also represented Burmese political geography as a series of city-states juxtaposed against a wild landscape populated by tribal groups living outside state control.⁵⁹

Buchanan was introduced to the governor of the Shan states himself in the capital, who described the area as a half-wild borderland populated by a cornucopia of different ethnic groups, parts of which had only recently been conquered.⁶⁰ He had originally styled himself the prince of Kengtung, a Shan state near the Chinese border, but Buchanan later learned that he was actually a Burmese official acting as regent. He was also serving as the provincial governor, and as such, was living in Bhamo, the provincial capital, which he described as a major regional trade entrepot populated by a variety of ethnic groups: Burmese, Chinese, Siamese, Palaung, Lawa, Karen, Shan, Kachin and several other names Buchanan could not make out. The man also spoke some form of Chinese and reverse engineered this list, giving him the names of all these groups in Chinese as well. He said that, in the hills, most of the province's inhabitants were Kachin, but the number of tribes present rendered the province a "microcosm of the empire." The governor pointed out which Shan states were under his control and which were either under the control of other states or, in deep mountain areas close to the border with Assam, independent (he mentioned that these distant states on the border with Assam were heavily influenced from the

⁵⁸ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 72-5.

⁵⁹ Scaled-down copies of these maps, as well as Buchanan's commentary on them and biographical vignettes of their creators, can be found in Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava, drawn by a Slave of the King's Eldest Son'; Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan'; Buchanan, 'Account of a Map constructed by a Native of Taunu, of the country south from Ava'; Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Tarout Shan Territory'; Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the country north from Ava'; Buchanan, 'Account of two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma'; and Buchanan, 'Account of a Map drawn by a native of Dawae or Tavay'.

⁶⁰ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 85-91.

Indian side). He also pointed to a small number of Chinese towns under his control, taken during the war fought between Burma and the Qing dynasty in the mid-18th century.

The governor explained how informal rule in the Shan states was achieved, using methods familiar to the British in India. Authority was not exercised over each Shan prince directly by the king, but rather was mediated through feudal networks that had long preceded the establishment of Burmese power in the region. Many lesser princes were under the immediate authority of Mogaung, which, until its conquest by the Taungoo in the 16th century, had dominated a powerful confederation of Shan states that at points had ruled much of Burma.⁶¹ He provided a list of the principalities under his control, and those under the control of the Mogaung prince, and said that although there were 99 Shan princes, 9 had extensive governments of their own, meaning that they commanded the allegiance of other princes, who paid homage to him only indirectly.⁶² (This repetition of the number 9 was likely not meant to reflect numerical reality, but rather to convey the impression of an iterated political landscape in which power was reproduced in pyramidal layers).

Though heavily intertwined with the Burmese, Shan princes were also autonomous actors in their own right. A Shan prince was described by the Bhamo governor as the ruler of a ‘conquered nation,’ whose office was permanent and hereditary. Though he simultaneously held rank in Burmese officialdom, he was considered to be minor royalty – had the right to use the trappings of state, such as a gilded umbrella. An Armenian at the court of the heir apparent explained, in response to Buchanan’s curiosity about some Shan princes also in attendance, that they were like Indian rajas – hereditary rulers of minor principalities who, though subject to the king, could not be appointed or removed without the consensus of their countrymen.⁶³ Wood was later told that they frequently rebelled against the Burmese. “Like our polygar rajahs, all of them were willing to take advantage of any circumstance in order to avoid paying their tribute,” he said to Buchanan, alluding to a similar form of rule practiced by the Company over the fractured, proliferating landscape of ‘little kings’ in Southern India.⁶⁴

⁶¹ Mangrai, *The Shan States and the British Annexation*, pp. 15-81.

⁶² Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 85-88.

⁶³ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 79.

⁶⁴ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 83; the term ‘little king’ is closely associated with the work of Bernard Cohn and Nicholas Dirks. Bernard Cohn, 'Political systems in eighteenth

Across this region, much imperial jousting had taken place over the course of the 18th century, producing shifting borders and irregular sovereignty arrangements. Buchanan learned of this primarily through interviewing merchants, mercenaries and other Indian Ocean sojourners with experience in Burma after he had returned to Calcutta – Portuguese, Indians and natives of coastal Burmese provinces. A Muslim Indian who had been employed as a mercenary in the Burmese army during the mid-century wars fought between Burma and China over control of the Shan states recounted how during the war, the prince of Kengtung had ceased paying tribute and started provisioning the Qing armies, prompting an expedition against him. He had been at the decisive engagement, and noted how after the Burmese won, not only had they brought Kengtung back into the fold, they had also seized Chinese territory, in particular gold and silver mines, and installed customs houses to collect revenues. He gave an overview of the political balance sheet of northern Burma as he knew it when he left, pointing out Shan states tributary to Burma, those who sent representatives but no tribute, and those that had no relationship at all, though he cautioned that any intelligence he gave would fast become obsolete because the state of the area was “constantly shifting according to the power of the Burmese monarch and the caprice of his government.”⁶⁵

This loose, shifting, overlapping and distinctly imperial form of sovereignty was reproduced on Burma’s borders with Manipur and Siam as well. Buchanan was able to obtain from a slave of the heir apparent a geographical account of the marginal zone between Siam, China and Burma. They corrected the maps produced by French Jesuits in China and the philosophes relying on their information, who, probably through a spurious application of European-style concepts of sovereignty, had represented the borders of these states as contiguous with one another.⁶⁶ The slave pointed out that the triangle area between the three states was home to a wide variety of smaller political formations, over which the three major powers of the region exercised only incomplete and shifting control. Burma’s recent successful invasion of Siam had put it in a

century India: the Banaras region,' *Journal of the American Oriental Society*, 82:3 (1962), pp. 312-320; Nicholas Dirks, *The Hollow Crown: Ethnohistory of an Indian Kingdom* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987).

⁶⁵ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 135.

⁶⁶ Buchanan was carrying with him during his travels copies of the maps produced by the French Enlightenment geographer Jean-Baptiste d'Anville, compiled from information relayed by French Jesuits employed in mapping activities in Yunnan and elsewhere by the Qing court. His maps endowing China with European-style borders are included in Jean-Baptiste Du Halde, *Description Geographique, Historique, Chronologique, Politique, et Physique de l'Empire de la Chine et de la Tartarie Chinoise*, Vols. 1-4 (Paris: P. G. le Mercier, 1735).

dominant position in the Shan principalities located in what is now Laos and northern Thailand – but this was an anomaly that he predicted would change, as these states had traditionally been more closely connected, culturally and politically, to Siam.⁶⁷

In the contested zone between Manipur and Burma, exactly who a Shan state owed allegiance to was unclear. Buchanan spoke to the son of a Burmese official who was able to speak Manipuri (and was learning Bengali by the order of the king), who claimed that all of the Shan states bordering Manipur were under Burmese control. Residents from Shan states located next to Manipur itself provided a more complex picture, claiming that they were also subject to heavy Manipuri influence, but that their true political allegiances were with Mogaung, the historical political center of the Shan states. Buchanan concluded that these states were the subject of a tug-of-war between Burma and Manipur in which loyalties frequently shifted. The slave of the heir apparent agreed with his assessment, reasoning that after Manipur's destruction, it was likely that all the Shan states in the region had come under Burma's control, but that since the Manipuri king had once again managed to regain his throne, feudal relationships were likely in flux.⁶⁸

In both the maps and oral testimony provided by Buchanan's sources, a clear pattern emerges. The Konbaung dynasty practiced a flexible, shifting form of informal imperial rule over its northern borderlands. Sovereignty was exercised primarily through high-level governance bringing together the region's various local potentates into loose coalition, and a bare-bones system of military outposts and customs houses meant to secure the state's vital interests. This was a system of rule structured by past context. The representative of the Burmese monarch was not the sole wielder of power, but rather exercised a form of sovereignty diffused through layers of feudal obligation originating in the Shan states' pre-conquest political history. It was also dynamic. Rather than sovereignty truncating neatly where it met the borders of another state, all major powers in the region exercised waxing and waning influence over indeterminate chunks of the political landscape, leaving anomalous situations in which states caught between multiple potential overlords frequently changed hands or simultaneously looked toward two or more centers. Far from being in a state of stasis, northern Burma as it comes across in Buchanan's diaries is a classic example of how Southeast Asian 'galactic polities' interacted with their

⁶⁷ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 85-88, 92.

⁶⁸ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 97-9.

borderlands in practice, through the expression of a fluid form of imperial sovereignty. It is also a striking testament of the extent to which colonial observers, when they were producing knowledge through inductive inquiry and not simply imposing their preconceived notions on the world, were able to take account of evidence suggesting that the relationship between sovereignty, territory and ethnicity was construed differently in Southeast Asia than it was in Europe.

ASSIMILATION OF TRIBAL HIGHLANDERS

In this section, I argue that Francis Buchanan's ethnographic work in late 18th-century Burma demonstrates that when colonial knowledge was produced through inductive inquiry rather than imposed theoretical frameworks, it could yield genuine insights into the fluidity of ethnic identity in precolonial Southeast Asia. His observations on the Yo and Chin tribes living on the ecological margins of Burmese civilization were compiled through oral testimony, indigenous maps, and direct, state-facilitated encounters with tribal elders and their Burmese rulers. The information he collected reveals a pattern: that in the places where highlanders and lowlanders met, they melded into each other – partly through ecological adaptation and partly through incorporation into state structures – in a way that was causing radical ethnic transformation. This led him to an unorthodox conclusion for a man of his time: that language and ethnicity had no necessary relation. His findings not only challenge later colonial and nationalist narratives that sought to define Southeast Asian ethnicity in rigid, territorially bounded terms; they also show that when and where these patterns persisted, colonial observers were capable not only of inadvertently capturing them but also of consciously recognizing the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity in the precolonial world.

Verbal descriptions given to Buchanan of the Yo place them as an ethnic group living in the intermediary space between highland areas populated by Chin and lowland areas populated by Burmese. Early on, he learned that the Yo lived in state-like principalities, organized internally into a hierarchical structure, which was in turn under Burmese governance, similar to the pattern seen in the Shan states, suggesting that they represented the furthest extent of the dissemination of state-like structures of governance into agriculturally marginal environments. This is the settlement pattern described in oral testimony collected by Buchanan. He spoke to the headman

of several lowland, riverine villages in south Burma which abutted the spine of mountains to the west forming the border with Bengal.⁶⁹ This man gave a rough description of the ethnic geography surrounding his village, identifying the Chin as living in the hills, several settlements belonging to the Yo, an intermediary group, and between them, settlements containing both. A similar description was given to Buchanan by an elderly Yo man who was present in the train of a Burmese government official. Buchanan noted that the man differed from the Burmese in dress, but that his language was a dialect of Burmese. He described the country beyond his village thusly: the river banks were inhabited by Burmese villages, subject to Pagan; beyond them in the foothills were Yo settlements; above them were two Shan settlements; and beyond those were the Chin, who inhabited the hills. Elsewhere Buchanan himself observed that the sides of the mountains he could see from his riverboat were dotted with villages that he was told were populated by a mix of Yo and Karen, another tribal highland group.

A third, nearly identical description was later given by five of the Pagan governor's relations, who came to visit the embassy with their patriarch as it was passing through the area. They named the region's principal settlements, describing lowland areas as being populated by Burmese, highland areas as being populated by Chin, and the Yo as occupying agricultural settlements in the foothills between them. These same informants drew Buchanan a map which he included in one of his articles published in the *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*.⁷⁰ The map is organized around a highland/lowland spatial orientation. Pagan is at the center in a river valley crosscutting the map, surrounded by Burmese villages and temple sites. Yo city-states are scattered throughout the foothills to the north, bounded at their extremity by a shapeless, jagged blob labeled the 'Chin mountains.' The correlation between ethnicity and environment is unmistakable – the Burmese are placed in the lowlands, which are civilized, central and familiar, the Yo in the foothills and the Chin in the high mountains, which are wild, peripheral and unknown.

⁶⁹ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 109-114.

⁷⁰ Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan.'

These descriptions illustrate the complex intersection of environment, ethnicity and political power that characterized precolonial Southeast Asia.⁷¹ At the base was ecology, which dictated the locations of settlements and ways of life. Ecology, location and lifeways in turn had a strong relationship to identity, encouraging ethnic differentiation along localized lines, often corresponding to minute niches in an area's social and economic ecology. Politics floated over top of these domains, and was the most rapidly shifting of them, consisting of the tying together of bundles of settlements through conquest, governance or the establishment of tributary relationships.

Added to this was an element of movement and change at the ground level. Populations intermingled, both in terms of the settlements of different ethnic groups existing side by side and in terms of different ethnic groups coexisting within the same settlement. Communities, when crossing boundaries of ecology, entering into new areas of settlement and changing their ways of life to suit, could also shed their old ethnic identities and take on new ones – an inference correctly made by Buchanan and other contemporaneous European observers. The collection of the kind of testimony described above led to Buchanan concluding that the Yo, far from being a primordial ethnic category, had likely emerged through a process of acculturation by which highland tribal groups, passing from hill to valley, adopted some of the characteristics of dominant lowland cultures.⁷² A missionary, Vincenzo Sangermano, whom Buchanan met during his journey, reached a similar conclusion, having this to say about the Yo: "They are supposed to have been Chien, who in progress of time have become Burmese, speaking their language, although very corruptly, and adopting all their customs."⁷³

Buchanan provides us a description of a close encounter with a Chin community that was undergoing a process of incorporation into the Burmese state and simultaneous cultural assimilation. This was arranged by the viceroy of Pegu, who summoned before Symes and

⁷¹ See Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, pp. 36-9 for an overview of this relationship; also Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma* and Fredrik Barth, *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries: The Social Organization of Culture Difference* (Boston: Little, Brown & Co, 1969).

⁷² Francis Buchanan 'An Account of the Frontier between part of Bengal and the Kingdom of Ava,' *Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 2 (1825), p. 54.

⁷³ Rev. Father Sangermano, *A Description of the Burmese Empire* (London: Oriental Translation Fund of Great Britain and Ireland, 1833), pp. 33-4.

Buchanan some Chin elders so they could be observed and questioned.⁷⁴ They were brought down and arrayed before the two travelers dressed in their finest clothes, likely ceremonial – silk and black cotton, striped and bordered with red, white and yellow bands, ornamented with cowries and headscarves. The officials present explained that these were ‘kiayn yeen,’ or Chins under Burmese control. They lived on the Burmese side of the mountain range separating Burma from Bengal and Assam, and Burmese chiefs ruled in their villages. ‘Kiayn yain,’ or those not under Burmese control, lived in the deep mountains.⁷⁵ They had no chiefs, and perfect equality was established among them. Both were “equally ignorant of reading, writing, laws and government,” and had “no knowledge of a god,” according to local officials, suggesting that they conceptualized Chin tribes under their control as lacking in the characteristic markers of civilization in a Southeast Asian context: social hierarchy, hereditary rulership, literacy, continuity in government and Buddhist belief.

One of the better-dressed and presumably higher-ranked among the elders was selected to be painted by Symes’ Bengali painter. While this was happening, Buchanan, through an interpreter, asked him where he would go after death. He answered that he would become a child and would be made so by the father and mother of the world. Buchanan asked who these were. He replied that they grew in the earth, as trees grow in a field – one green, the other desiccated – and that they lived on a mountain. Buchanan later conversed with a group of elders who elaborated on these beliefs. They told him that long ago, the father and mother of the world were the king and queen of all Chin and that the souls of the dead went to them; they lived on a mountain. The Chin prayed to them, but only in the afterlife itself; in this world, they could not hear prayers. When Buchanan ventured forth the notion that men were rewarded or punished in the afterlife for their good and evil acts, they scoffed, saying that in their country, there was no sin. They explained that they burned their dead and collected the ashes, carrying them to their houses where they kept them for six days. They then carried them to the place of burning and buried the urn, erecting a wooden image of the deceased over the grave to protect it. One of the Burmese village chiefs who ruled over the Chin later clarified this account, saying that the mountain referred to in these tales was in the abode of the independent Chin and that the Chin subject to

⁷⁴ Buchanan, 'Observations during travels through Burma on mission to Ava,' pp. 118-20.

⁷⁵ The terms ‘yeen’ and ‘yain’ roughly correspond to wild versus civilized in Burmese – thank you to Dr. Jonathan Saha for this clarification.

the Burmese also carried the ashes of their dead up into the high mountains and buried them there, “where their gods reside.”

The specific details of these stories do not correlate clearly with those collected by modern anthropologists of the Chin, though some dim resonances can be detected in the use of imagery related to family, birth and nature.⁷⁶ What they do suggest is that these Chin were part of social and cultural networks running into the highlands while simultaneously being part of lowland political and economic hierarchies. This was likely what the anthropologist Theodore Stern termed a ‘plains Chin’ community.⁷⁷ Having migrated into the Burmese dominated lowlands they entered into a simultaneous relationship of political and cultural subordination to the Burmese state and Burmese civilization. Though this relationship introduced new pressures to acculturate, their move was likely in the recent past, because they still retained a variety of linguistic and cultural markers that separated them out from the wider Burmese population and social and religious ties to highland communities; the plains Chin studied by Stern in the 1960s were much more thoroughly integrated into lowland life.

The term Chin apparently originates in Burmese and was a catch-all used to refer to a large number of culturally similar communities occupying the highland spine running between Burma and Bengal. Yo was a term of self-identification in use by the same people. F. K. Lehman, an important anthropologist of the Chin, tells us that it did not exactly denote ethnicity but rather lack of sophistication, in contrast to the people of the plains, who were viewed as unscrupulous but materially and organizationally sophisticated.⁷⁸ Buchanan’s use of the terms in his diaries is shifting, likely because he was just adopting the terminology of whoever was giving him information at the time. This linguistic instability is an important reminder that, the further back in the history of ethnography one goes, the more shapeless the forms of those being studied become, until it is not clear who is being referred to at all. In this moment though, when they first enter into the colonial archive, the group or groups being referred to as Chin or Yo do not stand alone. They are deeply entangled with lowland political, economic, social and cultural networks

⁷⁶ F. K. Lehman, *The Structure of Chin Society: A Tribal People of Burma Adapted to a Non-Western Civilization* (Urbana: University of Illinois Press, 1963), pp. 28-39.

⁷⁷ Theodore Stern, 'Language Contact between Related Languages: Burmese Influences upon Plains Chin,' *Anthropological Linguistics*, 4:4 (1962), pp. 1-28.

⁷⁸ Lehman, *The Structure of Chin Society*, pp. 3-5, 28-39.

in a way that makes it difficult to draw distinct boundaries between them and other ethnic groups;⁷⁹ exactly the pattern described in the 1960s by Lehman, who argued that, rather than having developed in a vacuum, Chin society was ‘subnuclear,’ meaning that it was fundamentally oriented towards and adapted to living alongside plains dwellers.⁸⁰

Given the nature of these raw encounters, it is perhaps unsurprising that Buchanan’s formal linguistic analysis is notable not for lending an artificial coherence to the relationship between language and identity in the region, but for drawing attention to its very disconnect. Buchanan included in an article in *Asiatic Researches* a description of all the languages he had encountered in Burma – four dialects of Burmese, three Tai languages, the speech of Manipur, a Chin language, two Karen languages (Mon and Burmese Karens), the language of Pegu, those of Hindus and Muslims settled in Arakan, and that of Cachari slaves in the capital. On varieties of Burmese, he noted that the people of Arakan, Ava, the Yo states and Tenasserim spoke languages that appeared similar to him in most respects, yet all four groups differentiated themselves from each other (though Arakanese and Burmese acknowledged a common relation), and political fault lines ran between them: Arakan was a conquered state, the Yo were ruled under local princes in the same way the Shan were, and Tenasserim had traditionally been ruled by Siam. The same was true of the Tai, who, though displaying many similarities in language and culture, were fragmented both at the level of politics and identity.

Among highland tribal groups, this disconnect was even more pronounced. Unlike in the lowlands, where there was a general agreement between different ethnic groups on terminologies and forms of identification, those of highlanders and lowlanders often bore little resemblance to each other. He used the Karens, another highland tribal group, as an example. The Burmese distinguished between Burmese and Mon Karens; some Karens themselves understood the distinction, but Buchanan surmised that it was likely because they had significantly acculturated and adopted Burmese ideas. Most Karen he spoke to made no distinction between subgroups,

⁷⁹ François Robinne and Mandy Sadan, ‘Postscript: Reconsidering the Dynamics of Ethnicity through Foucault’s Concept of “Spaces of Dispersion”,’ in *Social Dynamics in the Highlands of Southeast Asia: Reconsidering Political Systems of Highland Burma* by E. R. Leach, ed. François Robinne and Mandy Sadan (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 299–308.

⁸⁰ Lehman, *The Structure of Chin Society*, pp. 221–29.

rather prioritizing lineage over ethnicity, and displayed extreme linguistic diversity, even in the case of settlements within relatively short distance of each other.

Buchanan came to the conclusion that although the peoples of the region bore shared physiological and linguistic markers, a localized conceptual ecumene, highland/lowland divisions and the vicissitudes of migration, cultural drift and political contestation had left the region configured along hopelessly entangled lines. "Language of all adventitious circumstances," he wrote, "is the surest guide in tracing the migrations and connections of nations; and how in a nation, which bears such strong marks of being one, radically the same, languages totally different should prevail, I cannot, at present, pretend to conjecture."⁸¹ He cautioned his contemporaries not to draw quick conclusions about ethnicity based on language, drawing parallels closer to home, pointing out that Bengal had been heavily influenced, culturally and linguistically, by both the Mughal Empire and the EIC, but that Bengalis were neither Persians nor Englishmen. Acculturation was far from evidence of a common origin, "a circumstance," he wrote, "to which, if antiquarians had been attentive, they would have been saved from the greater part of that etymological folly, which has so often exposed their pleasing science to the just ridicule of mankind."

As was the case in the other avenues of inquiry he pursued, Buchanan's ethnography of tribal people at the Burmese empire's ecological periphery consisted mostly of the collection of oral testimony, paired with rough geographical sketches from indigenous informants of a variety of backgrounds. These methods allowed him to capture evidence of the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in the liminal spaces between highland and lowland in late 18th-century Burma. His observations reinforce the idea that ethnic categories were neither primordial nor fixed but rather shaped by conquest, migration and cultural and economic exchanges. In recognizing this, Buchanan anticipated key insights later formalized in modern anthropology, demonstrating the extent to which colonial-era observers, when guided by inductive reasoning, could produce sophisticated depictions of other societies that did not artificially reduce their complexity.

⁸¹ Francis Buchanan 'A Comparative Vocabulary of some of the Languages Spoken in the Burma Empire,' in *Supplemental Volumes to the Works of Sir William Jones*, Vol. 2 (London: G. G. and J. Robinson, 1801), p. 953-4.

CONCLUSION

In this chapter I considered some of the implications of Francis Buchanan's methodology, which primarily consisted of the collection of oral testimony and geographical sketches from indigenous informants of a variety of backgrounds, on the character of the information he collected, both at a factual level and at the level of discourse. The first two sections looked at the presence of a variety of non-European voices in the text, from both elite and non-elite backgrounds. I looked at the general methods Buchanan used to collect information, and the ways in which Burmese officials represented ethnic difference in their conversations with embassy members. Though less standardized and less connected to bureaucratic mechanisms of rule than those of the colonial state, their ways of conceptualizing ethnic difference were also conducive to the conquest and rule of other groups, and in these early encounters were already beginning to be absorbed into the colonial archive. In the next section, I showed that, in descriptions of captive Manipuris serving as a labor reservoir for the state around the capital of Amarapura, a complex layering of voices can be detected, including those of Burmese elites, whose statements on the subjection of Manipuris to corvée demands evince a matter-of-fact imperial pragmatism, and those of Manipuris themselves, whose statements are indicative of tensions in many directions, not just with their conquerors.

I also pointed to some of the ways in which this information can be used to construct a picture of Burma that is far from flat or static but rather gives full scope to the ambiguity and fluidity produced by the exercise of imperial power on Burma's ecological and political frontiers. I detailed how Buchanan elicited from a variety of informants the outlines of a shifting form of informal imperial rule in the Shan states, where multiple powers projected divided and overlapping claims to sovereignty over a fluctuating space. Finally, I looked at the material collected by Buchanan on highland tribal populations, showing that, rather than imprisoning them in a rigid system of racial classification, his methods and results pointed in the opposite direction, to a series of political, economic and sociocultural entanglements between different ethnic groups in the liminal space between highland and lowland, producing ethnic transformation among highlanders passing through a porous boundary into lowland life.

The material collected here aligns neatly with a major trend in modern Southeast Asian studies historiography in that it contains plentiful evidence of the inadequacy of using a nation-state framework for the analysis of precolonial Burma. The Konbaung dynasty emerges here not as a proto-nation, but as an expansionist imperial power whose authority was exerted through a combination of direct rule in core regions and indirect control over tributary states and frontier populations. Rather than governing through uniform administrative structures, the Konbaung dynasty extended its influence into frontier regions through negotiated tributary alliances and the projection of military power, a loose and flexible but effective means of control over peripheral zones. One of its key strategies was a process of ‘cosmopolitan ingathering,’ in which subject populations from conquered territories – such as Manipuris, Arakanese, and Siamese – were forcibly relocated to the capital or other key population centers to serve as artisans, soldiers, or laborers. This practice not only concentrated skilled manpower in the imperial core but also served as a political tool, undermining the power bases of subjugated states by siphoning away their subject populations.

The play of imperial power produced a marked lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity in late 18th century Burma. Outside of core areas, the Konbaung state ruled through a layered and flexible system of control, in which its sovereignty was partial, negotiated and shifting, rather than being bureaucratically imposed. Often, that control skipped over areas not conducive to settled agriculture, and extended only to tributary rulers; beneath that level, intermediaries mediated access to populations on the ground, and engaged in their own fractious political contestation. Ethnic identity was similarly in flux. The state’s social engineering of demography meant that entire populations were frequently uprooted, resettled, and reorganized in order to fulfill the resource demands of the state, leading to a situation in which many of the groups most directly under state control were non-Burmese, who developed hybrid cultural identities or assimilated over time. Similar transformations also occurred on the highland/lowland verge, where ethnic differences between Burmese and Chin (highlander/lowlander) were mediated by a third category – Yo, which seems to have referred to Chin groups acculturated to Burmese lifeways and incorporated in varying degrees into the dynasty’s political networks.

Buchanan's diaries were also an important opportunity to look at the relationship between knowledge and power in a non-European context, and the ways in which early colonial officials in their collection of information layered themselves over top of these other nexuses and drew sustenance from them, not only logistically but also in terms of perspective. The Burmese had their own ideas about ethnicity and civilization and savagery which, although less standardized or connected to bureaucratic governance than those of colonial officials, were remarkably similar in their ideological effect; through cross-cultural encounters with different groups of pre-colonial ruling elites, these ideas bled into the colonial archive. These findings suggest that the relationship between knowledge and power, so well-studied in a colonial context, was present in some form and to some degree in non-European, premodern states as well, and that what happened in the process of European colonization of South and Southeast Asia is that these ideas were taken up, reformatted, systematized and enshrined in the machinery of governance in a new way – but not invented.

The findings also speak to the multiplicity of voices to be found in early colonial records of cross-cultural encounter, including those of what might be characterized as subaltern groups – though in this case these were not the colonial state's subalterns, but those of another empire. The fragmentary evidence that emerges from these encounters of the perspectives of such groups provides some insight into the consciousness of conquered people in the Konbaung empire. Grievances were present, but expressed in a fragmentary and localized manner. Without the hallmarks of modern political consciousness – print culture, mass literacy and increased population circulation within the framework of a modern state – there was no possibility for connecting fragmentary and localized experiences into a single unified identity or cause. Modern ideas of political equality and liberation have a specific history – they emerged in Europe largely in the 18th century and spread across the world in unison with European imperial expansion. Before that point empire was the normative form of polity, even in very small states where expansion played out on a microcosmic scale.

At base, I hoped to demonstrate in this chapter that the knowledge collected by the colonial state could align with empirical reality, at least as it is described by modern scholars, much more closely than it is often given credit for, if certain conditions prevailed – namely, if it was produced through inductive methods beginning with the collection of new information,

especially that procured from indigenous informants. The stereotype that colonial knowledge cannot be connected to any possible indigenous realities emerges from the analysis of fiction, grand theoretical tomes based in textual criticism or recycling primary accounts at a secondary or tertiary level, or travel writing produced primarily through visual observation. The early anthropological approach taken by Buchanan produced results that are much denser and more unexpected, filled with voices other than his own.

CONCLUSION

In this dissertation I first explored the decentralized nature of EIC governance on its Bengal frontier in the 18th and early 19th centuries, demonstrating how it remained reliant on precolonial organizational structures as the main conduit through which it went about securing its limited interests – and how as a consequence many of the patterns characterizing precolonial borderlands remained intact, such as divided and overlapping sovereignty relationships, uninhibited flows of mercenaries and migrants, or political contestation at the local level that the Company could not establish control over, and sometimes was not even privy to. I then reconceptualized the Company's two main interventions on this frontier in the late 18th century – the Welsh expedition to Assam and the Symes embassy to Burma – not as manifestations of a grand, top-down strategy of conquest, but as arising from the desire to tamp down on mercenary, rebel, criminal and other forms of unapproved violence, factional conflict at the local level, competition over tributaries and resources, military incursions and other expressions of power by other actors. Political expansion and economic exploitation were also pursued, but opportunistically, and sometimes by individuals acting of their own accord rather than as a matter of institutional policy.

I showed how the Welsh expedition was drawn into Assam by rampant factionalism in the wake of state breakdown, how this intra-elite conflict structured the mission's stay in the kingdom, forcing Welsh to take sides and find allies who benefited from and became dependent on his patronage, and how his reliance on these groups for political intelligence colored his own interpretation of the reasons why conflict had broken out, what traditional order looked like in the kingdom, and what needed to be done to restore it. I also discussed the extent to which Francis Buchanan, in his collection of information on Assam while based in neighboring Goalpara district, was influenced by the views of his informants: pro-monarchy factions in the Ahom aristocracy, whose perspectives were diametrically opposed to those of Welsh's informants; Garo tribal chiefs, who used communication with Buchanan as an opportunity to garner Company support for their resistance to the encroachment of lowland landowners into their territory; and Bengali Brahmins, whose knowledge of the caste-tribe continuum in Rangpur and Assam had a clear ideological thrust, ordering the world along lines conducive to the needs of rulers and acting with prescriptive effect, helping to forge populations that were more uniform, productive, and amenable to state control.

I made an effort to salvage from this archive evidence of the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in precolonial Assam. Early colonial records indicate that the Ahom state was ruled by a conquest elite originating in northern Burma and organized as a 'galactic polity' along distinctly Southeast Asian lines, with a dispersed, borderless political structure predicated on control of human bodies. Rather than being home to an Assamese proto-nation, it was populated largely by Tibeto-Burman tribal groups, many of which were also present in surrounding states, augmented by an influx of high-caste Bengali migrants clustered around regional courts. New concepts of political legitimation and social organization were inducing widespread ethnic change, including in the Ahom court, which constituted the most important and well-documented example of the strategic incorporation of Hinduism into regional polities. That all of this can be recovered from early colonial knowledge I hope demonstrates the extent of its depth, ambiguity and fertility for 'against-the-grain' readings.

In the late 18th century, the Konbaung dynasty was at the peak of its power. From its origins in northern Burma, it had expanded to encompass a large chunk of continental Southeast Asia, swallowing up states and populations and rendering rulers across the region tributary. The dynasty operated an ambitious and pugnacious foreign policy, having set its sights on further expansion, both into areas immediately adjacent to Bengal, and into Bengal itself, and its ritual and rhetorical mode of conducting diplomacy reflected this imperial orientation. The Symes embassy had to find a way to interface with the cultural edifice of this empire while simultaneously looking to further the Company's own imperial interests, which included economic concessions, the establishment of a permanent diplomatic relationship, and the collection of information. I traced its success in the latter area back to the social realm, in particular the ability of Symes and his entourage to integrate themselves into Burmese elite networks and cultivate contacts within them, yielding a windfall of knowledge. An imperial pragmatism evinced by both sides produced an uneasy and fleeting detente.

In my analysis of the knowledge produced by the Symes embassy, I concentrated on Francis Buchanan's working methods, primarily consisting of the collection of indigenous testimony and maps from a variety of figures – and the implications of those methods, both at the level of discourse and in terms of empirical results. I first highlighted the multiplicity of voices to be found in Buchanan's writing. Pieces bubble up of a homegrown discourse of civilization and

savagery, and of the packaging and ordering of the kingdom's population into discrete units of rule organized around the monarch. He also observed the fallout of the enslavement and forced relocation of tens of thousands of people from the conquered state of Manipur to the area around the capital, where they formed a captive labor population serving the state and its elite. Burmese officials' statements on these practices reveal pragmatic *realpolitik* justifications, while those of Manipuris suggest not only tensions between conqueror and conquered but also a variety of cross-cutting tensions produced by the smaller scale exercise of imperial power within Manipur itself. Finally, far from artificially portraying Burma as being trapped in the stasis of tradition, Buchanan's diaries tell a dynamic story of imperial expansion. Indigenous representations of political geography suggest that in its northern borderlands with China and Siam, Burma was engaged in a complex, dynamic tributary politics in which it was just one of several larger regional powers putting forth contested, overlapping claims to sovereignty over shifting confederacies of local rulers. A process of 'cosmopolitan ingathering' can also be detected, including the assimilation of Manipuris, Arakanese, Siamese and other conquered groups into the social, economic and cultural life of the capital, as well as wholesale ethnic transformation in liminal spaces between highland and lowland, where Chin groups were being enfolded into the cultural complex of Burmese civilization – patterns that so obviously pointed to the instability of ethnicity that they changed the minds of a small subset of early colonial observers like Buchanan.

In terms of broad-scale conclusions, firstly this whole northeast frontier area formed a coherent whole. Assam, Burma, and Company-ruled Bengal were not three separate states neatly divided from each other by clearly defined borders, but were mutually connected through large, indeterminate borderlands, populated by a number of smaller principalities and punctuated by large tracts of ecologically marginal terrain in which state power quickly dissipated. These were wide open spaces, characterized by the extensive circulation of people, goods and ideas, porous, multiethnic social systems, and a decentralized, pyramidal politics, in which local rulers formed shifting confederacies over which larger regional powers put forth contested, overlapping claims to sovereignty. In the late 18th and early 19th centuries, the amorphous frontier between these three states was still operating largely according to historical patterns conserved from the pre-colonial period.

All three of the large states described in this dissertation – Burma, Assam and Company-ruled Bengal – were dynamic imperial formations, forged through processes of conquest and resource extraction interacting with local rulers, semi-autonomous communities, interstate trade routes and diasporas, and the terrain itself, which in mountain, marine and other difficult environments posed a significant obstacle to the projection of sovereignty. The free, informal play of imperial power over such obstacle-strewn terrain produced sprawling, irregular domains, cobbled together out of multiple smaller states and communities, dividing some and amalgamating others into larger, conformed units. This ad hoc, incorporative form of state building produced many different holdovers and exceptions, resulting in a kind of stratigraphy where multiple ruling elites and the material detritus and practices of previous regimes were stacked on top of each other, sometimes several layers deep; such states did not end abruptly at borderlines but instead tended to taper off into a variety of interpenetrating political and economic arrangements.

None of these states occupied political footprints that perfectly overlapped with the economic, social or cultural formations beneath them. None monopolized force; they were only the largest and most potent political actors, sharing that realm with many others, from zamindars and border rajas to invaders, client kings, tribal chiefs and wayward bureaucrats, and a whole host of criminalized forces, including pirates, bandits and rebels. All were fundamentally oriented to intervening in, shaping and taxing economic activity that emerged from below and outside (the labor and surplus of agricultural communities or long-distance trade networks), or generating new forms of economic activity through the use of state power (mercantile monopolies, the forced relocation of slave populations). All three states were also forged through the gathering together of many different communities under the direction of a conquest elite, combined with extensive migration, creating fragmented, internally stratified societies; large-scale forms of political identification coalesced around these existing polities, rather than preceding and giving birth to them.¹

The EIC was different from other regional states, primarily in its oceanic and mercantile orientation, as well as in the sophistication of its techniques of bureaucratic governance. It

¹ Victor Lieberman, 'Ethnic Politics in Eighteenth-Century Burma,' *Modern Asian Studies* 12:3 (1978), pp. 455-482; James Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed: An Anarchist History of Upland Southeast Asia* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2009).

oversaw a highly disciplined organizational system characterized by a constant, high-volume circulation of directives from top to bottom and information from bottom to top, and in which factionalism and personal ambition, though still ever present, had been significantly subordinated to institutional interests. It also wielded many of the institutional innovations and forms of knowledge that would become characteristic of the modern state, from hospitals, prisons, military bases and colleges to the census, the museum, the archive and the cadastral survey. It is easy, however, to overestimate the penetrative effect of these early signs of modernity. In the 18th and early 19th centuries, many of these features were still new in Europe itself;² in a colonial setting – where the state was of a fundamentally different nature, meant to augment the metropole, and therefore was a much more limited and targeted phenomenon – when these features were present, they tended to be deployed in a much more circumscribed manner, and were conjoined to states and societies with their own historical trajectories.

One of the main points that I sought to drive home in the dissertation was the weakness and decentralization of the early colonial state on its frontiers. In the frontier districts of Rangpur and Chittagong, the Company was initially presiding over the sovereignty structure that had been built up by the Mughals. Only slowly and in piecemeal fashion did it begin to impose a more European-style sovereignty framework on its borderlands. This was a process that took place mostly in the 19th century; the Welsh and Symes missions represented the earliest glimmers of the Company's ambitions in this quarter, but those ambitions at this time had to play out in a political landscape largely dictated by surviving pre-colonial patterns.

One important subset of these patterns consisted of local power struggles in Rangpur and Chittagong districts. In Rangpur district, a shadowy military market thrived beyond Company control, enabling groups of bandits, mercenaries, and wayward landlords to exercise significant coercive violence in the pursuit of their own political and economic interests. European private traders and even local Company representatives behaving in a nefarious fashion also represented significant challenges to the Company's ambitions of creating a European-style state in Bengal. Eighteenth-century Chittagong posed similar obstacles to the imposition of a neatly ordered sovereignty framework. The Chittagong Hills were dominated by hereditary rulers largely

² See the introduction to Bernard Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996).

outside of the Company's control, offering only a cotton tribute according to Mughal precedent. These minor rajas frequently rebelled against Company authority while also simultaneously pursuing their own microcosmic plans of expansion.

Above these localized struggles, the middle level of power politics consisted of elite factionalism and the strategic maneuvering of indigenous power holders seeking to leverage Company support for their own ends. The deterioration of the Ahom monarchy led to intense intra-elite struggle between various groups and individuals vying for control over offices and territories. The Company was drawn into this cutthroat world of political contestation in an attempt to contain what it perceived as disorder threatening to spill over into Bengal, and found itself playing the role of imperial patron, courted by those who hoped to use its military might as a tool for their own consolidation of power. In Burma's western borderlands, the collapse of smaller states such as Arakan and Manipur created a similar wave of elite conflicts, as exiled rulers and displaced nobles sought to enlist both British and Burmese patronage in their efforts to regain power. These groups were politically sophisticated and opportunistic, presenting their struggles in terms that would appeal to the Company's strategic concerns while simultaneously pursuing their own personal ambitions. Early colonial expansion was intimately intertwined with such local conflicts, which provided inlets into neighboring states that could be used to gain control of them with little resistance or expenditure of resources.

At the highest level, these localized and middle-level power struggles shaped the strategies of both the Burmese and British, forming the landscape upon which their imperial ambitions played out. The EIC's policy towards the Konbaung dynasty originally was one of containment, aiming to use diplomacy to limit the possibility of direct confrontation and mutually arrive at an ordered border agreement. The withdrawal of Welsh from Assam created a political vacuum in that kingdom, in which rival contestants for the throne reached out to multiple surrounding states, inviting them in to intervene, including the Konbaung dynasty, which eventually pursued such an offer. The Burmese army launched a full-scale invasion of Assam in the early 19th century and simultaneously began to annex smaller principalities bordering on Bengal, such as Manipur and Cachar, leading to a situation in which the presence of multiple Burmese armies at key points along the Company's frontier compelled it to adopt a different approach. The First Anglo-Burmese War, which was the result of a chain reaction originating in these local crises, ultimately

ended in the Company's victory, the permanent occupation of most of Bengal's northeast frontier, the wresting away of many of Burma's conquered territories, and its eventual annexation by the British Empire by the close of the 19th century.

In this dissertation, I took the view that the knowledge produced by the early colonial state, as with contemporaneously produced indigenous knowledge and academic knowledge in the present, emerged from an ideological field, but that there are other, equally important dimensions to it. One is the extent to which it is rooted in experience. The colonial archive is immensely thick and varied. It is layered, with the highest and most influential layers – grand scholarly tomes, position papers by leading bureaucrats, famous works of fiction – also tending to be the ones furthest removed from actual experience. These highest layers tend to be the most ideologically charged and least illuminating; more immediate records produced through cross-cultural encounter broadly occupy the same ideological field, but are overlaying a much denser tangle of facts entering in from the environment.

Knowledge meant for internal bureaucratic consumption tended to be connected to *realpolitik*, and was produced through the application of an empirical rationality that could be highly developed. This empirical rationality was exercised within an imperial institutional framework pursuing a variety of ends such as conquest, security, control of subject populations, resource extraction, or the encouragement of economic productivity, and the results it produced were oriented toward those ends, constructing new domains of knowledge correlated with and designed to facilitate each. These accretions of knowledge brought to light some phenomena while obscuring others, rearranged information to create new objects of knowledge, artificially froze dynamic processes in time, introduced self-serving interpretations, and sometimes just plainly got things wrong; but the colonial state's bureaucratic knowledge was not fantasy. Its power came as much from what it was able to grasp as how it was able to grasp it.

The material collected on Assam and Burma arose from the application of a variety of techniques, from direct observation and textual analysis to cartography and statistics. I focused on the collection of indigenous testimony, a key strategy for accessing information which could not readily be gleaned either from available documentation or the naked eye – for example structural descriptions of the kind typical of the early human sciences, or real-time intelligence on immediate political developments. Such information was collected from a variety of

informants, usually religious and political elites, and often presents in a liminal state, bearing traces both of colonial ideas and others that arose from nexuses of knowledge and power preceding, existing alongside and linking up with the colonial state. Though less institutionalized and less governed by instrumental rationality than their colonial equivalents, non-European discourses of human diversity and civilization and savagery also ordered the world along lines conducive to the needs of rulers and acted with prescriptive effect. Nor did these ideas die out in the colonial period; they were incorporated into the colonial archive, and endlessly parsed and built on in an effort to create that much more detailed, fixed and practically applicable form of knowledge characteristic of colonial bureaucratic drives.

The voices of more marginal people also enter into the colonial archive, for example those of highland tribal chiefs, outlawed mercenary bands, or conquered communities that had been forcibly relocated by the Burmese state. These voices do often express resistance to those who held power over them, but it was a resistance that tended to be expressed in particularistic terms, and without any clear revolutionary agenda, which can only appear as a result of a systematic understanding of the wider context of power relations in which one is nested.³ It was only after the changes wrought by colonialism – the creation of a broader and more uniform political and economic arena, the linking together of similar communities, and the introduction of print culture and Enlightenment-derived ideologies – that such struggles could be universalized.⁴

Knowledge produced through cross-cultural encounter, while shaped by colonial objectives, could also contain valuable raw information. By reading these documents critically to identify patterns in the ways in which territory, sovereignty and ethnicity related to each other in this early period, both within the boundaries of the early colonial state and outside them, I was able to reconstruct a picture of the frontier that emphasized in all three of Burma, Assam and Company-controlled Bengal unrestricted cross-border mobility, overlapping and divided sovereignty, and extensive malleability in the realm of ethnic identity. In these early records, the seeds of a more Europeanized, proto-national interpretation are already present; but in the late

³ The question of how to create revolutionary consciousness in populations not naturally endowed with it is one that Marxists have long struggled with. See Antonio Gramsci, *Prison Notebooks* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1992).

⁴ Benedict Anderson, *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (London: Verso, 2006); Ernest Gellner, *Nations and Nationalism* (Oxford: Blackwell, 1983).

18th century, at a time when these more open-ended, fluid relationships still flourished, colonial knowledge produced through inductive inquiry was usually able to detect them in some form, even if observers did not comprehend them in the same way that a modern scholar would.

The findings presented in this dissertation are confined to a relatively short window of time – roughly twenty years at the end of the 18th century – before the imposition of formal colonial rule in Assam, Burma, or anywhere along this northeastern frontier, apart from Bengal itself. This study does not attempt to trace these patterns forward into the 19th or 20th centuries. Whether the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity, or the multi-sided political contestation observed in my research, were later flattened by the bureaucratic logic of colonial administration and cultural imperialism, or whether they persisted – possibly in new forms – longer than is often assumed, remains an open question. The thesis demonstrates continuity between the pre-colonial and early colonial worlds, but only laterally across a relatively narrow slice of time; it cannot speak to the long arc of colonial rule. A future area of inquiry for me will be the extent to which these patterns can be traced into the latter half of the 19th century and beyond.

Another caveat is that, even with careful reading, the colonial archive remains a partial and opaque window into the past. The EIC had targeted aims in collecting information, linked to its realpolitik priorities. Most of the available information clusters around issues of obvious political or economic importance, such as warfare, factional conflict, political structures, social cleavages, agricultural productivity, statistics on commerce, or cartographic information that allowed colonial planners to assess the geographic extent and composition of neighboring polities and to identify trade and marching routes. Officials tasked with collecting intelligence on this frontier also often lacked deep cultural context or the linguistic expertise necessary to engage in textual analysis. As such, many topics are simply absent because they were not relevant to the strategic priorities of a conquest state and monopolistic commercial firm. Key aspects of subjective worldviews – for example the relationship between religion and law, an important aspect of Burmese political culture – are largely absent from their observations, which is why scholarship based primarily in indigenous language sources will always be irreplaceable.⁵ The knowledge

⁵ See Christian Lammerts, *Buddhist Law in Burma: A History of Dhammasattha Texts and Jurisprudence, 1250–1850* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2018); Andrew Huxley, ‘The Importance of the Dhammathats in

produced by the early colonial state was not comprehensive, nor did it capture any timeless truths. At best, it was a series of external observations made at specific places and times, bolstered by statements collected mostly from allied informants. My only contention is that these observations and statements can be plotted in such a way as to reveal patterns that were not immediately recognizable to the people who created them.

A final, largely unanswered question is the extent to which my arguments about the inductive methodologies characteristic of early colonial intelligence collection efforts and the indigenous knowledge embedded within its products can be generalized to later periods. The consensus in other studies touching on similar questions seems to be that, over time, as the information emerging from early encounters was hashed and rehashed for purposes increasingly divorced from indigenous contexts, the fact that later and often self-serving colonial interpretations rested at the end of a long chain of transmission – at the bottom of which often lay indigenous testimony – was increasingly obscured.⁶ I do think though that there is scope for an examination of this question in frontier areas, as colonial control and understanding of them often lagged behind core lowland areas. Many remained beyond the reach of even the late colonial state's administrative structures and largely unknown well into the 19th century. I suspect that pinpointing the earliest drives for the collection of knowledge on remote upland areas would reveal a similar reliance on indigenous informants, even if first contact was at a much later time period.

Limitations aside, I believe that my findings in this dissertation point to an important phenomenon – a layering effect, in which the company superimposed itself onto existing structures rather than replacing them outright. Colonial rule emerged out of a political landscape that was distinctly non-national in its composition, characterized by the ideologically universalizing but in practice heavily decentralized exercise of sovereignty; liminal borderland spaces where states and civilizations seamlessly melted into each other; and ethnic identities that were often fragmentary, tied to specific locations, rulers, or environments rather than to the wider

Burmese Law and Culture,' *The Journal of Burma Studies* 1 (1997), pp. 1-17; Andrew Huxley, 'Positivists and Buddhists: The Rise and Fall of Anglo-Burmese Ecclesiastical Law,' *Law and Social Inquiry* 26:1 (2001), pp. 113-142.

⁶ Several of the contributors to Carol Breckenridge and Peter Van Der Veer, *Orientalism and the Postcolonial Predicament: Perspectives on South Asia* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1993) for example David Ludden and Nicholas Dirks, note this.

umbrella categories of modern times. It also emerged out of a political landscape characterized not by fixity but by dynamic contestation on multiple levels. These patterns heavily influenced the early colonial state itself. While at its highest levels the Company may have operated as an impersonal bureaucracy on Weberian lines, it was a metastatic phenomenon, grafted onto a large variety of moving precolonial political, social, and economic processes. Rather than envisioning it as a hegemon imposing order from above, it is more accurate to see it as an emergent phenomenon – its strategy and form taking shape in response to conditions in the regions in which it operated.

This layering effect also extended to the realm of knowledge production, much of which occurred where the colonial nexus of knowledge and power linked up with others. Most notably allied religious and political elites, but in general a cast of figures of a surprising variety of backgrounds served as intermediaries, shaping the information that filtered into the early colonial archive. Their agendas and biases can be detected in early colonial accounts. Some are merely fossilized curiosities; others had a serious effect on colonial interpretations of colonized people, a cross-pollination of ruling discourses. If read ‘against the grain,’ texts constructed in this way can also be made to provide evidence of precolonial political and social realities that were radically at odds with both later colonial and nationalist ways of understanding ethnicity, space and political order.

Overall, I hope that the arguments and evidence I have collected in this dissertation will help answer the question of the influence of the pre-colonial period on early colonial rule. The colonial state undoubtedly had a transformative impact on the region, especially from the mid-19th century onward, but it did not appear on a blank slate. European imperial states did not immediately overwrite the histories of the states and societies they conquered – especially not when operating in regions of the world with large populations, deep civilizations, and robust statecraft traditions. Rather, they converged, shaping each other in ways that defy modern disciplinary boundaries. Though it may be more convenient – and maybe even to some extent necessary given the professional constraints involved – to study European and non-European history, and the premodern and modern worlds in isolation, in practice there was only one unbroken chain of events, spilling across periodization schemes and defying national and civilizational divides.

APPENDIX A (MAPS)



Figure 1: This is a 1794 reprint of a map originally constructed in 1779 by James Rennell, who conducted the first European-style cartographic survey of Bengal. The map is highly detailed when it comes to lowlands and river valleys under Company control, but highlands and states along the frontier are either rendered in a vague fashion or are completely absent, revealing both the geographic, political, and intellectual limits of British power at the time.

Source: James Rennell, *Map of Bengal, Bahar, Oude &c.* (Laurie & Whittle, 1794), <https://www.raremaps.com/gallery/detail/51654/an-actual-survey-of-the-provinces-of-bengal-bahar-c-by-m-laurie-whittle-rennell>.



Figure 2: This is a map of the Burmese Empire created by a slave of the heir apparent. It reflects an indigenous spatial logic: there is no fixed scale, and the map is organized according to key geographical features like rivers. Ethnic groups and tributary states feature prominently. The map also differentiates wild or independent tribal groups from civilized or tributary ones and places them in ecologically marginal spaces, suggesting an imperial concept of the assertion of rule over diverse populations.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 2 (1820), pp. 262-271.

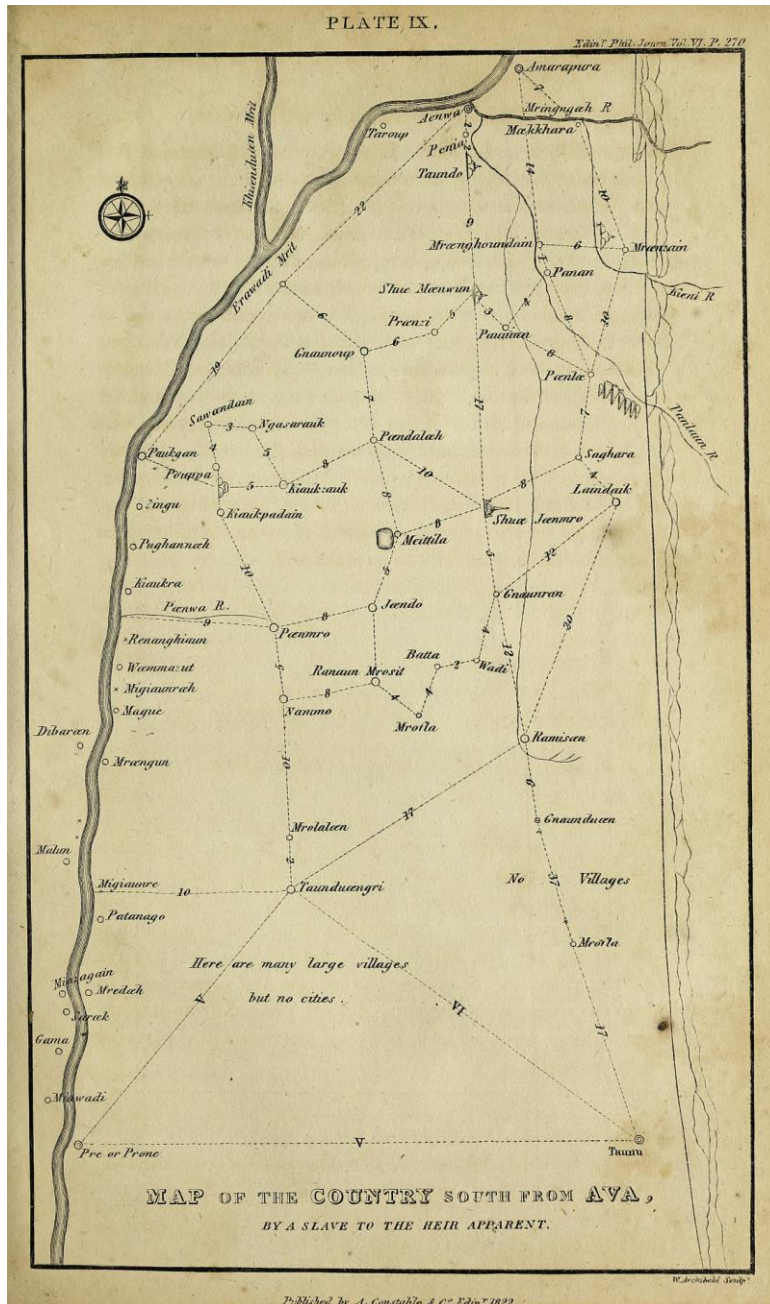


Figure 3: This is a map of the territory south from Ava. It emphasizes routes and distances between settlements in a mathematically informed fashion. It was created by a local person who was coached by Buchanan to represent space in this way, which served the needs of the early colonial state. Like many of the maps in this section, it represents a hybrid of European and non-European mapping traditions.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map by a Slave to the Heir-apparent of Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 6 (1822), pp. 270-273.

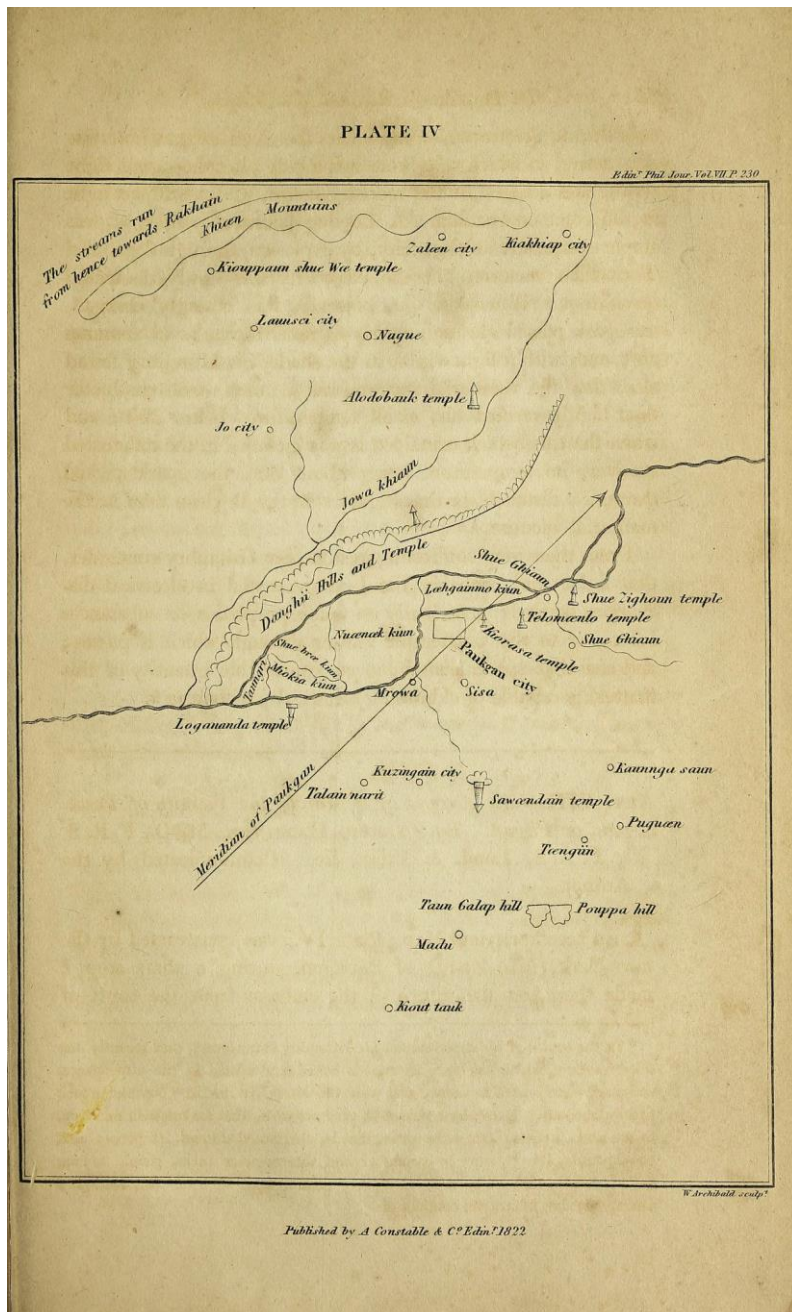


Figure 4: This is a map of the city of Pagan (or Bagan today). It is a sacred geography centered on the main city, with settlements and temples surrounding it in mandala-like fashion. Highland tribal groups are placed in peripheral areas associated with wilderness. A north-south meridian juts through the map, likely added by Buchanan or at his behest.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'An Account of a Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 7 (1822), pp. 230-239.

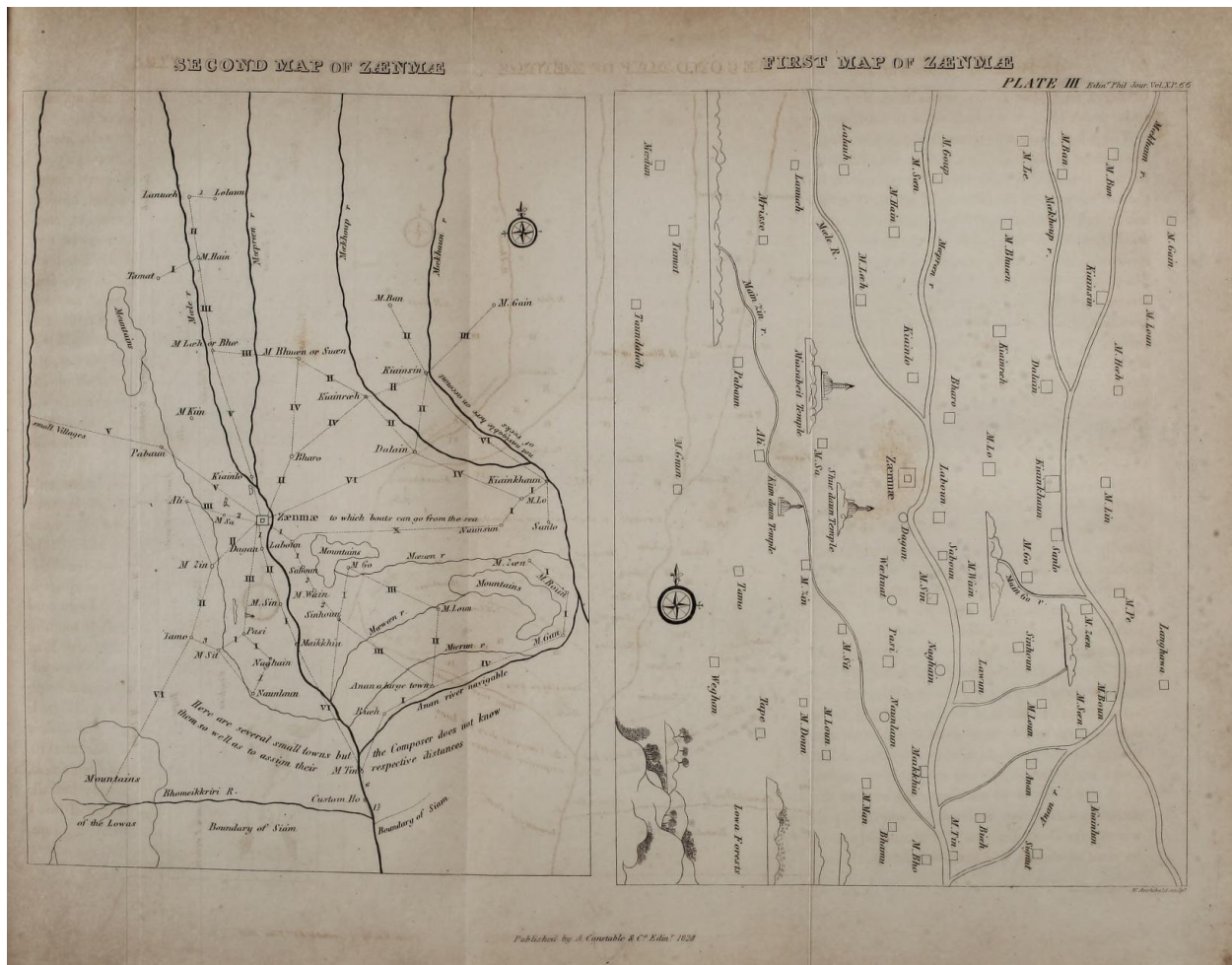


Figure 5: This is a two-part map of Chiang Mai, today in northern Thailand. The left is a route-based map representing distance in a mathematically informed fashion, likely at Buchanan's behest. It also includes a boundary with Siam, which was guesswork – in reality, in the late 18th century, Chiang Mai was in a shifting set of overlapping tributary relations with multiple surrounding states. The right-side map depicts a mandala cosmology in which the central settlement of Chiang Mai is surrounded by smaller subordinate ones. Like many of the other maps in this series, it too emphasizes rivers and temples, as well as a highland–lowland divide.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of Two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 10 (1824), pp. 59-67.

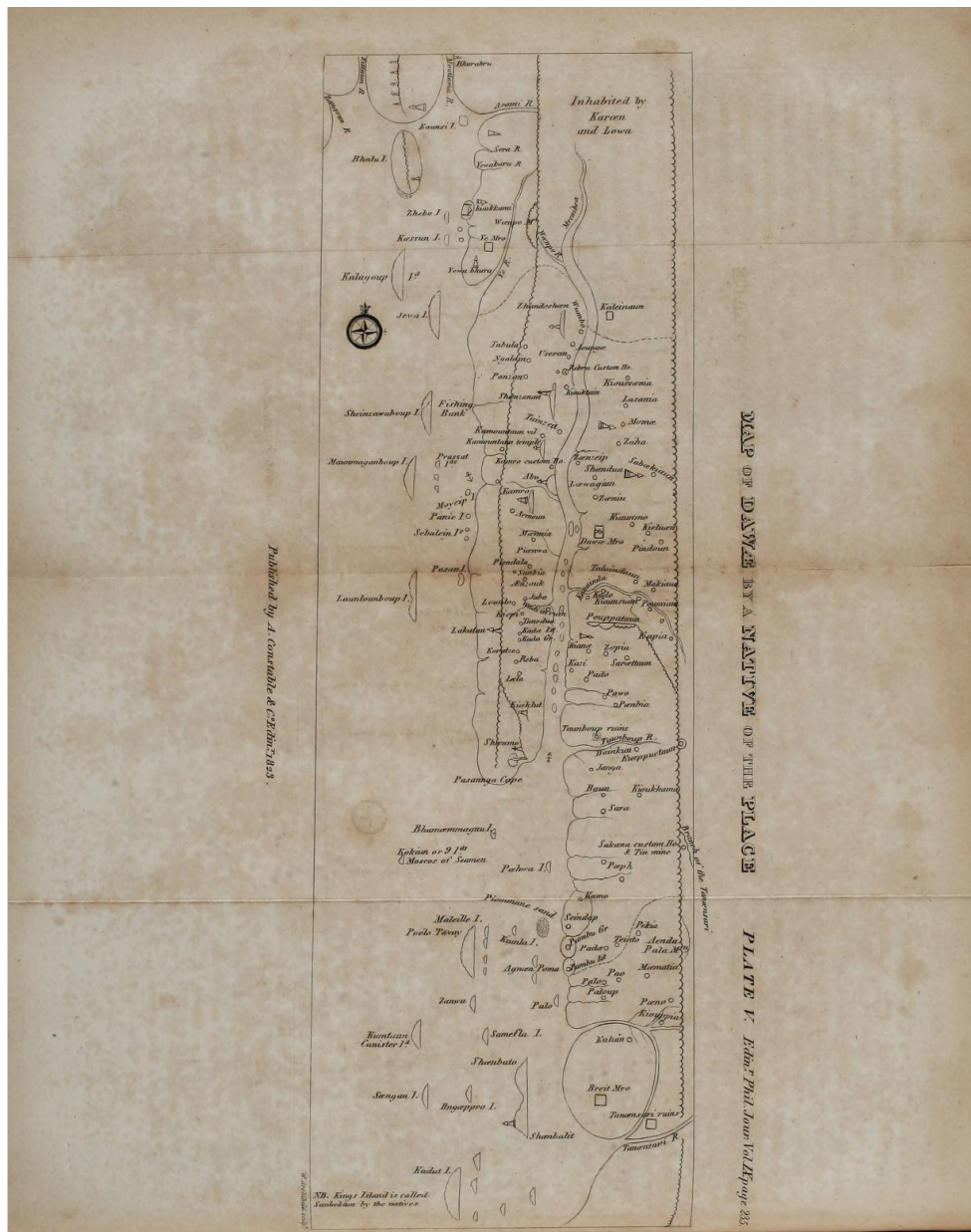


Figure 6: This is a map of the coastal city-state of Tavoy. It would be oriented east–west on modern maps, but here the coastline appears from north to south. It reflects a maritime logic in that settlements are all positioned either along the coastline or along river inlets. Like many of the other maps in the series, tribal groups are placed in the furthest margins of the map and are associated with wilderness.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map drawn by a native of Dawae or Tavay,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 9 (1823), pp. 228-36.

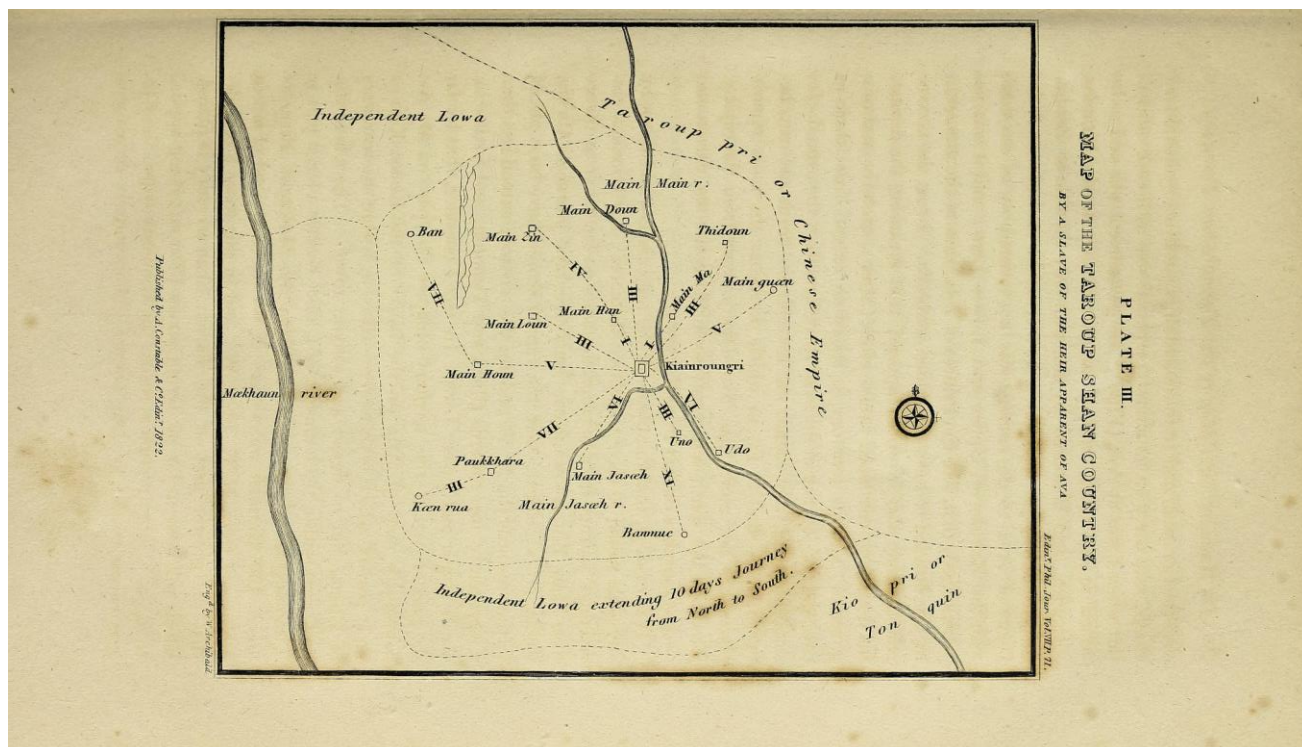


Figure 7: This is a map of the Chinese Shan states, today in Yunnan. It centers on the city of Keng Hung and is constructed in a mandala-like fashion, with most of the surrounding city-states placed in relation to the center. Peripheral tribal groups are placed in marginal spaces at the corners of the map. Mathematical routes have been added by or at the behest of Buchanan, as well as projected boundaries which in reality did not exist – this region was the site of multiple wars between Burma, China, and Siam in the 18th century and sat at the shifting periphery of all three.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the Tarout Shan Territory,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 7 (1822), pp. 71-75.



Figure 8: This is a map of the space north from Ava. It is distinctive for its rich depiction of plant life in a style highly reminiscent of surviving Burmese indigenous maps, meaning that it was likely created by someone with prior experience in map-making. It is oriented in a non-European fashion, depicting a space that would today be represented as moving north to south. Here it moves east to west, and relies on the Chindwin and Irrawaddy river valleys as a central orientator.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of the country north from Ava,' *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*, 4 (1821), pp. 76-87.

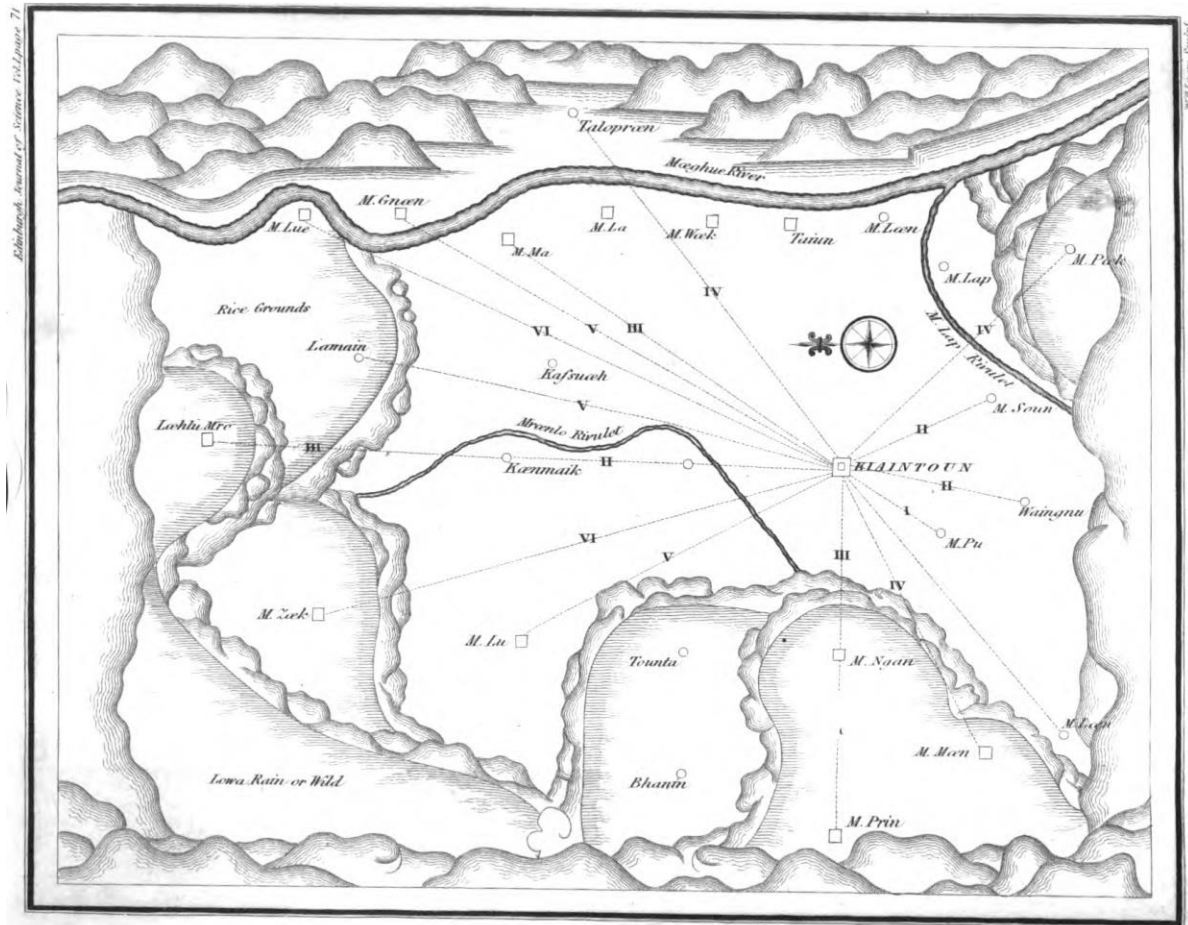


Figure 10: This is a map of what is today the state of Laos. It is encircled by mountains on all sides, which are represented as an ecumene bounding the central lowland space in the middle. The central settlement, likely Luang Prabang, is represented in mandala fashion as being surrounded by satellites. Natural features such as rivers and rice-producing regions are central to the map's concept of space, and tribal groups living in mountains or forested spaces are placed at the margins. Travel distances have again likely been added by Buchanan.

Source: Francis Buchanan, 'Account of a Map of Upper Laos, or the Territory of the Lowa Shan,' *Edinburgh Journal of Science*, 1 (1824), pp. 71-73.

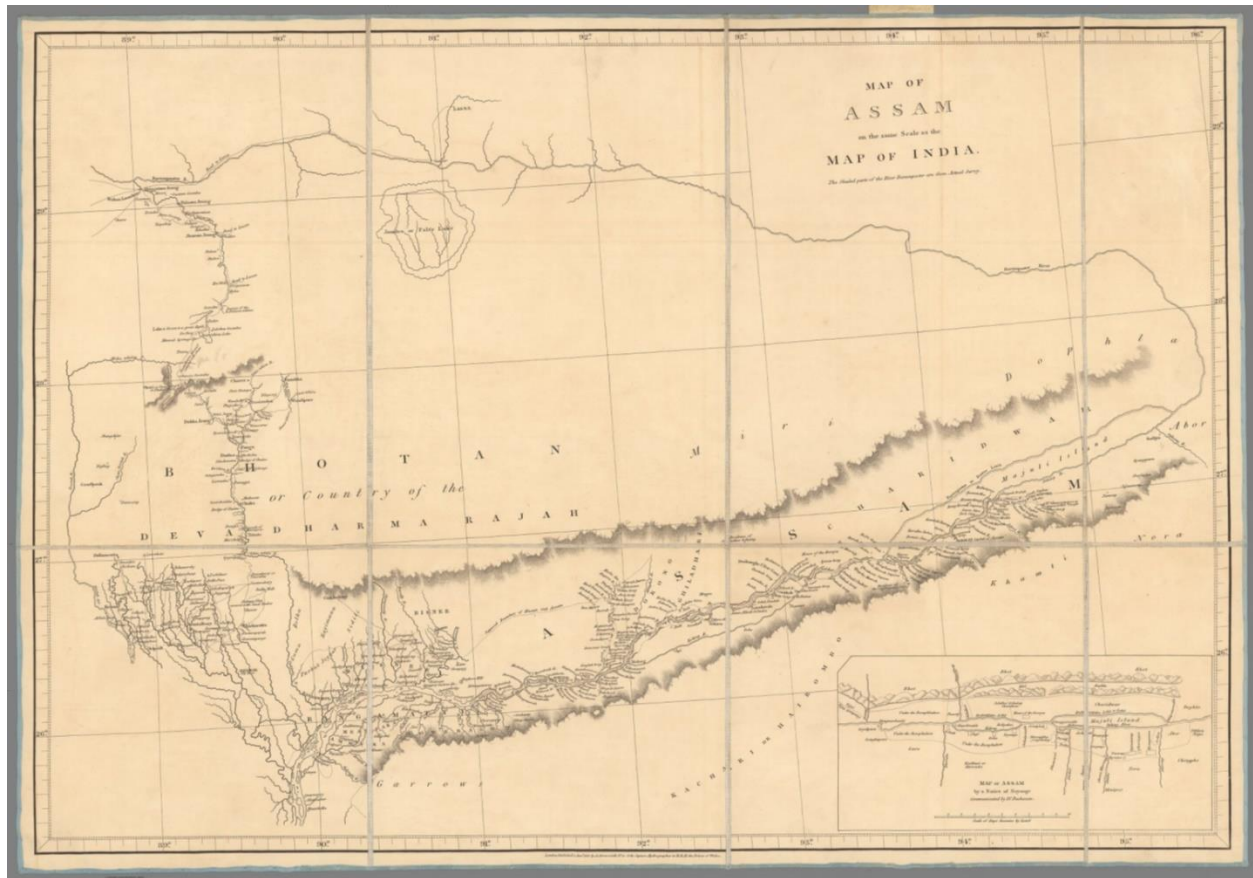
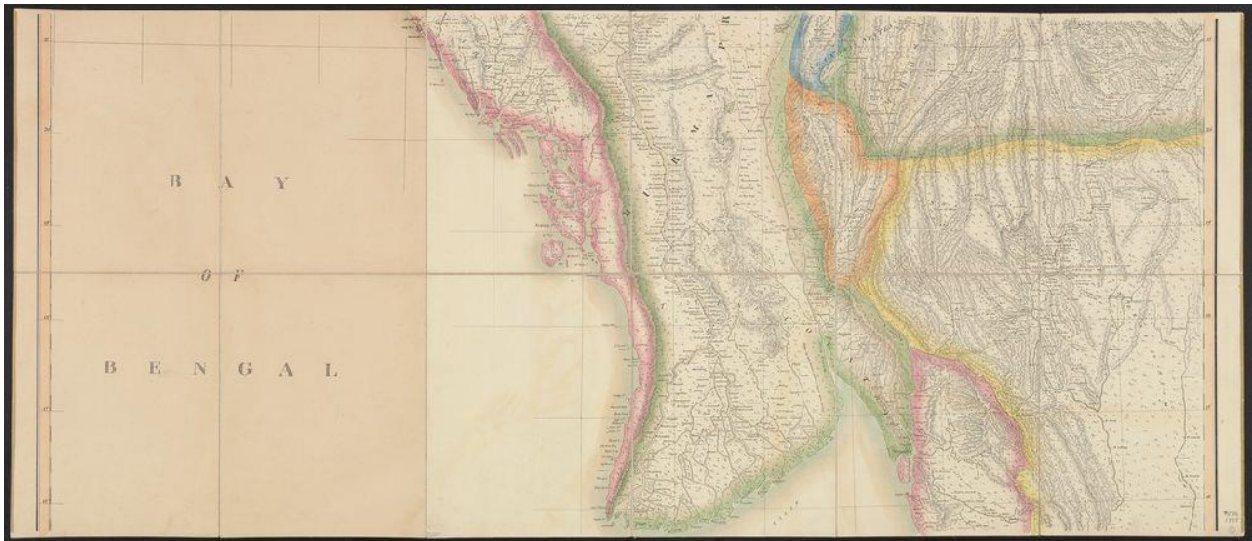
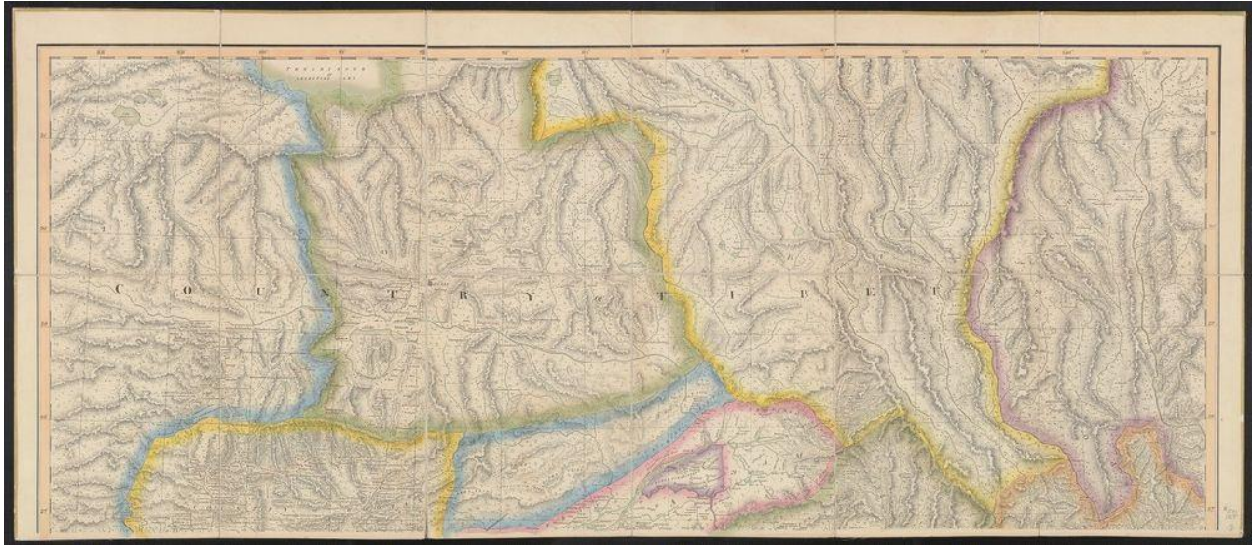


Figure 11: This is a map of Assam, constructed in London but based on information provided to the mapmaker by Francis Buchanan, who himself was relying on Thomas Wood's surveying data. It follows the river route taken by Wood while he was attached to the Welsh expedition to Assam, including his loop into Bhutan. An indigenous map has been inset at the bottom corner, which Buchanan also drew on in his attempt to comprehend the region. On both maps, Assam's frontiers are largely represented as empty space, reflecting the limits of both colonial and indigenous knowledge.

Source: Aaron Arrowsmith, *Map of Assam on the same Scale as the Map of India* (London, 1816), <https://www.raremaps.com/gallery/detail/60665op/map-of-assam-on-the-same-scale-as-the-map-of-india-the-sha-arrowsmith>.



Figures 12 & 13: This final map (the middle sheet is missing) was created by Robert Pemberton after the First Anglo-Burmese War, through compiling and synthesizing a number of smaller maps – many created by Francis Buchanan or his indigenous informants – as well as the efforts of surveyors attached to the various army regiments fighting against the Burmese in the highland spaces between the two states. The area around the state of Manipur was likely mapped out by Pemberton himself; he was embedded with a regiment of Manipuri soldiers throughout the war. The detailed mapping of the Irrawaddy valley was likely based on Thomas Wood's earlier work on the Symes mission. This map represents a clear epistemological break with indigenous concepts of space, imposing European-style borders on all of the states in the region. The ambiguities marking the relationship between sovereignty and space in the precolonial period are still partially present, however: Pemberton preserves liminal tribal zones between major states, and represents tributary polities as being semi-autonomous and marked out with clear boundaries.

Source: R. Boileau Pemberton, *Map of the Eastern Frontier of British India, with the adjacent Countries* (Calcutta, 1838), <https://collections.library.yale.edu/catalog/1551291>.

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